Her Beacon of Hope

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/25225132.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Glimmer (She-Ra), Catra & Glimmer (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra), Glimmer & Micah (She-Ra), Adora & Bow (She-Ra), Bow & Glimmer (She-Ra), Adora & Bow & Glimmer (She-Ra)

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Additional Tags:
Chipped Adora (She-Ra), Mind Control, Angst, Hurt/Comfort, Angst and Hurt/Comfort, Angst with a Happy Ending, Near Death Experiences, Blood and Injury, Swearing, Alternate Universe - Canon Divergence, Nightmares, Panic Attacks, Flashbacks, Developing Relationship, sort of more like repairing relationship, Forgiveness, Fix-It, Apologies, Fix The Hell That Was s5

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English

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Part 2 of Chipped!Adora

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by curiousscientistkae

Summary

Adora has been captured and chipped by Horde Prime. Glimmer tried to free her from the clutches of Prime but fails, resulting in her becoming seriously injured and Adora fully allowing the chip to take over her mind. Separated and in the midst of Etheria about to be fully taken over, Glimmer remains determined to save Adora. Meanwhile, Adora is lost in her own perfect world. Though when she looks closer, somethings don't seem right.

There are things both girls want to say to each other during all this, apologizes and confessions, but now they might be too late to say any of it as the world and themselves begin to break and fall.

Notes

So I had so much fun with the other chipped!adora that is linked I...ended up with this lol. Yeah it is a little darker but when i asked on tumblr, people wanted it so here it is. Rn I have a couple chapters done and I am still working on it (this probably is all I am gonna working on rn i'll probably work on other things also but idk) but it will rn update every two weeks. Once I get more queue I can do weekly and if need be, switch it back. So ye. I will put tw when I can but I still hope you enjoy. I do highly recommend reading the one shot as this fic shoots off from the fight scene in it so there are refs to it.

Anyway again enjoy. Tw for this chapter is blood, serious injury, and near death

See the end of the work for more notes

Darkness Falls

Adora cannot pull her eyes away from the sight laid out in front of her. The sword she holds slips from her shaking grasp, falling through the air before hitting the ground with a clatter. Her body follows suit, her legs giving out. Her knees catch her fall. Hands cover her mouth, stifling a growing cry attempting to crawl its way out of her throat. Her vision becomes blurred with tears. All she can see are vivid colors. Shades of purples, blues and pink meld together perfectly but one color sticks out like a sore thumb. Bright red.

So much red…

Instincts kick in. She reaches out her hands and presses them hard on the body in front of her, hoping that there is some sliver of hope it isn't too late. The blood seeps through her bare fingers, staining them in its brilliant color. The owner of the blood lays motionless, her sparkling eyes shut. Her face has become ashen. There still is a hint of a smile on her face, a left over from her last pleas and reassurance. Even when faced with death, she never stopped fighting. She never stopped trying to reach through the darkness that once clouded Adora's mind, trying to pull her back into the light.

"Glimmer. Glimmer *please!* Wake up!" Adora's voice comes out broken, nothing like her determined tone she always tries to put out. Her cries are not heard. It doesn't look like the queen is breathing. Adora is scared to listen for a heartbeat. She presses her hands harder on the wound in Glimmer's body. The one *she* gave her.

"C'mon, Glim! You got to get up! You've never been one to not fight and sit still. Please...get up...for me…I...I..." her voice quivers at the end, the last two words she wants to speak trapped inside a tight throat. Still, she gets no answer, not even a twitch of the body. She tries to speak and finish her sentence but no words come out of her mouth. Only sobs.

This cannot not be real. This *has* to be a dream. Only moments before it felt like a hate filled nightmare. One similar to those that plagued her ever since she was first infected by the First One's tech. But unlike those, she cannot wake up from this at all. Everything starts to play back in her mind and Adora cannot find a button to turn it off.

It all started with Glimmer entering the room and Adora feeling a growing sense of anger. Anger over everything they said and did to each other the past few months began to boil over inside of her. She wanted Glimmer to understand the hurt that filled her body and the mess it left her mind. But she never wanted *this.* Yet...she still went through with it. She still charged and attacked Glimmer with the intent to maim and kill. She still spat out words like knives that could be twisted into the queen's heart...She still allowed herself to push her sword through Glimmer's body, not even trying to fight it off. Now, she has quite possibly murdered the Queen of Brightmoon, one of her first and best friends upon leaving the Horde, and the person who started to win over her heart.

Memories of her time with Glimmer flood her mind. Offering her own room in the castle and accommodating it to her needs. The time she tried to cook something for Adora to try for the first time only for it to be burned. Both laughed it off and still ate it anyway and neither minded the taste. Or whenever she had nightmares of her time at the Horde or the things Catra did to her and everyone else, Glimmer would rub a soft yet strong hand across her back for comfort as she cried everything out. Fighting alone alongside her, laughing with her, feeling so proud when she took over the throne from her mother, and always finding hope and comfort when she was by her side.

No matter how many negative memories that might plague her from their recent months of their arguments and fracturing of their friendship, it couldn't shatter the love she has for Glimmer. All she ever wanted to do is see her become the best queen Brightmoon has ever seen. She just wanted to keep her safe from any more harm. Now she has thrown all of that out the window.

Adora feels the back of her neck begin to itch as she pulls her hands away, guilt and despair spreading across her body. Looking down at her palms she finds them stained red. No matter how many times she will wash them, there will be no way to rid them of what they did. She wants this nightmare to end. She wants to wake up and find herself back in Brightmoon's castle, nestled up against Glimmer in her bed. The warmth and safety of that moment in her head is a million times better than the horror laid out in front of her.

A headache starts to form.

I can take that pain away, little sister, Horde's Prime dark and heavy voice echoes in her mind. Adora grasps the side of her head. The voice grows louder and louder, drowning out any thoughts she might have. *Come with me, and I can help you.*

Her mind begins to show her images she longs for. Being back at Brightmoon, no war raging on outside, and being right at Glimmer's side. A smile going from ear to ear is plastered on her face as she looks at Adora, eyes lit and sparkling, and full of a gentle warmth and welcoming invitation. Nothing is wrong. Adora can't feel any anxiety boiling inside of her or self-doubt trying to tear her down. All she can feel is love and tenderness for the queen.

Glimmer sticks out her hand. Adora hesitates for a moment, a voice in the back of her head telling her this is wrong. She shouldn't accept it and to fight back against what she is thinking. It tells her this is all in her head, made up and fake. But how can this not be real? They won the war didn't they? She and Glimmer have repaired their relationship by the looks of it. Another voice tells her that by taking the offer, she can live the rest of her life with the queen and be one as well, ruling besides her. Nothing will ever go wrong ever again. That voice drowns out the other and Adora takes the offer. She squeezes Glimmer's warm hand tight, refusing to let anything pull them away ever again.

Outside of her mind, Adora stares blankly ahead of her, eyes bright green. A voice tells her to rise and leave the queen. Without a second thought, she slowly stands to her feet, grabbing her sword as she rises, and turns on her heels. The warrior princess, in the clutches of Horde Prime, heads out of the room, waiting to hear her next order. Unbeknownst to her, a groan escapes Glimmer.

Glimmer's body is heavy. It feels like she has been dropped into a vast, thick, black liquid. No matter how hard she tries to open her eyes or twitch her body, nothing works. Coldness nips at her skin, as if she has been thrown out into the Kingdom of Snows during the middle of a blizzard. Why isn't she shivering? If only there was something to warm her up. The first thought she has on what can give her that is Adora. The blonde always radiates heat. So many nights did the queen wrap her arms around the girl to take that all in.

Adora…

What did Horde Prime do to her? He turned a once happy and kind person into a cold and violent one, having no hesitation to attempt to kill. Even with her eyes colored completely in a sickly green, Glimmer could see the hate and blood lust in them. But that isn't Adora, far from it. She knows the blonde would never harm her, not even when she was rightfully angry with her. And yet…

There is a clamor. It sounds far away to Glimmer. She attempts to reach out to it, make sense of what is going on but she cannot grasp onto it. No matter how hard she tries, she never gets close to it. She tries harder to move, to get up, or just open her damn eyes but it is to no avail. The heavy black liquid that surrounds her body becomes heavier, *thicker,* and she finds herself wanting to sleep for all of eternity. Glimmer is about to accept this and go into a deep slumber when suddenly a noise is right on top of her.

It sounds muffled, like someone trying to talk underwater. Something hot touches her body. She decides to try and stay awake a little longer. Glimmer attempts to focus on the words and make a lick of sense. The only thing she can muster is that she knows the owner of the voice despite not being able to put a name to it, and it belongs to a teenage boy based on the crack in his voice. She wants to answer him, give him a reply and ask him what is going on, but everything stays locked in her mind. Another voice, one raspy and belonging to what she assumes is a girl, enters. It is loud and harsh compared to the boy's softer tone. Suddenly, something lifts her up. This time she feels a groan escape her lips. Finally, a word spoken by the girl is clear when it enters her mind

Adora.

The last moments she had with Adora flood her mind, giving faded colors and shapes to her dark world.

Adora backed her up against a wall, leaving no room for escape. Adora, no, Horde Prime mocked her, calling her a weak and pathetic queen before impaling her in the abdomen. Glimmer clutched the sword in her hands, knowing full well that the removal meant nothing but death. The sickening laugh, mixed of Horde Prime's and Adora's, echoes in her mind as she recalls the events. Glimmer felt her life seeping out of her as the controlled blonde slowly pulled the weapon out of her. She only stopped momentarily when Glimmer spoke.

"It's okay, Adora...It's okay…" Glimmer knew if Adora remembered any of this, she would never forgive herself. She wanted to make sure the blonde would not be eaten away with regret. "None of this is your fault, okay? ...I'm...I am sorry f-for everything. P-Please don't keep hating yourself for that either…"

Her voice was so broken and weak when she spoke and she felt hot tears fall down her face. Somehow, a smile was managed. "I didn't want to hurt you...You have every right to be angry...I'm so sorry. Just...Just know that I love you. Nothing ever changed that.

I was...to stupid to let go of my pride and...tell you how I felt. I've *always* loved you, Adora, and I always will…"

The last thing she recalls before everything slips away from her is the sword being freed from her body and the return of Adora's brilliant blue eyes, filled with terror and tears.

Glimmer slowly starts to stir as a soft hum fills her ears. Her body feels like it is made of lead and then some but with enough force, she is able to pull her eyelids apart. She finds herself alone in an empty, metal coated room. Her brain slowly boots back up, reminding her that this is a room inside Darla. Why she is here, she cannot answer. All she knows is she is lying on her back on some bed and it hurts to breathe. Attempting to even move an inch of her body sends waves of fire through her. She bites down on her lip hard, nearly drawing blood as she holds back a cry of pain.

Nothing makes sense. Why is she here on Darla? She can't remember where she was before, a thick fog blocks any attempts to pull out memories, but it wasn't here. What is causing her pain? Gingerly, she grabs the edge of the light blanket over her and lifts it up. The whole of her lower half is wrapped in white bandages. Her eyebrows furrow. Did someone or something hurt her? Maybe Bow knows what is going on. Against better judgement, she attempts to get out of bed. The second she tries to put weight on her leg, she crumbles to the ground.

"SON OF A BITCH!" Glimmer cries out, unable to hold it back. It feels like her whole body has been thrown into a pit of boiling lava and a million sharp needles are stabbing her at the same time. She curls in on itself, trying to ease the pain somehow. It is all she can think of, the fire raging through her, leaving little in its wake. Her words become only curses.

The next thing she knows, Bow is at her side, asking her if she is alright. Glimmer shoots him a glare, which quickly answers his question. He helps get her back into bed and in a more

comfortable position. The fiery pain begins to quell. The soft touch of Bow's fingers brushing against her forehead as they fix her bangs help ease her aching body. Not wanting to risk anymore suffering, Glimmer only shifts her eyes to look at Bow.

He has seen better days. His dark brown eyes are dimmed from tiredness, though Glimmer can still find a spark of light in them, and bags hang underneath them. His hair is unkempt. Has he not slept at all? She opens her mouth to speak but her best friend cuts her off.

"Save your strength," he says in a hoarse voice.

Glimmer gives a slight shake of her head. "W-What happened?"

Bow thinks for a moment, his fingers still playing with part of her pink hair. "We're trying to figure that out. We started to get worried about you, you weren't answering any call. So, we went looking for you and…" he falls silent.

"I was hurt...Wasn't I?" she asks. When he nods, she continues. "I am guessing it was pretty bad if everything hurts like hell and my whole lower half is wrapped up."

"Yeah. We didn't know if you…" he sighs and uses his free hand to wipe away a mist from his eyes. "Do you remember anything that happened? We still can't piece it together."

Knowing it probably isn't a good idea, Glimmer sits up. Bow tries to stop her but she pushes away his attempts to keep her grounded. Being up straight will help her think. He finally catches on and helps her sit up with minimal pain. She runs a hand through her hair as she tries to remember the events that lead to the position she finds herself in. The fog before has begun to lift. Her whole body becomes tense as the image of a controlled Adora enters her mind. The shortened, slicked back hair, the white clothing with the Horde symbol painted across her chest, and those sickly, glowing green eyes.

Glimmer's heart begins to race and she has forgotten how to breathe. Laughter from Adora, sounding wrong and not her own, fills her ears, and she battles the blonde, trying to reach out and pull her out of whatever trance she was in. For a moment, she was able to do so, a sea of blue replacing the green from her eyes, and tears rolling down her face. But that was only for a moment. Flashes of memories come quickly before she watches herself be impaled with a sharp sword by the girl she has started to fall in love with.

"Hey! Hey! Glimmer!" Bow's voice breaks through her train of thought. He wraps an arm around her and pulls her close. "What happened? You gotta breathe. Breathe and tell me what happened."

Between being held and the sound of Bow's heartbeat starts to bring her to her senses, enough to begin understanding what plays in her mind. "Adora! Sh-Horde Prime did something to her Bow! I-I don't know what but he's controlling her!"

"What?!?"

"I found her but she w-wouldn't listen to me! We fought and...and I thought I almost broke though but I couldn't! I couldn't and she...she did this. She did this and I couldn't save her."

Sobs overcome her and her body shakes. Bow holds her tight, trying to make sense of what he just heard. "I'm so sorry, Glim. I don't know what to say but I am sure we can fix it. Somehow."

Glimmer doesn't believe him. How can they fix this? Horde Prime is a force to be reckoned with, with just one snap of his fingers he can destroy worlds or crush armies like ants. Whatever he has done to the warrior princess, it won't be an easy feat to overcome. The queen knows she is lucky to be alive right now. She tries to tell herself that something could be done but her brain but nothing works. How did things end up like this?

She should never have tried to tap into the Heart of Etheria. If she never tried to, she never would have been kidnapped. Adora never would have gone after her and gotten captured herself. Horde Prime never would have his cold hands around her and taken over her mind. Maybe if she never got into spat after spat after *spat* with Adora, they never would have been separated, never been apart and could have figured something out together how to stop the encroaching Horde. So many things could have played out differently if things didn't go to shit between them.

A mix bag of emotions begins to fester inside of Glimmer. A wound that she never allowed to heal and let it grow for months now spills out all of its infectious poison into her body. She feels guilt over everything she said and did to Adora and being unable to free her from Horde Prime. Sadness over the loss of her friend and never being able to apologize and say how she feels to her when a sword wasn't inside of her body. Fear over what this now means for the rest of Etheria and if Adora ever is brought back, what she will think about what she has done. And-

"Hey, Bow! Is Sparkle alright?" a voice echoes in the metal halls. Looking over Bow's shoulder, Glimmer sees the magicat Horde soldier appear in the door frame.

Anger. Anger finishes off the toxic soup boiling inside of her. Her hands slowly curl into a tight fist, her knuckles turning white. They went onto Horde Prime's ship the first time to save the magicat because Adora's good natured soul couldn't leave her behind. Catra was the reason Double Trouble was in Brightmoon, causing problems and sending back information that ended with the fall of Salineas. The shapeshifter helped put salt into the wounds between Adora and Glimmer. A reason Glimmer became so on edge was from suddenly being thrown into being queen, a role she never thought she would take on, all because Catra decided to say 'Fuck you, Adora' and open up the portal. And if she never did that, Horde Prime would never have been alerted to the presence of Etheira and been right on top of them the second Adora brought them back to the wide and vast universe.

She must be oozing out this hatred. Catra's ears fall flat on her head and she takes a step back, looking small. Glimmer swallows the growing feeling trying to crawl out of her throat. She bottles it up, hiding it away in a corner of her mind. There is no time for lashing out right now when Adora is still out there, doing only the gods know what under the control of Prime.

Glimmer pushes away from Bow, wiping the tears away from her face. "I'm fine, Catra." Try as she might, bitterness still slips out.

Catra slowly enters the room, staying a couple yards away from the pair. Her tail flicks behind her, ears still flat against her head. One arm holds the other. "I'm glad you are alright, Sparkles. You had everyone worried."

"How long was I out?"

"Nearly two days," Bow tells her.

"WHAT?!?" The shock of the revelation causes her to jerk, sending another wave of pain through her body. "Fuck!"

"You really have to take it easy, Glimmer. Your body needs to rest. Lay back down."

"No. No! I already have been out for two days now. Who knows what Prime has done to Adora during this time. I am not going to sit idling by anymore."

"Glimmer, please," Bow places a hand on her shoulder. "I know you are worried. We are all worried. But what are we going to do? You are hurt. Going back on Horde Prime's ship for a third time isn't the best idea either. We barely made it out when getting you off. We tried to find Adora then but we couldn't when you were clinging to life.

"There isn't much we can do right now. We have to get back to Etheria and regroup and go from there. Horde Prime most likely is on his way there now so Adora must be heading back as well. That is our best option right now."

Glimmer grumbles something. He is not *wrong.* She doesn't like the idea of Adora spending any more time with Horde Prime. But what good *is* she if she can barely move without feeling like someone is beating the ever loving shit out of her? With any luck, she should be back on her feet quicker than most might think. A perk of having an immortal mother, sped up healing. It probably is the reason why she is still breathing.

"Fine...I'm not laying down but I will try to take it easy."

"Thank you. I am going to go tell Entrapta that you are alright. I will get you something to eat. You must be starving."

He says nothing more before leaving. Catra remains standing where she is, looking at Glimmer with hesitation. When it is clear she will not be leaving, Glimmer asks, "What do you want?"

Catra shifts on her feet. "I don't know. I guess...I just still wanted to make sure you were alright. You did come after me to save my life."

Yeah and look where it got us, Glimmer thinks to herself. She sighs, knowing Adora wouldn't want her to lash out at her former friend. "It's no big deal. If you don't mind, I'd like to be left alone right now."

Catra nods before slowly exiting the room. Now alone, Glimmer takes a breath. What a mess she now finds herself in. Not only is Adora gone, who knows if she is lost forever in that chip that was behind her neck. That has to be controlling her. Now this vile, horrible being has the power of She-ra at his side. He wants to use her for his own gain. She has no idea how Prime would be able to get Adora to turn into She-ra, during the brief period the two girls were together the blonde told her about the sword and its shattering. How he could possibly use She-ra, she cannot wrap her head around.

Still, he said he sensed the warrior inside of Adora. Whatever that means, she doesn't like it. Prime is a forceful being and he might

just be able to access the power. And once he does, what does that mean for Etheria? Having one of the most powerful beings on the planet as his puppet. And she is the key to the Heart of Etheria, a huge well of powerful magic. If he gets to it, if he has control over She-ra, there will be little hope for anyone to stop them.

She feels herself about to cry, burst open like a damn and flood a whole town. She holds it back, a choking noise managing to slip out. Enough tears have been shed already, no need for more. Glimmer tells herself that she needs to stay strong right now and save her energy for figuring out what to do. No matter what she and the others come up with, the queen is determined to get Adora back safely, no matter what.

Adora can't help but stare at the being sprawled out on her chest, nestled in her arms and fast asleep. Glimmer breathes steadily and softly. The morning light from the new, bright sun shines into the large room, giving the queen a halo of gold light around her body. To the blonde haired warrior, she looks like the most beautiful angel, sent straight down from the heavens. How she got so lucky to get the chance to hold Glimmer in her arms and call her her other half, she does not know or understand but accepts wholeheartedly.

Adora uses a free hand to gently rub a thumb against Glimmer, soft, warm, and colorful cheek. Part of her wants to pinch it from how cute she looks but there is no need to disturb the queen. She deserves all the rest in the world after working so hard. Even with the world at peace, Glimmer is always out and about making sure everyone is okay and has enough to eat. Besides, she could watch Glimmer sleep for hours on end and never grow sick of it.

However, the queen slowly starts to stir. She mumbles something before amethyst colored eyes flutter open. Glimmer blinks before the shift to meet Adora's sky colored ones. The light inside the vivid purple irises shine bright like the stars from her dreams and

that dot the night sky, full of life and love. A soft smile spreads across her face.

"Mmmmm, g'morning, my early bird," Glimmer mutters, still half asleep. She shuts her eyes once more and buries her face deeper into Adora's chest, inhaling her scent.

"Morning my night owl. How did you sleep?" Adora asks. She continues to stroke the queen's cheek. When Glimmer says something, it is muffled. "I can't hear you when your mouth is hidden."

Glimmer tilts her head, eyes still shut. "Fine. What about you? No nightmares?"

"None. You keep them at bay, ya know."

"Glad I can help." A yawn escapes her. Adora gives her a slight nudge.

"You gotta wake up, hon. We don't have to get out of bed but you shouldn't sleep until noon either."

Glimmer groans before opening her eyes again. She places her chin on Adora's chest and sticks out her tongue, her nose scrunched. Adora returns the gesture, making both girls laugh. Adora's heart begins to flutter hearing the bubbly laugh, a sound she can never grow tired of. If she could record and capture the sound, she would play it nonstop until the recording broke.

"You know, my mom and dad are going to be running the kingdom today. Gives us plenty of time to do whatever we want. What do you say to that Miss Always Needs To Be On The Move?"

"I think it is absolutely wonderful. Anything where I am with you will make me happy, even if it is just staying like this."

"Oh, that's new." Glimmer raises an eyebrow. "What did you do with the old Adora who can never sit still?"

“I am still here. I just am taking pointers from you. Is that such a bad thing?”

“Not in the slightest.”

Adora grins. She lifts her head up just enough to lock lips with the queen. Glimmer does not protest, pushing herself into it. The kiss is soft, like a butterfly gently landing on one’s cheek. Warm like a fireplace in the middle of winter. And perfect, just like all the ones she dreamed of when she longed for Glimmer to be her girlfriend. The scent of Glimmer’s lavender shampoo from the day before fills her nose, making her think of lying in a flower field where a gentle breeze brushes across her skin. She feels the queen’s arm snake around her neck and fingers stroke the skin beneath her hair.

They are slow to break apart but air is needed. Adora never lets go of the queen, keeping her close to her body as their eyes meet. “I love you so much, Glimmer.”

"I love you too, Adora.”

Adora stares out a large, glass window. Down below her is her planet, ships encasing it. She says nothing while looking at the army that threatens her home. Soon she will be back on the ground. There will be no reunion between her and the princesses. No time for that. No need for that. Horde Prime will give her a purpose, a role to take up. Whatever he wants, she will do and be the hero he needs.

Even when footsteps slowly make their way to her, she does not turn her head. She stands tall and still like a statue. The noise of someone walking stops when they are right at her side and is replaced by a deep voice. “What do you think of it, little sister?” Horde Prime asks.

Adora says nothing. She continues to stare out as they draw closer to the colorful world of Etheria. Horde Prime continues.

“This world has been just a pain, has it not? Etherians are so pesky with their magic and princesses. You would know that first hand, wouldn’t you? They always needed you to save them or fix their problems all the time. You must have grown so tired of it. But now we can put them in their place once and for all. Wouldn't you agree?”

Adora only nods. Horde Prime grins.

“I still do wonder how She-ra works but we will figure that out as we go. For now, we will be landing soon. Will you come with me to prepare? You must look ready to return to this planet. Must make your mark.”

“Yes, brother,” Adora finally speaks. She follows Horde Prime out of the room.

Aching

Chapter Notes

> okay i lied I updated now partly because I have something to do next monday and I really don't want to deal with getting it out while I am busy. But also I am just...gonna post whenever I feel I am ahead a bit rn its 2 and some out (meaning I am working on chapter 5) so if I need to skip a week I will. If you don't see an update by about 3pm est, then it won't update that week as an fyi
>
> anyway I am still learning how to do chapter fics so sorry this came out shorter and hopefully it's alright this is all out of my comfort zone (so ie sorry for the ending). still I hope you are enjoying it and another fyi i do read all comments I get on my fics I am just shy and quiet with answering but aksgjbaskgj
>
> anyway see ya whenever either maybe next week if I get a breather or the week after

Glimmer finds sleeping to be hard. After being out for practically two days, her body and mind have little interest in being unconscious any longer. It doesn’t even bother to attempt to find it when she tried to close her eyes before. So instead, she stares up at the ceiling, one arm draped over her forehead, waiting to store up enough strength to pull herself out of bed. She was able to draw some from the food Bow has been bringing her but half of it lies uneaten on the table besides her. Between being stabbed practically in the stomach and the feeling of dark vines wrapping around her body, sucking any happiness out of her, her appetite is almost nonexistent. At least she managed to get something down. That’ll make Bow happy.

She raises her free hand to her face, running a thumb against her knuckles. She still doesn’t feel real. *Nothing* feels real. Feeling skin against skin does little to bring her mind back into her body.

Everything inside of her is numb and heavy. Even if she cannot sleep at the moment, Glimmer wishes time would just pass by and not drag on at a snail's pace. How long has she been in bed now?

If only there was some type of magic to turn back the clocks and prevent any of this happening. Stop Horde Prime from taking Adora. Stop herself from attempting to tap into the Heart of Etheria. Stop all the fighting that occurred between them that helped cause all this mess. Reset and go back to when times were simpler and happier. Back where Adora was right by her side, making everything right in the world.

There is no such magic as far as she knows, however. Even if there was something like that, it is not like she can do it. Squeezing her hand close, she attempts to summon sort of magic. Her fist sparkles only for a moment before fizzling out. She tries harder, using all her might, but nothing holds. Stupid recharging. Glimmer wonders if when they get back to Etheria, if her Aunt Castaspella can help return her spellcasting abilities. Whatever the older sorceress does to keep her magic flowing inside of her surely should help her. She has no idea what the state of her kingdom is. If it is overrun then she will be cut off from recharging her sparkles and teleportations. She has to find some way not to be defenseless.

Sighing, she lets her hand fall back down to her side. She then takes a deep breath, attempting to gather her thoughts. One thing at a time. First thing's first. Getting back to Etheria without being shot down or captured. Bow told her when he brought some food that he, Adora, and Entrapta barely made it off the planet when they raced to recuse her. Only with everyone's help did they succeed. Now, they are alone. There has to be something that can be done. There *always* is something. Thankfully, there is some time to think right now. A pit stop more or less. Apparently Darla's sensors picked up on a presence of magic on the planet and everyone figured why not check it out. It also allows for Darla to take a break. Apparently her engines needed a breather. Once everyone comes back, they can rest for a moment and think of a game plan.

Not wanting to lay around any longer, Glimmer decides to say 'fuck it' and get up. Thankfully, Entrapta made her a makeshift crutch out of spare parts she had after rewiring Darla. Must have been a lot and hopefully nothing important is in there that she might have misplaced. Glimmer carefully swings her legs over the bed and reaches for the metal stick. It is cold to the touch. She shoves the curved top under her armpit and tests her weight. A small winces escapes her but it is far better than when she first attempted to walk. Slowly, she hobbles out of the room.

The ship is quiet, only the banging of pipes behind the metal walls give off an ambiance. She wonders who is still left on the ship. Someone must be onboard so a quick getaway can be made in case things go south. Bow also probably would want someone to stay behind to watch over her. Did he stay behind to ensure his best friend is okay? Or could it be Entrapta? While knowing mostly machines, she is the only one who would have the best idea about how the body works and how to patch it up if Glimmer needed medical aid. Or maybe Catra? The best person to have in a fight but is the worst for comfort. To her surprise, it is none of them. Rather, sitting in the cockpit are Starla and Jewelstar.

"Oh! Uh, hello?" Glimmer says.

"Oh, Glimmer! Hello! How are you feeling? Are you okay?" Starla asks. She quickly is at her side. Glory chirps and jumps off their owner's shoulder and onto Glimmer's. They nuzzle their head against her cheek.

"Sore but I will be alright. Hey, Glory," Glimmer rubs the top of their head. "I just needed to get out of the room. What...What are you two doing here?"

"Your friend Entrapta sent us a message about what happened so we came to help as soon as we could," Jewelstar informs her, walking up next to his sister. "We got here a little while ago. Sorry to hear about everything. I am glad you are okay."

“Thanks...Where is your sister?” Glimmer looks around the room, searching for the eldest sibling.

“She went with your friends to investigate. We stayed behind to watch over you and keep an eye out for any danger.”

“Ah! Thanks again, I guess. But wait...What are you guys doing here anyway? I thought you were going back to your planet?”

“Change of plans. We are going to come back to Etheria with you to aid you in your fight against Horde Prime. Just have to wait for the others. Hopefully they are not too long. I am getting a little worried,” Starla admits.

Glimmer looks outside the windows of the ship, seeing nothing but a desolate world. She wonders what happened here. Did Horde Prime get a hold of this planet and destroy it? If so, what ‘trophy’ did he take from here. Did she see it from her time on the ship? Is this what Etheria will look like if they don’t stop him?

Starla offers to get her a glass of water. Glimmer happily accepts the offer and staggers over to the pilot seat. Jewelstar stays right by her, just in case. She settles down into the seat and runs a hand against the arm rest, feeling all the controls beneath her fingertips. Did Adora sit here and command the ship towards her? This was Mara’s after all, the prior She-ra. That sort of makes this Adora’s ship now. What was the blonde thinking when she was here, traveling through the vast strangeness of space?

Starla soon reappears with a glass in her hand. Glimmer thanks the bubbly girl and sips the liquid down. The coldness feels good against her throat. There is not much to do as they wait for the rest of the group to return. The two siblings do catch the queen up on what exactly is going on. Bow only told her so much before darting off. As she was told before, Darla did pick up on something residing on this planet. The magic source seems strong and curiosity got the better of them. The Star Siblings actually met up with the group here and after talking it over, they split up

to where they are now. Once everyone is back and settled, it is off to Etheria.

While they wait, Starla begins to tell Glimmer some story from her childhood in an attempt to pass time and bring up everyone's spirits. It is one about the time she decided to hide while under the watchful eye of her sister and brother. Apparently the two of them took forever to find their younger siblings. While Starla is laughing over it, Jewelstar only rolls his eyes. Glimmer joins along with the younger of the two.

At the sound of doors opening up, Glimmer turns her head around, craning her neck to peer over the seat. The missing members of the crew appear, dressed in spacesuits to survive the harshness of space. Most of the group come back empty-handed, except Catra. The magicat, on the other hand, has a large, dark reddish purple, feline-like being with a turquoise mane and tail. It shadows her every step.

"Oh! You're up! How are you feeling?" Bow asks when he spots Glimmer.

"Fine," Glimmer tells him when he draws close. "How was everything? What did you guys find?"

"Magic! This whole planet is made out of it!" Entrapta suddenly shouts. "Oh if only we could stay longer so I could research it."

"Mind telling me what the hell that thing is?" Glimmer points to the new creature entering the room. It makes a noise similar to a meow.

"Melog," Catra states. "They kind of bonded with me. Is the last of their kind. Told us how Prime and The First One wrecked this place."

Melog makes their way to Glimmer. They sit down in front of her and tilt their head. Glimmer sees their tail flicking back and forth as they slowly blink at her. After a moment's pause, the queen reaches out and rubs her hand against the top of their head. The

feline's body is smooth and soft like velvet and they let out a purr. Glimmer cannot help but smile.

"You like that, huh?" she asks them. "I guess welcome to the team!"

Melog makes another noise before darting back to Catra. Everyone begins to gather around the pilot seat, though it takes a moment for Entrapta to sit down. Once everyone is settled, Bow walks over to the main control panel and hits some buttons. A pink colored map then appears. All around the room there are holograms of planets and stars slowly circling around. Glimmer reaches out to touch one of them. It flickers and becomes distorted. Removing her hand, she looks around, trying to find where her home planet is. She spots it near the center of the room. The second her eyes land on it, her heart drops to the bottom of her chest. Ships, large and small, surround the planet. Just how many are there? How are they even going to get past all of them and get their feet back on Etheria? What is happening to everyone left behind?

"What the fuck," is all Glimmer can say.

"I know it looks bad, I am not going to sugar coat it," Bow starts, "but we have been figuring out how to get past them."

"Did you come up with something? 'Cause that looks near impossible to do!"

"Well, thanks to Perfuma, we were notified in advance about the blockade. So we really have to thank her when we see her. We were having trouble trying to figure out what to do. Honestly, we almost gave up hope but then Melog came along."

Glimmer turns her head to the new member of the crew. "What do they do?" Almost on cue, the feline disappears. "What the hell?!? Did they just teleport?"

"Not exactly," Tallstar finally speaks. "Our new friend here can turn invisible. Can turn others invisible. We were thinking maybe they

can help us sneak through the blockade."

Melog reappears, purring as Catra pets them. Glimmer turns her gaze back on the hologram in front of her. "Do you think this is going to work? What are the odds? Are we really going to put everything on something you guys just *met?*"

"Well...it's better odds than any other idea we have had so far," Entrapta says. "We are betting everything on them not being able to see us and not having scanners. If they have anything to detect unseen objects then we might as well be served on a silver platter to the Horde."

"Let me guess, there is no plan B?"

"I honestly still can't believe you guys would come up with a back up plan. Always seemed like you didn't know what you were doing," Catra states. When Glimmer shoots her a glare, she puts her hands up in defense. "Sorry. But no. Not really. Like Entrapta said, everything else we try to come up with doesn't come close to winning odds as this plan does. We have to rely on your guys' dumb luck you always seem to have."

"She is right. This is the only idea," Bow pipes up before Glimmer can say anything towards the last sentence. "Before Melog we had nothing. It's our only shot."

Glimmer sighs, defeated. "How long will it take to get there?"

Bow pushes some buttons, turning off the map. "A couple hours. It is probably best to get some rest in. We should all meet back up before we make the attempt. Fair?"

Everyone nods, agreeing to the idea. Glimmer gives Starla her bird back and begins to walk back to her room. Bow offers to walk with her but she tells him she made it to the cockpit just fine, she can get back to her room. Besides, she needs to get back on her feet as soon as possible. She doubts she will find any sleep but driving herself mad thinking about this plan will not get her

anywhere. She makes it halfway towards her quarters when something catches her attention.

Glimmer stops at a door. It is nothing out of the ordinary. It looks the same as all the others in this ship. She more than likely passed it before on her walk to the cockpit, taking little note of it. Now, it beckons to her. She takes a step closer and presses a hand against the panel besides it. The metal door opens with a *swoosh*.

The room is quiet, still, as if time has frozen in place here. Glimmer slowly steps forward, wondering what this place is. In the dark she sees a bed, neatly made. All the ends are tuck into place and the sheets have been smoothed out, leaving no crease at all. A bag sits at the edge of the bed, waiting for its owner to return and spill out whatever is inside. Drawing closer, a new item appears in the line of sight. Made into a neat square, rest a red jacket. Part of a uniform. The belt that accompanies it lays nearby. Her legs nearly give out at the sight.

"Adora…" Glimmer exhales. She reaches down and grabs the jacket, one of many the blonde keeps in her wardrobe. Despite it being a piece of the Horde, the familiarity of the fabric was something Adora always clung onto in a world that was always new and changing around her. Carefully, the queen unravels the jacket, holding the clothing tight in her hands. Her body begins to shake.

She places her nose in the center, inhaling deeply. The scents of the outside world floods her senses. Pine, sandalwood, patchouli. She is transported into the forest. The place Adora loves to train and be in, hating to be trapped inside the castle walls. Glimmer can see her in her mind, breaking a sweat. Her lively laugh, one with a snort despite her best efforts, fills her ears after she tells a joke. It is so full of life, happiness, and *love*. When was the last time she heard that from her? Her pure, uncensored laugh that could make anyone stop and listen to it. When was the last time she saw her light up so much she could put the brilliant, shining Moonstone of Brightmoon to shame?

Glimmer exhales, pulling the jacket away from her nose. She is back in the cold, empty bedroom. A noose begins to form around her neck, tightening as every second passes by. Her vision begins to blur as she struggles to hold back the torrent of tears in her eyes. Will she ever get to see that piece of Adora again or is this all that is left of the girl who ran away with her heart?

She takes a deep breath, holding back the tears. There is no time for that. Glimmer allows only a few drops to trickle down her face, releasing some pressure building up inside of her. She quickly gets rid of them with her arm and turns her attention to the bag sitting alone on the bed. Should she take a peek inside? It is not great to look at one's buried possessions but when will Adora return, if ever? Maybe there might be something in there that could help them somehow as they draw closer to Etheria. Adora always came prepared for almost anything. Maybe there is something else in there she could hold onto. The gods know she needs that right about now.

After a few more moments of deliberation, she takes a seat on the bed, the jacket draped over her lap, and reaches for the bag, pulling it close. It has some weight to it. Inside she finds some tools like duct tape that looks as if it has already been used, some extra rations of food and water, and the staff Adora has been using in lieu of her sword. Glimmer reaches in and pulls it out. With a click, it expands, ready for combat. Adora had to go unarmed when she attempted to rescue Catra. That sure backfired in her face. With another click, the weapon shrinks back into a carriable size.

Glimmer shifts around some more, not much to note until she brushes against something at the bottom. Her fingers curl around it and she fishes it out. In her palm is a golden color bracelet, one that you can easily manipulate. Stretch and pull in all directions. In the middle of it rest a purple crescent moon that you spin around. All of the air in the queen's lung escapes her at the sight of the jewelry. She gave it to Adora long, long ago. A bit after they became friends. The gift was to help busy the blonde's hands when she became overwhelmed by something and burn off the

negative energy. It also was the first gift that Glimmer ever gave her. Possibly, it is the first gift Adora ever got in her life.

Adora kept it. She brought it along on this mission to rescue the queen. Glimmer hasn't seen this in a while and begun to assume with all the fighting between them, she rid herself of the gift. Her stomach twisted into a tight knot. Why did she ever think Adora would do something like that? She owes her so many apologies. She needs to get out of this room before she bursts into tears.

She begins to put everything away and leave and is just about to drop the bracelet back in the bag when a voice catches her attention. "I thought you were heading back into your room. What are you doing here?"

Glimmer looks up and finds Catra standing in the door frame, holding herself. Melog's head peers around her legs, their ears flat against their head, matching the magicat's. Glimmer ends up shoving the bracelet in her pocket before she stands up, setting aside the jacket. "None of your business."

"I am just trying to check up on you. No need to get snippy, Sparkles."

"I couldn't care less about that right now, Catra. In case you haven't noticed, everything has gone to shit! Horde Prime has an iron grip on Etheria and who knows what is going on down on the planet. Oh, and *ya know!* He fucked with Adora's mind and had her nearly fuckin' murder me!"

Glimmer notices Melog jerk back and seemingly grow smaller. Catra stands firm as she speaks. "Oh yes, I *so* couldn't see that or guess we were fuck when Bow and I found you on death's door. So is this my 'thank you' for that?"

"I don't have time to fight with you. What do you want?"

"I was just walking around and saw the door open. Is that a crime?"

“No.” Glimmer retorts. “Now if you excuse me, I am going back into my room.” She begins to stagger out of the room. Catra doesn’t attempt to stop her, even as the queen bumps into her. Glimmer gets a few feet down the hall when the magicat speaks again.

“You know, Glimmer...You have every right to be pissed at me for all the shit I did but I want to save Adora just as much as you. Fighting isn’t gonna help us. It’s the least we can do to repay Adora for risking her ass for both of us.”

Glimmer hears the echo of steps fill the room before slowly disappearing. Once the hall becomes quiet, she runs a hand down her face. Catra, for once, is right. There is no need for fighting right now. Tempers have to be kept until more of the dust settles down. In a couple shot hours, the attempt to get back on Etheria will take place. Everyone needs all the rest they can get before this occurs. Hopefully she can find some.

The ship soon comes to a stop in the outskirts of Etheria. Glimmer stares out the window, her eyes fixated on the colorful marble in the distance surrounded by hundreds of ships. Her throat is dry and she feels the palms of her hands begin to sweat at the sight. Everything is hinging on the hope Melog can make the whole of Darla invisible and they can punch their way through the blockade. Her nerves run wild, firing off like someone got their hands on a box of fireworks and is setting them off willy-nilly. She may have gotten in only five minutes of rest before her mind decided not to shut up. Now that everyone is here and the final preparations are finishing up, maybe she can finally catch a break.

It will be drawing close to three days now that Adora has been in the control of Horde Prime. Three days to long. Once Glimmer can get her feet on Etherian soil and take a rest, she will stop at nothing to get the blonde back. This idea everyone came up with *has* to work.

Bow step up next to her, placing a hand on her shoulder. It is time. Everyone watches with bated breath as the ship's engines come back to life and Melog uses their powers, turning everything invisible. The second they cannot be seen to the naked eye, Darla blast forward, shooting through an opening in the blockage. No one on board the ships around the plant seem to notice what is going on. Back in the atmosphere of Etheria, everyone releases the air trapped in their lungs.

"I can't believe that fuckin' work," Catra is the first to say.

"Home," Glimmer says. They're one step closer to getting back Adora.

The Return

Chapter Notes

> heyo another chapter. I will say that probably the night before on my tumblr ill have something saying if i'll update that week or not depending how far I am with the queues. Anyway this is so far one of my longest chapters so hopefully y'all enjoy it. The only thing i can really think of of a warning is some like self doubt/hatred later on

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Etheria has become quiet. Even after over a two decades long war, the people of the planet always tried to find a way to find a light to fend off the darkness that always surrounded them. Parities, telling stories of old, or fighting a good fight and refusing to give up no matter that cost. Adora never got bored whenever she visited a village and a smile always managed to find its way across her face. It always was fun to learn new things from years of being in the Horde or just get away from the responsibilities that came with her role as She-ra and attempt to relax for once in her life. But now there is nothing of the sorts. No life cannot be found at all. Not even the birds sing as Adora walks through the forest. The blonde no longer cares about such things anyway.

She looks around, trying to locate anything, her face obscured by the hood over her head. Her glowing green eyes scan the area, spotting nothing but the thick foliage of the Whispering Woods. Adora squints, hoping something will pop their head out and show themselves. Horde Prime does not like anyone to slip through his fingers. According to others, some stragglers from a village recently brought into his light have been spotted in this area. Adora has been sent to search for them, already starting to have a track record for capturing runaways, and bring them back to her brother. She is determined to make him proud and prove herself. It does not matter if she has been walking for hours now, she will find them.

The snap of a twig catches her attention. A grin forms on her face as she begins to stalk over to a set bushes. One hand hovers over the sword on her side. Finally, it is time for some fun. There has been a lack of excitement. When she is only a couple feet away, something darts out. Adora quickly side steps, expecting this. A young boy appears, a broken metal pole in his hands. The blonde is quick to knock him off his feet, slashing a wound into his leg for good measure. The boy hits the ground hard, holding back a cry of pain. He will not be going anywhere any time soon.

Pathetic boy, a voice in her head says. She steps forward, hoping for a quick and easy capture. Adora wonders how this boy was able to stay hidden for so long. He is nothing more than a child. Doesn't matter much now. Her work is complete and he too will be able to see what good Horde Prime can bring and why running is pointless. She is about to reach down and restrain him when another noise catches her attention.

Adora turns around just in time for another boy, roughly the same age and looking similar to the first, bolting out. She wastes no time in blocking an attack from his pole with her sword. With all her might, the blonde flings him back. He manages to stay on his feet, staring her down with fire in his eyes. Adora wonders if there is a third brother who will appear to try and strike her down. Even if there is, that will not be an issue. The two look no older than thirteen or fourteen. This should be an easy fight.

The second boy charges once more, arms raised as he attempts to land a blow on his opponent. Adora blocks again, barely even blinking. Before the boy can react, she knees him hard in the stomach, knocking all the wind out of him. The boy gasps and collapses to the ground, dropping his weapon.

Is this really all Etheria has to offer? No wonder why they need to always ask you for help no matter how trivial the problem was, the voice in Adora's head says.

Adora scoffs as she walks forward. The voice is right. Why did she ever defend a people like this? How did they never learn how to

defend themselves at all? Always had to save them no matter what.

She kneels down and reaches into the bag at her side, pulling out a rope and a small device. With a click, the gadget in her hands starts to beep. In a matter of minutes, more of Horde Prime's army will come and take them away. All Adora has to do is hold them still until they arrive.

"You damn bastard," the uninjured boy spats at her. "Horde Prime won't win, ya know that? We will stop you!"

Adora tightens his restraints before moving onto his brother. The other boy winces as she ties the rope right around his injured leg. She then forces both of them to sit up and places them back to back. The uninjured boy keeps his gazes on her, eyes still burning with hatred.

"She-ra will stop you! You will be screwed once she appears. She'll kick your ass!"

Adora starts to laugh. It is deep and cold, one that can easily send ice down someone's spine. Anyone who knows her would be taken aback and be horrified by the sound coming out of her mouth. It does not belong to her at all. She stands up and removes the hood from her head. All the color drains from the boys' faces as they look up in horror to see their hero standing in front of them. Despite not being in her warrior form, her face is still well-known to all those in Etheria. This is not the first time she has gotten this reaction and a dark grin forms on her face.

" *I don't think she will be saving you anytime soon,* " Adora says, her voice sounding exactly like Horde Prime.

Adora makes her way down the slick corridor. Clones walk past her, neither speaking to each other. She keeps her eyes ahead as she draws closer and closer to where Horde Prime waits for her. By now, he will have heard about her capture of the runaways. He

will be pleased that she has never failed him yet in these endeavors. There also is something else, however. Once she had finished her mission, he summoned her back to the ship. That is about as far as she knows.

She steps into his chambers. It is large, sleek, and white. Prime sits on a chair set in the middle of the room and on a large staircase. Resting in front of it is a large screen with multiple images playback. Looking at the video feed, Adora sees robots and clones marching through villages (some of which burn), Etherians being chipped, and people running for their lives. Adora doesn't so much bat an eye as she continues to step forward, not even as one part of the screen shows herself taking down the two young teenage boys.

Horde Prime spins in his chair as Adora draws closer. When she is a few feet away, Adora kneels down, bowing to her brother.

"Rise. You have done well, little sister," Horde Prime says. He stands and begins walking towards Adora. "You have become quite the valuable asset. How do you feel right now? Happy you can finally get back to a world that used you?"

Adora pulls herself to her feet and nods. If Horde Prime had eyebrows, they would be raised. "You are quite the quiet one. Such a difference from when you first came to me. Does not matter. What I honestly wonder about is how you can become She-ra."

He touches a cold hand to her face. Adora's body jerks and becomes tense, a reaction caused from long ago scars left by people she thought "loved" her, as he moves across the cheek and down and around her neck. She feels him tapping against the chip embedded on the base of her neck. Since her fight with the queen, it has been repaired and fixed. Horde Prime has ensured this one will not be easily broken. He begins to rub it as he thinks out loud.

"I know she is in there. You have summoned her once before when you thought you could not. When I searched through your memories to get to know you better, I saw her. Something about this place called Beast Island? The weak queen of yours, despite hurting you so deeply, you kept thinking about her? Somehow, *she* summoned She-ra in you. I wonder if she can do it again, despite the circumstances."

Without so much as a warning, something sharp pierces Adora's neck.

Adora walks through the courtyard of Brightmoon, humming a tune as she goes. Birds chirp alongside her, singing their own songs. The blonde can't help but watch them as they fly around high in the sky or hop around the ground, searching for any worms to chow down on. She even spots some rabbits and chipmunks scurrying around. Everyone seems out and about. After all, it is gorgeous outside. Only a few clouds slowly swim across the bright, crystal blue sky. The sun warms everyone who ventures out but does not bake them. Whenever the wind picks up, it is a cooling and comforting breeze. It is a picture perfect day.

She continues her walk down a smooth, white pathway, looking at all the sights around her. Adora spots Bow playing with some children who have wandered onto the grounds from a nearby village. The gaggle of five and six-year-olds chase him around a grassy field. Once they catch up to him, they all jump on him, bringing him to the ground, laughter filling the air. Adora smiles at the sight.

Looking around more, she then locates Catra, or rather her arm and tail. They are the only thing visible as she snoozes on a branch in a tree. The magicat has worked hard and long to make up for the things she has done and now the two have repaired their relationship. Part of Adora wants to stray from where she is heading, go up to the tree and spook Catra for the hell of it. She decides against it, however. Let her friend have a nice nap.

Finally, she spots Angella and Micah. By many strokes of luck, not only has Micah been able to return to his home but Angella as well. While Glimmer has remained on the throne, the two are never far away, always willing to help their daughter when she needs it or take over for some days to allow for relaxation. For now, they have been catching up on many years apart. Both husband and wife rest on a balcony overlooking the courtyard. When they spot Adora walking down below, they wave at her. Adora grins and returns the gesture.

Now there is only one person left to find. Walking down the pathway, she soon comes to the end. It has led her to a field of flowers of all shapes, sizes and colors. They dot the courtyard in a vibrant rainbow, welcoming anyone to enter. Adora slowly makes her way through, careful not to trample on any of them. Those that are tall enough, she runs her hands against, feeling the soft petals brush against her fingertips. Some friendly bees buzz past her on their way to pollinate the field, keeping it alive and looking brilliant. Towards the middle of the meadow, she finds who she has been looking for.

Glimmer sits in a patch of purple, bell shaped flowers. Looking closer at them, Adora can see shiny, black, round berries attached to the steams. As she gets closer to her girlfriend, she sees that Glimmer has one of the flowering plants in her hands, twirling it around in her fingers. Adora settles down next to her, sitting cross legged and leaning back slightly. "Took me forever to find you," she says.

Glimmer snorts. "I am sitting out in the open, how hard was it to find me? You must suck at hide-and-seek."

"Shut up. I'll have you know I am pretty good at searching for people! I was just taking in all the sights. Anyway, what are these? I don't think I have ever seen them."

Glimmer plucks one of the shining berries off the plant and rolls it between her fingers, studying it. "Belladonna. It means 'Beautiful Lady'."

"So like you?"

Glimmer gives her a playful shove. "Dork."

"Ah come on, you love me!"

"Somehow, yes."

Adora chuckles before placing a peck on Glimmer's cheek. She still has no idea how she got to be so lucky to have Glimmer as her other half but she is not about to question it. As she pulls away, she winces. The back of her neck begins to tingle and no amount of rubbing it is making it go away.

"Are you okay, love?" Glimmer asks, concern filling her eyes.

"Yeah. Yeah I am just fine, Glim. My neck just started to itch. Gods, I don't know why it won't go away. Did a bug bite me or something?"

Glimmer shifts so she can look behind Adora. "None that I can see."

"Weird...So, uh, what are you up to? Besides chilling out here."

"Eh, not much. Just relaxing. Did you want to do something?" When Adora shrugs, Glimmer begins to tap a finger on her chin and clicks her tongue in thought. "Not really sure either. Hm...Oh! Ya know what I haven't seen in a while? She-ra!"

"She-ra?" Adora asks. She thinks. When was the last time she became the warrior princess? She remembers being her when attempting to stop Light Hope from unleashing all the magic from the Heart of Etheria. But she sacrificed the sword, thus She-ra, so the destruction of the world could be stopped. Yet, there was that time when helping out the Star Siblings. She felt the power of She-ra coursing through her body, giving her the strength and energy to do anything she could put her mind to. It felt amazing to feel like she was on top of the world again and nothing could stop her.

But everything is jumbled up after that. Her eyebrows knit together as she struggles to pull something from her mind. No matter how hard she tires, nothing comes up. She rubs her neck more, threatening to turn the skin red. The feeling of panic slowly creeps across her body. Why can't she remember anything?

"Hey." Glimmer's soft voice breaks through her train of thoughts. A hand squeezes her shoulder and brings her back down to the ground. "Everything alright?"

"It's nothing. I...I just don't remember how I can be She-ra without the sword," Adora tells her. "I really hope my memory problems aren't getting worse."

"Hm. Well I can't say I know how you do it. You just...do but I can try to help. I got you to do it before, didn't I? My dad and Bow told me all about Beast Island."

Adora feels her face become warm. Beast Island. When she was at a low point with dark vines wrapping around her body and sucking any warmth and happiness out of her. Before she gave in and allowed for that feeling of hopelessness and numbness to fully take over, memories of her time with Glimmer flooded her mind and gave her the will and strength to fight back and find She-ra once more. She still doesn't understand how it happened. But if it happened before maybe it can happen again.

"Thank you, Glimmer."

"Glimmer…" Adora whispers as the sharp feeling in her neck disappears. She gasps and pulls away, a hand resting where she felt the sensation. Her head turns towards Horde Prime.

"No need to overload you. I might want She-ra but if you become incapacitated then it will be all for not. As your brother, I do need to keep my little sister well and happy. But this is a start, putting it in your head. In due time we will summon She-ra. For now, I think I will keep you at my side and away from others. No need to

let anyone somehow slip away and alert the world about you. Come."

Adora nods and draws her arm back down to her side. She follows him towards his chair and stands next to him as he takes a seat. Her hand twitches, momentarily summoning a flash of light, as her mind digs for an answer how to become She-ra.

Glimmer takes a step off of the ship, gingerly placing her foot on the ground. A part of her wishes to not have her boots on and feel the soft grass between her toes. She has no idea how long she was trapped on Horde Prime's ship in the middle of space but it was far too long. The warmth and comfort of returning to her home planet pushes the thoughts of the cold and lonely cell away from her mind. Between the overwhelming joy of being home and the injury on her leg, it feels like she is about to collapse. Glimmer pushes her weight onto her crutch, keeping herself steady.

"Perfuma said our new base camp is nearby. Hopefully we are still in the clear," Bow states, looking at a communication pad in his hands. He then turns his gaze towards Glimmer. "How are you feeling?"

"I will be alright," Glimmer tells him. "Do we have any idea who is there?" She wonders if her father is there. Now knowing that he has been alive this whole time, she hopes that he hasn't been taken away for real. There is so much she wishes to tell him and ask him. What will he think of her? So much runs through her mind. The last thing she wants is to lose someone else before she can tell them what she always wanted to say.

Bow shakes his head. "No. We have to be careful with communication. She only gave me location and even then I had to decode them. We should get moving."

The group follows Bow through the Whispering Woods, taking extra precaution not to be spotted. Glimmer stays in the middle of the pack, Tallstar on her left and Melog on her right, tailing Catra

in front of her. Bow and Entrapta take the head while Jewelstar and Starla bring up the rear. Every step taken, someone is scanning the area. No one likes the eerie quiet that hangs over them. It's like anything can pop out of nowhere at any moment.

Bow announces they are drawing close. Glimmer wonders what everyone is up to. Who might be at the campsite and if everyone is okay. She hopes that her aunt or father are there. She wants to see the faces of her family again and be wrapped in their arms. Her heart starts to race in her chest as they are about to break through the forest brush.

The next thing anyone knows, Frosta pops out of the blue, her fist encased in a large sheet of ice. No one has anytime to react before she connects with the side of Catra's face, sending her flying backwards. Everyone jerks in surprise. Melog's tail and mane puff up and they meow in shock. Catra remains on the ground, holding her cheek, and groaning.

"Holy shit," Glimmer says. Part of her is upset that Frosta quite literally beat her to the punch with Catra. She turns her head towards the youngest princess. Frosta has both her hands and ice. Her eyes are trained on Catra, waiting for the magicat to stand up again.

"What are you doing here, Horde Scum?" she shouts. "Trying to lead Prime to us?!?"

"Woah! Forsta! Put those away!" Bow says. He steps in between her and Catra, who now is sitting up and has Melog licking her face.

"Why?!? ...Who the hell are these people?!?"

"Friends." Tallstar steps forward. She puts her hands up as she kneels down in front of the young girl. "We are here to help. You are a brave one for jumping out like that all by yourself."

Frosta narrows her eyes, still unsure. "Well...I have to protect my friends!" She then looks at Bow. "Are they friends?"

“Yes. That is Tallstar and over there is her brother Jewelstar and her sister Starla. And Catra is helping us right now. She is on our side.”

Before anyone can say anything else, Perfuma appears. She looks ready to attack but drops her fist when she sees everyone. “You’re back! Oh thank the gods you are safe! What is going on here?”

“We can explain later. Right now, we need some help.” Bow gestures to Glimmer. The queen gives a small wave, wishing he didn’t do that. She will be fine with some rest and in a few days time with her body's speedy healing ability. There is no need to worry and fuss.

“Oh, Glimmer. What happened?” Perfuma asks, fret written all over her face. She begins to look around, quickly realizing something is amidst. “Where is Adora?”

The air becomes heavy. No one answers the nature princess right away, their eyes falling to the ground below them. Even if Glimmer wanted to answer her, she finds she cannot do so. Her throat has tightened so much, the only she can do is stagger air in and out of her body. If it wasn’t for the crutch under keeping her up, she probably would be on the ground, her legs unable to keep her weight. With her free hand, she places it on her stomach. She can still feel the cold, metallic blade inside of her.

“It’s...a long story, Flower Crown,” Catra breaks the silence. She slowly strides up to the group, her cheek a bright, angry red. “There is not enough time to explain everything out in the open like this.”

“O-Oh. Well, come.”

Everyone follows. The place where the Rebellion has set up camp is surrounded by the thick brush of the Whispering Woods. Small buildings scatter the clearing. Some have been here for a long time, built with the intent to stay, while others look like they can easily be knocked down and move around. People walk around

the site, taking a look at the group passing through with curious eyes. Some sharpen weapons, others eat or sleep, and some nurse injuries. Everyone looks defeated. Glimmer hears whispers forming. Those of joy in seeing the queen of Brightmoon returning home and those of wonder where She-ra is. She tunes them out.

Once inside a stone structured, everyone settles in. Perfuma brings everyone tea. Glimmer thanks her but does not drink the hot liquid. Rather, she rolls the cup between her hands, soaking in the warm. Bow, Entrapta, Catra, and the Star Siblings recount everything that has happened over the past few days. Glimmer's mind starts to wander as they speak, not wanting to hear everything once more.

She stares down at the liquid in her hands, her tired reflection glares back at her. Glimmer swears that her mirrored self narrows her lilac eyes, looking with anger in them. She can hear a voice in her mind, asking her why she is just sitting here doing nothing, why she is so powerless to do anything. She couldn't stop the Heart of Etheria, she couldn't stop herself from being captured or free herself, she couldn't save Adora.

How can you be so pathetic? You are nothing like your mother, a voice grows louder in her mind. The room becomes cold and her skin begins to crawl. *You were always a small and ineffective princess with your powers. No matter how hard you try, you always fall flat, don't you?*

It feels like she is drowning. She can't breathe. Something grabs a hold of her and drags her down into a dark, murky depth. Her skin tingles, becoming unbearable, making her want to break out of it. But she is frozen as the voice grows louder and louder, drowning everything else around her.

How will you ever save Adora or stop Horde Prime when you couldn't even defend yourself? You always needed someone to come and save you.

"Shut up," Glimmer mumbles to herself.

You are going to fail just like you did with Salineas. Just like with all the other land the Horde stole while you were cooped up in the castle. You couldn't even figure out who Double Trouble was until it was too late.

"Shut. Up." The cup in her hand begins splashing out the tea. Glimmer ignores the burning sensation on her hand.

Adora needed you and you left her out to dry and look at what happened. Your beacon of hope, the one who wanted to be a hero to you. You'll never be that to her after everything you did.

" *I SAID SHUT UP!"*

"GLIMMER!"

Glimmer snaps her head up. She finds Perfuma kneeling in front of her, worry written all over her face. The sensation in her hand becomes unbearable and she shifts her drink, holding her aching body part in her mouth. That is when she realizes the cup is missing half the tea and a crack has formed on the side. Everyone is looking at her with concern. Even Catra stands close by, her dual colored eyes staring in shock and her mouth agape.

"Hey. Glimmer. Are you there?" Perfuma asks.

Glimmer takes a moment to ground herself. She presses her feet hard on the floor, inhales deeply, and brings herself back into reality. Removing her hand from her mouth she says, "Yes. Sorry."

"Are you okay?" Bow asks, "You scared us there."

"I don't want to talk about it."

"Are you sure?"

"Yes. I am. What is going on? Are we planning anything?"

"Not yet. We are working on it but right now we are just going to share information and piece things out together."

Great, more not finding Adora. "Alright."

Glimmer tosses and turns in her sleep. Fingers tightly grip the fabric around her. Beads of sweat line her forehead and her breathing comes out staggered. A whimper escapes her lips as her mind betrays her. She sought out the nothingness of sleep but she ended up finding a horror show. It started off bad but only got worse and worse. The fighting she had with Adora. Feeling left alone when she needed her the most. That last fight before the Heart and then being captured. Horde Prime looming and threatening presences hovering over her, able to do whatever he wants with a snap of his fingers. Locked alone in a cell with nothing more than her thoughts and regrets. Adora under his control. The sickening sound of her laugh causes goosebumps to form on her sink. Her sight becomes red and she can taste iron in her mouth as she feels cold metal break through her abdomen.

The next thing she knows, Glimmer shoots up straight, gasping for air, and pain erupting across her body. She holds her stomach, praying for the feeling of the sword inside of her to disappear. Glimmer grits her teeth, hissing as she exhales. Over and over in her mind she tells herself that what occurred was a nightmare. A playback of what happened to her. Yet, the image of Adora harming her is burned into her mind.

That's not her. That's not her... Glimmer tells herself. *Adora would never do that. Breathe….Breathe...*

Her body slowly starts to relax as she inhales deeply. Once the pain has drained away she removes her hands from her stomach. So much for rest. Glimmer turns her head and looks out the window. Night has turned into day. Sunlight pours into her room. The queen is still unsure of the sun, not used to waking up to the world being this bright and warm. Are other planets like this? How do they deal with it on a day to day basis?

Glimmer shakes the thought from her mind. That is the last thing she should be concerned about. There is much to do today. Many

people are already out on missions, her father and aunt included. So much for seeing them again but a status report should be coming today. Glimmer prays they and everyone else are safe and not chipped. She and the others were informed yesterday that Adora is not alone in being chipped. Many Etherians have been put under the control of Horde Prime. People are beginning not knowing who to trust.

Glimmer will be stuck behind, forced to stay at this base camp, until she can properly walk and fight again. Doesn't help her magic has yet to return. At least she can command others where to go and stay guard here. Better than nothing. But speaking of her injuries, they need to be checked on. A task that cannot be done by herself she gives a call to Perfuma. The princess has promised to stay nearby to help with medical care. In a short amount of time, she arrives and begins to aid the queen.

"How bad does it look?" Glimmer asks after some time. She looks at the injuries as Perfuma works on them. With the little knowledge she has about healing and medicine, the gash on her leg and the stab in her stomach do look like they are healing. They don't bleed and the bandages removed from her body only have tints of red on them. Though, they only looked scabbed over. Shouldn't they not be as horrible to look at? They are red, long, and deep. Even with Perfuma's gentle hands, a simple brush of her fingers causes the queen to twitch. She'll never get to Adora in time at this rate.

"Sorry. But this cream will help, trust me. And from what I was told, it could look worse. You're healing, so that is a good sign. You still shouldn't push yourself too hard."

"I should be healing faster, though, and I can't just sit still right now! You know that!" Glimmer's voice comes out louder than expected, the words getting under her skin.

"Easy, Glimmer!"

"I'm sorry. I shouldn't have yelled."

“I understand. It’s...stressful. Everything going on. I’m worried for Etheria, for my people...for Adora.” Perfuma reaches for the new set of bandages and wraps them around the queen’s battered body. “We will figure something out but we are outnumbered. We have to play smart. I am sure there is something you can do that doesn’t risk more injury. We will get her back, don’t you worry.”

“I’m just so scared. I could barely break through to her before and it didn’t work. What if I can’t next time and she is trapped in his clutches forever?”

“We will find a way. Even if you only got to her for a moment, you still *got through.* There has to be a way to fully get her back and I am sure you will be able to do it. You love her more than anything, right?”

“I’d do *anything* for her.”

Perfuma smiles softly and places a hand on Glimmer's. “Then she will come back.”

The simple gesture breaks off a chip on the heavy weight resting on Glimmer’s heart. “Thank you, Perfuma.

“I am here to help. Now that we patched yourself up, why don’t you get dressed and we can head outside and see what everyone is up to.”

Glimmer nods. She gets dressed as quick as she can. Once ready, she and Perfuma exit the makeshift structure. The late morning light temporarily blinds Glimmer as she steps outside. She blinks it back until her sight becomes clear. Others are already up, walking about where they have made home for now or standing guard on the outskirts. Tallstar is among those keeping an eye on everything while her sister talks to some Etherians. They will only be here for a couple more days before they will move to a new location. Keep the enemy from finding them. As the princess and queen make their way to the main area, Glimmer spots Bow, Jewelstar, Catra already there.

Bow stands near a large table, looking at a map spread out in front of him. Jewelstar does the same, jotting down some notes on a scrap of paper. Catra is off to the side, still nursing her cheek from yesterday. Frosta must have gotten her real good. The magicat is the first to notice the two new beings in the room and walks up to the table, joining Bow. "Took you guys long enough."

"Good morning to you as well, Catra," Glimmer says. She turns her head towards her best friend. "What are you looking at, Bow?"

"Seeing what a good location for our next base will be. Better plan it now before we leave. Been a bit difficult."

Glimmer looks down at the map. Nearly the whole map is colored a bright shade of red. Only a select handful are green. She notices some of it has been highlighted over by the red. A lump begins to form in her throat. "Have you heard back from anyone else?"

"Only a handful. Your father and aunt said their scouting mission was going just fine and should be back tomorrow. Scorpia said she had a run in but was able to handle it herself. No one else has said anything, though."

Glimmer hears Perfuma sigh a breath of relief at the statement. The queen is happy to hear both the good news of her friend and the rest of her family are handling themselves just fine. Still, it is worrisome not to know how the others are. Hopefully, they are all okay and will somehow manage to get word to them. Frosta is among the princesses who have stayed behind at base camp. She most likely is still sleeping. The young girl definitely deserves it. However, she will need to rise soon. She and Perfuma will be heading out to help villages not yet overrun by Horde Prime's armies. Less of stopping them and more of evacuating everyone as his army draws close.

"That's good. What are you planning on doing, Catra?"

"Help you figure out a plan attack. This is the Horde after all. Even if it's not Hordak, he had to learn it from somewhere. Maybe we

can figure something out that Prime is planning."

"The more heads the better," Bow says.

"Yeah...Thanks," Glimmer says.

"Well, I am going to go get ready," Perfuma begins to tell the trio. "Hopefully Frosta will be ready by the time I am done. If everything goes according to plan, we should meet up with you elsewhere. Once we are done we will figure out something to send to you guys to ask where you are."

"Stay safe," Glimmer says.

"Don't worry. I will see you guys soon."

" *Come on, Adora. I know you can do it!" Glimmer says, trying to pump up her girlfriend.*

Adora concentrates as hard as she can, focusing all of her energy and might into thinking of becoming She-ra. Her dominant arm is outstretched, thinking about the smooth metal in her fingers. She tries to remember the feeling of being the warrior princess. The magic coursing through her veins, the strength in her muscles, and the joy it always brought to her heart. For a moment, she can feel something bubbling inside of her chest, like a warm ball. It begins to spread, entering her shoulders and top of her abdomen. She can see something forming in front of her but as if someone has snapped their fingers, it disappears.

Adora growls and runs her hands down her face in frustration. She was so close this time. She can still taste the feeling on her lips. Why is she even attempting this? There is no way She-ra can be summoned without the sword, which wherever the shattered remains are is still a mystery to the blonde. Yet, Glimmer keeps insisting on it. Keeps saying she can do it. Even with the support of her girlfriend, Adora cannot shake the growing feeling inside of her that she will continue to fail.

"That was really close that time! You're getting better at it!" Glimmer says. "I know you can do it!"

"Why do you think that? Every time I get close, she slips right through my fingers! I think holding onto oil is easier than holding onto her."

"Let me think." Glimmer begins to pace, tapping a finger to her chin, her violet eyes shut. Adora watches her think and rolls her own eyes. She wonders how the queen will ever come up with anything. How can anyone? The last time she became close to becoming She-ra again, she still doesn't understand how it happened. All she knows is she wanted to protect her friends from harm. But the world is at peace now. There is no more threat. If only she could remember how the Horde was defeated. She had to have become the warrior princess to win unless everyone just got lucky. Why can't she remember it? The frustration of not being able to turn into her grows and the confused thoughts don't help. Something doesn't feel right.

All of a sudden, Glimmer drapes her arms around Adora's shoulder, locking them behind her. The queen pulls herself up, pressing their lips together. For a moment, Adora becomes tense, not expecting the gesture, but quickly her body relaxes. Fireworks explode in her body and she feels light as air. Her own hands find their way to the queen's back, pulling her even closer. The heat from her body comforts Adora, reminding her of everything that is right in the world. What was she thinking about again?

"What was that for?" Adora asks when they break their lips apart, their arms still wrapped around each other.

A sly grin appears on Glimmer's face. "I thought a kiss might work. Give you a little pick me up and remind you how special and wonderful you are. How do you feel?"

"Like I am on top of the world. Your kisses are always amazing!"

"Well, if you become She-ra, you can get some more. Hero."

Adora feels her heart pump in her chest. A kiss is always a great bribe. She nods and the two pull away. Feeling a new surge of energy she stands tall and proud. Nothing can ever go wrong when Glimmer is around. Not to mention, it is a little fun to show off a bit to the queen. Sticking out her arm, all her thoughts go into becoming She-ra. The warm feeling in her chest forms and spreads, never ending and reaching every inch of her body. It explodes out of her.

Horde Prime stares at her in wonder. The chip remains intact in the back of the blonde's neck. Adora stares blankly at him, a dark sword gripped tightly in her grip. Prime circles her, taking in how she looks. At first glance, she does not look much different than all the other times she became She-ra. Tall, nearly meeting Horde Prime in height, muscular, and emanating power and strength. But upon blinking and getting over the fact you are looking at She-ra, things take on a different look.

Upon closer examination, this is not the case. Her blonde hair remains short, unable to flow behind her. The once golden colors of She-ra's uniform now shine a bright green. The wings on the crown that sits on top of her head bear a resemblance to those of bats. A cape around her waist, the inside a dark grey, reaches down to the ground. Another piece of fabric attached to the front of her belt falls to nearly the same length. Finally, bits of metal cover her fingers, looking like claws. She looks less like She-ra and more like another Prime.

"Wonderful," Horde Prime says, grinning from ear to ear. "Wonderful! I knew she was in there somewhere. You just needed a little help from the queen. You really do care so much about her. I am amused by it. Now let's see what you can do."

Adora marches her way through the woods, an army of robots and clones trudging behind her. A village draws closer and closer. Prime wants it captured. She will not fail him. There is no room for error or mistakes. The quicker she gets this done the better.

The people of Etheria have been stubborn and a pain in the ass to conquer. Still, every little bit counts and she will not let her brother down.

When she is yards away, there is the sound of an explosion behind her. Adora whips her head around to see not only a large sheet of ice has formed but large, thick vines wrap around robots, crushing them under their weight. She grits her teeth. Horde Prime warned her about the princesses and how much of a nuisance they are. The queen of Brightmoon already was a handful. Now there are more. Guess they decided to attempt to protect good for nothing town. Adora looks around, trying to find them. Ice starts to speed towards her, threatening to freeze her in place. When it comes close, she swings out her sword, shattering the frozen water and stopping it in its tracks.

"I won't let you get to this village!" a young sounding voice says. A small child with short, dark blue hair appears out from a sheet she has created. "You're not gonna-Holy shit!"

"Frosta! Watch your-" a new princess, taller and with long, pale blonde hair, appears. "Oh my gods. Adora…"

Adora uses their shock to her advantage. She lunges, ready to strike them down. Before she can get close, the taller princess unleashes large vines that wrap around Adora's body. They squeeze her tightly, holding her in place. She grunts, using all her might to free herself from the princess' grasp.

"Adora. It's us! Perfuma and Frosta!" the taller one shouts. "We're your friends! Not your enemy! Please stop!"

Her plea goes unheard. With a swift move of her arm, Adora snaps off a vine and uses her sword to cut through the rest. Not wasting a moment, she charges at them. Perfuma shoves Frosta out of the way, only having milliseconds to defend herself. More vines pushes the blonde back. A growl escapes her. These princesses really are annoying. Thankfully, the rest of the army is

closing in. A dark chuckle begins to come out of Adora at the sight.

“What do we do?!?” Frosta asks. She sends another wave of ice across the ground, breaking a whole line of robots. They are quickly replaced. “This is bad. This is bad.”

Adora steps forward. She must put a stop to them. Get them to stop being such a bother. They are the reasons why Horde Prime hasn’t been able to take control as fast as he would like. They should be done away with like the queen but that is a last resort. The princesses are the key to tapping into the magic Prime desires. With one already missing from the equation, the more alive the better.

She watches as Perfuma suddenly wraps plants around the young girl and throws her back through an opening, away from She-ra and the army. Before Frosta can do or say anything, more vines appear, blocking her path.

“Go!” Perfuma shouts. There is no room for arguments in her voice. “We can’t win! Get as many villagers as you can and back to the others and warn them!”

“But-”

“Someone has to warn them! I’ll be fine just go, Frosta!”

Frosta hesitates for a moment before she darts into the woods. Damn it. Someone finally got past her. Horde Prime will not be pleased that she failed him. Her sights on the remaining princess. Perfuma stands ready to fight.

The princess lunges. Sword and plant meet. Perfuma tries all her might to push Adora off her feet but it fails. Adora digs her heels into the ground, standing her ground. She lashes out, swings her sword in an attempt to incapacitate her. Perfuma darts out of the way, the tip of the blade slicing part of her hair.

“I am not going to let you hurt anyone else! Adora, Prime, whoever I am talking to right now, you won’t. You won’t keep her forever!” Perfuma shouts.

Adora swings again. The longer this goes on, the more she thinks it is better to just end this once and for all. A way to the magic can still be figured out without the princesses. Perfuma is quick on her feet. Adora thinks, waiting for the right moment to land a perfect hit. When she spots her moment of opportunity, she unleashes a dark wave of magic. The princess is knocked off her feet, hitting the ground hard. The magic explodes near a set of houses. They are set ablaze.

Perfuma coughs as she pulls herself to her arms. Before she can do anything else, Adora reaches her. The blonde grabs the fabric the princess wears and lifts her off the ground. Smoke fills the air and in the background, stragglers unable to make it out in time flee from the flames and army. Adora keeps her sights on Perfuma, holding her tight.

“Adora...Adora I know you are in there somewhere. Please listen!” Perfuma begs. Her hands feebly attempt to unlock the fingers wrapped around her. Tears at the edges of her dark eyes refuse to fall. “You are stronger than this! Come back to us! We miss you. Glimmer misses you!”

For a moment, Adora lossens her grip on the princess. She tilts her head, taking in what she just heard. Perfuma continues to talk. “You didn’t kill her, Adora. She is *alive!* She is okay, Adora. And she wants you back. She wants to see you again. We all do. Please...Please come back. Fight it! If for anyone, do it for *her!* Do it for Glimmer! ”

This is interesting, is it not? Etherians really are resilient. Doesn’t change our plans, the voice in Adora’s head says. *Bring her back. We will keep her alive for now.*

The tight grip on Perfuma’s shirt. Her mind rids itself of any thoughts that might have been forming in her head, preventing

them from going any deeper. All that she can think of now is bringing Perfuma to Horde Prime.

Chapter End Notes

so my friend CountDorku helped me with the controlled she ra design cause I suck at it. He has his own story which was recently competed but has like another part being worked on that just started that is on his bio but aksgjabsgaj read the first one first. Anyway again, updates will depending how i feel with how far I am so my tumblr will be good to look at to see if it will get updated next week.

Comments and kudos are always welcomed

Messages

Chapter Notes

> another chapter woo! okay so it might actually be on a two week update for a bit cause I am working on an upcoming glimmadora week event so that has been eating away at time and the chapter I am working on now might be pretty long or least meaty/heavy so it will take time. sorry if this one is also a little shorter
>
> so yeah hopefully y'all enjoy. still doing my best trying to write a chapter fic so as always kudos and comments are appreciated

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The day drags on, each hour feeling like two. Glimmer zones in and out of reality. She does her best to listen to where everyone will be moving next to keep Horde Prime off their tails but she will have to ask Bow about it again later. There is something in there about Mermista and Sea Hawk, who have been keeping an eye on Brightmoon. Whatever Catra says Prime could be planning becomes static in her head. She is well aware she should listen to what the magicat has to say about the new Horde army but honest to the gods, she does not want to hear her voice. At some point, the queen finds herself back in her tent, starting up at the ceiling. She can’t quite remember how she got here but there is something about not really being hungry in her memory.

By early evening, Glimmer decides to go see what Entrapta is up to. She has not seen the science princess since coming to this camp, having darted off to conduct experiments. The queen finds her towards the end of the area in her own tent. Inside, wires, pieces of metal, and tools like wrenches and screwdrivers are all scattered across the room. It is like a maze to walk over. Entrapta is at a table, her back turned to Glimmer. In both her hair and

hands, are parts of a Horde robot. Careful not to trip and fall over the mess, she slowly makes her way to the older woman.

“What are you doing, Entrapta?” Glimmer asks. She looks at the table. More robotic parts are placed haphazardly on the wood. Some in bits, some together, some looking like Entrapta is running tests on them. Just looking at it and trying to figure out the science behind it all gives Glimmer a small headache. “You having fun here?”

“Oh yes I am! All this tech is so new and interesting!” Entrapta states. “I could look at them for hours. I wish I could get my hands on more of these.”

“You still need to tell me what you are doing.”

“Oh! Right. I am trying to see if I can find any information out of their memory bank. See if we can learn anything on where Horde Prime will attack next or if there is anything we can use against him. I haven't found anything yet, however.”

Glimmer frowns. “Great…”

“Don’t you worry! I will figure something out and Horde Prime won’t know what hit him!”

Entrapta grins from ear to ear. If anyone can figure out how these robots work and get some use out of them, it is her. Any foothold the Rebellion can get they will take. Glimmer can’t help but feel a little better, knowing that the other princess might be able help turn the tides in this hell they find themselves in.

“Hey,” Glimmer starts. She picks up a piece of broken metal and tosses it back and forth in her hands, wondering what it could be. “Do you need any help? I’m kind of useless right now. I might not know much about tech bu-”

“Of course I would love help!” Entrapta shouts, taking Glimmer off guard. “And don’t worry about not knowing anything! I will guide

you along. Now do you mind getting that screwdriver over there?”

Glimmer blinks, coming back from the shock of being cut off so suddenly. Once she can think properly, she nods. The rest of the day becomes a little more clear. Most of the time she has no idea what is coming out of the older princess’ mouth, she probably has a better understanding of First One’s writing, but Entrapta seems happy just to have ears listening to her. Night soon falls and Glimmer finds herself starting to doze off. She excuses herself and heads off back into her tent.

Sleep does not come easily. Another night of tossing and turning. Images of Prime sinister smile and Adora’s lifeless, glowing green eyes fill in her mind, haunting her. She feels the cold hand of Prime on her cheek and hears his laugh coming out of Adora’s mouth. Soon all that flashes in her head is her battle and defeat against Adora. Upon the second time of waking up with a start, Glimmer decides to simply lay in bed and wait for the morning sun to rise above the horizon. If she has to guess, she probably only got a total of three hours of sleep.

When she grows tired of being in bed doing nothing, Glimmer gets up and heads to the center of camp, seeing if anyone else is up. Most of the people waking about getting ready for the day she does not have a name to the face. Someone looking like they are from Plumeria offers her something to eat for breakfast. Glimmer accepts it and nibbles on it, more so to have something to chew on since her stomach doesn’t seem to care if it receives food or not. During her walk, she finds one familiar figure by a small fire. Catra.

The magicat sits near the dying flames, her legs drawn close to her chest with arms wrapped around them. Melog is curled around her feet, asleep. Catra does not seem to notice the queen drawing closer and closer to her, not even her ear twitches. Glimmer doesn’t understand why she is walking closer to her enemy, though she wonders if she needs to add the word “former” to that. In all honesty, she would rather have nothing to

do with Catra but there isn't any time for that. When she is a couple feet away, Glimmer clears her throat.

Now Catra twitches. Her ears stand at attention as her head snaps around. Her dual color eyes stare up wide at the queen. After a moment, she simply says, "Hey."

"Hey…"

"Do you need something?"

Glimmer chews on the bottom of her lip, trying to figure out what to say. "No. I was just walking around. What are you doing up early? I never pegged you as someone to be up at this hour."

"I can say the same thing to you. And since when did you care about me?"

"When did I say I was? I'm just curious what you are up to."

"That's the Sparkles I know. But if you are wondering, I couldn't sleep. What about you? You look like shit so I am guessing you are in the same boat?"

"Yeah…" Glimmer looks around, trying to find someone else to talk to. No one. Not even the Star Siblings are around. She really wishes Adora was around right now. What would she do with Catra right now? Talk to her? Forgive her for all the shit she has done? Part of Glimmer wonders if she is planning on backstabbing what remains of the Rebellion but so far she has been nothing but helpful. Still, just looking at the magicat causes anger to boil inside of her.

She decides maybe not to start anything and go search for something else to do. "Well...I will catch you later…" Glimmer starts to move when Catra suddenly stands up, shocking Melog awake.

"Wait, Sparkles. I-"

Before she can say anything, a noise catches both of their attention. They turn their heads around to see Swift Wind landing close to them. “Hello Glimmer! And, uh, Catra…” he looks over the magicat hesitantly before returning his gaze back at the queen. “I bring news! Friends actually!”

Before anyone can say anything else, Castaspella is drawing close to Glimmer, shouting her name. Arms wrap around her, crushing her. A yelp of pain escapes Glimmer at the gesture. Her aunt quickly lets go. “I’m sorry. I am just so happy you are okay. I heard what happened.” A tender hand finds Glimmer’s cheek, a thumb softly rubbing the skin. “I don’t know what I would've done if you never came back.”

“I’m alright, Aunt Casta. You know me. Tough and stubborn,” Glimmer reassures her. “It takes a lot to knock me down. I am so glad you are safe. You don’t know how happy I am to see you.”

“You get that stubbornness from your father. You and him are just the same. Speaking of which…” Castaspella looks over her shoulder. “Micah?”

Glimmer cranes her head, feeling her heart stopping in her chest. Stepping out from behind the older sorceress is a man who looks a few years older than Castaspella. He has a stocky and smaller frame. Jet black hair streaked with grey falls down past his shoulders and dark brown eyes are warm as they stare back at her. There are only slivers of memories, more of feelings than images, in her mind of this man but all are of comfort and love. Arms that held her tight during storms. A scratchy beard to make her laugh as it rubs against her cheek. And a loving whisper as she is tucked in her bed goodnight.

“D-Dad?” Glimmer asks. Her sight becomes misty. She blinks, clearing her vision to clearly see the man who has always been a fuzz of colors in her mind. Is this still a dream? Is someone going to suddenly pinch her and snap her awake? Will she then find herself back on Horde Prime’s cold and lifeless ship? After so much hell occurring the past few days, she wouldn’t be shocked

to find out this is all in her head. But when Micah takes a step forward, closing the gap between them, she knows this is all too real.

Glimmer's legs move without thought. She staggers even with the crutch but she ignores the pain. Not even a near trip stops her. The second she is in arms length of Micah, her body finally gives in and she collapses into her father's arms. Micah is careful as he wraps his arms around his daughter, mindful of her injuries. Tears falling down her face, the young queen buries her head into his chest as she accepts his embrace. It is just like she remembers from all those years ago. For a moment, all her worry, all her anxiety, all her fear and doubt disappears.

"Hi, sweetheart," Micah whispers softly. A hand lifts and runs through her hair. "You've gotten so big. You look so much like your mother."

Glimmer looks up. Tears stream down his own face and his smile is bright. "I've missed you so much."

"So have I. How is the queen doing?"

"I have seen better days. How...How are you? What's been going on at home?"

Micah pulls away, putting his hand on Glimmer's shoulders. "Everything is fine. The Horde hasn't reached it yet and your friends who lost their kingdom have been doing everything to help keep it standing. We don't know when Prime will come after Brightmoon but everyone is ready for a fight."

Glimmer sighs a breath of relief. For a moment, she can relax and have one less thing on her plate to worry about. Micah turns his attention to Catra. An eyebrow raises seeing the young woman in a Horde Uniform. "Are you the one Bow sent a message about, the one that defected?"

"You can say that. I helped get Sparkles out of Horde Prime's clutches," Catra states.

And more or less caused the death of my mother, Glimmer thinks to herself.

"Well, thank you." Micah looks back at his daughter. "How are you holding up? Do you need a healing session? Bow said you were pretty beaten up."

"That actually sounds like a nice idea."

"Let me handle that," Castaspella cuts in. "I hate to break up the father-daughter reunion but Micah, you never were the best at healing spells. I will be back with her soon enough."

Micah slowly nods. He places a kiss on Glimmer's forehead. "We have a lot to catch up on. I will be here if you need me. Gonna check on everyone else."

"Okay, Dad."

The two part ways and Glimmer follows her aunt into her tent. The two settle down, Glimmer resting on her bed while Castaspella removes her bandages. Her aunt's face darkens.

"Is everything alright with your healing, Glimmer?" Castaspella asks.

Glimmer takes a moment to answer. She watches as her aunt's hands light up in a soft, blue color. They are placed first on her injured leg. A cold, relaxing sensation spreads across the wounded area. Pain seeps out of her and her aching muscles relax. A sigh escapes her lips. If only the feeling can take over her whole body and erase the sharp, heavy pain in her chest. Finally, she hesitantly says, "Not great. I don't know why it is taking so long."

"If there is time, I can teach you some more healing spells. It is good to know, especially now." Castaspella moves her hands around. The wound starts to slowly shrink. "But, Glimmer, don't beat yourself up. You are doing everything you can."

“Wh-What do you mean?”

“You know what I mean.”

Glimmer turns her face away. How can she say that? She wasn’t there. She wasn’t the one who went to the First One temple and got the Heart to active. She wasn’t the one who failed to rescue the young woman who has captivated her heart. She isn’t the one who every time she closes her eyes, sees the horrified expression on Adora’s face when she realized what she was forced to do. She isn’t the one who has to live with what she did and how it helped bring on the destruction of the world.

“I know it’s hard, sweetheart. But you have to remember, you can still fix things,” Castaspella says. “After all, your father has returned home and Brightmoon still stands. There still is hope. You just have to find that sliver of light and hold onto.”

“What hope is there when Horde Prime is taking over all of Etheria and also has Adora and is making her do his bidding? No one has seen or heard from her since she attacked me. Who knows what she is doing right now. Not to mention, I am completely powerless.”

Her aunt shifts her hands upwards, stopping at Glimmer’s stomach. The queen groans for a moment from the sharp pain of being touched. But like before, the sensation starts to drain from her body. “Not necessarily. I don’t know about your princess powers, but have you even tried to use any spells at all?”

“N-No. I haven’t.” Glimmer gives her a look. “I wanted to ask you how you keep your powers.”

“I don’t need to recharge, it’s not like the princess powers. Mostly, you just rest and you have been back on Etheria for a couple days now. You forget there is magic all around. I don’t think I can heal these wounds anymore so why don’t you give your magic a shot?”

Before doing anything, Glimmer looks herself over. The gash on her leg has shrunk considerably, though testing the weight, it still

is sore. The one on her abdomen still looks worse for wear, scabbed, jagged, and red, but it too has become smaller. Another small victory. Maybe now she can actually get out there and fight. If her aunt is right, maybe she will have more reason to go back out on the battlefield.

Taking a breath, she thinks of a spell. One simple and not overly complicated. She traces an image in the air with her finger, a pink light following closely behind. Glimmer feels her heart starting to race as she feels magic beginning to course through her veins. With the flick of her writs, she sends the spell forward. It hits the legs of a small table, flipping it over. The queen beams. Her first reaction is to jump up in the air, pumping her fist. But her body protests.

"Ow, fuck," Glimmer clutches her stomach. "Bad idea."

"You still need to take it easy and you might not be at full strength with those powers," Castaspella places a hand on Glimmer's shoulder. "Just remember what I said, alright? Your powers are tied to your emotions after all."

"I will keep that in mind. Thank you, Aunt Casta."

Bow suddenly enters, pushing back the flaps of the entrance and popping his head in. "Sorry to interrupt. But there are some villagers coming. It is best we greet them and see how they are doing and what they need."

"Right." Glimmer follows him out. The two walk into the campsite as people begin to stagger in. Catra is nearby, watching the flow of newcomers. The queen keeps an eye out for familiar faces. Maybe some people she knows through the kingdoms or maybe one of the other princesses still out could be in the group. These people either found this location through word of mouth, like Perfuma or Frosta telling them where to go, or got guided by someone. When she does not spot anyone she knows, Glimmer is about to give up when the ice princess burst through the brush.

There are scrapes all over her body, twigs and leaves sticking out of her hair, and she is out of breath. There is fright in her eyes. Before anyone could say or ask anything, the young princess crashed into Glimmer, wrapping her arms tightly around her. The queen holds back a wince of pain. Despite the healing from her aunt, the wound awakens at the touch and shoots off waves of hot pain.

"Ack! F-Frosta? What's wrong? Are you okay? What are you doing back so soon?!?" Glimmer asks. She places both her hands on the child's shoulder. "Where is Perfuma?"

"She told me to run! She-She sacrificed herself! He's got her!" Frosta gasps. Tears are on the verge of spilling out of her eyes.

"Wait, what?!? Do you mean Prime?!? What happened?"

"He's got She-ra! He made her attack us!"

"He made Adora do it?!?" Glimmer curses to herself. She isn't shocked Adora is still in his grasp and at least now there has been a sighting. But what must have it been like for the young princess to see Adora like that? Or for Perfuma to give herself up to protect her from their friend. Hopefully Prime isn't on a murder spree with the princesses. But then something hits Glimmer. She shakes her head and gives Frosta a look. "Wait a minute. We told everyone Adora was being controlled. Why are you surprised?"

"No! No you don't understand! He has *She-ra*! She attacked us as her!"

Realization punches Glimmer hard in the face, making her body turn ice cold. The words ring in her ears. *He's has She-ra*! How did he succeed in doing that? She had no sword, nothing to connect Adora to She-ra. Did he create one? Find another one? The world begins to spin along with her thoughts. The queen is sent back to the Kingdom of Dryl, trying to pry the sword out of a raging Adora. Then she is at the Northern Reach, struggling to stay ahead of her best friend who's out for blood. Both of those times

She-ra was out of control, seeking only to destroy. Now, she is in the hands of a calculative and cold being. Glimmer dares not think of what he can do with that power on his side.

Glimmer slowly turns her head around, looking at everyone else in the group. The grim reality of the situation slowly sets in. Color has drained from everyone's face. Bow has a hand covering his mouth, shock written in his eyes. Catra stares wide-eyed off in the distance. Surely they both remember the Northern Reach as well and how much destruction she can cause when she is not holding back. This is the worst case scenario. The queen gulps before looking back at the young girl still holding onto her.

"I hate to ask, but is there anything else you can tell us about what happened?"

Frosta shakes her head. "No. She just...I've never seen Adora like that before. That wasn't her. Perfuma…"

"She will be okay, Frosta. She is strong and smart and would not give up easily. We will get both her and Adora back, I promise you that. But you need to go rest now. Go find my father, he will help you. You did good and everything will be alright."

Frosta looks up at her, not quite convinced. Glimmer herself doesn't quite believe her words either but there is no time for doubt. Finally, the young girl nods and leaves.

"What are we going to do?" Catra asks. "Sparkles?"

Glimmer doesn't answer her, not knowing what to say.

Night falls. Tomorrow she and others will be leaving to find a new spot to rest for a while. Some people have already left, knowing it is not good to all go in one shot. But right now, she really doesn't care about that. With everyone asleep, she searches for a new weapon to use. Between wanting to save her magic for when she needs it and not necessarily knowing where her staff could be now, she cannot summon what she normally uses. Something else

will be needed. Eventually, she ends up settling on using Adora's own staff. Keep a part of the blonde close to her, defend her and fight with her despite not being with her.

Now that she can use her leg for the most part, there is no need for her crutch. She packs away some more items into a bag before sneaking her way out of the tent. Glimmer is careful to pay attention to her surroundings. She doesn't want to be caught and told to go back to bed. There has been enough waiting around. Enough doing nothing as Adora remains in Horde Prime's grasp longer and longer. No one is going to stop her.

Glimmer makes it into the woods and is about five minutes in when Melog and Catra suddenly appear in front of her. The queen jumps, surprised by the sudden presences. "C-Catra?!? Were you following me? What the fuck?"

"Maybe. What are you doing?" Catra asks.

"*Something*. I am not waiting for an opportunity to drop in our laps. The longer we wait the more Prime will take over and the more he will make Adora do gods know what. At this rate, she will be on a murder spree and I am not going to let that happen."

"So you are going to get yourself killed then? You know going alone in your condition is pretty much suicide. I knew you princesses were stupid but I didn't think it was this bad. Adora will kill you like while she is like that. Or did you learn nothing from the Northern Reach?"

"Oh I learned that you would stop at nothing to fuck with Adora because you couldn't stand her doing her own thing and being a better person. I still don't know how you stopped her from killing you then. Must have been some dumb luck."

Glimmer starts feeling the anger she has been repressing coming up and seeping through cracks. She no longer cares. It is late, it has been almost a week since Adora was captured and

brainwashed. Etheria is practically on fire. Catra will not be another obstacle on her mission to rescue Adora.

"I'm surprised you aren't taking some joy in seeing Adora like this, seeing her lose. Didn't you want that when you nearly ended the whole world and pretty much caused the death of my mother?"

"Maybe the old me would have been but someone called me out on some of the shit I did and after seeing what Prime could while on his ship...I want to fix things. I don't know how or what to do but I want to make things right somehow."

"You really want to make things right? How about you go back in time and not pull that switch? Not pull it so Prime wouldn't know we were here. Not pull it so my mother wouldn't be dead. Or-Or bring Adora back! I know I fucked up here and I will be damned if I don't get Adora back for what I did. You're not gonna stop me."

Glimmer walks forward, purposely bumping her shoulder into Catra's. She stops when she hears Catra speak up.

"I told you, this is suicidal, especially how you still are at the moment. And I never said I was going to stop you. I don't think you should go off getting yourself killed because you didn't think." Catra waits for Glimmer to face her to continue. "I can't bring your mother back and...I am sorry. I wanted to say that before we got cut off by your family. But I can help you get Adora back. Two of us against her are better than one and we both know how she fights and how she works."

"Why?"

"Do you listen? Gods. I said, I want to make things right. You all can hate me after this, do whatever you want when this war is over and if we are all not six feet under. But I want to make it up to everyone...to Adora...Maybe I can't do that, makeup for all the shit, but I want her to be allowed to choose if she wants me back in her life or not. I can't make it up to her and she can't have that chance to decide for herself if she is being mind controlled."

Glimmer looks her over. There still is that defiant look in her eyes. She still is standing as tall as she can. But there is something different. Her ears are pulled as far back as possible and her tail flicks around behind her. Melog copies her. Glimmer takes a breath.

She isn't wrong. Glimmer has no idea what she is going to do if she finds Adora. Now that she can turn into She-ra, it will be that much harder to defend herself or figure out a way to break Adora free of Prime. Maybe some extra help will do her some good.

"What do you say, Sparkles? Do you want me to help you or not?"

"Yes. Let's go get Adora back."

Adora stands still as a statue, standing guard over her most recent captive. Horde Prime has ordered her to stay put until he returns. She is no longer in her She-ra form, no need for that to watch one helpless princess. It still is a wonder how these princesses have been thorn in Horde Prime's side for this long if she was able to take one down so easily.

Eventually, Adora does turn her head to look at Perfuma. The tall princess glares back at her through the force field, eyes full of fury. Her hands tied up with a thick rope. Her pleads for Adora to come back to the Rebellion have long since ended. Must have finally realized it was pointless. It will never happen anyway. The blonde thinks how she was a failure to them, unable to stop Hordak from taking over most of Etheria and losing the sword. But now she is with Horde Prime. She is anything but a failure to him. Why would she want to leave?

Footsteps draw her attention away from the Princess. Horde Prime soon is by the cell door. He opens it and steps in, Adora following close behind. Perfuma's eyes dart to Prime as he kneels down and smiles. His hand grips Perfuma's chin, causing her to wince. The princess then speaks, "What do you want?"

“Here to see how you are doing. You are a guest here after all,” Prime says coolly. He removes his hand.

“You’re very hospitable,” Perfuma scoffs. “What have you done with Adora?”

“I finally gave her what she always wanted. Got rid of her fears, anxieties, and doubts. Finally gave her a chance at happiness and a better life.”

“She doesn't look happy. More like a mindless zombie.”

“Oh but trust me, she is.”

“What are you going to do to me? Control me like you are Adora? Kill me? No matter what you do, the others will stop you. They will get Adora back and you won’t win.”

Horde Prime chuckles. “You Etherians never know when to give up. Adora’s own beacon of hope couldn’t do anything for her, how do you think any of you will? As for you, I will not kill you nor control you. I will keep you alive and out of the way, for now. Soon, your planet will belong to me as well as yours and the other princesses runestones and that magic you all are hiding.”

“What are you planning on doing?!?”

“You will see in due time.”

Perfuma turns her eyes back on Adora, who has remained silent throughout this all. “Adora, *please* snap out of it! I don’t know what is going on in your head but you have to listen! Gl-”

“You really don’t know when to stop talking, do you?” Prime cuts her off. He stands up and sets himself between the princess and Adora. “Maybe you should have some distractions.”

With a snap of his fingers, the wall behind Perfuma lights up. Images soon fill it of Etheria. Of a place that Adora does not quite know but is slowly being taken over by Horde Prime’s armies.

Perfuma turns her head around, eyes wide, watching what is occurring on her planet. Happy now, Prime turns his attention at Adora. The blonde stands up straight and proud, waiting for whatever orders that are about to come.

“Come now, little sister, let see if we can find your so-called friends. Maybe you can pay them a visit.”

He begins to leave. Adora waits for him to exit first, looking at Perfuma whose eyes are still glued to the screen. The blonde looks at it also, watching people surrender knowing a fight will only lead to their destruction. Without any more words being uttered by anyone, Adora finally turns and leaves the room to hear what her brother has in store with her.

Chapter End Notes

> i also forgot to mention ill be randomly throwing other fics to read that are glimmadora and my friend EtherianFrigatebird fic is wrapping up soon so kasgjbakgjsa go check it out

Cracks

Chapter Notes

> hey finally a new chapter. I should be able to update next week so yeah. Also i struggle with fight scenes so aksgjbsakjgsa take it for what its worth

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Glimmer, Catra, and Melog slowly make their way through the Whispering Woods. Every step they take is taken with care. Any twig, leaf, or loose pebble on the ground they do their best to avoid. The worst thing to happen now on their mission is to be overrun by robots or clones or be attacked by anyone who might be loyal to Horde Prime. So much can go wrong with this mission but Glimmer feels a growing sense of solace inside of her. The magicat stays a few steps ahead of her, taking the lead of tracking. The queen wonders how far she would have made it if she was by herself.

They head towards where Perfuma and Frosta were. Having left during the middle of the night, they probably will reach the area Adora was in my early or mid afternoon, depending on how fast they tread. At this rate, it seems like it will be closer to the latter. Glimmer wonders what Bow and the others will think when they see her and Catra gone. She only left a small note on her bed saying ‘Gone to get Adora. Don’t follow. Will find you later.’ Who knows if Catra left one but either way, Bow will probably have a stroke and then an earful for them upon their return.

While they walk, Glimmer looks around the woods. She cannot recall ever being in this part of the never ending forest but the further they go in, the more her heart sinks. At first, she barely notices marks on the trees or breaks of their branches. But as time goes on, some trees have fallen down and not by natural causes. Others have slashes or burn marks on their bark. Some sturdy limbs have fallen to the ground and lay in several pieces.

Everything that Prime touches he destroys. Glimmer swallows a hard lump in her throat thinking about Adora being in his grasp.

"Let's stop here right now," Catra says, her voice breaking the silence. Glimmer freezes and gives her a look. "Look, we have been walking for a couple hours now."

"Right…" Now that she mentions it, Glimmer's legs do feel heavy. She finds a spot to rest under a tree, some yards away from Catra and Melog. The magicat sighs as she finds her own place to rest. Neither speak as they take a pause in their search. Glimmer barely looks at the other girl, not knowing how to feel about her being around.

While she waits to get moving again, Glimmer digs into her bag. She pulls out a bottle of water and sips some of it down. Catra does the same with whatever she brought with her. The queen wonders how long it will take to find Adora. With any luck, since the attack on the village and Perfuma and Frosta having happened not that long ago, she will still be in the same area. Though, time still has passed. For all anyone knows, Adora could be long gone. Off to another area of Etheria, being forced to terrorize others. A hand finds her stomach as she wonders just how far Prime is making her go.

Glimmer grips the bottle in hands at the thought. Hopefully she has been the only victim in attempted murder. From what she can remember, the two times Adora was infected by the First One tech Entrapta found, upon being freed the blonde only had vague, dreamlike memories of her bloodlust. Still, she felt a deep guilt and barely slept for several nights afterwards. What will she remember if she is ever freed now?

Glimmer puts the bottle back in her bag. There is not much else inside. Some food just in case, a small map, and the bracelet she gave Adora long ago. A hopeful good luck charm to have on her. Meanwhile, Adora's staff rest in one of the outside pockets for easier access. It is wishful thinking that she won't have to use it

or her magic for that long. Though, maybe with Catra and Melog it could be shortened.

Speaking of the magicat, she turns her attention back on her. It'll be best to have an idea of what they are going to do. "So...are you ready for this?" she asks.

Catra blinks. She looks at the queen a little confused. Did she zone out? After a moment, she speaks. "I-Yeah. I think so…."

"That *totally* sounds reassuring."

"Well I mean, do you have any idea how we are going to stop her? Like, get Prime to stop controlling her?"

Glimmer thinks for a moment, tapping a finger on her chin. She does her best to recall her fight with Adora many days ago. There is a small fuzz around all the images she sees, her brain already trying to block out the events that transpired. Doesn't help trying to recall that day is threatening to cause her body to break out into a cold sweat.

She remembers Adora's voice, sounding just like her but coming out so cold and lifeless. Those laughs, both when it was mixed with Horde Prime's and when hers came out without any of her inflections, sends shivers down her spine. But what haunts her the most is when her bright sky blue eyes stared back at her, tears about to spill out and hurt and anger filling them. She wants to stop remembering, her heart is racing and breathing takes extra effort, but she pushes on in search of any answer.

She remembers throwing Adora off of her in a desperate attempt not to be choked to death. There was a noise, metallic in nature. For a moment, Adora's eyes shone their normal color before filling back up in a bright green light. What was on her neck again? She already forgot. Straining her mind, she recalls when she first entered the room noticing something on there. An attempt was made to remove it and well, that didn't work.

“There was something...on her neck. I think that thing, like a chip or whatever, is doing it. I tried to get it off before but couldn’t so I don’t know if that is it exactly,” Glimmer tells Catra. “Other than that, I have no idea what Prime could have done to her.”

“So that’s what we have to aim for the neck. That can’t be too hard. I’ve been able to get on her back before and knock her down.”

“Are you talking about the time you fucked up her back when you attacked my home?”

Catra starts to rub the back of her head. “Not one of my proudest moments...But I am being serious. If I can do it again and get close, maybe I can do something about whatever is on her neck.”

“Then that is the plan of attack I guess.” Glimmer stands and throws her bag over her shoulders. “Hopefully it doesn’t kill us. If she can turn into She-ra now, we are in for a fight.”

Catra rises to her feet, walking close to the queen. “Well we fought her once at the Northern Reach. If she isn’t going to hold back, then we shouldn’t either until we bring her to her senses. Are you ready for that?”

“I’m ready for anything if it means getting her back.”

Adora waits for them. Her hood covers her face and being perched up in a tree helps conceal herself even more. She wants to revel in the surprise that will come on the faces of the former allies traveling towards her. With her former best friend coming along, why not take some pointers from Catra in the art of popping out of nowhere. While she waits, she takes out a small device and turns it on. Screen after screen she flicks through, searching for the magicat and queen. It takes her a minute, they must have found a place without eyes in the trees and sky, but she finally finds the pair and their unknown companion. She stops

and watches them. It looks like they are still on track for coming this way.

As she watches the video feed, Adora can't help focusing in on Glimmer. Her body acts without thought, zooming in on the dual-color haired girl. She wonders how the hell she could have survived a wound to the stomach. Surely, the loss of blood would have killed her. But as Horde Prime has said, Etherians are quite resilient.

While her mind is only filled with thoughts on how to defeat the queen for good this time, her heart races inside of her chest. It refuses to stop, nearly going as fast as a bullet fired from a gun. Her hands shake as her fingers move the screen around, causing the camera to momentarily jerk in a different direction. Adora squeezes her eyes shut, trying to stop her body's reactions. There is a prickle at the back of her neck as her body begins to settle down. Once control is taken back, she returns her gaze back on the screen in her hands. Glimmer and Catra have stopped and are talking, whatever it is there is no audio to hear. An attempt is made to focus on the magicat but her gaze shifts back to the queen, her heart beating just above a resting pulse.

When they start to move again, Adora turns off the device in her hands and shoves it in her pocket. They will be here soon. While the time passes, she thinks about the rest of the plan Horde Prime has. Once the queen and the magicat are done away with, there will be less in the way of gathering the runestones. With Perfuma captured, it will be far easier to get the Heart-Blossom. The Pearl and the Black Garnet will be in their hands soon enough. One thing Hordak has been useful for is taking over Salineas and the Fright Zone. Only the Kingdom of Snows and Brightmoon stand in their way.

Soon this planet will be in Horde Prime's control. Adora will see that through to the end.

After some more moments of waiting, the sound of footsteps approaching catch her attention. Adora shifts, careful not to cause

noise, and looks through the brush. Sure enough, Catra and Glimmer are drawing near. The blonde waits for a moment, holding her breath as the duo comes closer. She watches them inch closer and closer. The pair talk about which direction they should take next, which she ignores. With some luck, the magicat strides several feet a head, back turned to the tree. Perfect. After one more long moment passes, she jumps, ready to pin the girl to the ground.

Just before she connects with Catra, she notices the twitch of her ears. The second she touches her, Catra uses her weight and movement against her. Sharp hands grip the clothing and the two somerset forward. The next thing she knows, Adora is flug off of her former best friend. The blonde manages to catch herself and land without skidding across the ground. Both girls rise to their feet at the same time.

"Even mind controlled you fuckin' suck at sneak attacks," Catra says, her eyes narrowed. "Though, I will give you some credit for *almost* getting me."

"Adora, please listen to us. We know you are in there somewhere," Glimmer starts, "we aren't leaving without you."

"What Sparkles said. Even if that means we have to knock your sorry ass out."

Adora chuckles darkly. " *What makes you think she would want to come back?"* A smile grows as she watches horror form on Catra's and Glimmer's face. Both their eyes are wide. The magicat's ears fall flat on her head and the creature that shadows her cowards behind her legs. The queen, meanwhile, is frozen like a statue. Adora locks her hands behind her, slowly starts to walk around the pair, and begins to talk again in her unnatural, Horde Prime voice.

" *Why do you two try so hard to bring her back? You all said and did some interesting yet saddening things to each other. I do not know about you but I can tell you both Adora has been in so much pain. I only have done her a favor."*

"What type of favor is controlling her and making her do things against her will?!?" Glimmer spats. "How the *hell* do you know what she feels or are you just toying with her?"

" *Oh?"* Adora raises an eyebrow. *"But I am not Your Majesty. I can see all her memories, know how she feels. Sans talking through her, all I ever do is give her a nudge. She grew weary and unsure of her role as She-ra, never knowing if she was living up to what others propped her up on. Was heartbroken and devastated by all the betrayal and hurt from you two. Why not allow her to finally express those emotions?"*

"You bastard!"

" *I am only trying to help her and give her some peace. Do you really want to take that away from her? Maybe I need to remind her of the hurt she has been through to show you all how she feels."*

Images fill her mind, nearly flooding it. She sees herself back at the Horde with Catra, arguing with her about something the magicat did and caused serious trouble for both of them. Shadow Weaver was far from pleased with either of them. Then she is at Brightmoon, watching it burn as Catra's nails tear deep, jagged scars on her back and side of her face. Even now, there are still nights she cannot lay in her favorite position from the ache the healed wounds cause. She's tied up against a pole, screaming for her friend not to pull the lever.

Glimmer enters her mind. Blaming her for her mother's death, a death she didn't want to happen and tried to prevent. Some days Adora wishes she could have swapped places with Angella. Then there is being tricked into being bait without her consent. Even after she caught onto what Glimmer was doing that didn't help. And that last fight. The one over the Heart. She never did listen to her warning, did she?

Adora's blood begins to boil at the thoughts. She grits her teeth so tight she could break them. More images of fights and spats with

both the magicat and queen flash in her mind. Those sleepless nights where her tears became dry from hours of use before. She can feel that heaviness that weighed down her heart inside her chest like an anchor, the one she hid in order to try to make things right. She had to swallow the weakness that threatened to show and attempt to fix all the problems made.

And for what?

Kill them, the voice inside her brain says.

All other thoughts she might have in her mind disappear and are replaced by those two words. She says nothing more as she thinks about becoming She-ra. In a flash of light, she feels power coursing through her and herself beginning to tower over the two. The light soon disappears and she draws her sword out. Both Catra, Glimmer, and the dark purple and blue feline look on in horror at the sight.

"Shit, Frosta wasn't kidding," Catra says.

Before Glimmer can add anything else, Adora charges.

Both Catra and Glimmer dive out of the way as Adora's sword descends down on them. Dirt and dust shoots into the air. Glimmer staggers as she attempts to get her footing, her leg not happy from the sudden movement. Once she is stable, she reaches for the staff and pulls it out. She does it just in time to block a heavy blow from Adora. It has been ages since the queen last sparred with the legendary warrior princess. She has forgotten the might and power she gives off with every swing of her sword. And it has only increased with her lack of holding back. It takes everything in Glimmer to remain upright.

"Adora...Adora please. You have to be in there somewhere," Glimmer shouts. The second the weight of She-ra is off of her, she darts to the side, evading another attack. "You have to be in there somewhere, I just know it! Please listen!"

Adora does not so much as flinch. She charges again, ready to hurt and quite possibly attempt to kill Glimmer again. Before she can strike down, something sails through the air and hits the side of the blonde's head. Both she and Glimmer turn their hands in the direction to see Catra standing some yards away, tossing a small rock up in the air.

"Hey, dumbass, did you forget about me like always?" Catra taunts. "Or are you gonna give all the love to Sparkles? Guess I am chopped liver."

Glimmer hears Adora scoff at the comment before jumping out of the way from another strike. While she recovers, the blonde turns her attention to her former best friend. Nimble as ever, Catra barely bats an eye as Adora comes at her.

"There we go! That is more like it!" Catra leaps around, doing her best not to be hit. Melog follows closely behind, attempting to trip Adora up or at the very least, distract her enough so the magicat isn't killed. "Try, Sparkles!"

Shit, right! Glimmer takes a small moment to think of a spell. She wishes she had learned more but that doesn't matter much now. There still are enough filed away in her brain to throw an attack at Adora. She can see from where she stands what she saw before still on her neck. Some moments pass as she waits for an opening, not wanting to hit Catra. Once she finds an opportunity, a second where the magicat has drawn her closer, she unleashes the magical blast of energy. It hits her in the back of the left shoulder.

"Fuck!" Glimmer exclaims as Adora whips her head around at her. Even with her eyes completely filled in by green, anger is written all over her face. Glimmer badly wishes for her teleportation powers right about now.

Adora begins to step forward, all her focus on the queen, when Catra jumps up on top of her. She raises an arm high in the air, claws out as far as they can go, and poised to strike the blonde's

neck. As her arm is brought down, Adora's free hand shoots up and grabs the fabric of her uniform. All the magicat has time to do is gasp and she is flung off of the blonde. Glimmer watches her fly through the air before hitting the ground, hard, several yards away. She skids to a halt, coughing and gasping for air. Melog races over to her, leaving the queen all alone with Adora.

"So about that blast to the shoulder…" Glimmer begins. She does not get far when Adora is nearly on top of her. There is no time to react towards a blow to the stomach. All the air is forced out of her lungs and much like Catra moments before, is sent backwards off the ground. Unlike her sort of ally, her body connects with a tree. Glimmer gasps, trying to suck in any oxygen she can get but is to little avail. Her body slips to the side, items from her bag spilling out, and curls in on herself.

Between the lack of control from her lungs and the pain radiating from her stomach, Glimmer cannot move. She prays to the gods that her aunt's healing spells are strong enough to keep her wound from tearing open. The last thing she needs is to nearly bleed out again. If it has opened once more, she has no idea. All she can feel is the burning pain spreading throughout her body.

Adora starts to draw closer. She has begun to laugh again. It is a far cry from her usual warm and vibrate one. This is empty and cold, one of pure wickedness that freezes the queen even more in place. Her brain screams for her body to move, to get out of the way from the looming death heading towards her. But her limbs are like jelly and refuse to listen. A hand manages to shift, knocking some objects forward.

Glimmer waits for her death to come. There is nothing else she can do other than pray that someone like Bow or Catra or her father or *anyone* can free Adora and hope they can give her the comfort and support she will surely need upon hearing about the faith of the queen. She squeezes her eyes shut, not wanting the last thing she sees is Adora striking her down.

But after a moment, she reopens them. Adora has frozen in place only a few feet away from Glimmer. Her sword is pointed at her, waiting to strike. The blonde's gaze, however, is drawn away from the queen. Glimmer follows it and sees her eyes are on what fell out of her bag. In particular, the bracelet.

Glimmer manages to push herself off the ground and sit up straight. Coughs still escape her but somehow, she can get some enough air in her lungs to prevent herself from blacking out. Glimmer attempts to speak but only a wheeze escapes her. She groans, focusing everything she can on getting words out, before attempting again.

"Adora...Adora I know you are....you are in there. Stop...Stop and come back! We can make...make things right…Please…"

Adora slowly turns her head towards the queen. Her face is devoid of emotions at first. But the second her eyes land on Glimmer, it twists back into hate. Her sword raises up and is aimed right for her throat.

"ADORA!" The only thing Glimmer can do is throw her arms up in a feeble defense.

There is a sound of something akin to a roar. Melog slams into Adora, their mane and tail a vibrant red, and forces her back. The alien cat momentarily knocks her balance off. They jump off before Adora can force them off herself. As the blonde finds her footing, Melog runs up to Glimmer. They nudge her and help her to stand. Catra soon is at her side.

"What the hell just happened?!?" Catra asks, a bit out of breath.

"I have no idea," Glimmer replies. She bends down and grabs the bracelet. "I think...I think this might have gotten to her for a moment."

"How the hell does that stupid thing do that?!?"

Adora is now back on her feet, ready once more. Glimmer puts the jewelry away. “I’ll explain later. I would like to live.” She looks back at Adora. A small sliver of hope enters her heart. This is proof somewhere deep inside her mind, Adora is somewhere in there. There has to be a way to break through to her again. If only they can damage that chip or break it. It would make things so much easier.

“Adora!” Glimmer shouts, “Just hang on a little longer! We will get you freed!”

The blonde responds with another charge. Catra and Glimmer bolt out of the way. Adora spins on her heels and slashes her sword close to the magicat. Catra has barely enough time to duck out of the way. She still is a millisecond too late. When she moves out of range from Adora, Glimmer sees a red nick in her right ear.

Glimmer attempts to strike next. She thinks of another spell and with the aid of the staff, sends a blast forward. Adora is quick to spin around and deflect the bright ball of magic away. It hits a tree, destroying it. But then something appears that nearly makes Glimmer’s heart stop.

Robots, a ton of them, slowly make their way through the forest. They are no match for a whole army.

“Shit, shit, shit!” Glimmer repeats. “Catra!”

The magicat eyes widen in horror at the new sight. “Son of a bitch. We are fuckin’ dead if we don’t leave.”

That is definitely something Glimmer did not want to hear. She knew it was coming but it does not make things any better. Adora is gearing up for another attack. If they don’t leave now, there will be no escape.

Melog jumps in front of Catra and Glimmer, making a noise. Glimmer turns to Catra. “What did they say?”

“Get on them,” Catra tells her.

“What?”

“Just do it, Sparkles! Get on them! They don’t have to get us far just away from this shitshow!”

There is no room for an argument. Both girls hop onto Melog’s back. In a second, Glimmer feels her body tingle, similar to when she teleports. It then hits her. They must be invisible now. Adora seems surprised by this but anything else written on her face soon becomes too far away to read.

I t is a quiet day in the Kingdom of Brightmoon. A lot of days have been quiet, actually. Since the end of the war, there has been a stillness to everything. Adora still is getting used to that but she is starting to enjoy it. She likes the feeling of not always being on edge, fearful of something popping out of the shadows with no warning. She can finally sleep peacefully at night knowing that the world is safe from harm. Everyone is alive and well. All is perfect.

The blonde walks down one of the main long and winding halls of Brightmoon. She has little in mind about where she wants to go. Wherever her feet take her she will see. Could be the courtyard, could be a training room, or just could be going to a balcony to relax up there. There is a lot of downtime now and she has to find some way to fill in her time.

As she walks, she starts to make mental notes on what to do with Glimmer. Whenever she gets free time from her role as queen, the two do their best to spend it together. One of those days will be coming up soon and Adora wants to plan out the whole day now. Maybe they can go visit another princess. Maybe swim in the seas of Salineas or sail on them or have a snowball fight at the Kingdom of Snows. There is so much the two can do, Adora really needs to write everything down so she does not risk forgetting any of it. Hopefully her girlfriend likes whatever she comes up with.

She is completely lost in her thoughts about spending time with the queen. While walking, unaware of her surroundings, Adora suddenly slips and falls. She winces and holds back a curse as her chin connects with the smooth, cold tile of the halls. Once the pain rolls over her body, she flips herself over and looks down at her feet, wondering what the hell she fell on. Surely, there was nothing there before and there isn't any carpet in sight for her to stumble over. But what she finds is something she least expected. A bracelet. She reaches out for it, taking it in her hands, and pulling it close.

It's not that big and is mostly a bright yellow in color. The only expectation to this is a purple, crescent moon in the middle. Adora knows where this is from. A memory of shortly after coming to Brightmoon surfaces in her mind. Taking a guess, it must have been about a month since leaving her life behind at the Horde and starting anew in the large kingdom. At the time, she was in Glimmer's room with the then princess, enjoying her hair being braided by her new found friend. What the conversation was she cannot recall but it led to her picking at the beds of her fingernails.

Glimmer noticed and stopped her. A soft hand, one unmarked by years of training with no rest, landed on her own rough and scarred ones. The princess didn't say much but instead told her to wait there a moment. She disappeared, leaving Adora with half done hair, before returning in a cloud of sparkles. In her hands was a small box.

"Take it," she had said.

Hesitantly, Adora obliged. She took the box and opened it up. It was the bracelet. Confused, she asked Glimmer about it. She can still hear her soft voice that day in her mind.

"It's for you. It's a gift so keep it. I know you probably never got a gift before and you said you never really 'owned' anything so now you can say that. You also can play with it, stretch it out or fiddle with the moon. Gives your hands something else to do."

Adora remembers nearly crying at the gesture and always did her best to have it on her, even if it was in her pockets. How did it end up on the floor?

She tries to think, pull something out of her brain to recall where she last left it. Nothing comes up. However, one thing leads to another. She can't remember what she did with the piece of jewelry. Just like she can't remember how Horde Prime was defeated. Hell, the more she thinks about it, how did she and Glimmer start dating? Adora feels a headache forming near her eye. A groan escapes her lips and she clutches the side of her head.

Adora tries to focus on something, anything else. For a moment, her eyes stare out at the hall. It is empty, no one else is around. She takes a deep breath, hoping to keep the pain away and prevent herself from having an attack while trying to figure out the gaps in her mind. But then, she sees something as her eyes pass a window. It happens in a flash, like someone took a single frame of film and somehow is showing it to her without context. It is gone in the blink of an eye but all her years at the Horde has trained her to analyze her surroundings in a short frame of time. It is all she needs for her blood to run cold.

Through the glass, what once was looking out on the ground of Brightmoon becomes seeing Glimmer out in front of her, on the ground. She clearly is not in her kingdom at all but in the depths of the Whispering Woods, surrounded by green grass and her back up against a tree. A horrified look is written on her face and her arms are raised in front of her in defense. Adora swears she sees something wrapped around her leg and stomach, as if she has been hurt. When she shouts out her name, it is pleading.

Adora shouts at the sight, quickly backing up. Her back hits the wall, ceasing her movement. Her eyes stay locked ahead, even as the image has disappeared. What the hell was that? She wonders if it is a trick of the light but how is it possible to see something that clear and vivid? Why did she hear her girlfriend's cry as if she was right there? Where is Glimmer anyway? Didn't she tell her

that she was going to visit Bow or someone? Her heart pounds in her chest, threatening to break free, and she finds it hard to breathe. Thinking is not any easier either.

Suddenly, there is a sharp pain in the back of her neck. Adora jerks at the sensation, feeling as if someone has stabbed her with a scorching knife and twisting it into her spine. She grits her teeth, holding back a sharp cry of pain, as a hand slaps over her aching body part. It does little to aid in easing the agony. Through it all, she hears the faint noise, as if it is coming from two halls down, of Glimmer shouting her name once again.

"G-Glim…" Adora says through her teeth. The pain is unbearable. Tears prick at the edges of her eyes. All she can do is sit, tense, rubbing the back of her neck and riding it out. Slowly, the hot feeling subsides. Her skin still prickles but her body can finally relax. She gasps for air, her heart continues beating against her chest like a drum. Her free hand lifts and her eyes land on her very first gift.

*Something in the back of her mind tells her something is not right. She chalked half of it up to the anxiety running its course through her body. Everything is perfect now, there is nothing to worry about. Maybe she just saw things, though that doesn't explain the pain she just felt. Why did she hear Glimmer's voice also? ...And why **is** everything so perfect? Maybe her anxiety is not all a lie.*

"What are you doing?"

The voice shocks her, nearly causing her already sped up heart to leap out of her body. She jerks back before snapping her head around towards the direction of the noise. Looking down at her is Glimmer. One of her eyebrows is raised and there is a curious look in her eyes. Okay, now things really aren't making sense.

"Glimmer? W-What are you doing here?" Adora asks, still on the ground.

"Checking on you? I was walking by and I saw you like this. Do you need help getting up?"

*Adora shakes her head. "I'm fine. I just need a moment. But seriously, what are you **doing** here? I thought you left the castle and weren't coming back until tonight."*

Glimmer shrugs. "Came back early."

Adora narrows her eyes. She could have sworn the queen did not leave that long ago. This is far too early. The blonde swallows a lump in her throat. She then shoves the bracelet in her pocket, hoping Glimmer did not see it, and stands to her feet. Her neck still tickles but she is able to ignore it for the most part. "Why did you come back so early?"

"You sure are full of questions today. But I just wanted to come home. Is that so bad?"

"N-No! I just was curious...You're not hurt are you?"

Glimmer gestures to herself. "No? Are you okay, Adora?" She walks closer to the blonde. Hands land on Adora's arms, gently moving up and down. "You look tense."

The feeling of her girlfriend's hands on her arms normally gives her a sense of comfort and relaxes her racing mind. That still rings true, for the most part. Glimmer's soft skin is nice against her body but there is something different. Even through the fabric of her shirt, she could sense the heat that radiated off of the queen. Now, there is nothing.

"I'm fine, Glim," she lies. Adora feels a new, dull sensation on her left shoulder and rubs it. Hopefully Glimmer doesn't question it. There is no need to cause alarm until she figures out what is going. "It's nothing."

"Are you sure?"

"I am. Don't worry about it." Adora quickly thinks of anything else to say to avoid more questions. "Hey, since you are back why don't we go do something?"

A soft smile spreads across Glimmer's face. "Sure, love. Anything for you."

Melog keeps running, long after the sounds of metal feet stomping on the ground disappears. They keep moving until the woods become too thick to move through with two people on their back. Though, on the flip side, this allows for more cover. The feline slows to a stop and reveals themself. Catra and Glimmer hop off of their back and take a moment to look around. Sure enough, they are alone. Safe, the two settle down on the ground. Melog crawls towards the magicat, who rubs the top of their head. Glimmer, meanwhile, stares off into the distance, trying to process all that has just occurred.

Another failure. Is this one worse than the other? Sure, no one almost died and had to be carried off in a heap but there were little hints of Adora's consciousness returning to her. Though that one little moment there was a good sign that somewhere the girl who always tries her best to put her best behind her and strive to protect others is in there. She isn't lost. Yet, there was that time before Adora had actually came back for a moment. Even if it was one of anger and hurt she still was *there.* This wasn't like that at all.

Glimmer clutches her hands into fist, her fingernails threatening to break both the fabric of her gloves and her skin. How is she going to get through to her? Shouting and pleas haven't seem to have much of an effect other than possibly pissing her off more. The bracelet only stopped her for a moment, like when your eyes are drawn away by seeing something move in the corner. What else could work? Glimmer tries to recall anything that could pull Adora out again. Maybe something else that she owns? Something else that might have a meaning to her? But what? Anything that could

be of use is most likely back at Brightmoon, which who knows when return to her home will be?

She chokes back tears starting to form. She doesn't want to cry right now, especially in front of Catra. Crying would mean admitting that trying to rescue Adora will be a feat and then some. It would mean owning up to the fact she has no idea what she is doing and is hoping for some unforeseen forces to aid her in this fight. She can't let them fall. She can't let herself feel weak and helpless.

It doesn't work.

Her tears slip out of her eyes as if a dam has broken wide open. A hand covers her mouth in an attempt to stifle her cries but it does little to help. Her body shakes almost violently and her stomach has twisted so tight into a knot she feels like she is going to puke up what little has been in her stomach as of late. Catra ears snap to attention and confusion is written on her face. After a moment, she scrambles to her feet and comes close to the queen. She attempts to reach out a hand but Glimmer quickly pulls away.

"D-Don't," Glimmer states. Even if Catra has been nothing more than helpful as of late, she still remains the last person to seek comfort from. She rather have Adora, Bow, her aunt, father, or mother try to calm her. But they are all either far away, controlled, or dead. Glimmer swallows before speaking again, "Don't touch me. I don't want to be touched."

Catra pulls her hand back. "Uh, okay…" her ears flick in thought. "Do...Do I do anything?"

"No," Glimmer shakes her head. "No just...just leave me alone. I want to be alone."

Catra says nothing more. There is a simple nod of the head before she slinks back to Melog. Once she has her space back, Glimmer buries her face into her legs, letting her sobs overtake her. She doesn't know how long she cries her heart out. It is a slow

calming of her body. Even as her tears dry and her eyes become puffy, some coughs and gasps escape her as her body still trembles. More long moments pass before her body stops moving without command and she is able to pull her head away from her legs.

“You feeling better?” Cata asks after a beat. Glimmer doesn’t answer her. She keeps her gaze away. Catra continues. “I have no idea how to comfort you, that has never been my strong suit, so I am not gonna try.”

“Thanks…” Glimmer scoffs.

“I thought you princesses never gave up. What ever happened to you all going off about ‘no princess left behind’? Don’t tell me that you are giving up now. What happened to the queen that always was a pain in my ass? Though you still are right now.”

Glimmer finally turns to look at her. There isn’t malice in her voice, more of a slight annoyance. Yet, something inside of her tells her that somehow the magicat is trying to make her feel better. Whatever it is, she won’t let her mock her. “I’m not giving up. Not yet. I just...need to figure something out. I’ll get her back. Then we can defeat Horde Prime and go back to being at each other’s throats.”

“There’s the Sparkles I know. Good. I didn’t want to keep dealing with your sorry ass.”

“Tck." Glimmer rolls her eyes. "I can say the same to you. I dunno how Adora ever handled you for so long.”

Catra shrugs. “I have no idea either. I’ll ask her once she comes back. Now,” she gets to her feet, “you ready to move again?”

Glimmer nods. “Yeah. Let’s get back before Bow dies from a heart attack from us being missing.”

Chapter End Notes

alright another shout out cause im doing these cause read my friend's fics sakgjbsakgjsa

I Thought I Wanted This is written by my friend Athetos. Its a post s5 fic that does have glimmadora in it but deals a lot of catra's and adora's relationship. I don't want to give to much away but ye

A Calm

Chapter Notes

> i apologize if this chapter is a little wonky or whatever I had some trouble with it and then forgot to edit it until this weekend so that was fun (and I am still getting used to writing chapter fics). That and the next update is something I really wanted to get to so aksjbagsasbg again sorry. Anyway I dont know if I will update next week yet or if it will be two weeks because, had a bit of a rough week and didn't get any writing done for the buffer
>
> So whenever I figure that out, which could not be until the end of the week, I will edit the summary with the correct date/say it on tumblr. But yeeeeee. Hopefully this chap is okay for the time being :v

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It most likely will take a day to find the new campsite. It is much further than the one before. Both Glimmer and Catra agree not to return to the old site at all. Even if some people might linger behind, it could be dangerous. From their trip before, there were signs everywhere that Horde Prime’s army was drawing close. No need to get captured or be followed. Speaking of which, the pair focus hard on their sight and hearing on the woods around them. Even if they feel safe, there is no need to let their guard down in the slightest.

During a break, as evening starts to draw close, Catra starts to touch her injured ear. She winces. The bleeding has long since stopped, leaving only a dark red crust over it. Thank the gods she was able to move out of the way in time so she didn’t get her head cut off. Yet, that must hurt. Even if Glimmer doesn't want much to do with Catra, that wound shouldn’t go untreated. It must hurt and could easily lead to infection.

“Let me see that,” Glimmer says, walking over to Catra. The magicat gives her a look.

“It’s nothing. I have gotten way worse before. Nothing to concern yourself about,” Catra tells her.

“Gods the Horde really beat that shit into you all, didn’t they? Look, if you don’t want my help fine by me, I won’t help. But I figured you wouldn’t want to have an infection. Do you want my help or not?”

Catra gives a small wave. “Fine. Do whatever.”

Glimmer kneels down next to her. She remembers back to the movements of her aunt’s hands from the other day. Her hands become a soft blue in color and they reach up and gingerly touch Catra’s wounded ear. The magicat hisses through her teeth at the touch. Glimmer waits for a curse to come at her but it is a sigh that escapes Catra’s lips. The wound begins to close, the red disappearing. There is no way she can replace the silt that now rests in her ear but at least this is something. She continues to use the spell for a few moments, making sure nothing will reopen in her first attempt to heal something. When she is sure nothing will happen, she pulls her hands back.

“Thanks, Sparkles. Awfully nice of you,” Catra says.

“Don’t get used to it. I know it hurts like hell.” Glimmer walks away to find a spot to settle down for the night.

They come up with some idea for who will stay awake first and when the shifts should change. Around two hours to sleep and then wake up the other. The two ended up playing a game of rock-paper-scissors to see who gets to sleep first. Catra loses. Part of Glimmer is happy she can sleep first but another half wishes to stay up first. Doesn’t want to miss anything...Doesn’t want to have nightmares. But her body demands it sleep and she curls up on the soft dirt and grass.

Glimmer doesn't know if she ever fell asleep. No dreams come to her, no feeling of slipping into darkness. She closes her eyes, still feeling the grass blades tickling her skin, and then after some long moments, Catra's sharp hands are on her arms. They go through this cycle until the sun begins to break across the horizon. Time to get moving again. Both have a rough idea of where the next camp is and use both their knowledge given to them to take some guesses where it could be. It takes a couple tries to find the right spot and they almost bump into some robots in the process. Thankfully, Melog turns them invisible right away and they avoid getting captured. Finally, after many hours of searching, taking breaks, and keeping their guard up, they find the new site. Almost the second they step in, Bow appears, not looking very happy.

"What the heck, Glimmer!" are the first words out of Bow's mouth when he sees her. The queen sees the piece of paper in his hands.

Glimmer scratches the back of her head. "I...Yeah I got nothing… Sorry, Bow."

" *Smooth,* Sparkles," Catra says.

"What were you thinking? Running off like that? You too, Catra. You both gave everyone a heart attack!"

"I'm sorry. Honest. I just wanted to…." she sighs and looks down on the ground. Unable to finish her sentence. She hears Bow sigh to himself. Steps draw close to her and hands are wrapped around her body.

"I know, Glim. I am still not happy with you but I get it." He pauses for a moment before pulling away. He places his hands on her shoulders before speaking again. "Guess things went bad? Want to talk about it?"

"What is there to say? We tried to save Adora but she nearly killed us and we had to hightail it out of there before she actually *did!* We couldn't even do anything to the chip…"

“The what?”

“Uh, about that,” Catra starts.

Glimmer snaps her head up, nearly hitting Bow in the process. One of the magicat’s ears flick. “Catra?”

“That thing is tough as nails and I don’t know if I did anything but before I got fuckin’ yeeted into oblivion, my claws did touch it for a second. Honestly doubt I did anything, it was only for a split second but I felt it.”

“Why are you telling me this now? Why didn’t you say anything before?!?”

“Well between you crying, us having a very uneasy alliance right now, and trying to figure out when to sleep and not be found by Prime, I couldn’t find any time. And, again, I don’t think I did anything seeing as Adora still nearly murdered us and barely listened to us. Just figured I’d point it out that I got close.”

“Well not close enough. Gods, I need to be alone right now.”

Without saying anything else, she heads off to somewhere quiet in the camp.

Adora runs a clean hand over the runestone, feeling the coldness against her skin. The stone has lost its sheen and the colors are dull. It no longer rests at the base of the tree in Plumeria. The images of taking over one of the kingdoms still are fresh in her mind. Capturing those that call that place home, taking out anyone who tried to resist, and finally ripping out the power source of one of the princesses. It took some time to drag this all the way back to Horde Prime’s ship. Now they just have to figure out how to tap into the power and use it.

More will be coming. The Pearl from Salineas should be coming soon. The easiest to take once Prime’s army rids the sea kingdom

of his brother's it will be easy pickings. Slowly and surely, the rest will follow and their power will be theirs. The rebels will cease to exist. Then it will be on to the next planet.

After some more time of thinking of her new accomplishment, making her brother even prouder, she exits the room. There is a small amount of downtime before she will be off on her next mission. She has lost track of time since joining Horde Prime. Maybe a week or so but whatever the case, Adora has been working hard to help her brother. One mission after the other she goes on, almost always coming back with a victory, with little moments in-between them. The only 'failure' she has had so far is the escape of the youngest princess. Though, it was not like she came back empty handed.

Adora steps into the prison cell. The farthest wall is a screen once more, recapping the events from the day before at Plumeria. Villagers trying to escape, those attempting to protect their home and losing, and the taking of the runestone. All being led by Adora. A feeling of pride starts to swell in her chest, knowing she has done right by Horde Prime. However, there is something else mixed in there. A small part of her whispers in her ear, asking her why she did this. It is quickly removed from her thoughts when she shakes her head and looks at the prisoner in the middle of the room.

Perfuma stares at the screen, either not realizing Adora has stepped in or not caring. Adora slowly makes her way to the princess. She finds the other girl with tears in her wide eyes. Her hands cover her mouth, blocking out any noise she can possibly be making. The screen flashes more images of Adora taking over Plumeria, a dark smile on her face. When the princess finally spots the blonde, she snaps her head towards her, anger flashing in her eyes.

"Why are you showing me this?" she asks. "Why are you making Adora do this?"

" *What makes you think Adora doesn't want to do this?"*

"Because I have known her for over a year now. She never would do something like this. She's not a monster like you are!"

" *We all have a side of ourselves we hide from others. Any and all anger and hurt everyone's precious hero bottled away I am simply allowing it to finally break free. She kept feeling like a failure, like she kept disappointing you all and wanting to live up to the name of She-ra. Why not let that all out and have someone who can give her praise she craves?"* Adora pulls something out of a hidden pocket. A red flower, one that grows all over Plumeria. She begins to play with the petals, plucking them out, and walks around the room. " *I can't believe you princesses still haven't caught onto it. Tsk."*

The screen shows the tree that once held the runestone being cut down. It took sometime to finally pry it free. The magic from the stone kept pushing anyone who attempted back. It is not until Adora enters does anything happen. She brings it down with only a couple of swipes of her sword. As she watches, a memory surfaces of the first time she went to Plumeria. How they were disappointed she couldn't heal the runestone. Now they don't have to worry about that. No more need to look towards She-ra for answers she doesn't have.

Perfuma turns away as the tree falls. Try as she might, she can't hide the crack in her voice.

"You're just manipulating her then. Using her emotions against her for your own gain. You bastard. And you won't get the other runestones. Whatever you are planning, it won't happen."

" *Plans are already in motion for that. Only a matter of time. If you still don't believe that then I guess I will leave this on for a little while longer."*

Adora begins to walk away. She places her hand on a pad, opening up the door. Her foot steps out into the hallway and that is as far as she gets before Perfuma's voice stops her in her tracks.

"You won't win. The others will stop you. They'll get Adora back. *Glimmer* will stop at nothing to get her back. She loves her too much to let you have her."

Adora whips her head around. Her hands become fist, crushing the flower. Just hearing Glimmer's name sends her heart and mind into a tailspin. The queen somehow survived both her attacks. She was the one who for months did nothing but fight and argue with her and made her feel horrible. The one who when she tried her best to do good and help out, only ended up spitting it back at her face.

But she also was the one who gave her a new home and helped her leave the Horde. The one who before shit hit the fan, made her feel better whenever she was feeling like she fell into a deep, dark hole. The one who slowly showed her what love was and made her feel something special for.

Adora lets out a small growl, her mind beginning to wage war on itself. One side yells at her, reminding her of all the heartache and suffering she had to endure for months. The other side fights as hard as it can to tell her off all the good times they had and how both were under so much stress. That there was regret on both sides. How did they allow things to get so bad between them?

She ditches the flower and exits the room, closing the door behind her, her mind and heart still racing. The back of her neck aches as she takes deep breaths, trying to settle her shaking body. Her thoughts are slowly replaced by the voice of Horde Prime, drowning out the war that goes on inside. *We really should deal with that pesky queen. She can't keep hurting you like this and making your mind a mess. Have to draw her out again. I think I know of a way. Let's begin getting read to head to Salineas.*

"Y-Yes b-brother," Adora says under her breath. She straightens herself out and sets her sights on the sea kingdom.

Not much happens over the next several days. More trying to stay hidden and away from the prying eyes of Horde Prime. More and more land is taken over by him, causing it to become harder to find safe places for the next camp. More and more survivors of attacks come seeking aid. Glimmer asks when she can if anyone has seen or heard about Adora. Nothing. The queen tries to occupy her time and not become overwhelmed by thoughts of what the blonde could be doing.

Her wounds are still slow to heal but thanks to her aunt, she has been able to go out on missions more often. It is nice to get out and do something finally, even if she is at half her strength and power. She is just happy to get out again and feel like she is doing something. If only she could know what Adora is up to. Not knowing what she is doing is more terrifying than knowing.

Finally after another move, there is some word. More stragglers come in. Familiar ones. They are from Plumeria. Many of them look injured and defeated. Glimmer helps with the aiding, bringing the injured and weak to the makeshift infirmary. While people are streaming through, she hears whispers of what happened. It makes her blood turn to ice.

It was Adora. Adora came all of a sudden. No one could stop her and the army with her. Anyone who tried to was quickly taken out. Everything happened so fast that not many people could process what happened until it was too late. The next thing anyone knew, Plumeria was captured and the runestone was taken.

Once she is able to, Glimmer leaves, needing time to process everything she just heard. She soon finds a spot on a soft patch of grass and settles in. Glimmer begins to stare off into the distance, not knowing what to think. Part of her wishes she didn't know what Adora was doing but now she does. She has helped take over Plumeria and has taken the runestone. It leaves a heavy feeling in the pit of the queen's stomach. What was going on in Adora's mind during all that?

Glimmer wonders how Perfuma is doing right now, if she is alive or not. If she hasn't been killed, is she chipped or fully aware of what is going on? Could she also be in the same position Glimmer found herself in all those days ago, locked alone in a cell, watching her home burn to the ground?

A hand runs through her hair. What is Prime planning on doing with the runestone? Is he going to go after the others? Glimmer makes a mental note to ask if anyone knows how the Pearl and the Black Garnet are. The last time she has been told, the Fractal Flake and the Moonstone are still safe. It helps that the Kingdom of Snows is hard to reach by any army, nestled high up in the mountains and a season of snowstorms is in full swing. Brightmoon, meanwhile, since the battle that was brought to it has been ready for any other attack. Even if they are no match for what Horde Prime might bring, they can still keep them at bay for some time. Hopefully enough to figure out what is going on and how to deal with it.

Glimmer wishes Adora was here and not being controlled. She always figured something to do when things looked bleak. And when she couldn't, when the two put their heads together, they could come up with something. Maybe it didn't always work but it was something and they could pick themselves up and learn from what went wrong. Now *everything* has gone wrong. Adora is gone and half the time Glimmer can't think straight. She just wants this nightmare to end and have Adora back, safe and sound. She wants to see her bright, wide smile and hear her infectious laugh again.

There are the sounds of footsteps. Glimmer shifts her eyes to look out of the corner of her vision. Her father is walking up to her. He stops a couple feet away and sits down on the grass besides her.

"How are you holding up?" he asks.

Glimmer doesn't answer right away. She doesn't know, in all honesty. If she has to describe how she is feeling the one word that would come out of her mouth would be 'nothing'. Everything

feels numb. It takes her extra effort to think about the question, her mind wanting to drift off into thinking of nothing. And what does she even say to the man who has been gone for most of her life? As much as she has missed him, she doesn't know him. Only through stories has she been told what her father is like. Speaking her feelings is already hard enough but how can she spill what eats her up inside to someone who is essentially like a stranger to her?

"If you don't want to talk about it, that's fine. We can talk about something else if you like," Micah says.

"No...No. Sorry, Dad, this is just...weird," Glimmer admits.

"I understand how you feel. Your aunt actually had to give me tips on what I could say to you. It has been so long since I tried to give out advice."

Somehow, this makes Glimmer feel a little better. "It's just...a lot. Everything. It seems so bleak and...I don't know if I can do anything." Glimmer wraps her arms around her legs and pulls them close to her chest. "I don't know if I have been a good queen...or a good friend."

"From what I have been told, you seemed to have been doing fine. Being queen at your age? I don't think I could handle that."

"Thanks…"

Silence fills the air. Glimmer chews the bottom of her lip, not knowing if she should say anything else. Out of the corner of her eyes, she can see her father is not having an easy time with this either. After some moments, the older spellcaster speaks up once more.

"Are you still thinking about Adora?"

"How can I not? I feel like I failed her. I never got to give her a proper apology for yelling at her and now I might not be able to.

Twice now I couldn't save her. Twice now I couldn't be…" Glimmer thinks of the right word to say. "I couldn't be a hero to her."

When her father makes a noise, she turns her head towards him. A small smile has formed on his face. "You two are so alike. She said almost the same exact thing about you on Beast Island."

"W-What?"

"Tell me about, Adora. I only had so much time to get to know her and I would like to know some more."

Glimmer thinks for a moment. "Amazing. She always is trying her best, helping people even if that means putting herself second. Brave, loving, hard-headed...I honestly can't find the words to describe her because how do you do something like that to someone as wonderful as her?"

Glimmer plucks at some grass blades for a moment, not knowing what to say. For all her faults, her stubbornness, her altruism that can be borderline dangerous, and her ticks about being on time and everything needing to be in order, Glimmer can't help but love them. Sure it can get on her nerves but they still make Adora *Adora.* Just like her warm laugh or her intelligence or the way she knows how to make the queen feel safe and sound.

"I miss her...a lot. I can only hope we can get her back. She's one of the best things that has ever happened to me. I might have messed things up between us before I got captured and I really want to make it up to her. Talk to her about what happened between us and try to fix things…"

"Don't give up hope, sweetheart. She is still alive, isn't she? She has to be in there somewhere. If I can fight for almost fifteen years on an island full of monsters and come back alive, I am sure Adora can find her way back from Horde Prime's control. There always is hope. You just have to know where to look for it."

"Aunt Casta told me the same thing. Where am I supposed to find it with this?"

“I don’t know. I clung onto the idea of seeing you, you mother, Casta, and Brightmoon again. That is what gave me hope.”

Glimmer attempts to think about to cling to. The whole hoping that she can break through isn’t doing so much anymore after everything that has happened. Even then, if Adora does come back there still is the question about what will happen between them. Will Adora forgive her? Can Glimmer forgive her? She wants her back so badly but everything that happened between them still stings. How will those wounds heal?

She takes a deep breath, saying nothing else.

“You must be hungry. Do you want to see what everyone else is up to and see if dinner is ready?”

Glimmer only nods and follows her father back to the campsite. The two find Bow, Frosta, Entrapta, and the Star Siblings sitting around a fire. Catra is there also but sitting on a large rock, off to the side. Glimmer is too far away from the group to hear them clearly but whatever they are talking about doesn’t seem to be bad. There are some smiles on faces. When she reaches the fire, the queen finds a spot next to Bow and Starla. “What are you guys talking about?” she asks.

“Not much. Just trying to get our minds off of things. You hungry?” Starla says. When Glimmer nods, the youngest Star Sibling grabs an extra plate of food and hands it to her. It is some mix of vegetables and some meat she does not quite recognize. Everyone else seems to be enjoying it so she begins to eat it.

“What’s the topic?”

“Just random old stories from the past,” Catra pipes up. “Arrow Head was just finishing up his story about some of his brothers and him being nerds.”

Bow rolls his eyes. “Well what about you? You haven’t told any stories yet.”

“Well...that’s a little complicated…”

“Why? Does the Horde not allow for good stories?” Glimmer asks.

“Well, a lot were shit but...all the ones that aren't involve Adora.”

Oh.

“Well...if you don’t mind me asking, can we hear them?” Jewelstar says. “I know it is a bit of a sore topic right now but I’d love to get to know her more. From what little time I spent with her, she seems great.”

Catra smiles softly. “She is. Too great for me after all the shit I put through her. I remember once when we were kids, maybe like twelve, I got into some stuff. Banged myself up pretty good,” the magicat rubs her left shoulder. “Adora patched me up even though I sort of dragged her into it all. She chewed me out but she still helped me for what I did… She kept doing that all her life…”

“She is pretty amazing,” Bow says. “Glimmer, remember the time you two met my dads and she was trying so hard to sound impressive she kept messing up words?”

Glimmer laughs. “Course I do. ‘Dora still sometimes will just say words wrong just for the hell of it. Makes me laugh all the time.”

“I remember that one time Adora first tried a snow cone and got a brain freeze. She was pretty startled, I guess she never had one before, but ended up still loving the snow cone.” Frosta adds on.

Stories start to pop up left and right. Some of the fun at princess prom before all the shit that went down, all the help she has given, the two times she got ‘drunk’, or about how she was able to bring the princesses together to re-spark the rebellion. The Star Siblings tell their own short story. How they fought Adora when they first saw her but quickly allowed her to eat with them (which she ended up eating most of the berries). Even for that short amount of time she was with the trio, she made an impression on

them. Every now and again, one of the moments earns some laughter.

The stories continue, Micah going on about Beast Island some more. Glimmer listens to them all. It is hard to hear them, stories from a better time, but a smile still finds its way across her face. Her heart lifts when Micah tells them how Adora was able to regain her ability to turn into She-ra by thinking of her, of Glimmer. So even after all they've been through, after that last spat they had over the Heart, she still cared about her. A knife twists inside of Glimmer's heart.

"What about you, Sparkles. You've been quiet. Don't got any stories?" Catra asks.

Glimmer thinks for a moment. It takes some time to search through her mind, shifting through months of hate and anger. There are so many good memories to pick, how can she choose? Mystacor, Adora's first night at Brightmoon, showing her all new things, sparing together...there is so much. Finally, she settles on something.

"I remember this one time, Adora wanted to surprise me for my birthday. Bow told her that it was coming up and explained to her what people usually do on birthdays. What with the war and what not, time for a party was hard. Still, Adora wanted to do something. I remember hearing her stay up late, which was odd for her, and asking if everything was okay. She just played it off and then kicked me out of her room. I was confused but hey, it was 'Dora. Who knows what she was planning?

"Anyway, some days pass. Forgot about it. Got so worked up thinking about how to push the Horde back again that I didn't realize what day it was until Adora burst into my room at like seven in the morning. I asked her what the hell she was doing and she first told me 'Happy Birthday' but then she told me to close my eyes. I listened and then when she told me to open them there was this purple, knitted scarf in my hands. It was a

little lopsided and uneven but Adora told me she got help from my aunt.

“She wanted to make me something really special and something I could use and somehow a scarf ended up being made. Adora knew it wasn’t the best since she never made one before and it was rushed because of the time frame but promised to make me a better one one day. I didn’t really care. She made it for me, took time out of her day and night to craft it. That was enough for me. I still have it back in my room but I think that is when I fe-” she cuts herself off.

“What?” Starla asks.

“N-Nothing. Adora is something else and there was so much fighting between us those last few months we were together. She hurt me and I hurt her. I hope that when this is all over and we get her back, we can have more of those good memories. They are some of my favorite memories and I’d love to have more.”

“I am sure we will,” Bow says, giving her a nudge. “Do you want to change the subject or talk more about her?”

“Nah, I like to hear some more. It’s good to hear them.”

Adora stares at the bracelet resting on the nightstand besides her, unable to sleep. Her mind has been a mess the past few days since the piece of jewelry randomly reappeared out of thin air. Every time she closes her eyes, she sees the image of Glimmer, fright written all over her face, somewhere in the Whispering Woods. The cry of her name echoes in her mind repeatedly. The blonde struggles to tell herself that what she saw and heard was not real, it was all made up. It just has to be...But why would her mind come up with such a terrible thing? It is not like she hasn’t been sleeping (up until this point). She hasn’t had any nightmares either to keep her up or mess with her mind. As far as she is aware, she hasn’t been drugged or infected by anything. Nothing should be causing this.

Yet, whatever is happening won't cease to be. At random, when she is passing a window or just looking out one she sees rips, as she has been calling them, in the world. They are all small moments in time but leave burns in her mind. The most recent are places on fire, frightened and horrified faces of Etherians, the bright red of blood, and the Kingdom of Plumeria under an invasion. Something about those last rips makes her stomach twist into a tight knot and threatens to make her throw up. Everything has been so perfect up until now, why is this happening?

*And why **hasn't** she had any nightmares? They used to plague her all the time. Even when Glimmer slept with her, and who is unconscious besides her now, they still would slither their way into her dreams and wreak havoc on her unconscious mind. Actually, thinking about it, has she had any dreams as of late? The more she tries to make sense of the world around her, the less sense there is. No nightmares, no recollection of how Horde Prime was defeated or when she admitted her feelings for Glimmer, no idea how Glimmer will sometimes appear out of nowhere with no rhyme or reason, and more. There has to be some answer but she has no idea where she could find it.*

Trying to distract herself a little, she shifts in bed, being careful not to wake her girlfriend. Glimmer sleeps peacefully, her arm draped over the blonde's stomach and her head buried in her shoulder. In the light of the moons, she looks beautiful. Adora always finds her as such, however. Even if things are confusing at the moment, the queen is all she could have ever asked for. More than that. Happiness and joy always is near when she is around Glimmer. But there has been something slowly growing in her chest, eating away at her as she tries to figure out what is going on.

She doesn't quite know how to describe what is beginning to weigh her down. Every time she looks at Glimmer there is that moment of warmth and peace but it quickly morphs into something else. She can feel goosebumps forming on her skin and her hairs on the back of her neck stand on edge. Just like the

feeling of warmth before, it quickly disappears. That doesn't make it any less unpleasant. They start to form now as she stares at the queen.

After some time, with the feeling only slowly going away, Adora decides to crawl out of bed. Thankfully, Glimmer stays fast asleep. Good. There is no need to be followed. Careful not to create any noise, she exists. Once outside, the blonde begins to walk around aimlessly down the hall, no destination in her mind. No one else is in the halls, thankfully. Her thoughts follow closely behind, waiting for her to let her guard down just enough to pounce on her. Adora picks up her pace.

She finally stops after some turns. Adora finds herself in a hallway she does not go down a lot. She leans against a cold window and looks outside it, taking a gamble. The world outside is that of Brightmoon. The dark canvas that is the sky is lit up by thousands of bright stars and at least half the moons. Everything is so quiet, still. There is an uneasy feeling in her chest. Growing up in the Horde where there always was noise going on, silence never was a good thing. Even if the war is over, it should not be this quiet.

She wipes away some of the frost from the window and looks at herself. There are bags forming under her eyes and she swears she looks a bit pale. The lack of sleep definitely is not doing her any good. Her body has become heavier and it feels as if some of her strength has been sapped from her. Adora has tried to do her best to sleep and gotten some, but is it still not enough to prevent her body from starting to deteriorate? Maybe that is helping her mind showing her things that shouldn't be there.

Almost on cue, she tastes salt in her mouth and smells seaweed. For the briefest of moments she sees the sea but it is gone as fast it showed up. Salineas is a long trek away from Brightmoon. Why would she feel like she is there? Adora groans and rests her head on the cold glass. She squeezes her eyes shut as a headache starts to form. They are kept closed until the pain disappears.

However, when the world comes back to her, it is not what she expected.

She is sitting at the table that once was used to map out everything going on in Etheria. A tray of food sits in front of her and Glimmer sits next to her, eating her own breakfast. Adora shoves her chair back, bolting out of it. How did she end up here?

"Woah! Adora, are you okay?" Glimmer asks. She stands up and walks over to her girlfriend.

"What the hell happened? Why am I here?" Adora asks, trying to keep panic from entering her voice.

"You left the room at some point during the night so I went looking for you. I found you passed out resting on a window. What was up with that?" Glimmer takes some steps forward and wraps her arms around Adora's neck. "It's not like you to pass out somewhere that random."

Fingers brush against her neck, near the base. Adora winces at the touch, feeling that hot pain from days before again. She removes her girlfriend's arms and holds her hands tight in her own. "I couldn't sleep but I could've sworn I never went back to bed. I never came here."

"You were really sleepy even when I woke you. Maybe you were just dreaming of some stuff, a nightmare, and it got all muddled? I walked you here half dead and you finally just snapped to reality."

Could that have been it? Could her dreams have blurred into reality? She woke up, passed out, and thought she smelled the sea? Sure, she has had a couple of dreams and nightmares where it took time to figure out what really happened and that her brain was just being horrible to her. But what about all those other times she saw things that shouldn't have been there? Those times she knows for a fact she was awake, wasn't she?

The headache comes back full force. Adora clutches the side of her head.

"What's wrong? Does your head hurt? Do you want me to get you something?"

"No. No, I am fine. Just a little headache. It's nothing."

"Are you sure? I have noticed you acting a little off and you look like you haven't slept. What's the matter?"

Adora takes a moment, debating to see what would happen if she spills. She decides to let a small leak of information out. "I...I just haven't been feeling great. I keep thinking about not remembering things like defeating Prime. Being here this isn't helping. Neither is my head."

"Maybe it's stress? You just gotta relax, everything is okay now and you don't have to worry about how we defeated Prime. It's done and over with. Just take a deep breath and chill for once. That will help you sleep and then maybe you will feel better after that."

Well, stress definitely isn't helping. Though, that is not what started this all. It has become a side effect. Adora turns her gaze away from Glimmer, not liking the thought it is just one thing or her answer about Horde Prime. The blonde knows she should tell her girlfriend more, after all they always used to share secrets, but something in the back of her mind tells her not to. She doesn't need anything else to worsen this headache.

"What are you thinking about?" Glimmer asks.

Adora takes a breath, hoping she can pull off an alright face. The pain from her head is almost blinding but she powers through it with a smile. "Nothing. I'm fine. Okay? I just need to eat and drink some stuff and then maybe this will go away."

"Well, if it does not go away tell me. I will fix it."

Glimmer pushes herself up onto her toes and places a kiss on Adora's lips. There is that warmth the blonde has grown to love but it isn't as strong. There is no tenderness to it. There is a feeling of nothingness and there is an uneasy feeling growing in her chest. This isn't right. But when they pull apart, she says nothing.

"How about we eat. I made your favorite," Glimmer says.

"S-Sure, Glimmer. Sure," Adora finally speaks. Something then pops into her mind. "Hey, can I ask a question?"

"What?"

We apologized to each other right? Like, I don't remember saying sorry for hurting you or talking to you about being hurt myself. I don't remember anything other than being on Darla."

That was all we needed. We realized afterwards everything would be fine and we are dating now, aren't we? You should stop thinking so much or you are going to make your headache worse. Eat."

Adora does as she is told and sits back down, though her thoughts never become quiet.

Chapter End Notes

This week shout out/fic rec is my friend's Say Anything future au/fankid fic She-Ra: Heart of Courage. It's a good fic and if you want some fankid stuff, there ya go.

Here

Chapter Notes

> surprise update! i couldn't resist posting this and also tomorrow is a holiday here in america so eh why not just post it now and take a break tomorrow? That being said, more than likely the next update will be two weeks so re catch up and because its just been slow the next chapter lol
>
> anyway, I do have to thank my friend Dorku again for looking over the fight scene in this and giving me tips and what not. hopefully yall enjoy this beast of a chapter and kudos and comments as always are appreciated

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora kicks the bit of rubble that sticks out of the ash that once was a building. The grey dust shoots up, creating a small cloud that floats up in the air. For a moment, she attempts to figure out what it is she just pushed over. Piece of stone, maybe from a fireplace? Or a table? Maybe it could have been part of a project someone was working on. Who knows and who cares. No one's around. Those that once called this place home either have been dealt with or slipped away. Only a few got away, less than before, but that is the least of her concerns. Maybe they will bump into Glimmer, wherever she is, and tell her what has happened. Have her seek Adora out once more or cross paths. She has been trying to do this for days now and nothing has come about it. Maybe something else will catch her attention.

She begins to walk, looking around for anything useful. Not much. Some material that could be used for building more robots. Some books that either avoided being burned or are not badly scorched could hold some information on Etheria and those that live on this planet. Nothing else catches her eye. Not surprising that many of these villages are not much to note about. The only places of worth are the kingdoms. Adora and Horde Prime have already

reaped the rewards from two of them. Three more. Three more and then all of Etheria and its' magic will belong to Prime.

Maybe kidnapping some more princesses will help draw her out? They always have been close to each other. Killing them could work also as they don't really need them. It's better to keep them alive, though, and break them into giving information. Still, either one of those ideas could make the queen furious enough to look for another fight. Out of them all, she needs to be rid of so Adora's mind can stop being spun into a mess. Glimmer is like an annoying thorn in her side. Stubbornly burying herself in her skin and no matter how hard Adora tries, she cannot pull her out. The sooner she is out the better.

For a brief moment, her foot catches nothing but air. It is enough to cause her to stumble. Adora quickly catches herself, preventing any fall to the damaged ground. She curses in her head, hating that her body seems to be protesting all the hard work she has been doing lately. The blonde straightens herself up. She takes a breath to recompose herself before continuing on her walk.

Still almost nothing but ash and rubble. A small doll lays near some fallen bricks. Adora picks it up and examines it. Scorch marks cover its body and some stuffing spills out from the cut on its leg. A small part of her wonders what became of the family that lived here and the child or children this toy belongs to. But the thought does not last long. The blonde tosses the doll a few more times in her hands before casting it aside. It rejoins the remainder of this home as Adora turns her back on it.

The villagers fought hard here, hence a lot of the destruction. Everything would have been torn down anyway and been replaced by Horde Prime's own creations but a message had to be sent right away. Hopefully, the Etherians will grasp soon what will happen if you keep resisting. Misery, pain, suffering, death, it will just make things worse. All of it can be avoided if they just accepted Horde Prime's light. He took away her own torment and she finally found peace. Why can't everyone else see that?

There is no point in staying here any longer. She will need to report back to Horde Prime, though he always seems to know what is going on. Regardless, he likes to see her after each mission to see how she is doing and to give her the next mission. She wonders what she will be expected to do next.

Whenever Adora heads back to where you are able to travel between Horde Prime's ship and Etheria, it becomes a blur to her. One moment, she is walking through the Whispering Woods, and then, she is in the sleek hallways. Even when she leaves it happens. Adora does not question it. As long as she can go to and fro, that is all that matters. She passes clones, prisons, and empty rooms. Down halls that all look the same she goes.

At one point, she goes down a hall that adds at least another minute or so to her travel to Prime. The other direction, one that shortens her time, is one she actively avoids. She has not been down there since her first time on the ship when she joined Horde Prime's light. There is no need to be there anymore. Still, every time she passes it, her heart picks up the pace.

Finally, she finds Horde Prime. He is talking to a clone. About what, Adora doesn't know. When he spots her, he waves his brother off before closing the gap between him and the blonde. "Still no luck on finding the queen?"

Adora shakes her head.

"Must be binding her time. Surprised she has not appeared yet even after everything. She is sworn to protect others and yet they end up under our own protection and light. Is she even fit to call herself queen when she can barely lead. Worthless and pathetic."

Adora cannot stop her hands from shaking. Try as she might, they twitch as something begins to boil inside of her. She clutches them into a fist in some attempt to settle them. Whatever the feeling forming in her chest is, it is hot and threatens to spread throughout all of her body. Hearing him talk about Glimmer and how she fairs as queen does not sit well with her for some reason.

Before she can put a name to what is growing inside of her, the chip on the back of her neck comes to life, becoming the only sensation she feels. Her body relaxes and her hands unfurl.

"No matter. You still have done good and I am proud of you little sister. You are a hard worker and have gone above and beyond what I needed you to do." Cold fingers are placed under her chin. Adora flinches slightly. Horde Prime ignores her discomfort at part of her face being touched and continues. "You do seem a little tired, however. I still need you to keep on working bringing others to the light but I think we can allow for an hour's rest."

Adora slowly nods. Prime slowly removes his hand from under the blonde's chin, who lets out a small sigh when he lets go. Part of her does not want to rest, there is still so much to be done, but orders are orders. She will not defy them. Adora steps out of the way to let him pass and walk down the end of the hall, disappearing behind a corner. Once he is gone, Adora finds someplace to 'rest' before heading back out.

Mission after mission Glimmer goes on, hoping to occupy her mind. Scouting and avoiding the watchful eyes of clones and robots. Helping take care of survivors of Horde Prime and Adora's attacks. Or staying back at whatever camp she finds herself at and figuring out a plan of attack or learning new spells from her aunt or father. Some nights she finds sleep though there always is a fifty-fifty shot of either waking up from a black void still tired and heavy as lead or be startled awake by nightmares of Horde Prime and him forcing Adora to do his bidding.

Glimmer wishes every chance she can get to find the blonde once more and do something. But after the disaster that occurred before, there needs to be a better plan. If she, Catra, and Melog can barely do anything against She-ra, there needs to be a lot of thought put into the next attempt. Bow keeps a close eye on her anyway, knowing how she feels and wanting to do the same but not wanting to lose anyone else. The queen cannot blame him at

all so she settles into this routine of trying to find some peace at night and doing whatever she can during daylight.

Any word about what is going on or if there have been any more signs Adora is in there somewhere have been far and few between. Communication has become worse and a lot has become word of mouth. Most of it is bad news. More places taken over. More people being kidnapped, disappearing, Glimmer wonders if any of them are being controlled like Adora. Worst of all, some people have turned up dead. A bitter, foul taste forms in the queen's mouth whenever she thinks if Prime has made Adora have a hand in that. Whenever that thought crosses her mind, she quickly shakes it from her mind and quickly finds something to do.

There are some victories. Small ones but helps keep hope alive. Taking out a number of robots or clones, getting more people to join their fight, and at least once, they have been able to stop the raid on a village. Even if Horde Prime's army will come back again, for now, they have been pushed back. That is something to smile about. Especially after everything that has happened as of late.

One day, Glimmer finds herself looking over some maps and notes, trying to take a guess where either they can strike or where Prime will hit next, or find a good campsite next. The latter has become harder and harder as of late. She bites down her lip in worry. Time is starting to betray them. If they don't think of something fast or a miracle doesn't drop on their laps soon, they might all be doomed.

When she starts to become tired of staring at papers and trying to piece things together, Glimmer decides to put everything away. It can wait a little bit. The queen stands up, stretches out her body, and begins to look around the campsite, seeing if anyone else needs help with anything.

Scorpia has returned, safe and sound from some successful missions. Glimmer hasn't spoken to her much or met her gaze, feeling bad for what happened with Perfuma. Whatever the

scorpion princess feels about what happened, she doesn't show it. Instead, like right now, she gets to know new faces like the Star Siblings. She and Starla really seem to have hit it off. That is good at least. Meanwhile, Mermista and Sea Hawk are still away. Last time the queen heard, they are still doing okay.

Entrapta is nowhere to be found, probably still tinkering with some robot parts or doing gods know what. Her father and aunt have been making up for some lost time and help those with magical powers train up as much as possible. Frosta does her best with that also, helping by sparring with some people. The queen won't lie, it is kind of funny seeing some grown-ass adults afraid of a small, twelve-year-old with ice for fist.

Finally, she finds Bow. Her best friend is firing off some arrows at a target, hitting almost all of them dead in the center. He stops when Glimmer walks up by him. "Hey. What's up?"

"Not much. Waiting to do something," Glimmer answers.

"Same. At least it is good to get some training in. Have you been practicing your magic? Gotten any stronger?"

"A bit yes." Bonding time with her father and aunt most of the time now is training. Her magic has almost come back completely and she has learned one or two new spells. Maybe they will be good against Horde Prime but who knows. At least she is starting to feel powerful again. Her wounds inflicted by Adora have almost all but healed. They are now just sore every now and again.

Glimmer is about to open her mouth to say something more when a noise catches her attention. She and Bow look towards the direction and both spot a light shooting up into the sky. In a moment, it takes the form of Horde Prime.

Everyone freezes at the sight. No one can pull their eyes away from the large, looming hologram. Where is it even coming from? At some point, Glimmer remembers someone saying Horde Prime has done something like this before. This is her first time,

however, and even if it is nothing but a projection, seeing her captor for the first time in a couple of weeks sends cold shivers down her spine. He still leaks out imitation and control. Glimmer feels her legs beginning to give out and she leans on Bow for support. He holds herself steady as Prime begins to speak.

"It has been quite some time since I last spoke to all of you," he begins.

Glimmer shudders at the sound of his voice. The last time she heard it, it came out of Adora's mouth. It was so unnatural coming out of her. So wrong and twisted. Now that it is coming out of its actual owner, it barely makes it better. She wants to block him out, not hear his voice any more than she has too. But there has to be a reason for his appearance here. Glimmer swallows the rising fear and anxiety as she forces herself to listen to him speak.

"You have shown to be quite strong, I will admit that. I never have met anyone as resilient and stubborn as all of you. I must say, it gives me some joy to finally meet some people once more with a bit of spirit. However, I must also say I have begun to grow tired of that spirit of yours. It has become quite the bother as of late and I think it is in both our interest if things go a different way."

"I suggest you stop resisting. It will only make things worse for you. Come to the light and everything will be so much easier. Your own She-ra has already joined," he shifts slightly, allowing Adora to appear beside him. She remains silent, her blank eyes scanning the area. Can she or Prime see any of Etheria from wherever they are? Can they see her and Bow and everyone else?

Just the sight of Adora causes Glimmer's breathing to become tight in her throat. By now, most everyone has gotten word about Adora in Horde Prime clutches. However, he must want to make it clear that they are on the losing side since the warrior princess 'on' his side. Glimmer prays that most people who have been affected by Adora know that this isn't her. That she would never

do anything like this. She isn't a monster and shouldn't be painted as such.

Glimmer wonders what Adora has been doing since their last fight. Her eyes stay trained on the blonde, wishing to just reach out and grab her from the hologram. Hold her tight in her arms and soak in her heat and tell her everything will be alright.

"We have taken two of your runestone and it has not ended well for those that tried to fight back. Surrender now and all this pain and suffering can end. Those that continue to fight will only face punishment. Join our light and you can find peace." With that, he and Adora disappear.

"He-He has another one?!? Who do you think it was?!? Do you think Adora stole another one? Do you think Brightmoon is okay?!?" Glimmer asks, clutching onto Bow tight. Could Prime already have gotten to Brightmoon? Or was it one of the other kingdoms? How close is he to gaining the others?

"I don't know. I wouldn't think so. Brightmoon is hard to get to," Bow tells her. "It can be anyone."

Glimmer looks up and sees he is trying to not panic. She attempts to follow his lead. "Maybe he is just trying to get into our heads. Maybe he only has the Heart Blossom and we still have most of the runestones."

"Maybe." he doesn't sound that sure. Glimmer steps away. She stares up at the pink, darkening sky. Even with Horde Prime and Adora gone, she can still feel their presence staring down at her and everyone else, as if they were nothing more than ants. The queen is starting to feel like she is one. That she has no power at all and anything can easily step on her and crush her.

Her gaze turns downward, her eyes searching around the area. Everyone has the same look of shock on their faces. Frosta is fiddling with the hem of her jacket, looking down at the ground. She probably is wondering the same thing Glimmer is thinking

about her own kingdom. Catra is chewing on her thumb, thought written all over her face. Scorpia creates some small sparks from her claws, possibly seeing if she still has her newly forged connection to her runestone. Glimmer wishes she can do that but alas, she cannot. Her want to return home grows. If only it wasn't so far away or so risky. If only she could teleport.

There is not much anyone else can do. Everyone starts to move about, trying to find something to do. The air is heavy and no one can seem to keep their shoulders from being pulled down by an unseen weight. It is quiet but whispers are everywhere. Some ask if they should give up or not. Others wonder what else they can do to win, if there is anything. Some ask what they should do about Adora, how they should stop her even if its by any means. The last one sits uneasily in Glimmer's stomach. The second she is able to, she heads into a small tent that has become her own quarters thanks to those that live here.

Glimmer begins to paces around her 'room', anxiety fueling her. She let her guard down for a moment, having some sort of hope with their minuscule wins, and now this happens. Hearing two of the runestone have been captured. One, she knows of. The other one can be anyone's guess. Could it have been the Pearl or the Black Garnet? Those two would be the easiest pickings. Could he have gotten up to the mountains and taken the Fractal Flake? And what about her own? Has Brightmoon finally fallen?

Everything that could go wrong is going on and even more so. At this rate with Adora doing his bidding and Prime collecting the runestone to do only the gods know what, all of Etheria will soon be taken over. What will happen to the planet she calls home and loves dearly? Be blown up like the Heart was set to do? Become a desolate wasteland of nothingness? Will everyone be forced to listen to him and do as told or risk being killed? Will there be anything left after everything is all set and done?

Glimmer can't help but feel like she has failed everyone. Her people, both those in Brightmoon and all across Etheria, for seeking out the Heart and causing the chain reaction that brought

Prime here. To her friends, Bow, and the princesses, for getting them all caught up in this mess. To her family, her mother, for not living up as queen and protecting those she has been sworn to. To Adora, for everything. The queen wonders how she will ever make it up to anyone for what she has done.

Anger begins to boil inside of her. In a flash, it overtakes her. She grabs the closest thing to her, some sort of metal scrap that she forgot to give back to Entrapta, and unleashes everything by throwing it across the room. It connects with a large, standing mirror that has not been used in some time, shattering it. Her breathing becomes ragged as her body begins to settle down from the release of adrenaline. Pieces of the reflective glass fall and land on the ground below. Her reflection looks back at her through the cracks that spread across the mirror, causing the image of herself to be spilt and parts missing for the absent bits of the glass. The harder Glimmer stares at the broken mess, the more her reflection glares back, daring her to make a move.

However, she remains still, not knowing what to do next. Everything is happening so fast, all at once. Glimmer takes deep breaths, trying to think but coming up with nothing at all. Her body threatens to break just like the glass feet away from her and it takes everything in her not to allow that to occur. She doesn't need another breakdown. Not now. That definitely won't make things any better.

The only thing she knows that she can do is she cannot give up. Not yet. If there is anything she can do to right all the wrongs she has caused, it is not giving up to see them through to the end. The queen decides to deal with the mess she made today with the glass later, being the least of her concerns at the moment. Instead, she grabs some papers out of her bag to try and focus her mind on some plan of attack.

Adora begins to avoid looking at any windows. She doesn't want to keep seeing things and feel like she is losing her mind.

Glimmer's comment on it being chalked up to stress days ago still plays in her mind. It does not help in the slightest. There is no way it can be that since it all started when she tripped over the bracelet (which while she thinks, she plays with in her hands). She keeps her mouth shut about it even though she wishes to ask more. Something else besides the windows has been bothering her now. It doesn't seem to be just them causing these rips.

The blonde swears anything that reflects light shows her something. Most of the time, it is the same as always. Spilt seconds of seeing some part of Etheira, some of it she does not know. Sometimes, she sees images of white, sleek halls. They are rare occurrences and she cannot put a name to it. Whatever it is, it always seems to be on the tip of her tongue but whenever she gets close, for some reason her neck aches. It always pulls her attention away. Adora has given up trying to figure out what those rips are from, not wanting any more pain. The worst though was the time she looked at herself in a mirror.

All she was doing was getting ready for the day. She was hoping maybe nothing would happen. Over and over again she repeated in her mind that if she could make it through twenty-four hours of not seeing anything, then it really could just be stress. And if it really was that, she could find a way to relax and finally rid herself of what she had been seeing. But just as Adora was finishing up, pulling her dark blonde locks behind her into a ponytail, her reflection changed. Her tired, scarred face was blank, no emotion anywhere. Her hair no longer fell past her shoulders. She has no idea where it ends, being slicked back into a uniform shape but it has been drastically shortened. What sent shivers down her spine the most from the flash was her eyes. Blue did not look back at her. Rather, a sick, glowing color of green.

It took everything in her not to cry out. A hand slapped over her mouth just as a scream tried to escape her throat and alert everyone in the castle. In a blink, the image was gone and the mirror reflected back her frightened face. Her bright blue eyes were wide with horror and she swore she was even paler from seeing herself like that. Adora quickly finished tying back her hair,

keeping her eyes away from the mirror, and headed out of her room.

That was a couple of days ago, she believes. Time has become just as confusing. Everything is confusing. The more she tries to puzzle everything together, the worse the unknown pain that lingers in the back of her neck becomes or the more tense headaches form. It makes all her attempts to do anything almost impossible.

Groaning and not in the mood for one of those things to happen, she shoved the bracelet in her pocket and presses herself harder against one of the outside walls of Brightmoon castle in an attempt to ground herself more. To make everything feel real again and not a mess. The sun that beats down on her gives her some sense of warmth and security. It seems to be the only thing that does that anymore.

She wonders where Glimmer is. With all the times the queen has appeared when Adora's heart and mind began to race like someone gave a child a caffeine shot, it is a surprise she hasn't appeared yet. Her appearing out of thin air used to be a normal occurrence but now it is creepy. Adora has been lowkey trying to avoid her, feeling something wrong about it. Not to mention the dismissal in her tone when she attempted to talk to her doesn't help. That is not like Glimmer at all. Least, not when they weren't fighting. And they aren't, right? She told her they made up...

Her eyes catch movement. Bow. Adora pushes herself off of the wall and jogs over to one of her best friends. He stops his stride as she comes closer. "What's up, Adora?"

"Bow, can I-" she pauses for a second, debating what to do, "ask you something stupid?"

He raises an eyebrow. "Sure?"

"You haven't noticed anything weird, have you?"

"Like what?"

"Anything. Seeing weird things or hearing anything? Just anything that would make you feel like something is up and you feel like you are losing your mind."

"Are you okay, Adora? You look tired. Have you been sleeping well?"

"That doesn't matter."

"Well if you haven't been sleeping then you might be hallucinating things so it does matter." Bow places a hand on her shoulder. "You should just rest and take it easy and then everything will be fine. It'll go away like a bad dream."

"It's not a lack of sleep! Trust me, Bow!" Adora states, a bit of an edge to her voice. "Something is wrong and I don't know what it is!"

"Everything is fine. There is nothing to worry about. There is no more war, no more Horde, and no more Prime. We can finally relax. You were trying to learn how to do that, weren't you?"

*"But that is **exactly** it! How did we win? How did we bring peace? I can't remember any of it! Everything is blank. One moment I am still on the ship, unable to talk to Glimmer about everything that happened between us because we had to save Catra's sorry butt, and the next, I'm here. Here and everything is alright. The war is won, Glimmer is my girlfriend, and Catra is my friend again. Oh, and Angella is back from the dead.*

*"I know thanks to Shadow Weaver my memory can be crap sometimes but it has never been like **this.** No one seems to be bothered by the fact everything is so peaceful. It doesn't feel right."*

"You might just be overthinking things. Maybe if you relax-"

Adora pushes Bow away before throwing her hands in the air. "Forget it! You are starting to sound just like Glimmer now. I am

still waiting for her to randomly appear and parrot what you just said."

She doesn't stick around to hear the rest of Bow's explanation. She will find her answers one way or another.

It has to be almost noon, maybe a little past it. Glimmer has no idea how to tell the time with the sun, apparently you used to be able to do so. She does her best to guess based on the time she knows it was when she left and her own clock. Hopefully, the queen is right with the hour. If she is not back at the camp by a certain point, people will begin to worry. After the fiasco with sneaking away with Catra, she (and the magicat) have been watched a little more just in case. No need for any more loss. Taking a breath, Glimmer continues her walk through some part of the Whispering Woods she doesn't know.

There has not been much on this scouting mission. Maybe one of two robots she was able to destroy but that is about it. If anything, she will be returning home *early* with nothing to show or say. That could be good, though. Least it is not like she is bringing back news she found some burned down village. But it isn't like she will be able to say anything useful that would help gain an upper hand in this mess. With any luck, someone might have something of use. When walking starts to become tiring, Glimmer decides to find a spot that is hidden enough and settles down.

Feeling safe, she begins to go over everything she can in her head. Adora has been controlled for around a couple of weeks now. Both fights with her have not ended well at all. She has helped capture not only one of the princesses but at least one of the runestones. Horde Prime has another which is anyone's guess whose it is if he is not bluffing. If Adora had a part in it, that is also a giant question mark.

More and more of Etheria is still being captured and who knows what is happening to those in the line of fire by Prime. Only a

small push back as occurred. She has mostly healed and gotten at least some of her powers back. No one has any idea how to defeat Horde Prime other than getting really lucky. He has to have some sort of weakness. Everyone does, don't they? What in the world can stop someone as powerful as him?

Snap!

Glimmer's body goes tense. She freezes like ice, refusing to breathe. No need to risk whatever caused that noise to locate her. After some moments of paralysis, she slowly moves her head out from her hiding spot. Enough to peer over the brush but not enough, hopefully, to be found. At first, she spots nothing but greenery. Maybe it was some sort of animal that already scurried off. Glimmer is about to release the breath trapped inside of her throat when it gets sucked right back into her lungs.

Adora appears out of her blind spot. Glimmer shrinks, still trying to get a good view without being maimed. The blonde seems not to have picked up on how she is being watched. Her glowing green eyes scan the area intensely. Every spot she looks at is drawn out. The queen refuses to move a single muscle as Adora turns her attention towards her. It is agonizingly slow, waiting for her to turn around. At one point, Glimmer thinks she has been spotted when eyes stay right on her for several seconds longer than the rest. Finally, however, Adora's head turns and she begins walking away.

Glimmer allows herself to finally breathe. Her mind begins to fight itself with the thoughts pouring in. Should she book it and run and tell everyone where Adora is? Fighting her alone is a death sentence and she knows that all too well. Maybe more people can come and together everyone can take her down. But her eyes land on the chip on the base of the blonde's neck and her heart begs her to break it into a million pieces. To finally release Adora from the grasp of Horde Prime and have her safe and sound back in her arms.

She does have more power now and has recovered enough to stand fairly well on her own two legs. Maybe if she can aim and time an attack right she can hit the chip and break it. Or maybe she will miss again and have She-ra on her ass. If she sneaks away now and saves her own skin, Adora yes will be stuck longer but more people can help. Glimmer is about to make up her mind when the sunlight catches the metal of the chip. In just the right light, and if she squints enough, the queen can swear there is a thin, pale line across it. Did Catra nip it?

Fuck it.

Glimmer creates the first spell that comes to her mind. She has to get this right or risk another fight. A deep breath is taken before she shoots to her feet, revealing her location, and unleashes her magic. The ball of energy soars through the air, searching for its target. It is just about to hit Adora when the blonde quickly spins around. The magic nicks across her cheek, leaving a thin red line across it. Adora's face quickly hardens into that of hatred and anger.

"Well I guess we are doing this the hard way," Glimmer says, mostly to herself. Her hands light up as she prepares for a fight that is not in her favor. "You gonna say anything or what, Prime? Still too tired from your monologue the other day?"

A small smirk crosses Adora's face. Glimmer still feels herself go cold as Prime talks through Adora. " *You've made a foolish mistake, Your Majesty. I think it is time to end this once and for all."*

"Ya know, for once, I actually agree with you. Let's end this!"

Do not hold back until you get Adora back or it kills you. Glimmer thinks to herself. Without missing another moment, the queen fires a blast of magic at her controlled friend.

Adora jumps out of the way, dodging the blast. She sticks out her hand and Glimmer immediately recognizes what she is about to

do. Another spell fired. The blonde once again dives out of the way. Maybe if Glimmer can keep Prime from making Adora turn into She-ra, there can be a fighting chance. The queen has defeated Adora before in all the spars they have had. Hell, a couple of times she has successfully one-up the legendary warrior princess. But that was when she wasn't out for the taste of blood and destruction.

She cannot lose focus on her strikes. One false move and it can be all over for her. For everyone. If she is really lucky, maybe Glimmer can knock Adora off of her feet long enough to rip that damn chip off of her neck finally. She just has to focus. Focus on keeping Adora on her toes. Getting her back finally. Be able to see those bright, warm blue eyes once again. She just has to *focus.*

It's too much. Glimmer is so lost in paying attention she somehow manages to fail at it. Adora uses the split second opportunity to launch herself forward. She stops just short of the shocked queen and quickly sweeps her legs out from under her. Glimmer falls backwards, gasping as her back hits the hard ground.

Despite Adora now being out of her line of sight, she can see and feel the cold light appearing a foot away from her. There is no time to look, no time to confirm what is about to happen. Even though she lost at least half the air from her lungs and the world having a slight spin to it, Glimmer rolls towards her side. A second later she hears the sound of something sharp piercing into the ground. The queen scrambles as fast as she can to her feet. Just in time to jump out of the way from another swing from She-ra's sword.

She still feels sick to her stomach seeing the sworn protector of Etheria dressed in Horde Prime's garb. Even just seeing Adora a minute before in those white robes made her want to throw up her meal. It is so wrong. Like hearing his voice come out of Adora's mouth or the way she has laughed so coldly and lifelessly before. Everything is wrong and Glimmer is determined to make it right.

Glimmer looks over Adora, searching for any inkling of the blonde she longs to apologize and admit her feelings to. Still nothing at all. The queen knows she is in there somewhere. She was there on the ship. There was a small moment she was there, or something was, during her fight alongside Catra. It seems at random what breaks through to her. Words or a piece from her past. Glimmer tries to think of something while she avoids the murder attempts.

Magic is only doing so much. Some of it hits Adora but the blonde is unfazed by it. Glimmer wonders if her attacks have done any sort of damage at all. Everything else she either dives out of the way or deflects them. The queen only has so much magic to spare and cannot keep wasting it. Reaching behind her, she quickly pulls out Adora's staff and lets the ends spread out to full length just as the sword connects with it. Her heels dig into the ground in an attempt to stay standing as she is pushed back by the sheer force of She-ra's strength.

"I don't know who the hell I am talking to right now but know I am not going to give up. Not until I get Adora back," Glimmer growls.

She receives no answer. Glimmer uses all her might to push Adora back. It is enough to get an opening to jump out of the way. Adora is quick to charge forward, still trying to strike down the queen. Glimmer throws a spell at her and manages to temporarily blind her. The blonde winces and starts to rub her eyes to clear them. Now is her chance.

There is just enough time to snake her way around Adora. She sees the chip embedded in Adora's neck, still shining in the sunlight. A spell comes to her mind and aims it at what is quite possibly controlling her. It hits its mark, however, only a small crack forms. *Just how strong is that thing?*

The thought is her downfall. Adora, her vision returned, grabs a hold of Glimmer. In a moment, the queen is set flying. This time when she hits the ground, it takes her a moment to regain her

composure. It takes everything in her to pull herself to her hands and shake her head clear of the daze. Her eyes then find the blonde, who slowly is making her way to her, eyes still bright green.

"Adora! I know you are there! Are you just going to let Prime control and use you? You are stronger than this!" Glimmer shouts. It does little. Adora continues her trek towards her, a dark grin on her face. Glimmer's fingers dig into the dirt as she feels herself grow angry and annoyed. "Damn it, Adora! Will you listen to me!"

This seems to trigger something. Adora freezes in her place. Her body twitches and her eyes snap shut. She groans, hands clutching the side of her head. The next thing that happens makes Glimmer's heart stop in her chest.

Adora's eyes open once more. The green has disappeared and is replaced by an all too familiar blue. They are still blank. No, there is something else. Confusion? She looks around, as if not knowing where she is until she locates the queen, who now has gotten to her knees. The blonde's eyes go wide.

Glimmer struggles to get words out of her mouth. They are trapped like her breath. It has been far too long since she last saw those eyes she has fallen in love with. The ones she wishes to see first thing in the morning and the last thing at night. It is the thing that always managed to make her smile a little no matter how down in the dumps she was. Finally, a single word wiggles free from the straw that has become her throat. "Adora?"

Adora takes a step forward, opening her mouth to say something. But she is cut off by a sharp cry of pain. Eyes shut close and hand is back gripping her head. The next thing Glimmer knows, the glow of green has taken Adora over once more.

Not wasting any time, knowing what will happen next, Glimmer gets to her feet. She readies herself with the staff, a new sense of elation washing over her. That thing is more than likely controlling her and breaking it, even the smallest bit, has done something.

Maybe, just maybe, Adora can hear her. Maybe, just maybe, she herself can fight through whatever holds her back.

She lets Adora get close. Glimmer deflects a blow from Adora, pushing her back only a bit to allow herself to speak close and clear. "I know you are in there, Adora! Fight! It! You have never given up in your life, you're too hard-headed for that. Don't quit now! Whatever it is Horde Prime is doing to you is a lie! It's all in your head. I am not your enemy!"

Adora answers with a growl. She attacks once more, bringing down all her weight on the staff that is keeping the queen from being injured. The trusted, metal pole can no longer take the abuse and breaks in two in Glimmer's hands.

"Shit!" she shouts. She holds tight onto both pieces, not knowing if they can still be of any use, and quickly jumps as far away from Adora as possible. Thankfully, she is able to get some yards away. Adora stops and struggles to proceed forward as if something is holding her back. If Glimmer is going to do anything to free her, she has to act now.

There is only one thing she can think of. A last resort that will drain her of all her magic for who knows how long. She will be powerless again if this fails. But maybe she can break the chip or short-circuit it enough to allow Adora to pull through and take the reins back herself. This means allowing the broken pieces of her weapon to fall to her sides. Adora seems to be losing her fight right now. Her eyes still are glowing bright and she is starting to make slow steps forward. It is now or never.

Taking a deep breath, Glimmer traces out the spell in front of her. It is large, larger than anything she has ever created before. Shapes of stars line the outline of the forming, pink circle. She can feel all of the magic coursing through her veins. It is powerful and consuming and it is like she can do anything. That she is on top of the world. There is only one thing she wants to do. Save Adora. It nearly killed her once but that threat of it happening again and succeeding will not stop her.

Adora now is walking forward with no resistance. Her time is up. Glimmer has no time to make sure the spell is correct or totally finished. She has to do it now or risk never having this chance again. *I'm so sorry, Adora,* Glimmer thinks to herself before unleashing the spell. Brightly colored stars shoot at and sail towards Adora.

The second it leaves her grasp, she collapses to the ground. Almost all the energy has been sapped from her body. The world spins around her but she forces herself to watch her spell hit Adora. In the blur that she struggles to focus on, Glimmer sees the blonde stagger back from the magic hitting her a number of times, almost falling to the ground. She is stopped when she shoves her sword in the ground, keeping herself semi-upright.

Glimmer blinks, bringing everything into sharp shapes and colors. Adora stands to her feet, eyes still green. For a moment, the queen sees sparks coming out from behind her neck. Shit, was it still not enough? She watches Adora starting to walk forward, probably out to kill her.

"Adora...Adora please…" Glimmer says, not knowing what else to do. "Please fight it. I know you can! You don't belong with Horde Prime. You aren't evil. You're good. So good. You belong with us!" Glimmer takes a breath, her voice beginning to rise. "We need you here, Adora! *I* need you!"

Adora stops dead in her tracks at the comment. Once again, her body begins to tremble as a fight for control takes place. Glimmer watches as a hand struggles in the air before stopping at her neck. In a swift moment, she rips off what she can from the chip. The next thing the queen knows, Adora is lit up, about to revert back to her own body.

Adora paces around her room. She has given up on sleep now, her mind consumed with piecing everything together. Half the time she avoids looking at any windows or mirrors, not wanting to set herself off. The other half she stands in front of one of them,

waiting impatiently for anything to occur. Every time she sees something that does not belong, the blonde attempts to reach out and touch it but it always disappears before it is in her grasp. All of this gets under her skin.

She has completely given up asking anyone about it. No one seems to believe her and keep telling her to stop thinking about it. Sleep, it's just stress. If she lays down then everything will go away. But she will not rest, not until she gets answers. Only then will she have some peace of mind to finally close her eyes.

Adora rubs her still itchy neck as she thinks about everything leading up to the gap in her memory. She and Glimmer fought. There was a lot of venom and hurt thrown at each other. She left with Bow to find Entrapta on Beast Island and found not only her but the lost king of Brightmoon and Glimmer's father, Micah. Glimmer somehow managed to activate the Heart of Etheria and Adora had to give up her powers to stop the world from blowing itself up. Horde Prime captured the queen and Catra. Adora went to rescue Glimmer and later Catra. And then…

Nothing. The last thing she remembers before finding herself back at Brightmoon with Glimmer being her girlfriend is stepping onto Horde Prime ship. After that is pure darkness. What is missing? How ***much*** *is missing? Did she get knocked out? That could explain some of her gap, plenty of times when she got hit hard enough in the head she couldn't recall some of the events leading up to it. That still doesn't explain why she can't recall the defeat of Prime or telling Glimmer how she has felt about her months now.*

Adora bites down on her thumb, almost drawing blood. Someone knows something and they are refusing to tell her jackshit. She hates being lied to and no one telling her the full story. Her gut tells her the one who knows all the answers is the one who sleeps in bed with her every night. It is about time she gets those answers.

So she waits and waits for the queen to appear. Adora does not know how long she paces around the room, nearly creating a ditch until Glimmer appears. There is a smile on her face as she walks up to the blonde.

"You know I have been looking all over for you," Glimmer says.

"Yeah, I bet," Adora mumbles, scratching her cheek. "I was waiting for you to show up."

"Oh? Why? Do you need something?"

"Yeah. I would like for someone to tell me what is going on! No one is answering my questions and I am tired of it."

"Have you still not been sleeping? Adora, I told you to rest and-"

"Stop brushing it off!" Adora shouts. "Stop doing that! You and everyone keep doing that and I hate it! Sleeping isn't the answer!"

"Adora, calm down! I am just trying to help."

"It's not working! What happened between the time we tried to save Catra and a couple weeks ago? How did we defeat Prime? How did I become She-ra again?!? How did your mom come back?!? How did we end up starting to date! Tell me!"

"I will if you just calm down. You are way too worked up over this. And why are you like that? Aren't you happy everything is okay now?"

"Not if I don't know how it happened! Everything's so right it feels so wrong. Like at any moment something is about to shatter this all and I want to know what that thing is!"

Before anyone can say anything else, Adora feels a sharp pain in her neck. She winces and slaps a hand on her neck, not knowing where this sensation just came from. It feels like she got shot. Glimmer steps forward, possibly in an attempt to give her

girlfriend some relief, but Adora puts her free hand up and backs away.

"Don't you dare. Not until you tell me what is going on," Adora states.

"I told you there is nothing going on."

"Yes. There. Is!"

Damn it, Adora! Will you listen to me!

Adora jerks. Those words did not come out of Glimmer standing in front of her. It sounds like it is coming from her side. The blonde snaps her head around and sees one of the windows in her room. Another Glimmer is in its frame, looking angry while kneeling on the ground of the Whispering Woods. Without thinking, and ignoring the shout from the queen near her, Adora reaches out and touches the glass.

The next thing she knows, Adora has been transported into the Whispering Woods. Her heart begins to race in her chest as she looks around. What the hell just happened? How did she get here? And is she She-ra right now? It feels wrong being her right now and she can't put her finger on it before her eyes land on Glimmer. The queen's lilac eyes are wide in shock, some color drained from her face. There are scrapes all over her body and the staff Adora had been using after the destruction of her sword is in her hands. *What the hell?*

Glimmer finally opens her mouth, only uttering the blonde's own name. Adora begins to step forward, wanting to ask what is happening but something grabs her and forcefully pulls her backwards. A cry escapes her as she is tossed around like a ragdoll.

In an instant, she is back in her room, on her back. Adora quickly gets to her feet, panic filling every inch of her as she looks at the window once more. It only shows her one of the many courtyards

of Brightmoon castle. The blonde places her hand on it but nothing happens.

"You shouldn't have done that."

Adora shudders at the sound of Glimmer's voice, the hairs on the back of her neck stand at attention. It is cold and harsh. Even at her angriest, the blonde has never heard that tone from the queen. Slowly, she turns her head around to face the love of her life. Glimmer stares back at her. Her own eyes no longer are a shade of purple. Rather, a bright green that makes Adora sick. She then realizes both of them are in ankle-deep water that is the same shade as the queen's eyes. It is like ice, causing goosebumps to form on the blonde's skin, and slowly is rising.

"What the hell..." Adora manages to squeeze out of her tight throat. "You're ***not*** *Glimmer."*

"But I can be. If you want." 'Glimmer' walks forward, grinning widely. One of her hands finds her girlfriend's cheek, gripping it. Adora jerks, both from the invasion of space around her face and the freezing cold skin of Glimmer. The queen continues to speak as she rubs Adora's cheek. "I can be anything you want. I can take away all your pain and misery and give you nothing but love and hope. Haven't I done that already?"

"Who the hell are you? What have you done to Glimmer? To me? Who else isn't who they say they are?"

"I am what you always wanted. Don't lie to yourself. You want peace, don't you? To fix the relationships that have become so damaged you don't know if they can ever be repaired? To fix your mistakes? Don't you want to have Glimmer be your other half and live the rest of your life with her? Your heart cannot lie and this is what you always wanted."

Adora does want all that. But not like this. Not when there is something dark and menacing going on.

I know you are in there, Adora! Fight! It! You have never given up in your life, you're too hard-headed for that. Don't quit now! Whatever it is Horde Prime is doing to you is a lie! It's all in your head. I am not your enemy!

Glimmer's voice breaks through her thoughts. Once more, it comes from an outside source. This Glimmer sounds like hers. The fierceness of her words is all too familiar. They stick in her mind. Everything is a lie. This is all made up, a fake reality her mind has created. No, that Horde Prime has created.

For a moment, she finds herself staring down Horde Prime. Any words sent between them is muted as she is picked up by the color of her jacket and thrown into the same water that now inches itself up her body. There is a sharp pain on her neck before her whole world turns green.

She has to fight back. Adora grabs the wrist of the hand on her face and pulls it off. She shoves 'Glimmer' away and stares her down. Whatever Prime is doing in her mind, the first thing she has to deal with is the fake in front of her.

Adora lunges for her but 'Glimmer' teleports away. She catches herself before falling into the water and quickly spins on her heels. In the time she has known the real Glimmer, she has gotten used to judging when the queen will reappear. There always is a faint noise or a change in the air. The second her trained senses can hone it on it, Adora reaches out. Her hands lock onto cold skin and a shocked look from 'Glimmer'.

However, before she can do or say anything, 'Glimmer' quickly recovers and sends a blast of magic at her face. Adora lets out a shout and lets go. She tries to recover and grab hold of the fake again but like before, she disappears. Unlike last time, Adora cannot stop herself from plunging headfirst into the icy cold water.

It fills her nose and mouth and when she manages to come up, she is coughing. She turns her head around to look for her enemy

and finds the window is showing the, hopefully, real Glimmer and the Whispering Woods. As fast as she can, Adora gets to her feet and makes a break for it. However, she is stopped by a blow to the stomach, sending her flying back into the water that is now deep enough to submerge her.

'Glimmer' seems to have that same exact thought. All of her weight pressed down on the blonde, keeping her from bringing her head up. What little oxygen she has left in her lungs from the blow, Adora clings to as she attempts to throw off the fake version of her best friend. She is not about to lose like this. Part of her yells at her for not sleeping and eating well. Any energy and strength she has lost from that could be of use right now.

Suddenly, there is a sharp sensation all throughout her body. Her neck is the worst, feeling like someone is trying to rip something out of her. Adora can't help but gasp, letting the air out and water in. Not good. Not good at all. But as the pain overtakes her, she can feel the weight of 'Glimmer' becoming lighter. Enough to finally throw her off. She twists her body and uses the force and movement to remove the weight that presses her under.

Adora sucks in as much air as possible the second her head breaks free of her near icy tomb. Everything hurts and screams for the pain to stop. There is not much she can do about any of that right now. She has no idea where 'Glimmer' has gone off to now and the water is getting higher, faster by the moment. Her energy is still fading and if she doesn't do something soon, she might not have enough strength to keep herself above water.

Adora races to the window and touches it. This time, nothing happens. She can only watch as Glimmer stares at her in shock, powerless and defenseless with a broken staff at her sides.

"No, no, no!" Adora tries to break the glass but it does not work. She doesn't have it in her anymore to break it and the water is at her waist now, sucking even more energy from her. Adora squeezes her eyes shut, tears about to fill them. What else can she do other than give up?

Adora…Adora please…Please fight it. I know you can! You don't belong with Horde Prime. You aren't evil. You're good. So good. You belong with us! …We need you here, Adora! <u>I</u> need you!

Glimmer needs her. She can't give up now. She made that promise on Beast Island never to give up. The pain in her neck has become unbearable now and the only thing Adora can think of is reaching up at it. Her fingers suddenly find something there and without hesitation, she grips it as tight as she can and pulls with all her might. It stings but she doesn't bother to see what it is that she just removed. With the last bit of strength she has left, she focuses it all into her fist and punches the window one more time.

Finally, it shatters into a million pieces.

Glimmer starts, scrambling to her feet, arms outstretched, and catches Adora before she can fall forward and collide with the hard ground. Sparks of light shoot out from the chip embedding at the back of the blonde's neck as it short-circuits. Some pieces that Adora failed to take out fall, leaving only small parts and blood behind. The bolts of electricity cease as the chip gives one final beep of a cry before dying out.

Glimmer kneels to the ground, turning Adora over in her arms so she faces her. The blonde's eyes are shut and her breathing is irregular, gasping and coughing for air. Her shortened hair now is a mess, dark golden locks fall over her forehead. This is the closest she has been to Adora in weeks and Glimmer can see she is paler and feels lighter. What the hell has Prime done to her during the weeks he had her in his grasp, forcing her to attack her loved ones and destroying the place she calls home. She quickly shakes the thought from her head, however. There is a more pressing issue right now.

"Adora?" Glimmer asks. There is no answer. She gulps back the rising feeling of fear coming from the bottom of her stomach. The

sounds of her gasping for air and looking like death does not bode well with her. She presses. “Adora! Adora *please* open your eyes.”

A groan answers her this time. Slowly, eyes flutter open and look up at her. A light shines dimly in them and there is no trace of the sick, glowing green color that once filled them. Only a soft blue, as bright and clear as the spring sky, stare back at Glimmer full of warmth. A twinkle forms in them as a small and soft smile creeps across Adora’s face.

“Oh, my gods! Adora!” Glimmer cries, tears now flowing down her face. She pulls Adora closer, resting her forehead on the blonde’s in the embrace. “Y-Y-You’re back! Thank...Thank the gods you are back!”

Her body shakes, unable to contain the excitement, joy, and *relief* flooding every ounce of her being. Adora is back. Back nestled in her arms and away from Horde Prime. Back alive and breathing. The time away has forcibly changed her appearance but seeing those same loving blue eyes she first saw over a year ago in the Whispering Woods is all the queen needs to know this *is* Adora. It is not a dream, not a trick of anyone to capture her. It is real.

A noise catches her attention. Glimmer pulls away, seeing Adora’s mouth moving but anything she tries to say is inaudible. The queen sniffs, attempting to steady her voice as she speaks. Still, words shake. “C-Come again?”

A hand slowly lifts in the air. It finds Glimmer’s cheek. For a moment, Glimmer flinches. Adora’s once warm skin is cold. But the roughness from years of use and battle quickly reminds the queen who it belongs to. Despite the rugged feeling, the touch is as soft as a feather and gives Glimmer all the comfort she needs in the world. A thumb slowly rubs against her cheek, wiping away the stream of tears still falling. Finally, Adora opens her mouth again.

“I’m...I’m right here…” Adora’s voice is barely above a whisper and hoarse. But it is still *her* voice. Glimmer can’t help but chuckle at

the sentence she nearly misses again. She places her free hand on the one that touches her and presses her face further into it.

“You dork.”

The lights in Adora’s eyes grow, shining bright. Then, her eyelids become heavy and close. Her head rolls gently to the side, burying itself into Glimmer’s chest, and her body falls limp. The breaths she takes have slowed and become steady and light. Glimmer sighs softly.

“Rest. You deserve it,” Glimmer says softly. She gently places Adora’s arm back on her body before wiping away the tears from her face. There is a moment she takes one more look at the sleeping girl before shifting and standing up. Her body protests for a moment, both from the ghost of her old wounds reappearing and from those fresh from minutes before, but Glimmer ignores them all. There is only one thing that matters now. “I got you. Let’s get you home, ‘Dora.”

Chapter End Notes

> Shoutout this week is my friend LadyLazuli97 fic Despara. It's a mind wipe Adora glimmadora au and very good.

Together Again...?

Chapter Notes

> okay so Imma going to switch to a sunday update cause I realized school is back(? idk what schools are doing atm) and like most people work on monday and I asked on tumblr what to do and sunday was the most voted for. so yeeeeeaaaaahhhh. Not much else to say really, dunno when next chapter will be out if it's a one week or two week cause it got LONG and i still then need to queue up the other and like writing has been a bit slowed down cause depression is a bitch
>
> tw in this chapter: panic attack/flashback/some negative thoughts. Comments/feedback and kudos always appreciated

See the end of the chapter for more notes

She has to be close by now. Sure, she has had to make a couple stops to avoid being seen or to take a rest, such as now, but it has to be close. Glimmer left the campsite only a couple of hours before her encounter with Adora and it feels like she has been walking as long. Granted, that is a struggle at the moment. Right now, she sits behind a tree, keeping her ears and eyes peeled. She must take extra care for her sake and the sake of the unconscious body in her arms.

Adora has barely made any movements since breaking free of Horde Prime control. Only the occasional mutter or moan escapes her, telling the queen she is still alive. Glimmer watches her sleep as she takes her own moment’s rest. This still does not feel real, like she is dreaming and at any moment, someone will wake her and Adora will still be chipped.

Two weeks. Two weeks since she last saw her uncontrolled. Two weeks since they last had their quick embrace on the ship. Two weeks since they said once everything was said and done, they

would try to fix things. Even more time has passed since they actually have spent time with each other that did not involve going for each other's throats. Now she is back, albeit altered. Glimmer hates imagining what went on to change Adora's look so much. The sooner she can get her back to the camp and examine and out of these clothing, the better.

Glimmer shifts Adora, pulling her into a limp sitting position. Most of the metal chip on the base of her neck is gone. Shattered from their fight and ripped off by the blonde herself. In its place is dry blood. The pieces that remain are small. A sliver of what used to be the ring around the chip, a couple of the bits that stuck out from the side, and a small quarter bit in the middle stay lodged in her body. The queen reaches out in an attempt to remove what looks like to be a loose piece. However, the second she gives the slightest tug, a sharp, painful cry escapes Adora.

"Sorry! Sorry!" Glimmer says. She cradles Adora again. The blonde still is unconscious but her face has twisted into that of agnoy. "Okay, no touching that. Maybe Entrapta can get it out without hurting you. Sorry again."

She has no idea if Adora can hear her right now. Probably not. But her face does loosen after a moment. Glimmer wishes she could rid Adora of the rest of the chip. She already has discarded some sort of small communication pad the blonde had in a pocket. No need to have a random call from Prime or him using that somehow to find them. Hopefully, he isn't out looking for Adora now that she isn't a pawn in his game. Glimmer still finds it hard to look at the blonde in the white robes with his symbol on her chest.

Glimmer checks her surroundings once more. Nothing looks like it is about to jump out at and attack her. With a deep breath, she rises to her feet. For a moment, she wobbles, nearly falling over with Adora. The queen quickly catches herself, preventing any injury from occurring. Damn. She really needs to get home. Even if Adora is a little easier to carry right now, that battle and most, if not all, her magic being drained is doing her little good. It takes

her a moment to stable herself. When she feels like she won't collide with the ground, the queen begins her trek once more.

It seems like the forest doesn’t not want to let go of the pair. The queen hopes she did not make a wrong turn in her growing tiredness. She refuses to stop her stride, however. Not until Adora is safe. The blonde continues to mutter something Glimmer cannot understand or a groan is made. Still, she remains unconscious, showing no signs of waking up anytime soon. Maybe that is for the best. Not knowing what is going on in the world around her.

Though, the question of what Adora will remember enters into her mind. Glimmer hopes it is like the two times she got infected. Little recollection. The queen remembers Adora telling her she had flashes of those times in her dreams and woke up with the feeling of darkness. It is a horrible thing to have on her long list of nightmare inducing memories but at least if it is like that, she won’t have them play back to her as clearly as some of her others that Glimmer knows about.

After what seems like forever, a clearing starts to come into view. The campsite. Glimmer quickly picks up her pace and she finally enters what she has been calling home the past few days. She begins to look around, searching for any familiar faces. People slowly begin to take notice of her presence as well as the lifeless form in her arms. What a sight it must be to see the queen of Brightmoon step back into camp not only late but battle worn and holding the person who has been causing so much destruction as of late. She ignores any looks that she must be receiving as she searches for others. Finally, her eyes land on someone she knows.

“Bow!” she shouts. Her legs are aching and feel like they are about to come out from under her but she does her best to race over to him. Bow, who is talking to her father and aunt, snaps his head around. It does not take long for his eyes to go wide.

“G-Glimmer?!? Is that-” he stops when Glimmer gets close. He stares down at Adora, shock all over his face. “What?”

“It’s a long story. But I got her back, Bow! She’s back!” Glimmer says. Tears are threatening to spill out of her eyes as her voice begins to crack. “She’s...just unconscious. But I swear she isn’t being controlled by Prime anymore.”

Bow says nothing. His eyes, full of his own tears, stay locked on the missing member of the Best Friend Squad, as if he cannot believe what is happening. Glimmer gulps back some of her own tears, knowing that Adora still needs her right now. “Do you know where Entrpata is? I-I-There is something still on her neck. Maybe she can get it off of her, I can’t.”

“No, I don’t but we can find her. Glim, are you okay?”

“I’m fine. That doesn’t matter.” Glimmer tells him. She looks around. A crowd is starting to form. So many pairs of eyes are on them now it causes the hairs on the back of her neck to stand up. She picks up on a set of mismatched eyes in the sea of colors. They are wide and stay locked on her. Catra shoves someone away to get a closer look at the sight, Melog close behind her. She stays several yards away, ears and tail alert. After some moments of processing what is happening, she begins attempting to break up everyone, asking them what the fuck they are staring at and threatening to beat anyone who refuses to move.

“Glimmer. You looked pretty beat up and tired,” Bow tells her. “You both need help.”

“I will get help when I know for a fact Adora is okay!”

Micah talks a small step forward. “We can get both of you help. You must be tired from carrying her. How about I take her off your hands.” he begins to reach out his arms towards the blonde.

Without warning or even thought, Glimmer pulls Adora closer to her, cradling her as tight as humanly possibly. Her body becomes tense and curls in, adding even more of a shield for the

unconscious girl. She swears a small growl escapes her but she isn't completely sure. The only thing in her mind at the moment is Adora. She *just* got her back. It has been far too long since they were this close to one another. She doesn't want to let go, have her be taken away again, and allow an absence feeling in her chest take over again.

"Woah!" Micah jerks back, hands up. "Easy, Sweetheart."

"No need for a death glare," Bow says.

Glimmer relaxes slightly. "Sorry. I just...I missed her."

"We understand, Glimmer. But if we are going to make sure she is alright, let me take her." Now Castaspella is moving close to her, slowly. "We can find a safe place and I can do my best to look her over until we can fully figure out what to do. Okay?"

Glimmer still hesitates for a moment but her aunt is right. The queen also has no idea how much longer her legs can hold the weight of two people so she caves. Carefully, she places Adora into Castaspella's arms. The second the blonde leaves her arms, a soft whimper slips out of her lips.

"It's okay, 'Dora. I haven't left," Glimmer whispers to her. "We are going to get you help but I am going to be right by your side."

Glimmer follows her aunt, Bow close behind. Micah aids Catra in breaking up the rest of the crowd, though he does not use any threats against anyone. Glimmer suggests bringing Adora to her own quarters. They are close by and Glimmer can always find some place to rest if Adora remains out cold through the rest of day and night. When they get inside, it is still a mess. The bed is unmade, glass still litters the ground, and papers and whatnot are scattered around. Glimmer makes another note to clean up but that is the least of her worries right now.

Castaspella slowly places Adora down on the bed. The blonde's eyes remain shut, still no signs of consciousness returning anytime soon. The slow, steady, rise and fall of her chest is the

only thing giving Glimmer comfort as she watches her aunt's hands light up. They are a much paler shade of blue from the time she healed her and they hover over Adora's body, lighting up the areas below them in the same color. The queen steps closer.

"What...What are you doing? Is...Is she okay? Anything wrong with her?" she asks.

Her aunt does not answer right away. There is a tense look on her face and she begins to chew on the bottom of her lip. Fear, dread, and anxiety start to fill every part of Glimmer's being. Is Adora not okay? Is something wrong? Did Prime do some unseen damage to her? Did Glimmer herself cause a serious injury during her desperate fight to free her? The queen opens her mouth to ask those questions and more but her aunt cuts her off.

"Physically? She seems okay. Not great but nothing life threatening. I can sense her body is feeling exhausted and weak. But besides that and some minor things possibly from your fight, there is nothing else to worry about there."

"So she is fine?" Glimmer states. If she is just exhausted and weak, all she needs is some good TLC, right? Even if everything is still hitting the fan, that can be managed somehow.

"I don't know, Glimmer. Like I said, that is physically. I am no master healer but," her hands move to hover over Adora's head, "her mind seems dark."

"Dark?"

"Clouded. I can barely sense anything. Even when someone is unconscious, you usually can feel something. Usually what they felt before they were knocked out. But there is nothing with her. It's all...cold. Come here for a moment."

Glimmer looks at Bow for reassurance. He gives a shrug, not knowing what to say. With some hesitation, she steps up next to her aunt. The older woman tells her the enactment of the spell she just did and Glimmer follows suit. Once her hands are lit, she

hovers them over Adora, starting with her body. Parts of her own body begin to ache slightly. Wherever her magic is on the blonde, there is a sensation on the same spots on her. If the queen wasn't tired and sore enough, she can feel it now. Her body feels like lead. When Glimmer pulls away, everything disappears.

"Oh, Adora…" she sighs. Taking a deep breath, preparing herself for whatever is about to happen, she places her hands over Adora's head. The second she does that, her body becomes like ice. It is the coldest she has ever felt and that is all she can now feel or sense. Any emotions Glimmer has, her worry and fear for the blonde, suddenly disappear and are replaced by a heavy, dark numbness. It threatens to overtake her body and drown her. Any feelings Adora might have are lost inside her mind, locked and hidden away in an area Glimmer cannot reach. All there is is the cold numbness.

The queen jerks back, gasping. She begins rubbing her hands, trying to bring some warmth back to her as she looks at her aunt. "What the hell was that?!? That-That isn't from her being unconscious? Are you sure?"

"Not entirely but yes. It's hard to read people when they are not conscious but again, even then, you should be able to find something in there. There is nothing with her."

"She probably has been through a lot," Bow pipes up. He now is at Glimmer's side. "We should let her rest right now. You said you needed Entrapta right? We can let Adora sleep, find Entrapta, and then when she wakes we can go from there."

"You should get patched and rested up, Glimmer. I'll stay here with Adora a little while longer. You can come back later to check on her."

"Right...Okay." Glimmer kneels down and takes one last glance at Adora's still body. She still cannot believe the blonde is lying right in front of her, inches away. Now, she has to leave her again for an unforeseen amount of time. At least this time, she can race to

her side the second she wakes. Before leaving, she takes Adora's hand in her own and squeezes it. "I'll be back later, Adora. Sleep well. I'll see you soon."

The first thing that Adora becomes aware of is how heavy everything feels. It is as if Swift Wind is sitting right on her and is refusing to budge. She has no idea if he is on her, all she can see is pitch black. But it's not hard to breathe. He can't possibly be on her then. The next thing she recognizes are mummers. Whispers of words, like radio static she cannot make out, and hums of activity she cannot put a name too. Finally, she feels herself on something, lying flat on her back. It takes all the energy she can muster to crack open her eyes.

This place seems familiar. She is in a pitched up tent. Slowly blinking, she attempts to bring a name of where she is to mind and to rid the blur that is at the edges of her vision. Adora shifts her gaze, spotting some scattered papers on the ground and a table in her line of sight. She needs to get up for a better intake of her surroundings.

It takes even more might to pull herself into a sitting position. Every part of her feels like lead and if she falls back down on whatever she lays on, she will not be getting back up anytime soon. Once Adora feels like she won't collapse, she takes another look around. There is a broken mirror and a chest in the area. A moment passes before she realizes that she is on a makeshift bed. Words form in her head. It slowly hits her where she is. She is at the camp of the Rebellion.

Right, Adora thinks. That makes sense. Which is good at the moment. Her mind's like a maze and the last thing she needs is to be someplace unknown. Trying to search for anything, such as what happened the day before or what she has planned for today, is almost impossible. Tiredness is in every inch and vein of her body. How long has she been asleep? Last time she checked, rest has been something that has refused to find her. Guess now it

decided to show its face. Though, why does it feel like she got run over by a tank?

Adora places her hands on her face, beginning to run them down her skin as she tries to piece things together and rid herself of the heavy sleep. Her bangs run though her fingers, a familiar sensation. However, much to her surprise, the feeling is cut short. *What the?*

Adora reaches up again, taking some of her dark blonde locks between her fingers. She begins to work her way down. In no time at all, there is nothing in her grasp. It does not take long for her to realize there is a lack of hair touching her neck. A hand reaches back and finds that it stops just past where her neck starts. When did she cut it? An attempt is made to pull that memory out of the murk that is her mind. But her brain refuses to give her an answer, throwing up large walls and blocking any attempts. The more she tries to push the wall down, the harder it becomes. It threatens to split her head open.

She wants to get a better look at herself. Maybe that will help. Adora swings heavy legs over the side of the bed and manages to pull herself to her feet. Every step takes effort, like a weight is attached to her ankles. Her feet practically drag against the ground as she makes her way to the mirror. When she draws close enough, she stops. The glass has lines running all across it, fracturing herself. The focal point of the cracks rest near her reflection's heart, pieces missing and leaving a dark gap. Adora bends down and grabs a shard, playing with it in her right hand as she turns to look back at herself.

Certainly, there have been better days. If she feels like she has been hit by a tank, then it looks like it also. Her hair is indeed shortened to a considerable length. It needs to be brushed out, parts stick out all over. She is dressed in her grey tank top and shorts. Dark bags are under tired, dim eyes. There is a faint, red line going across her cheek. When did she get that? She also seems a shade lighter and it looks like a gust of wind could knock

her over from the lack of strength she feels. What the hell happened to her?

Pain suddenly radiates out of her right hand. Adora winces and drops the glass she was holding onto. After a few shakes to rid herself of the hot sensation, she takes a look at her injury. A gash is at the center of her palm, blood flowing freely, staining her hand a bright red.

The wall inside her brain crumbles in an instant.

Images flood her mind. She finds herself no longer in the tent. Now, she is in a clean, sleek room. A purple and pink form lays in front of her, red seeping out from under them. Adora needs no name to know who and what she is looking at. The blonde jerks back, almost violently, at the sight. Both her hands now are colored a bright, warm crimson. She snaps her head towards the mirror, hoping for something else to stare at. But it is far from helpful. What looks back at her still is her own reflection but it no longer matches what she saw only moments before. Now, her messy hair is slicked back, she wears a set of long, white robes with a black Horde symbol on her chest, and eyes full of a bright, sickly green color.

A scream escapes her, filling the room in the sound of terror. Adora falls to the ground in a failed attempt to escape everything that is appearing around her. Her heart races in her chest, threatening to explode, and it is as if she is breathing through a straw. She begins to crawl backwards as her mind betrays her.

One moment, she still finds herself in that clean, sleek room, Glimmer's body still sprawled out in front of her. The next thing she knows, Horde Prime stares down at her with a wide smile on his face, his eyes glowing the same green she saw moments before in her own reflection. A dark laugh echoes in her ears and is quickly followed by screeches of terror. She can smell smoke. Heat spreads across her body, making her feel like she is on fire. Things begin to blur together, becoming indistinguishable from

one another. All she can feel is how hot her skin is and a heavy, dark feeling growing in her chest.

Adora!

The new voice enters the mix of colors and sounds. It is deep and masculine. The images morph once more and Horde Prime is staring at her, looking pleased with himself. When her name is repeated again, she squeezes her eyes and slaps her hands over her ears, ignoring the stickiness on her right from her open wound. Despite the effort to block everything out, she can still see the glow of Horde Prime's eyes.

'Dora, sweetie, it's me.

Everything becomes still. The words linger in her mind, slowly pushing everything out of her mind. Why in the world would Prime call her something like that? Unless...it wasn't him. Slowly, Adora opens her eyes and removes her hands from the side of her head. The world takes shape into one image. She is in the tent she woke to. A couple feet away, King Micah squats near. His dark brown eyes are full of concern and worry. They are a welcoming sight compared to the green glow. Her heart continues to race in her chest but begins to slow down and she begins to gain some semblance of control over her breathing.

"M-M-" Adora tries to get words out but it is difficult. Her throat feels like sandpaper and as tight as a knot. She swallows before attempting again. But like before, she barely can get the words out, unable to finish them.

"Don't push yourself, Adora," Micah says. "Do you need anything?"

Adora nods and gestures for water, hoping he understands. Micah reaches down and pulls a canister from his belt. The second he sticks it out for Adora to grab, the blonde snatches it away. She does not think much of how much to leave the older man. The water, despite being room temperature, is soothing against her

throat. She ends up finishing it off, wishing for more, but feeling a lot better even if she just drank all of Micah's water.

She hands the canister back and is about to open her mouth to apologize for not leaving anything for him when a new noise catches her attention. Her body freezes in place, unable to believe what she is hearing. The voice is familiar and comforting even if it yells at people to move. It is the sound that almost always made her feel like she belonged and that everything would be alright at the end of the day. The sound is of home.

Adora turns her head towards the flap of the tent just in time to see Glimmer rip it back and step in. The queen freezes in place as her bright lilac eyes, with a sheen in them as tears threaten to spill out, lock with Adora's. Neither girl moves an inch. The blonde feels her heart and breathing stop cold. The image of Glimmer on the ground in a pool of her own blood still is burned into her mind. How is she standing here if that happened? A new memory crops up. It is fuzzy, like coming from a dream, but she finds herself in Glimmer's arms. The queen is smiling and crying as she stares down at her. Was that real? Is *this* real? She has to know.

"G-Glim...G-Glimmer?" Adora manages to finally croak out. The second the word leaves her lips, the queen races over to her and throws her whole weight against the blonde. Adora nearly topples over, caught off guard. Somehow, neither fall to the ground as Glimmer's soft, warm arms wrap tightly around Adora's body. Just like all the times she woke up in the middle of the night, frightened out of her dreams. When was the last time they were this close together? Her heart aches at the thought of how much time has passed.

"Y-You're a-alive?" Adora asks, unable to believe her eyes. She hesitates to wrap her own arms around the smaller girl, still feeling both hands covered in blood. The memory of a lifeless Glimmer continues to play in her mind. The sword *she* used on her is close by, stained red. The next thing replays in her mind is leaving the room, not bothering to see if the queen was breathing. She was sure she was dead. How is this possible?

"I am, Adora. I am," Glimmer whispers into her ears, tears in her voice. "I'm okay."

This is all she needs. Adora breaks, burying her face into the crook of Glimmer's neck as sobs overtake her. Her arms have a mind of their own and slowly find their way around the queen's back, wrapping tightly around her like a vice grip and refusing to let go. More images she wishes would stop playing appear in her mind. Attacking Glimmer, fighting her, disarming her, and almost killing her again and wanting to succeed in the attempt. She can feel the anger, the hate, the *bloodlust* from those memories and the rush of exhilaration from those attempts fills her. It makes her sick.

"I'm sorry! I'm so sorry!" Adora cries. "I didn't mean to…I didn't mean..."

"Shh, shh. I know, Adora. It's okay. It's okay now."

But it's not okay, Adora thinks to herself. She opens her mouth, wanting to tell Glimmer this, but only sobs escape her. All she can do is cry, staining Glimmer's clothing with her tears. Adora feels her own shoulder become wet as her body shakes uncontrollably. Neither budge an inch for several long moments. When they do break apart, Glimmer shifts her hands onto Adora's arms, still holding them tight.

The queen has seen better days herself. Her hair that has been combed neatly towards the side for months sticks out with a mind of their own. It is almost reminiscent of her old hairstyle. She has similar bags under her tired eyes. There are scrapes on her face, ones Adora knows she had a hand in giving. Shouldn't they have healed by now? Adora reaches up and gently brushes a thumb against one.

"They'll heal, Adora. Now that you are here," Glimmer states. She lets go of Adora's arms. "How are you feeling?"

Adora takes a breath, trying to steady her breathing. She wipes some of the tears still streaming down her face before speaking up in a rough voice, “Like crap.”

“I feel ya.”

Before anyone can say anything else, someone else enters the room. Adora has just enough time to crane her neck to look over Glimmer’s shoulder to see Bow darting into the tent. Like Glimmer before him, he essentially tackles the blonde in an embrace. Seeing this coming, she has just enough time to brace herself. She gives him a tight squeeze. When they pull apart, Bow has joined in on having tears stream down his face.

“I’m so glad you’re awake! It’s so good to see you,” Bow says.

“I can say the same thing.”

“Adora.” Glimmer says. Adora turns her attention back to her. She is chewing on her lip in thought. The blonde raises an eyebrow. The queen finishes her thought. “How is your neck feeling? Do you...Do you remember what happened?”

“Huh? My neck?” Now that she mentions it, there seems to be an inch on the base of it. Instinctively, she reaches up and goes to scratch it. Her fingers do not find skin. Rather, they find cold metal bits and scabs. Pain immediately shoots out through her body as if someone shot lava into her veins. She attempts to suppress a shout forming in her throat but it fails. A noise slips out of her through gritted teeth.

She hears someone say something but Adora has no idea what it is. She sees Horde Prime again, looming large over her. He grabs a hold of her and something is implanted into her neck. There is a large, bright emerald green pool in front of her. The ice cold water encases her. Images flick around quickly. More of Horde Prime, some of villages burning, looks of frightened Etherians, and Glimmer wounded. She feels like she is about to throw up.

“Hey, hey.” Hands find her shoulders and squeezes. “Adora! Look at me!!”

Adora turns her head in the direction of the voice. Glimmer, Bow, and Micah stare at her, the queen’s hands being the ones on her shoulders. Adora pulls away, not wanting to be this close to her. Not after seeing her injured because of herself.

“Are you okay?” Glimmer asks.

Adora swallows, not knowing what to say. Everything is a mess in her mind, like someone dumped boxes upon boxes inside of it and now she is forced to shift through them all, unable to pack them away. She attempts to shake the thoughts growing inside of her mind. “It’s nothing,” she lies.

“Are you sure? Do...Do you want to talk about it?” Bow asks

Adora looks at him and then at Glimmer. Another thing to add to the list of things she so desperately wants to talk to the queen about. Adora herself can barely grasp what plagues her mind, how can anyone else help at the moment? She shakes her head and sighs. “No. I don’t. Not...Not now. Please understand.”

“Alright. We don’t have to. But we should get the rest of that chip off of you. I bet it doesn’t feel good.”

“No...it doesn’t…”

“I’ll go get Entrapta for you,” Micah says, standing up. He exits the room, leaving the reunited trio alone. After some moments, Adora staggers to her feet. It takes her a moment to get to her feet. Both Bow and Glimmer offer to help her but she rejects them, wanting to do it herself. Once on her feet, the blonde examines her hand. The bleeding has slowed. It barely streams out of her. She wonders if anyone else’s blood is on her hands. Her brain is about to give her an answer. There is the feeling of something creeping up from the back of her mind. To stop it, Adora squeezes her hand shut and turns her head away.

“We should get that cleaned up,” Glimmer says.

“It’s fine. I can just wash it after Entrapta comes,” Adora replies.

“Adora. You can’t let that get infected.”

Maybe I should after everything. “I can handle it, Glimmer.”

“Adora let me help you!”

Adora looks back at her. That tone close to that of when she was putting her foot down over the Heart. She is taken aback by it, tense. Glimmer seems to have taken notice. A flash of anger that was in her lilac eyes fades as she relaxes. “Sorry. I just...let us see it. Nothing is going to hurt you here.”

Adora takes a breath, finally accepting the offer. She walks back to the bed and takes a seat. Out of nowhere, a small box appears. Glimmer pulls out some medicine and bandages. Adora turns away from her as the queen begins to wrap up her hand, not wanting to look at her or the blood. When she is done, Adora mutters a thank you before putting her hand to the side. No one says much else as they wait for Entrapta. At some point, Bow leaves to go do some things. Thankfully, Entraptra shows up shortly after. Eagerness is written all over her face.

“Hello, Adora!” the older princess shouts.

“H-Hi Entrapta,” Adora says. It's good to see she is still the same.

“It’s good to see you awake and back. I am here to help you! Are you ready?”

Adora notices the assembly of tools in her arms, not having a name for half of them. Her nerves begin to run wild. She trusts the princess but the sight does make her uneasy. Who knows what the hell it will take to get whatever is in her out. But if this is the only way, it has to be done. What is the worst that can happen anyway?

Adora nods and Entrapta gets ready to begin her work. The blonde shifts so her back faces the older princess. Instinctively, she reaches up to push her hair out of the way but freezes when her hands find nothing but air. Her breath catches in her throat. Right...The heavy, dark feeling in her chest from before begins to spread across her body, starting at her heart. She faintly hears snipping as she lowers her arms. Entrapta begins her work, snapping Adora out of her thoughts.

The pain is immediate. Adora gasps, jerking away and slapping a hand over her neck. "Shit!" The curse escapes her lips before she can stop it.

"Adora! Are you okay?" Glimmer asks. She is right at her side, a hand on her leg. The touch is both comforting, the warmth and softness is one she has longed for many days and nights, and of agony, she can't be this close to her. Yet, she pulls away only slightly, Glimmer's hand staying on her skin.

"Hurts…" is all Adora can breathe out.

"You just have to power through it. Once it's out, it's out. And then you don't have to think about it anymore." Glimmer gently squeezes her hand on Adora's leg.

She's right. Adora takes a deep breath, nodding. Now knowing what is to come, she prepares herself for the worse. She bites her lip, almost breaking skin, as Entrapta gets back to work. The older princess pokes and prods at her neck. She feels objects being pulled out of her a couple of times. All the while, Adora holds back cries of pain. Glimmer gently rubs her thumb against Adora's leg, giving some sort of comfort. After what feels like ages, Entrapta pulls away. Pain still lingers on the back of the blonde's neck but no longer feels like someone is trying to rip her apart from the inside.

"There we go! Though, someone should patch it up," Entrapta says. She whips around to face the other two, sticking out her hand. In an open palm, Adora sees bits of metal and wires. She

grabs one of the bits, examining it. She wonders where the rest of it is, there has to be more. Her eyebrows furrow in thought. What did Bow call it? A chip? Why was this in the back of her neck? Was that what she felt before being thrown into that vat of water?

“He...He used this on me...Didn’t he?” Adora asks.

“We are pretty sure, yes. You didn’t answer before but...Do you know what happened?”

Adora grips the side of her head. If the images she has anything to go off of, he made her do terrible things. Why then, when she remembers some of them, she has a feeling of enjoying it. “M-Maybe? Tell me…”

“We don’t fully know what happened but we think Horde Prime used that on you to control you. Use you against us.”

“I thought you might say that. Great...How long?”

Glimmer takes a moment to answer her. “About two weeks. You broke free yesterday afternoon and didn’t wake up until now. It’s I think almost one p.m? I dunno.”

Adora puts the bit back in Entrapta’s hand, not saying anything else. She does not want to keep thinking about this. It has become tiring to fight back memories forming in her head and really would like a break as more try to over take her. The less of a chance they have to appear, the better. At least now, the chip is out.

Glimmer doesn’t say anything either before standing up and walking around Adora, taking a look at the back of the blonde’s neck. Without saying much, she reaches for bandages. It does not take long for everything to be patched up. Adora wonders if she will have another scar to add to her every growing collection on her body.

“Does that feel better?” Glimmer asks.

“Yeah. Thanks. And thank you, Entrapta.”

“Anytime, Adora! We are glad to have you back. Now, if you excuse me, I must go back to my work.”

With that, the older princess leaves. Adora looks at Glimmer. “What is she talking about?”

“She has been trying to figure out anything she can about Prime with robot parts we brought back to her. Honestly don’t know what she has found but we all have been trying to do something,” Glimmer replies.

“Well, I guess there is no more point in sitting around here anymore. Guess I should get dressed.”

“I have some spare clothing. They were in your bag that got left on the ship when-” Glimmer stops short. She nervously rubs a hand on a neck before speaking again. “It's in the chest. I’ll get it.”

Adora follows. Glimmer unlocks the chest and pulls out the blonde’s trusted bag. It feels nice to see it again. The two move over to the table before the queen pulls out her old set of clothing, laying it flat against the wood. The blonde moves closer. Already, she feels a sense of uneasiness.

Adora runs her fingers against the fabric. The sensation is familiar. It is one of the few things that always stayed the same after leaving the place she called home for nearly twenty years. The uniform was the one thing she had left from the Horde. But now the idea of being back in a uniform, especially one that comes from the Horde even if it is different from Prime, gives her a bad taste in her mouth. Doesn’t help the matching set of clothing, from what her mind keeps wanting to show, is exactly the same as what she wore when she got thrown into that icy cold water.

"Something the matter?" Glimmer's voice breaks through her train of thoughts.

"I-It's complicated. I don't really want to talk about it but...it's still too fresh…" Adora takes a step back. She turns away from the clothing. "It's just a lot right now."

Glimmer looks at her, then at the clothing, and then back at Adora. "Do you want to see if we can find something else? I'm sure someone has to have something."

Adora feels a small smile form on her face. Even after everything, the queen still is trying to help her. It makes the dark feeling in her chest ease slightly. Is that all she wanted to do before? Help out with missions only to be forced to stay put away in the castle? What did she do to deserve her? The blonde takes a deep breath. "Yeah, I would like that."

Glimmer nods and disappears for a moment, searching for someone who might be able to help. Adora remains in the tent, not wanting to show herself to the world just yet. She knows it is only a matter of time before she will have to see everyone else. Face everyone that she might have hurt, those memories just waiting to pounce. Two weeks was it that she was gone? That is a lot of time to cause chaos. A lot of time for hidden memories to be. For now, she tells herself to stand up straight. There is still a war going on and things to do. She can't let this drag her down or let others be dragged down with her.

By the time Glimmer returns with a bundle of clothes, nearly blocking her head, Adora has forced the darkness in her as far down as possible. She still can feel bits sticking out of the bottle she made but it's enough to ignore, for now. When the queen sets the clothing down, Adora joins her and begins to shift through everything. It takes some time for the two to settle on something that fits and feels comfortable on Adora.

A dark, neutral colored jacket with a hood, a shirt some shades lighter underneath it, and a new set of pants and boots. There still feels like there is something missing. While taking a look at herself, seeing how she feels about another change in look, she catches a glimpse of her hands. She takes a chance and digs

around one last time before finding what she is looking for. Gloves, and fingerless. Glimmer gives her a small look but thankfully, doesn't question it.

Last thing on the plate is to clean the drying blood on her ear and attempt to fix her hair into something not as horrible. A wet rag manages to be dug up and used to wash herself clean. With her hair now quite short, it does not take long for it to be brushed out and made neat. Adora takes a quick look at herself in the broken mirror. No more ponytails, not for who knows how long, and time to get used having bangs. Between this and her new clothes, she cannot recognize the person who stares back at her.

When finally ready, Adora walks over to the mouth of the tent. She pauses before exiting. Her nerves are starting to work their way through her body, feeling like uncomfortable bolts of electricity. Who knows who is out there. What they will ask her or what they will think about everything. Adora still is piecing everything together herself but what else will cause something to crop up in her mind?

"Are you nervous?" Glimmer asks.

"You can say that," Adora answers.

"You saw how Bow and Entrapta were. Even myself and my dad. Everyone is dying to see you again. It's okay." Glimmer gives her a slight nudge. "Everything will be fine now and when you are feeling up to it, you can help us figure out how to stop Prime once and for all."

"Right…Let's get this over with."

Adora and Glimmer step out into the camp. The blonde winces, squinting back the bright afternoon light. A couple moments pass before she can see clearly. She begins to take everything in, assessing her surroundings. The camp is full of life. Chatter fills the air, still too mixed together to make sense of what is being said. Some people spar with one another, others sit alone eating

or bask in the sun, and then some walk about, going in and out of tents. Nothing seems to have changed, other than the area, since she left weeks ago.

A few pairs of eyes look over at her. Most are curious and surprised. A small handful seem to be unsure. Adora swears she can vaguely recognize some of the latter's faces. She turns her gaze away, continuing to follow Glimmer to wherever she is leading her. It does not take long for someone she does know to appear. The Star Siblings. Adora is taken aback by the sight of the trio. The last time she saw them, they were heading off elsewhere. What are they doing here in Etheria? Starla is the first to notice the pair coming in their direction.

"Hey! You're finally awake!" the youngest siblings shouts. She closes the gap between them, a wide smile on her face. Glory chirps happily at the sight of the blonde.

"Hey. What are you doing here? Not that it isn't good to see you," Adora replies.

"We decided to come help you," Tallstar starts. "You helped us and we wanted to return the favor. We are going to help take down Horde Prime once and for all."

"Oh! Well, thank you. I don't know what else to say."

"You don't have to say anything. We are just glad you are back. How are you feeling?" Jewelstar asks.

Adora gives a small shrug, rubbing an arm slightly. "I'll be alright. But seriously, thank you. I am really glad to see you guys."

"Same to you. And you have to thank Glimmer for that. She kept going after you," Starla states.

"Kept?" Adora turns her attention to the smaller girl. "What does she mean?"

“Ah! Well, okay that last time was by chance but I...might have snuck out at one point with Catra to try and get you back. Wasn’t my best idea since I was still recovering.”

Adora attempts to think for a moment. She recalls seeing Glimmer and her former best friend, and some other creature. The three fought with her, trying their best to win, but she easily overpowered them. Glimmer especially. It took a shift blow to knock all the wind out of the queen and leaver her defenseless. What stopped her from killing Glimmer? She remembers that cat thing tackling her before she could do anything.

“Wait...Still recovering? Did you come after me when you were hurt? What happened to not barreling through things? You could have gotten yourself killed!”

“Well what was I supposed to do? Did you want me to sit and wait and let things get worse or have you stay trapped?”

“N-No! But you still are important, you're the queen, and shouldn’t risk your life like that.”

“You’re important too, Adora. That’s why I went after you.”

Adora pauses for a moment, not exactly knowing what to say. She attempts to come up with a retort, opening her mouth, when a noise cuts her off. Both she, Glimmer, and the Star Siblings look towards it. Scorpia and Frosta are coming up fast. Adora quickly prepares herself to be crushed in the scorpion princess’ arms. Even then, she loses all her air the second her claws wrap around her and lift her off the ground.

“Scorpia! Ribs!” Adora wheezes.

“Oh! Sorry! Sorry!” Scorpia says. She puts Adora back down. “I couldn’t help myself.”

Frosta is more gentle. She wraps her arms around Adora’s waist before burying her face into her abdomen. Adora sighs softly and

places her hands on the young princess' shoulders. Frosta slowly looks up, tears in her eyes.

"I missed you too, Frosta." Adora says softly.

Something starts to form in Adora's head as she looks at Scorpia and Frosta. The blonde takes a breath, clutching the side of her head. She doesn't want another memory to form. There has been enough confusion in her mind already today in such a short timeframe, no need to continue to add to the pile. Somehow, she manages to keep it at bay.

"Hey, you alright?" Scorpia asks.

"Huh? Yeah. Don't worry about it. It really is nice to see you all again."

"You must be hungry. Do you want to get something to eat? I'm sure we can find something," Glimmer pipes up.

Oddly enough, she doesn't feel *that* hungry. However, getting something in her might do her some good and she can see what else is going on in the camp. She nods and Frosta lets go of her. The small group of friends begin to head off, being led by the queen of Brightmoon, something catches Adora's eyes. Some yards away, Catra stands near a tent. Their eyes lock with each other, neither move so much as an inch.

Adora does not know what to make of this. If her broken up memories serve her right, as well as Glimmer's word, Catra made an attempt to get her back also. But part of her wonders if there is an ulterior motive to that. There always seems to be something with the magicat. Always wanting something in return. Though what could she possibly want? Adora got captured trying to get her away from Horde Prime and had to suffer from it. What more could Catra ask for?

Adora shakes the thought from her mind, not wanting to bother with her former best friend at the moment. She has been up for how long and already got so much thrown in her face? With one

last glance, uttering nothing, the blonde turns her gaze away and follows a couple paces behind the rest of the group.

Chapter End Notes

this week fic rec/shout out is my friend's Crynelium/Jamz work Heartache It's a one sided Glimmadora (Glimmer) fic and it's good

Talk to Me

Chapter Notes

> ch tw for panic attacks, flashback, some blood, and negative thoughts

See the end of the chapter for more notes

What makes for a ‘mess hall’ is not much in the long run. A large tent holds some tables and not much else. Two are on the farthest side, trays of food resting on top of them. The remainder are on the other side with some other rebels sitting down at them, chit-chatting the day away. A few take some notice of the new group coming in. If anyone stares, Adora does not meet their eyes. She keeps her own gaze forward. She continues to trail a few steps behind the rest of the group as they head to grab some food.

Adora takes a glance at what is laid out in front of her. Some of it she recognizes, a few she does not. With so many people from different areas of Etheria here, she wonders what comes from where. Despite being to so many parts of the world, she can’t recall trying many of their dishes. Whatever the case, the blonde decides against trying anything new at the moment. Her stomach’s mood has not changed and if she might only nibble on things, no need to waste food that can go to others. She grabs some bread, some vegetables, and some sort of meat. Once Adora has gathered her food, she begins to head over towards where everyone has settled down.

While she heads over to join her friends, a tingling sensation runs down her spine. It suddenly feels like hundreds of pairs of eyes are on her. They bore into her and cause the hairs on the back of her neck to stand attention. She slowly turns her head towards one of the other tables. For a brief moment, she swears gazes were on her. But in a blink, the attention of those at the table is back at each other. If she isn’t going insane, Adora has no idea what their looks were like. Were they watching her because they

cannot believe she has finally returned? Or because they no longer know what to make of her and want to keep an eye on her?

Adora quickly shakes the thought from her head. She tells herself to ignore it, that it could have been nothing. Even if it was something, there are other things she has to deal with. The blonde finishes her walk to the table. Frosta, Tallstar, Scorpia, and Starla sit at one side while Jewelstar, Glimmer, and Bow, who randomly has appeared, are on the other side. For a moment, she debates where to sit, her heart longing for one over the other. Another part of her says otherwise. Refuse that part of her. She is about to make a final decision when Glimmer gives a small wave.

Adora takes a breath before taking a seat besides Bow before he can shift over. He looks taken aback. Glimmer herself looks crestfallen. Neither say anything about it, only exchanging small looks with each other. Adora does her best to ignore their worriment and begins to eat, nibbling on her bread. Looking down at her plate, despite being smaller in proportion to everyone else, Adora realizes that this is the best meal she has had in awhile. At least she can find some sort of enjoyment out of it even if everything tastes bland at the moment.

"So, how are you feeling? Now that you've been up for a bit," Bow asks.

Adora gives a small shrug. "Kind of tired but other than that, fine? I guess. Still just taking everything in."

"Take it easy, don't try to overload yourself," Glimmer tells her.

"I'll try not to. Though, speaking of which. Uh, what is the status of everything? You know...since I've been gone."

The silence that hangs in the air is more than enough of an answer for her. Guess things are either just as bad before she left or worse. The longer the quiet goes on the more she feels they are trying to come up with an answer that doesn't involve her. The

gaps in her memory are like missing puzzle pieces. She cannot get a full picture until she has them all, however, there is enough pieced together to get some idea in her mind. *Guess the Rebellion really is worse off because of me,* Adora thinks, unable to stop the thought from making a home in her mind.

"It's been a little rough, I won't lie, Glimmer answers, "but we are all still here, aren't we? Haven't given up yet! And now that you're back, I'm sure we can regain the ground we lost."

"Yeah! Horde Prime won't have any idea what hit him with you back!" Frosta shouts, a wide smile on her face.

"Well I hope I can get on my feet fast enough to help out," Adora says.

"Maybe tomorrow after you rest up some more you can train a little bit. That always cheers you up," Bow suggests.

"I like the sound of that."

Their conversation turns into small chatter. Mostly about the food or other nuanced things. Adora attempts to pay attention and listen in to her friends talk, not adding much with her own thoughts. A few times she enters her own little world, hearing nothing but static as she thinks about the state of the world and what can be done to fix it. At least twice Bow nudges her back into reality. At one point, just looking at the food below her makes her feel nauseous. Despite there being almost half of it left, she pushes it away, not wanting to make herself sick. That is something she definitely does not need.

At some point, Adora begins to play with what little hair she has. She struggles to wrap her head around the fact it is all gone just like that. Normally when deep in thought or worried, absentmindedly she would begin to play with her dark blonde locks. Now there is barely anything to do as such.

"Hey, what are you thinking about?" Bow softly asks.

“Huh? Oh, nothing. Don’t worry about it,” Adora replies.

“You sure? Doesn’t seem like nothing.”

“You know, you still look nice,” Glimmer says.

Adora knows she means well but she still winces at the comment. It is like a slap in the face. She mutters some sort of thanks as a way to quickly drop the topic. Adora ends up pulling her new hood over her head and ceases to stop playing with her hair. Thankfully, the topic is quickly changed. Everyone has more or less finished their meal and are ready to clean up and figure out what else there is to do. There is not much at the moment but everyone can usually find something. Once everyone is ready, they head back out to camp.

The group begins to break apart, going off to train or plan or get ready to scout, leaving the trio of friends alone. As she watches everyone leave to go about the rest of their day, Adora takes a look around. There does not seem to be any more familiar faces around. She turns her gaze at her remaining friends. “Hey. So where is Mermista, Sea Hawk, Swifty, and Perfuma?”

Both Bow and Glimmer freeze in place like an animal caught in a spotlight. They look at each other before the queen answers. “A-Away.”

Adora raises an eyebrow. “Are they alright?” She can see the sweat starting to form on Glimmer’s forehead. “Glimmer?”

“Well. Mermista and Sea Hawk last time we checked were fine. They had been helping hold down the fort at Brightmoon and elsewhere since Salineas fell thanks to Catra. Hopefully we can meet up with them soon. Swift Wind is doing some stuff, I forget what.”

“And Perfuma?” Adora presses. The same sensation she felt when she saw Scorpia and Frosta. Her heart begins to race in her chest and a feeling of dread threatens to overtake her. The nervous looks on Glimmer’s and Bow’s faces do not ease her in the

slightest. She fails to stop the answer from leaving the queen's lips.

"We don't know, Adora."

Adora sees herself holding the plant princess up in the air. Perfuma begs her to stop, to listen, but she refuses to listen to any of her pleads. She remembers debating on if she should just kill and get rid of her but something stops her. Whatever it was, Adora doesn't want to recall, she wants the playback of attacking her friend to stop. It only ends when Perfuma is thrown into some sort of cell.

"I-I-I-" Adora cannot get her words out. It is taking everything in her to swallow the anxiety and tears threatening to burst out of her. Her body begins to tremble.

"Adora. Adora, breathe," Glimmer says. Her hands find the blonde's arms, holding them tight. "That wasn't you. That was Prime!"

Adora shakes her head, attempting to pull away from the queen's tight grasp. She still did it. "I attacked her! I attacked her and kidnapped her! I locked her up!"

"So she isn't dead?" Bow asks. He gently places his own hand on her back.

"I don't...I don't think so. I can't remember, and I don't want to keep remembering right now, it's too much, but I think she is still alive."

"Then that good, Adora! That's good. We can still figure out how to save her. It will be okay." Glimmer tells her. "Take a breath. We'll figure it out."

"How?"

"I don't know. We just have to take everything one step at a time. Again, you're back! With your help we definitely can figure

something out.”

Adora finally manages to rip her arms away from the queen. Another thing to add to her list of things to fix. Hoping she can get to Perfuma before anything bad can happen to her. What will she think of Adora if they ever reunite? Will she hate herself for snatching her away and locking her up? Exactly how much of a mess has she made of the world? Anger begins to boil inside of her at the thought of what she has done.

“What good am I with no sword and Horde Prime’s the biggest threat there is?!? What are we going to do?!? Use me as bait again since he probably wants me back in his grasp?!?”

Glimmer cannot hold back a flinch. “No! I am not going to do that! I am going to make sure Prime never touches you again! But we will figure something out and not just rush in again! No more loss but we will fix this!”

Both stand tense as they stare each other down. Time itself feels like it has stilled. Out of the corner of her eye, Adora sees Bow standing nervously. Weeks have passed and it seems like not much as changed. Adora takes a breath and relaxes her shoulders, not wanting a cycle to repeat itself. “Sorry. There is just *so* much going on.”

Glimmer eases her own body. “I’m sorry also. We can figure out more tomorrow. There is no need to overload you right now. Does that sound good to you?”

“Okay, sure, Glimmer.”

“Hey, here.” Without much of a warning, the queen gently grabs ahold of Adora’s wrist and turns her hand so her palm is upward. Before the blonde can say anything, Glimmer drops a small, wrapped piece of candy.

“What is this for.” Adora asks. When Glimmer lets go of her, she rolls the sweet around with her thumb.

"An apology for the hair comment. I saw you wince. Bunch of people had these for the kids but I took some for the hell of it. It's my last one but I know no one has a bigger sweet tooth than you so take it."

You are sweeter than this to me, Adora thinks. She pulls the hood off her head. "Thank you. I'll savour it."

Adora tosses and turns in her sleep, unable to find any peace. Only the day before, there was nothing as she laid unconscious. Only a black void met her, causing her to skip a whole day of her life. Now, having a day full of memories, catching up, and trying to grasp what happened to her and what she did, it all comes right back at her. It does not show any signs of mercy.

At first, they are playbacks of what she remembered throughout the day. Glimmer's bloody and broken body laid out in front of her, her sword and hands a bright red. The smell of smoke and fire as she erases villages off the face of Etheria. Horde Prime looms all over, either showing his full self or just his glowing eyes. The images in her mind begin to morph into something new.

It starts off with capturing Perfuma and bringing her back some place, presumably belonging to Horde Prime. She watches with joy as images of Plumeria being overrun are shown to the princess, causing tears to form in her eyes. Prime soon joins them, talking to Perfuma. Whatever he says is muted. Adora can feel the anger in the princess' dark eyes bore into her as she laughs at her misery. More mockery, taunts, anything to make Perfuma break.

Things pick up speed in her mind as her heart races and she gasps for breath. She watches herself rip out the Heart Blossom out of the base of the tree. The Pearl from Salineas comes soon after. A voice commands her to take over the kingdoms, needing their runestones for a specific reason. She can't grasp why, the words are out of her reach, but regardless she listens. She listens without hesitation and with eagerness. She wanted to make

everyone who ever hurt her, who doubted her, and who made her carry the weight of the world on her shoulder feel the pain she always hid away in order to try and save everyone. The pain of having to stop the world from nearly blowing up twice and fighting for her life to do so.

She wanted to earn Horde Primes respect and adoration. And he gave her that.

Her mind refuses to let her wake. The images shift into something different. Of Glimmer once more. The queen stares at her with a sick shade of bright, glowing green. Blood flows freely out of her abdomen and one of her legs. A large, dark grin is plastered on her face. She inches her way closer. Adora tries to escape, get away from the threat, but her body has become like a statue and refuses to budge. All she can do is watch as this twisted form of Glimmer reaches her. An icy cold hand touches her cheek, causing her breath to get caught in her throat.

"*You did this to me*," Glimmer speaks in a tone the same temperature as her hand. "*You wanted this, didn't you*?"

"N-No! I didn't *want* to hurt you. I *never* wanted to hurt you," Adora replies, struggling to hold her voice steady.

"*But didn't you want me to understand how much you were hurting? Did you know **I** was hurting? Doesn't matter now. You still never held back when you attacked me. You still went through it all without second thought. You wanted this."*

"No! Shut up!" Somehow Adora slaps Glimmer's hand away. Her own hands cover her ears and she squeezes her eyes shut. It does little to block out the queen's voice blaming her for everything. She wants to flee, run away, scream, shout, anything to make it stop. It takes everything in her to fight back the voice in her head as it threatens to drown her.

The next thing Adora knows, she is springing to attention, gasping as her scream remains lodged in her lungs along with her breath.

Cold sweat forms all over her body, running down her skin. She can feel her heartbeat in her throat. Her mind has yet to return to her. She has no idea where she is. All she knows is the sense of fear, dread, and anger threatening to swallow her whole.

It was just a nightmare, Adora! Breathe! Gods, breathe! Adora tells herself. Her breath refuses to budge. She knows part of what she struggles to remind herself of is a lie. It might have been a nightmare but it was nothing her mind came up with. They came from reality. When breathing finally returns to the blonde, it comes out sharp and ragged.

She buries her face into palms, trying to gain some semblance of control over herself. Her body now has begun to shake uncontrollably. Tears are threatening to spill out of her eyes. Her mind is slowly rebooting but the damage is already done. She knows she took two of the runestones, along with a princess, and didn't let anything stop her. Everything has become clearer and leaves a foul taste in her mouth. How did she let this happen?

The twisted form of Glimmer re-enters her mind. Her eyes filled in with that horrible shade of green. The large wounds on her body flow freely with blood. Adora swears she has seen her before. Her racing mind tries to find the missing puzzle pieces that hold the answer she seeks. The Glimmer in her mind shifts, becoming just like the one she knows and loves. Smiling bright, warmth radiating off of her. Nothing about her is broken, all traces of the injuries inflicted on her are gone. A hand is outstretched, offering her something.

Like a sudden skip of a scene from a video feed, the image quickly shifts into being back on Horde Prime's ship. Glimmer, pale and in her own pool of blood, lays out in front of her. Adora remembers wanting it to end, for the whole thing not to be real and just something made up. Without warning, the image she sees changes again into Glimmer in picture perfect health. Back and forth it goes as a sentence starts to form in her head.

Come with me...

Where? Adora wonders. The images continue to flicker back and forth. A groan escapes her. She wants this onslaught on her mind to cease. She begins taking deep breaths, still struggling to regain control of herself. It feels like a noose is tightening every passing moment around her neck. A hand reaches down to grab her sheets, feel the soft, linen fabric against her skin for any anchor back down to Etheria. It does little to help her. She *has* to think and figure something out. What else, what else, what else? The images are continuing and starting to take new shapes. Ones of being right at Horde Prime's side.

Going to Glimmer is out of the question. Not right now when the image of her broken body, almost at death's door haunt her. She would not dream of seeking comfort from Catra. Scorpia? No, she was too close to Perfuma. No need for that reminder. Frosta is far too young and she barely knows the Star Siblings. Who else?

"Bow…" Adora manages to breathe out.

She staggers to her feet, legs shaking under her weight. He is only in the next tent over, only some yards away. She just has to make it that far and somehow not alert anyone else in the dead of night to her plight. With what little control she has left, she makes her way out of her own tent she was given several hours before. The cool, night air nips at her skin, helping her ground herself more but still not enough. She pushes forward until she is at the flap of her best friend's tent. Bow is fast asleep on his bed, snoring.

"Bow!" Adora gasps, still feeling her heart wanting to race out of her chest. He remains asleep. Adora sucks in a breath and attempts to speak louder and with more strength. "*Bow!*"

This snaps him out of his slumber. He is quickly on his feet, an arm reaching behind him, grasping at nothing in his flight to fight. "Who's there? What?" he looks around the room before settling down on the blonde. He pauses before his dark eyes go wide with alarm. "Adora! Are you okay?"

In a matter of moments, he is at her side. Adora nearly collapses into him as he wraps arms tight around her shaking body. “I think...I think I’m having a….a panic attack. Please, help. Gods, help.”

“Okay, okay. Breathe. What do you want me to do?”

Adora gasps for air in an attempt to listen to his advice. “Dis-Distract me.”

“Okay, uh...Dang it...Okay, tell me what you see in my tent.”

“It’s almost p-pitched b-black...how can I s-see anything?”

“Exactly. You really have to think about it. Tell me.”

Adora squints, trying to make out his room in the dim light. Outlines of objects slowly start to take shape. As they become sharp, she begins to list everything off. His bed, his weapon off to the side, some books, maps, a small table…

“...and, um, I think your communication pad is on the table?”

“Yeah it is. How are you feeling?”

Her heart still races in her chest but no longer feels like it is about to explode out of her. The breaths she takes gradually become even and steady. Adora continues to scan the room, keeping her thoughts elsewhere. Her body trembles but no longer shakes violently. “Not great, but better.”

“Good. I’m glad.”

Adora inhales deeply, taking a moment to keep the air she struggled to inhale in her, before exhaling. She pulls away from Bow’s embrace. “Thank you.”

“Do you want to talk about it at all? I’m awake now so I am all ears.”

Adora shakes her head before holding herself. “I...I don’t want to give myself another attack by mistake. And...it’s a lot. And it's like what? Three in the morning right now?”

“Are you sure?”

“Yeah. Yeah I am.”

“Okay. I know you don’t want to talk about it but do you want to see if Glimmer is up? She might be, knowing her, and I know she makes you feel better.”

Adora can’t help but chuckle a little. She tucks a loose strain of hair behind her ear before saying, “N-No. She kind of...is the reason I had it…”

“Oh? ...*Oh.* Adora…”

“I’m fine. I’m really tired now, I just want to lie down.”

“Adora, you know we are all here for you. Glimmer especially. She wanted you back more than anything in the world. She isn’t going to hate or blame you.”

“I know. There just...even before there was so much that happened. I don't even know what to begin with with her."

Bow gives her a small nudge. “You’re smart. You’ll figure it out. And I am here to help out. If you are going back to bed, did you want to stay here? I don’t know if that will help.”

Adora smiles softly, appreciating the offer. However, she doesn’t want to wake him up again with her nightmares, everyone needs their rest, and he already has done more than enough tonight. “Thanks but no. I’ll catch you in the morning, alright?”

“Okay. I’ll see you tomorrow.”

She gives him a small nod before exiting the tent. Half way through her trek back to her own quarters, she stops and looks up

at the night sky. The bright, shining stars stare down at her. Ever since she first learned about them so long, she has been fascinated by the brilliant lights. Wonder always filled her when she thought about what they would look like. Now they are here and for a brief moment, she got to explore them. Adora can't lie, she enjoyed being up in space and seeing the vastness of it. However, part of her wonders if it was all worth it.

She reaches her hand up and rubs the back of her neck. Hopefully, all she is looking at are stars and nothing more.

Glimmer wonders what it is like to have a full night's sleep. It must have been months ago, long before Horde Prime threatened to take over Etheria, when she slept through the night peacefully. She definitely had Adora with her then, nestled up besides her. And that is something else she has not had in ages. A small part of her was hoping yesterday when night began to fall, Adora would come back into her tent and be with her. Of course, that was a childish wish.

Adora had refused the offer and found an empty tent to take residence in. Glimmer did not push. It barely had been twenty-four hours since the blonde came back to full consciousness. So, alone in her room she went and for most of the drawn out night, she stared at the ceiling or walls or anything else, thinking of nothing but what tomorrow might bring. At some point, she must have slipped into unconsciousness for a brief time as one moment her room was dark, and then in a blink, light began to stream in.

Now, she hangs around camp, waiting for Adora to appear. Glimmer hopes that the blonde got better sleep then herself. She definitely needs it. There was no sneaking into her room so maybe with any luck, Adora found something. Though, knowing how Adora is, stopping Horde Prime would come easier.

After some time, and beginning to worry she would not show, Adora appears. Glimmer's heart drops somewhat in her chest. The blonde looks no better than yesterday, hell maybe even slightly

more tired. When Adora sees the queen, she smiles and gives a wave. After so long of knowing her, Glimmer knows Adora won't say anything and will play it off. Maybe distracting her is the best course of action.

Glimmer shrinks the gap between them. Together again, the pair get a quick bite to eat while the queen catches Adora up to speed some more. She does her best to leave out some information regarding what she did and what she possibly was involved with. If Glimmer is gonna distract, that is the last thing that will help. Tell Adora enough to catch her up to speed more and not overload her with the horrors she was forced to do. It seems to work. The blonde says nothing or shows any sign of remembering anything.

After getting some food into their systems (Glimmer noticing once again Adora not putting much on her plate) a suggestion is made to spar somewhat. Get Adora back into the swing of things and blow off some steam. Adora's sky blue eyes brighten at the idea. *Never fails,* Glimmer thinks. She happily guides the blonde where they can pick up something to train with.

"So...I broke the staff, huh?" Adora says when they begin to look at some weapons. Her hands brush across the ends of those she debates picking up.

"Yeah, ya did," Glimmer sighs. There was no point in hiding that fact when she will need something to defend herself with. "I still have the broken pieces but I don't know how much help they'll be."

"Great. No staff and no more She-ra. Least the Horde did one thing right and I know how to fight."

Glimmer raises an eyebrow. Guess both she has yet to recall that memory and no one else has mentioned that she has been able to somehow turn into the legendary warrior princess, though a darker version. Another thing to be aware of not to mention too soon. That definitely would break Adora's heart, knowing Prime

managed to bring She-ra back when she couldn't. It's still a wonder how he was able to do that.

"And you are one of the best fighters we have. Now hurry up and pick something so I can kick your ass."

"Don't get ahead of yourself yet," Adora starts. Her fingers wrap around a sturdy looking sword, "I still won more spars than you."

Glimmer opens her mouth for a playful retort. She is cut off, however, as Adora turns to show off her new weapon. A cold, shiver runs down the queen's spine as the image of the blonde in Horde Prime's clothing, eyes glowing bright green, and a sword poise to strike her down fills her mind. She can't stop the knee-jerk reaction of staggering back. Her heel trips over something unseen, causing the queen to fall flat on her back. Fear courses through her body as breathing suddenly becomes difficult and her heart lodges in her throat. Heat radiates off the scar on her stomach.

"Glimmer!" Adora shouts. Glimmer now is on her hands, her mind telling her to push herself back. In the moments it takes for her to regain control of her body, Adora is on the ground, looking at her with shock and worry. "What happened? All I did wa-"

"A-Adora. Adora, no!" Glimmer begins. Too late. She watches Adora's face become pale and fall with recognition. The same look as when it dawn on her what happened to Perfuma appears. Adora stares at the sword before tossing it aside with force. Glimmer swallows a dry lump, wanting to ease whatever must now be playing back in the blonde's mind. "Adora, it's not your fault, I-"

Adora is quick to her feet. Glimmer sees a sheen in her eyes as she begins to step back. "No. This was a bad idea. I'm sorry I...I have to go."

There is no time to say anything else. Adora is gone in a flash, disappearing just as fast as the image Glimmer saw of her

chipped self moments ago. The queen is left on the ground, stunned and confused about what just occurred. She knows that is no longer Adora. She is no longer in the grasp of Horde Prime and no longer is a threat to anyone. Never in a million years would the blonde willing harm her in any capacity. Glimmer wishes to forget that moment where she almost lost her life to the person she loves, yet her body refuses to do so.

Glimmer does the only thing she knows what to do. Hands find her face, covering it as she lets out a scream. Muffled or not, she doesn't care if anyone hears her. It barely has been twenty-four hours since Adora woke up and became aware of everything around her and already things are back to being fucked between them. Though, nothing was fixed between them to begin with. Now something else has been added to the mess their relationship has become. Glimmer kicks herself for reacting how she did but she couldn’t help it. How can anything be repaired when she is like this?

The queen continues to scream, refusing to stop until there is not a shred of oxygen in her lungs and her throat feels raw. Glimmer sucks in new air as she removes her hands. Tears have escaped her eyes, leaving streaks down the side of her face. She lies there, unmoving for several long moments. Guilt and regret begins to eat away at her soul. Staying in this position won’t do her any good, however. Summoning what little strength she has now, Glimmer gets to her feet. Her eyes find the discarded sword at the far side of the tent. There is not a single speck of blood on it.

Before leaving, Glimmer puts the weapon back on the table, joining the rest of its siblings. Now she has to figure out what to do for the rest of the day. As much as she wants to go after the blonde, tell her none of this was her fault and it was the queen’s own mind and body reacting to what happened when Adora wasn’t in control, it will have to wait. Going after her now will most likely lead to rejection. What little time they have at the moment, Glimmer knows both she and Adora need.

A couple days pass. Barely anything is spoken between the queen and the blonde. Every time Glimmer has tried to get Adora alone, talk to her in some semblance, Adora always figures something out to wriggle free of doing so. The only time they are together and 'talk' is when eating together or discussions of what to do next with others. Even then, they only speak for a brief moment at each other, mostly responding to things. It begins to get under her skin, the continued lack of communication. But there is not much else she can do. Glimmer herself finds herself busy half the time and worrying about hearing more stories of land lost to Prime.

Everyone begins to notice the reignition of strain between the two. Most don't ask about it, not wanting to open a can of worms. Bow and Catra press somewhat, wondering what the hell is going on. Bow takes a gentle approach, trying to give suggestions on how to talk to Adora or just tries to help get her mind off of the situation. Catra, on the other hand, is a little more brash. She saw Adora run out of the tent and later, Glimmer leaving frustrated. The queen does not quite like the magicat's advice of just sucking it up and ripping the band-aid off.

Glimmer doesn't know what to do or who to listen to. It does little to help her with sleep. At this point, she becomes too wound up to truly rest. Only for a couple minutes when she is sitting does she nod off before snapping right back to attention seconds later. The queen seriously begins to wonder if anything can be fixed between them if this keeps up.

During the afternoon, Glimmer finds herself absentmindedly chewing on her fork, not touching her food. She is alone, everyone else busy. From what she has been told, Adora is training with one of the Star Siblings. That pretty much is all she does now when not doing anything else. At this rate, she is going to work herself to death. Yet, Adora won't listen and continues to push herself. This is not good.

The sound of a plate sliding against the table catches her attention. Glimmer snaps out of her thoughts and looks towards

her side. Scorpia has taken a seat besides her.

“Mind if I sit here?” The scorpion princess asks.

“You already are,” Glimmer replies.

“So I take that as a yes.”

Glimmer rolls her eyes. “What’s up?”

“Not much...wanted to see how you were. You’ve been pretty gloomy lately.”

“Can you blame me? Adora is back and nothing has gotten better between us, I think it has gotten *worse!* I know it’s been a couple days since she came back and...a lot happened in the time she was gone so everything can’t be fixed right away. I just….I just don’t know what to do or say.”

Scorpia thinks for a moment, tapping her fork on her chin. After several long moments she speaks. “I don’t know if I have any answers. I’ve never been in a situation quite like yours and like you said, you need time, which we don’t really have.”

“Thanks for reminding me…”

“I know Adora means the world to you. Things are looking bleak all around and it seems like nothing can be fixed. But Adora needs you and I think you need Adora. But you can’t let this rift keep growing between you or it will become too big to patch up.”

“Where do I even start?”

“Start by being open. Let it out and stop holding everything back.”

Glimmer sighs. “That is easier said than done.”

“But once you do it, that weight will be lifted off of your shoulders, maybe enough so healing isn’t so much of a burden. Will you just try?”

“I’ll try…”

Adora holds back pants, refusing to believe she is already this tired. She only has been training with the youngest of the Star Siblings for no more than five minutes and already it feels like she has been at it for an hour. The blonde ducks out of the way from a knife throw, at least having enough sense for that. Still, her vision blurs with any exertion and the world threatens to spin out from under her. Adora groans, shaking her head to clear it. She really wants to chalk this all up to lack of sleep. Many times before she has trained when running on zero. But even with her nightmare filled rest as of late, she still has gotten *some* sleep. Why does her body feel so weak and heavy? It’s like she has been running on empty for a long, long time and like it has been working towards a breaking point.

Despite this, Adora pushes forward every time she has trained and is not about to stop now. With clear vision, she sees Starla staring back at her, fret written all over her face. Adora forces herself to stand up straight, using the new sword to keep her steady. “I’m fine, if that is what you are wondering.”

“Are you sure? You look tired.” Starla answers.

“I’m just...rusty. Don’t hold back, though. Prime sure as hell won’t.”

“We can take a break if you want. I don’t mind it.”

“No. Come on. Show me what you got!”

Starla makes a noise, not looking too keen on the idea. However, she listens and continues their sparring session. Once Adora is in a ready stance, the youngest siblings throws her knives at the blonde. Adora swiftly moves out of the way of one and blocks the other with her weapon. Starla whistles, calling for Glory. Adora has just enough time to duck under the claws of the bird.

However, she does not have enough time to recover. Starla is suddenly on top of her. The next thing Adora registers is lying flat on her back, staring up at the cloudless, bright, blue sky. Every part of Adora's body screams, wishing for everything to cease. She grits her teeth, holding back a cry as her body slowly settles down. With the blink of her eyes, Starla and Glory are hovering over her.

"I think we should stop, Adora," Starla says.

"I just need a moment," Adora can't stop herself from gasping. "Just...give me a sec."

"Adora, I've seen you train a lot. You're an amazing fighter and you deserve some rest. It won't help anyone if you push yourself too hard. Let me help you up." Starla sticks out her hand. Adora groans before taking the offer. She rises to tired legs. "You know, I still had fun training with you."

"For all of those five minutes?"

"Yes. Once you feel better we can do it again. How does that sound?"

"Sure. Whatever...I think...I think I am going to take a walk. Do you mind putting this back for me?"

Starla nods and grabs the sword. Once the weapon is out of her grasp, Adora leaves the training area with no destination in mind. All she can think about is how much her body has been betraying her. Nightmares, lack of sleep, barely wanting to eat, and losing so much strength she can barely fight at all. She has to pause for a moment during her walk to steady out the world again. Maybe she really does need rest but that is an almost impossible task.

She tells herself to power through it. She can rest once she fixes things and Prime is no longer a threat. It's the least she can do after all the destruction she has caused during the two weeks she was 'working' for him. It's the least she can do for Glimmer after scaring her. Just recalling the event from before adds to the

misery inside of her. A part of her wonders if it is the best that she stays away from her if she still continues to hurt her.

She wonders if anyone needs her at all in her state, if she would be of any actual help to the Rebellion or just more of a hindrance.

When the world finally stops spinning like a top, Adora is surprised to see Catra's weird alien cat has materialized in front of her. It takes a moment for their name to crop back in her head. She forgets who told her the name but she knows it's Melog. What in the world are they doing here?

Melog steps closer, pushing their head against one of Adora's hands. The blonde begins to run her fingers through it's soft, velvet like fur, earning a purr. Adora can't help but smile a little. That is, until Melog grabs her by the cuff of her jacket and begins to pull.

"Woah! Woah! Woah!" Adora yanks back but Melog has a tight grip on her fabric. "What do you want? I don't really have time to play."

Melog makes a noise, tugging hard and nearly knocking Adora off her feet. "Do you want me to follow you? Will that make you happy?" Adora asks.

Melog lets so and meows softly. Guess she was right. The alien cat begins to walk in front of her, looking back every now and again to make sure she is following. Adora has no idea where they are going until they reach the end of the camp. A lone tent, disconnected from the rest, waits for her. Adora feels her stomach twist into a tight knot. She knows who this tent belongs too. Melog disappears inside, leaving her all alone.

Adora hesitates for a moment, lingering at the mouth of the tent. Her gut twists tighter inside of her, telling her what lies inside is something she is dreading. Catra's the last person on the planet the blonde wants to see but Melog pretty much pestered her to come to her. If she tucks her tail and leaves, will the alien cat

follow her and drag her back here? Why does Catra want her? What in the world is so important that she had to send her pet to fetch her?

Inhaling sharply, and against better judgement, Adora enters the tent. She stops only a couple steps in, ready to exit at a moment's notice. Sure enough, Catra stands at the other end, Melog resting right behind her. The magicat's dual colored eyes stay locked on the blonde, her ears pulled back. She sees her tail flicking nervously behind her.

Neither speak. Adora finds her mind not blank on what to say, but filled *so much* with thoughts she cannot pick one to start. Confliction. Catra was her first friend and longest one. The one she told all her secrets to at the Horde. Yet, she used those moments of intimacy as weapons against her. Adora cared enough for her to try and bring her from the Horde and into the safety of the Rebellion, only for Catra to spat it back in her face and later blame her for leaving. Blame her for the world ending when it was *she* who pulled the lever and *knew* what would happen. Her decision to spite the blonde killed Angella.

Yet, from the pieces she has gathered in her mind and with what everyone has said, Catra risked her life in one of the failed attempts to free the blonde from Horde Prime's grasp. Adora nearly killed her. Staring down at her now, she can see one of Catra's ears having a small nick in it. Adora *wanted* to kill her when she gave her that as she thought about everything the magicat put her through. White, hot anger is starting to boil back inside of her as she tries to figure out what to do. Listen to the small sliver of care for the magicat that rests deep inside of her and that wants those moments of childhood back or cut her out of her life once and for all. Hands become tight fists. Even if she has done one good thing doesn't mean she is off the hook that easily.

It's Catra who finally breaks the tense silence between them. "Glad you came."

“What the hell do you want?” Adora asks, a hint of a growl in her voice.

“I just wanted to talk.”

“Talk? Talk about what? All the shit you did or how it helped lead to this mess. Which, by the way, is a little more pressing at the moment! Prime is gaining more and more control of Etheria every, like, *hour*. I think dealing with that is a little more important.”

“Look, you and I both know this has to happen one way or another. And if we are going to be both trying to kick Prime’s ass, I think maybe not being as tense would help.”

Adora groans and pinches the bridge of her nose. “Fine. Where am I even to begin? Why are you even here anyway?”

“Well, I mean, you saved me. The least I could do is help stop that piece of shit.”

“You’re not planning on backstabbing anyone? No Double Trouble here to cause problems? What do the others think about this?”

“No. Honestly. Trust me, if I wanted to do something I probably would’ve already done it. Frosta already clocked me and Glimmer gave me an earful. I am not here to make friends with you all and I think that goes the same for the others. I don’t want to see Etheria be blown up.”

Adora can’t help but laugh a little. “You’re one to talk! You tried to blow it up already! What the hell changed your mind? You know that is what tipped Prime off to our existence.”

“No shit. I figured that out already. I’m trying to make up for some of the stuff I did like stopping him and not letting him do what I almost did.”

“And how else do you expect to make up for everything else?!? For sending Double Trouble to mess with me, Glimmer, Bow, and the other princesses?!? Or taking over Salineas! Do you know how

many people you displaced or took their life away? Not to mention Queen Angella's life? You did that all on your own accord! And let's not forget, oh, blaming me for things out of control or cutting me up so bad I still have the proof of it on my face and back! Or leaving me for dead or infecting me with that First One's tech!"

Adora begins to draw closer to the magicat. Her anger, frustration, and despair from before and that has been building the past couple days grows, almost filling her. This is the last thing she needs right now. Seeing Catra. Be reminded of everything that happened between them. A friendship where both promised to look out for each other, to stay by each other's side, only for it to be shattered and turned into some bitter, toxic, and torn. Something that left the blonde broken and questioning herself before she finally punched the magicat as everything crumbled around her.

Adora stops a couple feet away from Catra. She keeps herself standing as tall as she can, refusing to show an ounce of vulnerability. There will be nothing for the magicat to latch onto and use against her. She herself does not shrink and stands defensively as the two continue to glare at each other.

"You really hurt me, Catra," Adora carries on. "You made me feel worthless and not worthy of anything or anyone. The only reason I went to rescue you from Prime was because I knew he was wicked and evil and no one should suffer from him. I think I have a feeling on what he would have done to you if I didn't come."

"Well, ya know, I told you *not* to come but you're an idiot and didn't listen to me."

A low growl escapes Melog. Catra groans, takes a breath, and mumbles a 'sorry' but her words cannot be taken back.

"Jeez, thanks. Maybe I shouldn't've come then...But I did...I don't blame you for what happened to me, it was my choice. Now I have to live with the fact it led to me aiding in destroying Etheria, attacking and harming those I'm sworn to protect, hurting my

friends and you, kidnapping Perfuma, and almost taking Glimmer's life! Gods know what else I did that I have yet to remember!

"...I have to live with that now…" Adora's voice grows quiet, a whisper. She allows the sentence to hang in the air. Despite knowing full well everything she did after her choice to save Catra was against her will, she struggles to take in what she said. Adora swallows a hard lump before continuing. "What about you? You hurt so many innocent people. I told you to live with your choices. Have you?"

Catra doesn't answer right away. Adora watches her eyes and one of her ears move in thought. She takes a deep breath before saying, "I know. And I am. Trust me, I got told off plenty before I got captured by Prime by someone. And…" she hesitates. Her sharp fingers curl and uncurl as she struggles to continue talking. "I'm...sorry."

"Little late there. Now you are sorry?"

"Yes, Adora. I am. Believe it or not, I actually am sorry for something." Anger begins to rise in her voice. She does not get far before she lets out a small yelp. She holds her hand and looks down at Melog, who glares back at her, growling. Catra takes another breath. "I'm sorry, Adora. I was angry. Felt alone and felt like everyone was out to get me. Becoming Force Captain made me feel powerful and like I could do anything and I choose to get back at you for simply getting out of the shithole that is the Horde. Which, that...I shouldn't have done that.

"You don't owe me anything. I wouldn't owe me jack if I was in your shoes but...I am sorry and want to make it up someway."

"Well, you are right about that. Me not owing you. Part of me really wants to sock you again." Adora sighs and takes a moment to think. She still does not trust Catra in the slightest and wonders if the magicat is just pulling her leg. Part of her wants to believe she is being genuine, part of her tells her not to fall for any more tricks. Only time will tell which is actually true. "But I really don't

know what to do with you right now, though I am still furious with you. We got other stuff to deal with and if you are going to help, then fine. Good, we need it. But there is no guarantee I am going to forgive you or talk to you ever again when this is all over."

“I don't expect much, not gonna be shocked if you don't."

“I can’t deal with this anymore. I appreciate the apology, if it's true, but I need time and really want to figure everything else out.” Adora begins to leave the tent, not knowing what else to say. She is about to leave and not see Catra again except in passing when the magicat’s voice stops her.

“One more thing, Adora...Don’t...Don’t let history repeat. You and Glimmer are made for each other. Don’t let things get between you two.”

Says the one who sent Double Trouble in, Adora thinks to herself. She refuses to look at Catra. “Why do you care?”

“Honestly, I don’t know.”

Adora says nothing more as she exits the tent.

Glimmer thinks about her talk with Scorpia for most of the day. Similar to Catra’s but less aggressive in tone. Maybe she really should just rip off the bandaid that has been slapped over their wound of a relationship and let it properly heal. It will be painful but if it can stop the crumbling, it is for the best. Now if only she can work up the energy to do so.

One moment, she feels like she can do it and spill out her heart to Adora, the next, she is gripped by fear and wishes to have wings to fly far away or and not deal with it. That last option is out of the question and not just because she lacks said appendages. No running from her problems, especially when the world and others need her. Glimmer is still the ruling queen of the largest kingdom

of Etheria. She has to do this. She has to do this. She *has to* do this.

"I can't do this…" Glimmer groans. She flops down on the hard ground, running her hands down her face. "Where do I even start with her? How do I even get her to talk to me?"

This all happened because you didn't talk. You're queen, suck it up, or you'll never have a relationship with Adora ever again.

Glimmer shuts her eyes, wishing her mind would shut up right about now, even if it is right. How did talking become the hardest thing to do between the pair? They used to do it all the time and with just about anything. Early in the morning, preparing for the day. In the afternoon, while taking a break and reassessing things. Or at night, when in the still and cloak of night, they'd spill their hearts out if something was hurting it. Now that is all lost in a mess of unresolved pain, anger, betrayal. The queen wonders if this is what happened between Adora and Catra. Unable to talk, only lashing out. Prime said it himself all those weeks ago that the blonde feared the same thing happening. Has that come to fruition?

"You okay there?"

Glimmer's heart skips a beat at the soft voice. Opening her eyes, she finds Adora looking down at her, confused. Her hood has been thrown back over her head, hiding most of her hair and parts of her face. However, the queen can still see faint lines running down her cheeks and a hint of red in her eyes. Has she been crying? Wasn't she supposed to be training with Starla? What the hell happened?

"Yeah. Just...ya know...chillin'," Glimmer lies. She pushes herself up into a sitting position, placing her hands on crossed legs. "What...What are you up to? How was it sparring with Starla?"

"Alright. Not, uh, not much too note. It was fun."

"Did you want to sit down? Or did you need something?"

"I'm good standing but yes to needing something. Not me but Entrapta said she had something to show you. Something about how the robots work or something. Don't really know since I was trying to recover from her popping out of nowhere and scaring me half to death. She told me to fetch you."

"Well, hopefully it's good news and not something horrible. We could really use some of the former right now."

"Yeah...anyway she is on the other side of the camp. I was going to see what the others were up to so I guess I will catch you later."

Shit, Glimmer. Do it now! Do it while she is actually talking to you. "Hey! Why don't you come with? You haven't seen much of Entrapta since she is always busy so why not?" *Idiot! Talk. To. Her!*

"I think...I think I am alright, Glimmer. I gotta go."

Adora begins to turn, lifting her leg to start her stride.

Do it! Before it's too late!

"Adora, wait!" Glimmer's hands reach out before she can stop them. Fingers lace around the blonde's wrist. Adora freezes in place, her back turned to the queen. "Please, wait. Don't go. Not yet. Entrapta can wait. I...I...I'm sorry."

Her vision blurs and she can feel her body beginning to shake. The only steady part of her are her hands, still locked around Adora's wrist. Glimmer takes a deep breathing, hoping to avoid a crack in her voice as she speaks. It fails.

"I'm sorry. Sorry for blaming you for my mother's death. I'm sorry for telling you the rebellion was in a worse spot because of you. I'm sorry for listening to Shadow Weaver more than you. You did not deserve any of that. You were trying your hardest, doing everything in your power to help, and the universe just wanted to keep fucking with you and beat you down. I should have never

used you as bait. That was a horrible thing to do. You are my friend and I used you as if you were a pawn in one of your chess games.

"I was under so much stress and grief. I didn't know what to do and I felt so alone. I just became queen without warning and the Horde was all over and yet I kept getting stuck in the castle while you and Bow were off on missions. Or I felt like I was being talked over by everyone. That my word as ruler wasn't being listened to. But I never should have lashed at Bow or you. I should never have snapped at you both and I should have listened to you about the Heart. That was not right, going after it when you told me what could happen. I was angry and hurt but that isn't an excuse."

Glimmer remembers back to what happened the first time they fought on Horde Prime's ship. The hate and anger that came out of her, unlocked by Prime. Anger over being cast aside, being ordered around, trying to make the queen happy only for it to be thrown back at her, and everything said between them. Adora was hurting, she still is hurting just like Glimmer is now. How much else is she hiding inside of her?

"I know we said on the Darla when you saved me we would talk but then...all *this* happened. I don't know if things can be fixed now after everything and I don't know if you can forgive me. I am sorry, Adora. I never should have done that and you never should have gone through what you went through."

Glimmer finds it impossible to continue talking. She struggles to hold back tears but many slip out and run down her face as sobs choke her. Her grasp on Adora begins to falter, enough to allow the blonde to leave and go about the rest of her day. However, as the queen finally lets go, the blonde takes a seat back on the ground, removing her hood from her head. Her gaze remains downward but her eyes are watery.

"I'm sorry also. You're not...the only one to blame here. I-I wanted to keep you safe. I didn't want you to get hurt or worry

after everything you went through. After your mother...died, sacrificed herself so I didn't have to, I wanted to protect you at all cost. Your mother wanted us to take care of each other, take care of everyone, and I guess I went a little overboard. I should have listened to you more. We were supposed to be a team and work together but I failed to take your word into account. You are the queen. An amazing, brilliant one at that.

"I didn't like what you did. Blaming me and using me as bait and everything else. I was stressed out as well because of the Horde and Catra and I guess I felt I wasn't being heard either. But I hurt you also and I am sorry for that. We are a team. Yet that was something we weren't the past few months…"

"I guess we both fucked up big time, huh?" Glimmer wipes some tears from her face.

"Yeah, we did…And...I think I can forgive you, I still just need a little bit. I know you didn't mean what you said and you did try to apologize before. Things just got way too hairy and insane at the end. Can...Can you forgive me?"

"Yes, Adora. The same goes for me. With forgiving and time."

Silence falls on them, neither knowing what else to say. Glimmer chews on her lip, trying to think of anything. So much still is left. "Is...Is there anything else you want to talk about?"

Adora wipes away her own tears. "I don't know about you, but I am beat with talking for today. Though, what about you? Is there anything else you want to talk about? I don't mind hearing it."

One of Glimmer's hands finds her stomach and clutches it. Part of her is happy Adora still does not quite look at her. "No. Later." Her free hand slides on the ground, stopping near the blonde's. "And Adora?"

"Hm?"

“Do you...Do you think anything will be the same between us? An apology is only a start and not a grantee but...do you think...we can fix everything that happened between us?”

Adora’s hand slides closer. Her fingers intertwine with Glimmer’s loosely. There is the slightest of squeezes before Adora answers her. “I hope we can. I’ve missed you.”

“I’ve missed you too.”

Chapter End Notes

> okay so i am gonna go on hiatus from this for a bit. I do have some of ch 10 done but I am burned the hell out rn. I have been working on this like non stop since June????? So I need like a break. Hopefully not more than a month? So i still have time to queue stuff up again but ye. I figured this ch was long enough and had enough to be like BREAK TIME!
>
> So i’ll eventually post on my tumblr when I will update again but for now enjoy this ch and some other stuff I can hopefully post while on hiatus (and kudos and comments are always appreciated)

12 Hours

Chapter Notes

> Look who is finally back! Sorry this took longer than I thought (and I DID NOT plan on post on EXACTLY 2 months after my last update, rip). It's 2020 and I live in America so Nov ALONE was a month. Anyway, that you for being patient and I probably am going to stick to a "update whenever the fuck I am done" instead of a set thing. I think that help burned me the hell out before. Either way, I will finish this. I hope you enjoy after so long and kudos and comments are always appreciated
>
> TW for this chapter is panic attacks and some negative thoughts and some blood + injury.

Another morning, another restless night. Adora groans, keeping her eyes shut momentarily as she rolls onto her side from her stomach. Normally, she would never lay as such. On her stomach, she feels defenseless. Even if her major organs might be more protected like that, it prevents her from getting to her feet right away. Any moment, no matter how small, where she is unable to defend herself during an attack can spell disaster. But the marks on her back suddenly began to ache during the night. Felt like fire, just like they did when Catra first tore into her skin. She wanted *some* sort of sleep and ease from her agony but in actuality, sleeping differently did little. If anything, all it did was cause the pain to migrate to her neck. Great...

Parts of her dream linger in her hazy mind. More puzzle pieces to add to mystery that is her chipped self. Attacking, injuring, and tying up two young teenage brothers. Watching large strains of her dark, blonde locks falling past her gaze as a clone stands in front of her and another behind. That image quickly becomes that of the clones helping her get dressed in the same robes they wear. Horde Prime continues to give her praise for what she has done and giving her one order after the next with no end in sight.

The feeling of enjoying his words and taking her anger out sends a shiver down her spine. Somewhere in the mix of him informing her of plans once they are through with Etheria, magic slips in. Adora struggles to grasp why he speaks about it. Why does he want the runestones?

Before she can wrap her fingers around it and pull it closer to see clearer, however, something else pops into her mind, blocking the attempt.

More Perfuma. More taunts. More watching her trying not to crack as images of her home burning and her people being attacked appear on a screen. More waiting to force the princess to spill any information. Though, there is a sinking feeling at the pit of Adora's stomach that she didn't really need to get anything out of her. She just wanted to watch her squirm. What was the last thing Perfuma said to her? Something about Glimmer? Speaking of the queen, why was the last image she saw before fully waking up that of her asleep, nestled in Adora's arms as if nothing bad ever happened?

Another thing that slips through her fingers. Maybe it is for the best right now. No need to start off her day on a *complete* sour note. There is still much work to do and she refuses to let these things become a bother to her or anyone else. Adora takes a deep breath, keeping it inside of her for several long moments before exhaling. However, before crawling out of bed, she reaches up and rubs the back of her neck. The bandage continues to cover the place where the chip used to be deeply embedded. How many days has it been now since it was removed? Three or four? Everything is so mixed in her head she can no longer tell.

"Time to get up, Adora," she mumbles to herself.

Adora summons the strength to get out of bed and ready herself for the long day ahead. She slips into her new clothing, her newly issued communication pad which she shoves in a pocket, and her new retractable staff. Similar to the one that was broken in her fight with Glimmer, the only difference is it being slightly shorter and not having any Brightmoon symbols or colors on it. Before

facing and seeing what the world has to offer, the blonde takes a moment to look herself in the mirror. There's a moment's hesitation, a mix of not wanting to see the person staring back at her and something else she cannot put her finger on. However, she keeps her gaze at the unknown woman in the glass.

Adora can no longer remember what she looked like nearly three weeks ago. Hell, what she looked like over a year ago is nothing more than a blur. The short hair, the darker clothing, the lack of light in her eyes, the scars on her face, and the weight that pulls down her shoulders. This is her, yet it is not. Something to get used to even though she rather not. Taking a breath, Adora fixes her hair into something not a mess and finally exits her place of rest.

Dawn has already passed. Adora only knows this from the amount of activity in the campsite. The sky above her is a grey color, matching the mood of many, and blocking the bright sun. It feels weird to be joining everyone this 'late' but better than nothing. She slowly makes her way towards the meet up place, the center of this camp. This most likely will be the last time collecting here as another move is needed to keep Horde Prime off everyone's tail. Though, places to escape and flee to are becoming far and few between. Everyone is looking for a miracle to push him back, even if it is just by a fraction.

You better help them and make up for all the havoc you've caused.

Adora continues to walk, doing her best to evade the voice in her head. She is well aware of the thought. Nothing will stop her from seeing Horde Prime's reign of terror coming to an end, no matter what it cost herself. It's just a matter of figuring out how to do so. The blonde begins to debate if she should attempt to dig through the mess of memories in her mind. Have them appear faster and become clearer and pull something out that could help the Rebellion. Know the atrocities she caused and try to make amends somehow. At the rate everything is going, she might have to do just that.

Adora enters the tent and finds several people inside already. Glimmer, Micah, Bow, and Entrapta, all of whom stop their chatter to turn their gazes towards the new being in the room. Adora manages to force a small smile and wave before joining the small group. “Hey. Sorry I’m late.”

“Everything okay, Adora?” Glimmer asks as she draws near.

“Yeah, why?” Adora asks.

“Because you are never late and no one saw you for breakfast,” Entrapta pipes up. She suddenly becomes quite close to the blonde. “Normally you are the first to arrive, not the last. So it is quite surprising. Usually a change like that means something might be wrong.”

“I’m fine,” Adora brushes her off and gently pushes her back. “Just the weather, probably.”

“Hm...Well it is good you are finally here. We are going to need your smarts. Oh! And I have extra tiny food if you want any! Save them just for you!”

“Oh! Ah, thank you. Maybe later, though. Not really that hungry.” Adora shifts her gazes towards the table in the center of the room. After some decision, she takes a seat towards the end. The others begin to select their spots. Bow takes the seat at the end of Adora’s side of the table while Glimmer stands behind the chair next to her. Despite their talk, the blonde feels a twisting of her heart with the queen so near. She longs for those days of old, when being besides her did not cause pain. However, looking down at her covered hands that once were stained in Glimmer’s blood, how can she ever do so?

Micah and Entrapta take their own seats across from the trio. The older sorcerer begins to talk first, guiding the others in some plans. First and foremost, finding a new place. With more robots lurking around and others who have joined Prime’s side willing or unwilling, this area has become dangerous with lurkers. The plan

is to move at nightfall and slowly make their ways to Brightmoon. Being one of the last strongholds, and one of the only actual places left, returning there is a must. Once that is said and agreed upon, no one else having an inkling of where to go next, plans of attack crop up.

They can't stay on the defensive forever. The sooner they go on the offensive the better. How is the ever lingering question. Down a princess and only having two Kingdoms left, their numbers are not in the best shape. A suggestion of catching him off guard enters the conversation.

"We would have to come up with something really smart," Adora cuts in. A memory covered in a haze of static begins to form. Shapes cannot be formed but the colors of purples and blue as well as brown and red are clear. She doesn't need to recall much else to know where this one is from. "He is not going to be easily tricked and...he has eyes in a lot of places. I'm surprised you--we've been able to stay hidden for so long."

"So it still could work?" Bow asks.

"It could, yeah, but it will be difficult." Adora tries to think of anything that could work as a headache begins to form. "Distractions could be of use. Fake-outs…Something to keep his attention away if only for a moment."

"That is definitely something to keep in consideration," Micah speaks up. "Anyone have anything to add to that?"

Everyone shakes their head, unable to contribute more to Adora's suggestion. Gazes turn back to the blonde, the only one if some semblance of an idea, hoping for more.

"I don't have anything other than that," Adora sighs, rubbing a temple with a free hand and squeezing her eyes shut. Stupid headache. She doesn't need this. There already is a cold, dark feeling gripping at her chest and slowly spilling out into the rest of her body as she thinks of their enemy. "Prime...is something else

and shouldn't be taken lightly. He's smart, calculative. He'll stop at nothing to get what he wants…"

Adora wonders if he is out looking for her. Wanting her back to use her again in the destruction of Etheria. Or now that she has been freed from his grasp, does he want to end her life outright and make a point about resisting? That is something right up his alley. There is no doubt in her mind he has something else planned for her and the blonde is far from looking forward to it. Just seeing his image in her mind sends her heart into erratic beats.

"Adora…"

Her eyes snap open. Glimmer and Bow stare back at her. Anxiety is written all over their faces. It takes a moment to realize the queen is rubbing her thumb against her own hand. Looking down, Adora finds her free hand has clenched into a tight fist. If it was not for the layer of fabric covering her palm, her nails most certainly would have broken skin. Slowly, Adora unfurls her fingers, letting them breathe.

"Anyway," Adora clears her throat, "what about you, Glimmer?"

"Hm?" Glimmer tilts her head to the side slightly.

"You have any ideas on what to do? I'd love to hear them. You're smart."

"Ah! Well. Yeah, I have some," a small smile breaks across her face and Adora swears she sees Glimmer's face tint red.

Flexing her fingers, letting the blood flow once more, Adora rests her head on her other hand. She listens to Glimmer lay out a plan, using her queen voice to keep everyone's attention on her. It does work for the most part with the blonde but she finds herself getting lost watching Glimmer speak. She has only ruled over Brighmoon for a short amount of time and yet she has grown into the role. That sparkling, needing to recharge, bold princess she

met all those months ago has become a radiant, powerful, determined queen.

Her chest grows warm, like a fireplace. The comfort it brings pushes the darkness and cold. Keeps creatures of the night at bay. She wishes to stay like this forever and not worry what will happen the second she leaves the security of the fire. For now, however, she soaks in the sight of Glimmer readily giving plans on what their next move should be. Adora can't help but smile.

"How are you holding up?" Glimmer whispers. Adora slowly makes her way towards the queen, bending down behind the same fallen tree as her.

"Fine," Adora lies. She does her best to keep her breathing steady, despite her lungs begging for more air. For all her years training as a soldier, she shouldn't be this tired already on a simple *scouting* mission. It is like the sparring session with Starla all over again. There was one moment she had to hide from Glimmer, a flash of blackness as she stood after a break. Now, besides attempting to get her breathing under control, her feet ache from use. That is another question the blonder wonders about, how after only walking for a short time it feels like she has been at it for weeks.

"Haven't noticed anything yet?" Adora quickly asks, refusing to let a thought enter her mind.

Glimmer peers over the tree. "No." The queen straightens out and takes one last look before hopping over the large planet. Adora quickly follows suit. When her feet land on the ground, Glimmer says, "Adora, are you sure you are up to this?"

"Yeah. I am."

"Adora, I don't want to push and tell you what to do but you shouldn't push yourself. Trust me, after...uh...everything...I think Bow wanted to tie me to a bed so I wouldn't keep hurting myself."

Adora refuses to look at the queen, despite being right. “Let’s just get this mission over with. Once we know the path is clear, then I can take a break. Alright?”

She hears Glimmer take a long inhale before releasing it. “Alright. Then let’s get this over with as soon as we can. You deserve it.”

“Yeah...sure…”

Adora and Glimmer continue their trek, hoping this path is good enough to take. Somewhere, close by, there is Scorpia. The scorpion princess had broken off in the other direction to give a wider range of searching. Though, if anything were to arise, she or the pair can come to the other’s aid quickly. The only reason Adora and Glimmer have remained together is the queen put her foot down and buried her heels in the dirt about splitting up. It was either the blonde went with Scorpia or stayed with her. Not wanting a fight, and part of her appreciating the looking after, Adora conceded.

As they walk, a noise catches their attention. Adora and Glimmer quickly hide, just in the nick of time. Out of the brush, one of Horde Prime’s robots appears. After several moments, it seems to be alone and is doing what the pair is. Searching. Wordlessly, the blonde and the queen gear up for an attack. This should be easy-peasy. Glimmer carefully circles around, thankfully not spotted. When the robot turns its gaze away, Adora is the first to attack.

Drawing her staff, she aims to destroy. As she draws closer and closer to the robot, Adora feels her blood begin to boil inside of her. The sight of the white and green machine, marked with Prime’s symbol, makes her grit her teeth and lose focus on where to properly strike. All she wants to do is slam her staff into it and turn it into nothingness. Blinded by her thirst to destroy, it takes the blonde a moment too late to realize the robot has it’s eye on her. Upon realizing this, and inches away, Adora strikes.

The robot staggers back from the force, going out of the blonde’s range for another attack. Neither of them have enough time to

recover before a bright ball of pink and blue sails through the air and connects with the head of the robot. It blows up on impact. With the main source of power ceasing to flow through it, the machine falls to its knees first before its side, never to rise up again.

"Hopefully that is the only one," Glimmer states as she appears. "Did it see you? ...Adora?"

Adora doesn't register the voice of the queen right away. Her eyes remain locked on the fallen robot, wondering how many she commanded before and if this was one of them. She clutches her staff tightly, itching to use it again. When her name is repeated, it snaps her out of a dark train of thoughts. "What?"

"Do you think it saw you? I know it turned towards you but did you hit it before it could get a clear look at you?"

Adora shrugs, "No idea. Hopefully not. Don't need anymore of its siblings on us." The blonde gives a kick to the robot before beginning to walk off. "We still have a lot to cover, we should go."

However, she does not get far.

Hello. It's a pleasure to see you again.

The voice turns Adora's whole body to ice. An unseen force suddenly wraps around her neck and tightens, constricting her airway into nothingness. A shaking of her body starts at her hands, causing her to drop her staff before it takes over her whole being. The voice is the one she has struggled to keep out of her thoughts and nightmares. Now, here it is, clear and crisp inside her head once more.

How is everything going? Prime continues.

The next thing Adora knows, she is on her knees, her hands clutched tightly against her ears. It does little to aid in the panic and fear drowning her in dark and cold water.

How is my little sister doing? Are you able to be She-ra or are you powerless once again without me?

"Shut up! Shut up! Shut up!" Adora repeats over and over again. Eyes squeezed shut, she feels tears streaming down her cheeks and collecting on her chin. *Why is he back? Why is he in my head again? Why won't he go away?!?*

" *Adora!"* Glimmer's voice enters the fray, sounding alarmed. Strong hands grip her arms, stopping a rocking the blonde didn't know she was doing. "Adora! Talk to me!"

"He's...He's in...my head again…" Adora's voice is brittle, completely broken. "Make it...Make it *stop!"*

There is no point in resisting. Surrender and I might consider going easy.

"Adora, it's a hologram. Please open your eyes, he's not in your head!" Glimmer pleads.

The blonde does as she is told. The first thing her eyes focus on are the soft lilac iris of the queen. Tears are running down her own cheeks. Glimmer is definitely holding more of it back. Mixed in the frightened and worried look twisted on her face, there is reassurance. The queen takes a breath before speaking again, doing her best to keep a steady voice. "Look."

Adora shifts her gaze upwards. Sure enough, high up in the sky and looming over everyone, is a grainy image of Horde Prime. He is not looking directly at her or anything in particular. The sight of him still makes the blonde's stomach twist inside of her, making her want to throw up. What little comfort there is from the realization this is not in her head is thrown out the window as he speaks once more.

"The more you fight the worse things will be for you. If you want to protect those you love and cherish, I would suggest laying down your arms."

Dark and bloody images begin flooding her mind. Some she has seen, some she hasn't. Many just mix together as the voice remains clear. "I'm sorry, I'm sorry."

"It's not your fault, Adora. Just breathe."

Then why do I still have these images in my head?!? Adora thinks to herself. However, only a whine escapes her as she squeezes her eyes shut.

"I know, Adora. I know," Glimmer softly says. Her voice has begun to waver. Adora feels hands moving up from her arms and being placed on her own that cover her ears. The world finally becomes muffled, helping bring some sense to herself. Then, the blonde feels the coldness of metal on her forehead mixed with the warmth of a body. The feeling helps keep her to the ground. When the queen speaks again, it is the only thing clear. "I'm here. It's okay. I won't let him hurt you. I'm right here."

If Adora wanted to say anything else, her words fail her. Sobs are the only thing to come out. Despite his voice now blocked by Glimmer and her own cries, the dark, muffled sound of him speaking still sends shivers down her spine. The queen does not budge an inch, keeping their foreheads and hands together. The only movement there is, is the stroking of her thumb against the side of Adora's head.

"He's gone," Glimmer breaks the silence after what can easily be hours. "You can open your eyes now."

Adora waits a moment before doing so. She takes deep breaths, trying to gain some sense of control over her trembling body. The voice of Prime lingers in her mind, threatening to implant itself and become almost impossible to remove. As it begins to take root, Glimmer repeats 'I'm here' in a soft tone. It forces Horde Prime's voice from her mind, keeping it from latching into her mind. Her heart still beating hard and her breathing choppy, Adora opens her eyes.

“Hey,” Glimmer says. She removes her hands from the sides of Adora’s face. Tears continue to slowly run down her cheeks, though a small smile breaks it apart. Her eyes are gentle and warm. “You okay?”

Adora slowly pulls her own hands down to her lap. She scans the sky and finds only the pale, grey sky staring back at her. No hologram. No Prime. It is just her and Glimmer. The blonde wipes away the river of tears on her face before answering the queen. “I think so? I don’t know…What about you?”

“I’ll be fine,” Glimmer tells her, drying her own face. “I...I dealt with that before so I was a little more ready than you. Think you can stand?”

Adora moves her legs slightly. They feel like jello but might be able to hold some of her weight. Carefully, the blonde begins to push herself upward. Halfway there, she wobbles, nearly collapsing on herself. However, Glimmer is quick to catch her and steady her out. Secured in an upright position, Adora lets go of the queen. “Thank you.”

“Not a problem.”

Adora takes another look at the sky, right at the empty space where the hologram stood. Her hands shake at the now memory of him looking out at all of Etheria. He wants everyone to surrender. The blonde doubts even if they did that, he would not keep his promise of going easy. If anything, all he will do is make everyone’s death a *little* less painful. The only way everyone will make it out alive is by refusing to give up, though that remains a slim chance.

“Hey...Glimmer?” Adora suddenly says. A knife begins to make its way into her heart, waiting to twist and tear it apart.

“Yeah?”

She hesitates for a moment, chewing on her lip. The question waits to be released and be given the dark answer. Already, it

leaves a bitter and foul taste in her mouth. Either way, Adora lets it come out. "If I heard right...he said something about She-ra...about being powerless without him…" After a moment of silence, Adora continues. "Don't lie to me. I need to know. I can't be left in the dark, not with so much at stake…Did...Did he...Did *I* …" she is unable to finish the sentence.

"Yes...I don't know how he did it. But…" Glimmer's gaze turns downward. A hand rubs up and down an arm. "He used She-ra against us...against you…"

It takes every ounce of strength not to lash out at the nearest thing. The anger from before at seeing the robot fills her. The invisible knife fully makes its way into her heart and twists *hard.* So not only did she attack her friend, assault those she swore to protect, and displaced and maimed so many, it was done as *She-ra.* Her mind, for once, refuses to recall being in that form but does she need to remember it? Not when she already has so much destruction in her mind and blood on her hands. How in the world can *Horde Prime* access the warrior when she could not? Does she even want to turn into her again knowing what she knows now?

Adora swallows her rage. She wants to hide herself away, throw up her hood and disappear. But there still is a mission. Still needs to do *something* for everything she has done. She needs to stay focused and not have anything block her sight or mind. The blonde reaches down and picks up her fallen staff, tucking it at her side. "Alright. Let's go finish this. Maybe see what Scorpia is up too."

She leaves before Glimmer can say anything else.

Glimmer stays a few feet behind Adora, both out of watching her back for protection and keeping an eye on her without being suspicious. Whenever the queen is not paying close attention for lurking robots or anything else, her focus is on the blonde. The way her footsteps are heavier, how her shoulders hunch, causing

her posture to shrink, or how whenever she catches a glimpse of her sky blue eyes, there are no lights. If there are any, they have dimmed. Sometimes, for a moment, it is hard to believe this is still the same, bright-eyed, blonde haired warrior she has gotten to know for the past year and half.

Though, she has changed herself, hasn't she. This whole damn war has forced everyone to grow up far faster than anyone should. It has taken away her childhood, from thinking she lost her father, to being thrown into a role without warning with the death of her mother. Not to mention, so many others who have died and the land lost and the ever consistent fear her home will fall. What has this war taken from Adora? No idea who her birth family is. Much of her body to be torn open and patched back together in a ragged way...To be forced to do nightmarish things to her home against her will.

Glimmer turns her head upward, looking at the dark grey sky. No Prime. Even then, she can feel her hands shaking. His voice lingers in her mind. The darkness that can make one's blood go cold. His looming size, becoming ten times bigger in the hologram. Or his taunts. The ones directed at Adora.

What is going through your mind? Glimmer thinks as she looks back at Adora. What was going on as her body was sent into an attack. What horrors did Horde Prime do to her that caused her such fright. Ever part of the queen's own body wanted to shut down, curl up, and hide away in the closet hole. She is tempted to do as such. But Adora needs her. She won't leave her behind again, even if she is unsure what to do right now or how much to try and pry her open.

Glimmer debates on her next move. She is not stupid. She knows what just happened will be eating away at Adora to the very core. An infected She-ra caused so many sleepless nights for her and the worst thing that happened there was Glimmer being flung around like a rag-doll. What will knowing being her caused so much harm and description cause? All the queen wants to do is take whatever pain is out of the blonde, let her spill it all out, and

release the weight that must be tied around her heart. Yet, she does not know the line Adora has drawn right now. How much she wants someone in or how much would be too much with pushing and causing her to clam up. After the death of her mother, there were many a night all Glimmer wanted was someone to sit by her and nothing else. Is that what Adora wants right now?

"I think we should start heading back," Glimmer says after some more moments of silence. "If we are somehow being tailed, we don't want anyone to see the whole path and we shouldn't be out at night alone."

"We should probably find Scorpia first then. She shouldn't be too far, right?"

"Probably not. Hopefully she is okay." The two begin to walk in the direction their friend should be in.

"Scorpia should be able to handle herself. And haven't heard anything from her so that is a good sign. Gods know we don't need to lose anyone else…We need good news."

"Well, besides that one robot, we haven't seen anything else. Which means we should be able to remain hidden. Heard Swift Wind might already be there and we should meet up with Mermista and Sea Hawk soon. That counts for something."

The corners of Adora's mouth twitch. That *definitely* counts for something. Glimmer will take any small moment she can get of the old Adora.

It does not take long Adora and Glimmer to locate their friend. Scorpia appears out of the brush shortly after the queen whistles a tune everyone agreed on to use. The scorpion princess has a large smile on her face and waves one of her large claws as she draws near her two friends. However, when she is some yards away, Scorpia freezes in place, her eyes going wide. "Get down!"

A bright, red bolt of lightning streaks across the area, passing right between a stunned Adora and Glimmer. The two snap their

heads around in time to see a robot nearly be sent sky high as it blows up. One more appears in its place.

"Shit!" Glimmer shouts. She jumps one way as Adora bolts the other, her staff drawn once again.

Glimmer's own hands light up as she preps for any spell that might pop into her mind. The robot fires a large blast of energy at Scorpia, causing her to dive out of the way. Without missing a beat, it turns around to face Adora. There is little time for the blonde to process and response as another powerful blast is unleashed from the machine. The only thing Adora can do without being killed is shift out of the way. The blast that connects with the dirt nips at her heels, causing her landing to be more of a tumbled.

"Adora!" Glimmer yells. The spilt second moment her eyes are on the blonde, who slowly recovers from the attack, proves to be a horrible mistake. The robot, not bothering to take out the fallen blonde, has spun around and points it's arm at the queen. The end already has become a blinding light. Glimmer has just enough sense to create a magical shield. Though, it is not as strong or large as it should be. With little time to save herself, the second the blast hits it, the pink shield shatters. It forces her back, causing a stumble. Before she can regain her footing, another blast is fired.

This time, it hits its mark. The blast of energy slices across her right shoulder, creating a gash. Glimmer bites down on her lower lip, holding back a sharp cry of pain as the ground comes up to meet her. She lands on her right side, causing further injury.

Damn it, damn it, damn it! Get up! Glimmer screams at herself. She scrambles to return to her feet but her right arm fails her. Every subtle movement of her shoulder sends an electrified pain throughout her muscles. The queen powers through to the best of her ability, knowing she cannot remain as a sitting duck. Just as she begins to find herself, the whirling sound of another blast of

energy enters her ears. Just before it can finish its own horrible melody, something cuts it off.

" *DON'T YOU **FUCKIN'** TOUCH HER AGAIN!"* Adora's harsh cries fill the air. Glimmer snaps her head up, her eyes landing on the scene playing out in front of her. Adora's staff piercing its way through the robot's head. Her blue eyes burn as she takes down the machine. Far from satisfied with the defeated enemy, the blonde begins to beat her weapon against the metal. "Don't! Touch! *Her!* " Adora repeats through gritted teeth and small growls.

"Holy shit," is all Glimmer can utter as Adora unleashes her rage against the robot, slowly turning it into nothing but parts. Where did all this anger and fury come from? Was she holding this all back? A memory flashes across the queen's mind. Back at Dryl, when the First One's tech first infected her. The blonde's wrath only ceased to be after the sword was ripped from her hands. After she was snapped out of the dark trance.

"Adora!" Glimmer begins. She struggles to get to her feet, her right hanging almost uselessly at her side. "Adora! I'm okay! Calm down!"

She does not listen. Adora continues to attack the robot, showing little signs of stopping. Glimmer can see pricks of tears at the corners of her eyes. The blonde is finally cut off when Scopia reaches her. Large and strong claws wrap around Adora's body, pinning her arms against her side, and holding her tight against the princess' chest. She is lifted off the ground and away from the robot.

"Woah! Easy, Hotshot!" Scorpia says. Her voice is soft and soothing as she slowly rocks Adora. "I think you got it good enough. You protected Glimmer. Take a breath."

Adora's breathing comes out harsh and ragged. Her eyes stay focused on what now is essentially scrap metal for several moments before shifting towards the queen. The second blue

meets purple, they become softer and the fire raging inside dies down. Adora blinks several times before speaking. “Glimmer?”

“You got it, Adora,” Glimmer reassures her, finally on her feet. She mumbles a spell to herself. Her left hands become a pale blue as she covers her injured shoulder. It won’t be much with her level of healing but with any luck, maybe some of the pain can go away. “I am going to be just fine. I promise. Thanks to you.”

“Thank the gods,” Adora sighs. She leans her head against Scorpia’s chest. “Thank the gods…”

“Do you want me to let you go?” Scorpia asks.

“Just give me a moment.”

Scorpia listens, keeping her tight grasp around Adora. Glimmer slowly makes her way to the pair. Adora takes long, deep breaths before finally requesting Scorpia to let her go. The princess listens and places the blonde’s feet back on the ground.

“Thank you, Scorpia,” Adora says. She sets her sight at the queen. “How’s the shoulder?”

“It’ll heal. We can patch it up more when we get back to camp. Hopefully there are no more robots. I have had enough of them today.”

By the time the trio returns to the campsite, others from their own respective scouting missions have returned. Glimmer continues to hold her shoulder, though she has stopped trying to heal it some time ago. No need to waste all her magic on that. Her feet almost drag as she makes her way through the area with the others. If there were not other things going on, she probably would and could pass out right here and right now and not care.

The first people to greet them are Catra and Bow. Melong trails behind them. Catra is the first to speak, quite bluntly. “You really know how to get the shit beaten out of you, don’t ya, Sparkles?”

Glimmer shoots her a look. “Seriously?”

Catra shrugs. “So, was the mission a failure ‘cause of that or?”

“From what we saw in our area, we should be okay to move,” Adora pipes up, keeping her gaze momentarily on the magicat before turning it towards Bow. “What about you guys? Think we will be good to leave tonight?”

Bow gives a small nod. “As long as we don’t draw too much attention we should be good. Some already have left and we will meet up with them there. That’ll be the last one before we go to Brightmoon.”

“And be backed into a corner,” Catra mumbles.

“Which means we can only fight back then,” Bow retorts.

“She does have a point,” Adora replies deadpan, her eyes elsewhere. “Prime definitely wants us to have no escape.”

“We can’t give up hope. We will get through this. But, how are you doing, Glimmer? You are pretty banged up.”

“Nothing some time and magic won’t fix,” Glimmer replies.

“What about you two?”

“I am fine. Got to use some of my powers more!” Scorpa gleefully says. “I am really starting to enjoy that!”

Adora fails to answer. Looking back at her, Glimmer sees the blonde has her staff in her hands, fully retracted. She rolls it around in her hands as her eyes remain locked on them. Her eyebrows have knitted in a deep thought.

“Adora?” Bow repeats.

Scorpia gives the blonde a small nudge. This snaps her out of whatever trance she was in. “What?”

“I was asking you how you were. Anything else happened while you guys were out?”

Adora tosses the staff around in her hands for a moment. “Not really. Got rid of some robots. Didn’t see anymore so everything should be fine now.”

Bow turns his sight, confusion and worry on his face, towards the queen. Glimmer mouths the word *‘later’* to him. “I am going to see if I can do anything about this,” she says out loud. *So I am not even more useless without my princess powers.*

A thought then crosses her mind. “Adora, you want to help me?”

“Huh?”

“It’s not in a great spot for me to do it by myself so I will need help...Would you like to help out. You know a little bit from the Horde, right?”

“Uh, yeah, s-sure…” Adora nervously replies. “Where should we go?”

“Isn’t there some tent nearby with some stuff in it?” Catra says, pointing towards a nearby area behind her.

“Yeah, she’s right. Follow me,” Glimmer tells Adora. It takes a moment for the blonde to begin walking. She keeps a small distance behind the queen but nothing entirely too far. Once inside, they get to work.

Glimmer finds the softest place in the tent, a patch of newly grown grass, and settles down on it. Maybe a chair would be better when assessing the damage done to her body but they are hard and cold and not many are around. The grass provides a much better comfort. Once the queen has gotten comfortable, she slowly pulls down the right side of her shirt, revealing the full extent of her injury. Already, the wound has begun to itch and it takes every ounce of Glimmer’s being not to bother it. That is a good sign, however. Her natural healing ability is making a

comeback and with any luck, she will gain control of her shoulder and arm again tomorrow or the next day.

Adora knows this all. Not to mention, Glimmer's and her family's own ability to use magic to heal. However, it is not a bright idea for the body to get used to just magic to fix itself. One must allow themself to do some work. And it will make the blonde feel better anyway. Hell, it will make *Glimmer* feel better. A lost 'tradition' between the two. Patching each other up after a battle or spar. The queen hears Adora taking a seat behind her, followed by the *click* of the medical kit opening.

"So, how does it look?" Glimmer asks.

"Do you want me to lie or tell you the truth?" Adora replies.

"Can you do both? Don't completely bullshit me but...bullshit me."

Adora snorts. "Well, it's not the worst thing I have ever seen but you still got a good chunk out of you. Now hold still. This will sting."

Glimmer hears the shaking of a bottle before a cold mist hits her wound. The queen winces momentarily before sighing a breath of relief. There is more shuffling behind her as Adora digs around the kit, letting the medicine settle and take root. Her wound, once itch and hot, now has cooled and relaxed. Finally, a large, white bandage is placed on the gash, sticking nicely to the queen's skin.

"There. Good as new." Adora tells her. There is a moment's pause before Glimmer feels the fabric of Adora's glove and the warmth of her finger tips against her skin. Her thumb brushes across her shoulder blade, as gentle as summer's breeze. "I always forget you have these wing markings on your back."

"I forget half the time myself. Sometimes I wonder if they are just weird birthmarks or if they mean something."

"Who knows. Maybe you will grow in wings some day. I bet they would be as beautiful as y-"

Adora suddenly cuts off short.

"As what?" Glimmer turns her head enough to look at the blonde. She is surprised to find Adora's face becoming redder and redder by the second and her free hand slapped over her mouth. The queen raises an eyebrow. "Adora?"

"N-Nothing!" Adora stammers, pulling her hand away from her face. "Forget I said anything! Well, not if you got wings they would be beautiful. Just everything else...which wasn't much...I should shut up now."

Glimmer studies her face and repeats the words over in her head. Realization dawns on her. The queen's own face suddenly feels as warm as the new sun in the Etherian sky. She quickly turns away from Adora and looks ahead of her, unable to think of anything to say. After several long moments, she manages to clear her throat and reboot her brain. "Thanks, Adora. That's really sweet of you. And...That's for saving my ass even if you went a little overboard destroying the robot. You got a little heated there. You alright?"

"Of course, Glimmer. I wasn't about to let that thing get you even more...And I'm fine. I just…had a moment…"

Glimmer spins around, wanting to have a more sound look at the blonde. Adora has her hand in her hair, dark locks spilling out from between her fingers. Before Glimmer can say anything else, ask if there is anything she wants to talk about, she is cut off.

"It's just been…*a day*. And we still have to move."

"Tell me about it." Glimmer sighs. She leans back, her body heavy. How much has happened in only a few hours? And in only a few more, she will be back on her feet and trudging through where she just was, guiding everyone. Just blinking for too long threatens to send her into a different realm. "What I wouldn't give for a nap."

"You deserve it after everything. Why don't you take a rest?"

"What about you? You also need it."

Adora places a hand on her neck, turning her head towards the ground. "I am not sleepy. I'll be fine. *You* were the one who got hurt so you need it more than me anyway."

Wherever her stubbornness is, Glimmer cannot locate it for the life of her. Her body begs for this. "Only on one condition."

"Which is?"

"Sit with me." When Adora snaps her head up, her eyes wide, Glimmer continues. Her fingers nervously pull at the grass below. "I just rather have someone with me. Better not to sleep alone when you have no idea what is going on and...what your brain might want to do to you. Ya know?"

"Yeah. I get you. Let's go find a slightly better place for that." Adora rises to her feet first. Glimmer begins to get to her own but half way up, the blonde's arms find her uninjured one and aids her upward. She does not leave the queen's side the whole time as they search for a spot to rest for some time. In a smaller structure, one where they two most likely won't be disturbed, they claim as their own.

Adora finds some chairs that look bearable to rest in. A bed might be slightly better for the queen but almost all the positions would cause some sort of pain to her injury. At least up right, the back of the chair should just miss gazing against the injury. After the blonde places chairs against a wall, Glimmer takes a seat first. Adora quickly follows suit.

The second the blonde settles down besides her, Glimmer's heart shouts at her to rest her head on Adora's shoulder. Use it like a pillow. She misses the strong and broad shoulders of the blonde. Once, they were her own, portable cushion. Now, is she even allowed to keep doing as such? Out of the corner of her eyes, she

takes a glance at them, thinking how her head would fit perfectly in them. But, she refuses her heart's desire. Not now. Not yet.

"Did you want me to wake you up at a certain point or no?" Adora asks.

"Maybe in an hour or so? Don't want to sleep for too long. That or if someone *really* needs us," Glimmer replies.

"Alright. Rest up now."

Glimmer shuts her eyes, letting her body slip into nothingness.

A moan escapes Adora as she slowly stirs. The flowery scent of lavenders fills her nose, pushing out the images of Prime that lingers in mind. Heaviness of sleep rests in every part of her body, weighing it down. The blonde looks around, trying to recall what is going on. She is still in the same place as before, she hasn't moved. Yet, she is pretty sure time has passed. There once was some light streaming through any opening. Now, it has dimmed. When did she fall asleep? Whatever the nightmare of Prime was playing out in her mind, she cannot recall much or anything else. That's new. How did that happen? And even with her body feeling like it is being dragged down, the more she wakes, the better it feels.

A yawn escapes her. If she has fallen asleep then she has to figure out what time it is and if there is anything else left to do in the day. No time should be wasted during war. As her mind continues to come back, slowly taking its time to stretch out, she realizes a soft blanket is draped over her, covering most of her body. Who the hell did that? The next moment, Adora registers someone resting on her shoulder. Glimmer.

It takes everything in Adora not to jerk and disturb the sleeping girl from where she sits. Her eyes are shut and she looks peaceful as she mumbles something. Right. Both she and Glimmer came here so the queen could rest after being beaten up. Guess the

events of today allowed sleep to overtake the blonde herself, despite not wanting it.

Adora can't pry her eyes off Glimmer. Part of her still does not want to be this close to her, not after what she did, but another part feels at ease. Even in the dim light, Adora swears there is a soft glow around the queen, making her heart skip beats in her chest. A third and final part of the blonde wants to rest her head back on the queen's and go back to sleep.

When was the last time they napped together, let alone *slept* together. Adora, honest to the gods, cannot recall. She has forgotten how wonderful it felt to have someone else by her side. The warmth, the comfort, the peace, it is something the blonde has not realized she desperately craved. When Adora shifts to get a better position in her seat, still doing her best to not wake Glimmer, she realizes one last thing. Somehow, under the blanket and in their rest, their hands have locked together loosely. She should pull away, unlatch their fingers and let Glimmer go. However, she can't help but tighten the grip somewhat. This backfires, though, as for whatever reason it awakens the queen.

"Hmm?" Glimmer's eyes flutter open. She slowly lifts her head and a yawn escapes her. For a moment, she looks around before stopping her line of sight on the blonde. "Adora? What time is it?"

"I have no idea. Not night but later." Adora slowly slips her hand away, hoping in Glimmer's delirious state she doesn't know what happened. "I...may have fallen asleep myself…"

"Told you you needed it." Another yawn escapes her as she stretches out her good arm and legs. She then looks down, seeing the covering, before turning back at Adora. An eyebrow is raised on her face.

"I have no idea either. I am trying to figure that out. How'd you sleep anyway? Any bad dreams or anything?"

Glimmer takes a moment to answer. “Okay actually...Not the best but not the worst. I...had a few bad dreams but it’s alright. What about you?”

Adora tries thinking about her dreams. She knows they were about Prime. She knows they were about her time in his grasp. But for the life of her, and maybe for the better, she cannot pull out the fine details of what they were. If anything, the best thing she can remember is his sinister laugh and glowing eyes. Adora groans, shaking the thought from her head. “I had some but it was bearable.”

Glimmer chuckles a little.

“What?” Adora asks.

“Nothing...It just reminds--” the queen takes a moment, longing in her eyes, “reminds me of old times…”

Adora takes a breath, her mind filling up for once with something welcoming. That first time she had a nightmare about the Horde and Catra, about what she could have done during her time there, Glimmer somehow chased them away. Like a lighthouse, the queen can push out the dark clouds and haze that takes root in her brain with her own brilliant light.

“Yeah...just like old times…”

“I really needed that. Thank you for that.”

Adora feels her face slowly warm and a smile threatening to break across her face. She turns away from the queen and begins to scratch at the side of her face. “Anytime, Glimmer. Uh,” there is a quick clearing of her throat, “we should go see what everyone else is up to. We probably will be leaving soon so we better get ready. You think you will be fine with your shoulder?”

Glimmer stands to her feet. Adora watches her test out her injured body part, quickly wincing. “I think I’ll be okay if I take it easy. Are you good?”

Adora stands to her feet as well. “Ready as I’ll ever be. Let’s go.”

Guilt Filled Heart

Chapter Notes

> hey another chapter lol. more on the shorter side. this was going to be longer but I split them up cause it was getting too long. That being said, I am struggling a little so idk when the next will be done. And, I am really burned out by she-ra now. I will finish this I promise but I don't know about the other stuff. I will try but yeeeeeee.
>
> Anyway, hope ya enjoy this little update. Not much in the way of tw i think? maybe slight panic attack but idk. Either enjoy. Kudos and comments are appreciated
>
> edit: I forgot! My friend Rod made cover art for this! Go check him out!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The new campsite is smaller than the last, despite there being more people to care for and others still streaming in. Brightmoon is not far away and with any luck, it is still standing and not burned to a crisp. Once they can get as many people as they can to safety, they can regroup at the castle and resupply as well. After that, Adora honestly doesn't want to think much of it. There are only two options. Surrender and die, or fight back and die trying. Only time will tell which of them will play out or if anyone will survive to see the future.

Not much happens within the first couple days at the campsite. The most notable thing that occurs is Adora nearly being trampled to death by Swift Wind. Overcome by excitement after such a long time apart, he forgets how huge and heavy he is. With all the tackling Adora has had to endure from everyone, she manages to keep him from crushing her when it occurs and returns the gesture with a tight hug around the neck.

More nightmares and sleepless nights. More memories of attacking others, being at Horde Prime's side, and not caring for the well-being of others floods her mind. More confusing, hazy images of being with Glimmer at Brightmoon enter the fray. Where are they all from? It all leads to more headaches...There are more talks about what to do with Prime closing in, leading to no real answer. Optimism is running low. Despite trying to keep hope, there isn't much left to go around. Everyday as more survivors come in or others return from attempts to find ways to overthrow Prime, less ground can be found.

Most of the days when not able to find sleep, so far the best she has ever had was that brief nap with Glimmer, Adora keeps her mind occupied by going on as many missions as she can or doing random jobs. Glimmer stays behind at first, recovering from her shoulder injury. Part of the blonde is happy that she is out of danger, at least for now. If only she can stay out of it forever. Eventually, though, she returns to missions.

During one morning, Adora heads out to see if there are any villages with people left in them. Bring them back before Prime can get to them. Glimmer will be off doing her own thing and they will meet up later for more (useless) game planning.

She heads off with Tallstar, Scorpia, and Frosta shortly after breakfast, which Adora once more finds herself eating lightly. They search around high and low, looking for anything. There is the occasional robot to fend off but nothing catches them off guard. During their search they find one village. However, it is totally devoid of life. Everywhere they search, no one can be found. By the dust that lines tables, it has been a long time since anyone has called this place home.

A debate is quickly brought up if they should take some of the supplies, mostly food that hasn't gone bad, and medicine. On one hand, if anyone were to come back here, then there would be not much left for them. However, if it has been some time since anyone has stepped foot in here, it's best not to let anything go to waste. After some back and forth, it is decided to take some but

not all of the items. Enough to restock somewhat but allowing for any stragglers to use themself.

After gathering some provisions and filling her bag, Adora and the others head off. Hopefully, some place with people. And hopefully...a place she has never seen before. This one the group has just passed through did not cause any head or heartache. The blonde prays for that streak to continue. She desperately wants a break and some semblance of peace.

More walking, more being careful not to be spotted and captured. As the sun begins its downward curve, the group is about to give up. However, Scorpia spots another village hidden within the brush, tangled in the branches and vines of the thick Whispering Woods. It does not take long for the four to cut through the brush and enter a clearing. Everyone does a quick scan of the surroundings. Most of the village already seems abandoned. The only signs of life are a handful of leaves tumbling down a path as the quiet wind blows against them. Buildings, small one story structures, stand tall and still. Peering into the windows, there are no lights. Whoever might remain or escaped here from other places, either have left or do their utmost to stay hidden.

“Do you think anyone is here?” Frosta asks, continuing to scan the area.

“Possibly,” Tallstar says. “It's best to check and not leave anyone behind.”

“Let’s split up. Cover more ground,” Adora suggests. No one opposes the idea. Everyone splits apart, taking different sections of the village. Adora heads towards the eastern part of the village. Not many buildings are in this area, many stand yards apart from each other. Almost all show no signs of life.

She is careful not to make her presence completely known. As much as she wants not to miss anyone, not leave someone to the clutches of Horde Prime, there is no need to be jumped by the enemy. Who knows if this is a set up. If there are any robots just

waiting to strike an unsuspecting person. Caution is key. Even as she slowly makes her way to the edges of the village, the blonde remains alert.

Adora reaches a new building and pushes back the tattered cloth in the door frame. She looks around the room encased by shadows. A couple chairs lay on the ground, silverware and plates with crumbs of food sit on a table. Stepping further, she can see objects that used to rest on the dressers litter the floor. Some are broken. Looking around, there does not seem to be anyone around. Whoever called this place home long since has abandoned it and left in a bit of a rush. There doesn't seem to be anything else here, nothing even of use to the Rebellion.

Her foot finds something soft. Adora slowly turns her head downward. Her boot covers most of it but it does not take much to realize what it is. Part of the yellow fabric sticks out from under her foot, cut in a way that looks like hair. There are hints of red and white as well. Adora swallows a dry lump in her throat, hesitant to uncover what lies under her. Her heart has ceased to beat inside of her chest and any oxygen in her lungs has dissipated. Attempts to remove her eyes from her foot are in vain. All she can find herself doing is taking a step back.

The She-ra doll stares back at her with its blue threaded eyes. The dirty imprint of the sole of her boot rests on the chest. In its hand, a sword is held high. A wide and proud smile is stitched onto her face, ready to take on any foe it might face. It is more ready than she is. Adora finds herself kneeling down on the ground. As her fingers wrap around the doll, there is a sense of déjà vu. At least this time, the horrible smell of smoke and fire is not filling her nose. She studies it, looking at very carefully crafted seams. A relic of a long, long ago time. How many monsters has this thing fought off compared to her?

CLANK!

Adora leaps to her feet, the doll falling back on the ground as it is replaced by her fully drawn out staff. "Who's there?!?" she shouts

with force. No answer. Adora slowly makes her way towards where she heard the noise of something dropping. A torn up couch. Her heart beat has returned and now pounds against her chest. Is there some small robot hidden, waiting to leap out and attack her? Maybe someone loyal to Horde Prime's cause? Anything is possible and she needs to be ready.

On her the tips of her toes, she rounds the corner. Her staff is poised to strike but there is no need for it. There is no enemy lurking behind the couch. Rather, a child no older than ten. The second Adora appears, they shrink, attempting to become one with the floor in their freight. Bright green eyes hidden behind dark bangs stare back at her in shock. Besides them, next to their foot, is a bottle. Adora can't help but sigh a breath of relief.

"Thank the gods." Adora kneels once more, putting her staff to the side. "Hey there, kid. I won't hurt you. You're safe now."

The blonde sticks out a hand, seeking to bring the child to safety. However, moving an inch forward in an attempt to reach them backfires. The second she does, the child flinches and moves back. Their eyes widen, remaining on Adora. It is then she realizes she has seen the same pair of eyes before in the tangled mess of her memory. When and where, she cannot pinpoint. But all that matters is the same expression stares back at her.

"H-Hey, don't worry." Adora does everything in her power to keep her voice steady. She tosses the staff to the side. "I am here to help, see? You c-can come with me. I promise it'll be okay."

She attempts once more to close the gap between them. One step forward causes the child to move a foot back. Now they are back against a wall with no escape in sight. Adora remains frozen in place unable to process this. In the reflection of their terrified green eyes, she can see her own glowing ones as she takes over their village.

"Adora?" Tallstar's voice enters the air.

Adora breaks eye contact with the child. She cranes her neck to look over the couch and sees the top of Tallstar's head. The older woman strolls up to the other side, looking down at the two. The second the child sees the new person, they bolt over to her. Tallstar jerks slightly as they wrap their arms around her legs. Adora slowly rises to her feet, her body feeling heavy as lead.

"Uh…?" Tallstar looks at her, not sure what to make of this.

"They are the only one here. We should bring them back," Adora answers in a low voice. She slowly makes her way around the couch, drawing closer to the eldest Star Sibling. As she does, the child buries their face in Tallstar's leg, causing the blonde to stop in her tracks, keeping a distance. "Have you found anyone else?"

Tallstar looks down at the child clinging to her leg before her dark eyes land on the blonde. "A few people. We are all gathering to get a head count before leaving."

Adora gives a small nod. "Alright. Lead the way."

"Come on, little one." Tallstar softly says, bending down to wrap her arms around their body and lifting them off the ground. "You are safe now and we are all here to help."

The child says nothing, only burning their head in Tallstar's neck. Adora follows Tallstar out back into the village. More silence. More signs of people leaving without second thought. How much longer will this place remain relatively intact? How many hours did people have left before Adora and the others came to get them somewhere that is more safe and has more time? How much longer can everyone keep this up before there is nowhere left to run to?

Scorpia and Frosta wait patiently for Tallstar and Adora in the center of the village. Several people of different ages and races wait with them. As the pair join everyone, the blonde can feel a tense air around the group. In some of the adults' eyes, Adora catches ire in them. She quickly looks away, facing her friends.

“Is this everyone?” she asks.

“Yes it is,” Scorpia answers. “Some took some convincing to finally leave and others came from elsewhere.”

“You guys found someone?” Frosta then asks.

Tallstar kneels down, allowing the child to crawl off of her. They quickly head towards one of the adults, clinging to their leg. She stands up as she says, “We should get moving. There is no use in standing out here like sitting ducks.”

“Is it a good idea to have her around?” one of the villagers asks.

Scorpia, Frosta, and Tallstar all exchange looks before turning their attention to Adora. The blonde has her arms crossed and quickly looks and turns her head away. There are fewer places to keep her eyes on than spots to run from Horde Prime.

“What are you talking about? Of course! She is amazing at fighting. We need her!” Frosta states.

“Prime isn’t going to suddenly take control of her? She isn’t on his side still? This village isn’t going to burn down?”

Adora grips her arms tightly, nails digging into fabric and skin. A whisper in her head wonders if Entrapta got all of the chip out of her neck. After all, the device was *embedded* there. Could there be any remnants left? Is the thing she was, the monster, not that long ago still lying dormant in her? Her anger, her hurt, her frustrations, all just waiting to be released once more.

“No?!?” Scorpia starts, shocked. “She always has been on our side!”

“Yeah! She’s our friend! Prime is the one who hurt people, not Adora!” Frosta adds on.

That’s half true, Adora thinks. Yet, her grip loosens on her arms. She finally looks at her two friends, both who stand as tall as they

can and have drawn closer to her, forming a small shield around her. Tallstar takes a step forward, putting herself in front of the trio.

"Adora is of no harm to anyone. Whatever might have happened, that is not important right now. We need to get you all somewhere safer so Prime does no more harm to you. We will deal with him but first we cannot stay here any longer."

The group mumble to each other before coming to an agreement. Tallstar gestures for them to follow her. Before she walks off, she places a hand on Adora's shoulder. "You did great today, finding the child. We couldn't have done that without you. We will stop him."

Adora only gives a small nod in response before watching Tallstar lead the way. Scorpia and Frosta stay by her, patiently waiting for the blonde to move. She needs a small nudge from the scorpion princess to get her feet moving, her friends matching her pace.

It takes half a day to return to camp. During the trip, Adora catches some glimpses from the villagers. They say nothing but they don't need to when all you need are their eyes. She wishes to tell them she didn't want to hurt anyone, ever. It was Prime who made her do it, and used her anger against her. Would they even believe her, however? It still was her after all that did that. She couldn't break free of the chip, she wasn't strong enough. In her mind, she helped cause this mess and hurt. Why wouldn't people be angry?

As they walk, getting closer and closer to the camp, Frosta and Scorpia make chatter. Most of it is about random things and sometimes takes effort for Adora to zone in on. But the pair do their best to keep her engaged in the conversation. A nice gesture.

Once back at the camp, Tallstar begins to bring the villagers towards an area to recover and rest. As they are led away, Catra appears. When not on her own missions and stuck at the

campsites the magicat has been doing her own random jobs. Seems like there is not much else to do other than help villagers. As she comes closer, Adora hears one of the villagers mumble *'Oh, great another Horde bastard* under their breath. If Catra hears it herself, she makes no note of it. Or the glares as she helps Tallstar out.

The group splits apart. No time to waste when there is still plenty of daylight left to burn. Adora wanders around, seeking something to do. What even *is there* to do? No other scouting missions right now. Not many places left to go. Maybe helping out taking care of others? But she wonders if anyone would want her hands near them after everything. What else, what else?

Adora looks all over for someone to do. So many people already have groups and are doing their own thing. There will be no meeting for a plan of attack for a couple hours, everyone has to return first. This is going to be a long wait until. Finally, though, her legs bring her somewhere. Glimmer. Be it luck, faith, whatever the hell you want to call it, Adora can't seem to get away from the queen no matter how hard she tries. Something keeps drawing her back to Glimmer's side, despite everything that has happened in almost a month. With her, is Swift Wind.

"Adora!" The stallion shouts. He gallops over, nearly taking off in excitement. He stops just short before giving the blonde a nudge with his muzzle. "How did everything go?"

Adora reaches up and strokes the short, white fur on his nose. "Fine. Recused some more people. No one hurt, thankfully."

Swift Wind pulls away, tilting his head. "You sure? You alright, Adora?"

"Yeah, I am. Just been...a long day. And it's not even over yet." Adora turns her attention to the queen. "Are you guys up to anything?"

Glimmer shakes her head. “Just trying to figure out what to do before we meet everyone else...to figure out what to do.” She keeps her eyes as the blonde comes a little closer, still keeping a small gap between them.

“Guess we are in the same boat. Mind...if I linger around?”

“N-No. I don’t mind.”

Adora jerks awake, nothing new at all. At least there is no scream coming out of her. Only gasps escape her as she snaps up, nearly falling off her makeshift bed. It takes her brain a moment to return and make sense of the real world. Before it does, her mind remains in the nightmares that have plagued her for well over a week now. Prime, Perfuma, fire and smoke, Glimmer bloody, Glimmer with her in a field of flowers, the taking of runestones, fighting Glimmer, and watching ships encase her homeworld. So much blurs together that the blonde has begun to give up trying to pull out one from the other. The voice of Horde Prime talking about said runestones lingers in her mind for several moments before fading out.

As her breaths help settle her body, bringing down from a horrible high, there is a new yet familiar sensation. One at the base of her neck. Without much thought, she starts to rub it. The bandage that once stuck to her has been removed. What is left is nothing more than a pale, jagged patch of skin. Matching all the other scars that litter her face, back, and body. At least this one is out of sight. If only the pain would cease to be.

Adora sighs as she finally comes back to Etheria. She wonders what time it is. Definitely either late night or early morning. Whatever one might call this time of day that is where the blonde finds herself. The debate of if she should go back to bed or not crosses her mind. It took forever to find rest and she probably only got an hour or so in, though all restless. Does she want to risk having more nightmares and waking up scared and confused just for just a small amount of sleep? Or should she stay awake

and find other things to do to occupy her mind, keeping the shadows from over taking it? Staying up and getting fresh air while keeping watch is an idea but she can count on one hand how many hours of good, genuine sleep she has gotten lately.

There is not any time to decide what to do when the world picks for her. Adora snaps out of her thoughts when she realizes that there is the sound of muttering, a small commotion, outside of her quarters. *Who the hell is up at this hour?* she wonders. The blonde crawls out of bed and sticks her head out of the door. There are not many people up. Those that do stand around, talking amongst themselves. Adora can feel the anxiety in the air, the hairs on the back of her neck stand at attention, yet there is no one rushing to get everyone out of the area. What is going on?

Her eyes land on King Micah, talking to his daughter and Bow. Adora quickly dips back inside her quarters to retrieve her staff for good measure before jogging out to join them. "Hey, what's going on?"

Everyone stops their chatter the second Adora appears. They all exchange a concerning look. This causes Adora to raise an eyebrow. Before she can say anything, only getting her mouth open, Bow cuts her off. "We were wondering where you were. Were you asleep?"

"Yeah? Why? Did something happen?" Did she sleep through something? Normally, the sound of a pin dropping can cause her to snap to attention.

"Uh, yeah. It's...not great," Glimmer admits. "You're not going to like it."

"What happened? Do we have to leave again? Is Horde Prime's army about to come? Did someone get hurt?!?"

"Easy." Micah places a hand on her shoulder. "It's none of those things…" He takes a breath before answering. "You just missed

Horde Prime showing up on his hologram. He...has the Black Garnet."

Everything becomes silent, cold. She can see the mouths of the others moving but all she can hear is static. Her sight becomes like she is looking through a small pipe, the hole no bigger than an inch. The Black Garnet, the runestone she knows the most about aside from the Moonstone, has been taken. It is not all that shocking, as being in the Fright Zone, an area already occupied by the Horde it is one of the easiest to get to. But now there are more in Horde Prime's clutches than there are still in the Kingdoms. Her stomach twists thinking why that is as such.

In her shortened sight, pink and purple colors enter. A whiff of flowers, lavenders, travels into her nose. The black edges of her vision fade away and Glimmer appears. The queen has her hands wrapped around the blonde's upper arms, giving a reassuring squeeze. Adora blinks, riding the blur around the smaller girl and everything around her. Her lilac eyes are full of fraught. An invisible knife slices through the blonde's heart at the sight.

How many times is she going to cause Glimmer harm or worry?

"Adora?" Glimmer says. "You there?"

"Y-Yeah, Glimmer," Adora says with a sigh. She runs a free hand through her short hair and gives a small squeeze of her head. "I can't believe he has another. This isn't good. At this rate, before we get to Brightmoon he is going to have all of them."

"We will figure something out," Bow says, stepping into her line of sight. "It'll be okay."

"Do you really think that?" There is an edge to her voice. Adora quickly bites down on her lower lip to prevent anymore from coming out. However, there is a flash of surprise across her friend's face at the tone. "Sorry…"

Bow takes a moment to think. "We still have two, Adora. The Kingdom of Snows is hard to reach and we are close to

Brightmoon. Two is better than none. We will figure out something. We always do."

"There is nothing we can do right now. We need to rest and regroup in the morning," Micah adds on.

Adora groans. There is no way in hell she will be sleeping tonight. She doesn't even want to close her eyes for even a moment right now. Even awake, the nightmares never end.

"Micah is right. We should go back to bed so we can be alert tomorrow," Bow states. "It's pretty late."

"I'm going to go on watch for a little bit. I need to clear my head," Adora replies.

"Are you sure?"

"Yeah, Adora. You need your rest," Glimmer tells her. She begins to slowly rub her hands up and down the blonde's arm.

Adora stares at the queen's shoulder. The wound almost has completely healed. That wound is a scar in the blonde's mind, however, not fading away anytime soon. How long has Glimmer been making sure she is okay? Even before breaking free of Horde Prime's grip, she has been doing everything in her power to get her back. Adora takes a breath before placing a hand on Glimmer's.

"You do also. I'll be fine. The Horde would make us work with little sleep anyway so I am used to it."

"Adora, *are you sure?* You look really tired."

This nightmare I have more control in. No need to enter one where I have no control. "I just need some air. I'll be fine." She gives a small squeeze of her hand. "Get rest so that shoulder can fully heal."

"Do you want someone to come with you?" Bow asks.

Adora shakes her head. “If it makes you feel better, I will see who else is on watch and stay close to them.”

Bow and Glimmer exchange glances at each other, silently communicating with the other, before looking back at the other member of their trio. The queen answers for both of them, “If you need *anything* come to one of us. Wake us up even if we are out cold. Alright?”

“Alright.”

Glimmer does not let go immediately. Her soft thumbs brush against Adora’s skin. Slowly, the queen lets go. “Don’t worry about waking me, okay?”

“Don’t worry, Glimmer. Go rest.” When Glimmer’s mouth becomes a thin line, Adora gives her a small push. “Go.”

“Promise?”

“Promise.”

Glimmer finally breaks off, her eyes lingering on Adora for several strides before disappearing. Once everyone has dispersed,the blonde leaves. A sense of guilt rises inside of her as she breaks her promise to come to either of her friends. *Let them sleep,* she thinks. *Let them have a break.*

She stays in camp today. Jobs cycle around and thus today, this is what lands on Adora’s shoulders. Normally, this wouldn’t have bothered all too much. Changes in paces are always nice. Break out the monotony and not fall deeper into the clutches of her mind during it all. Keep herself on her toes. Distractions are good. It would really be nice to have some right about now.

Adora checks over the dwindling supplies, seeing how much is actually left, what can be rationed and what cannot, and what is missing. The blonde grumbles to herself as she scribbles down not so great looking numbers. But that is not the only thing that

causes her to do so. Out of the corner of her eye, she sees a villager aiding in the check, begrudgingly. Adora doesn't need to take a peak to know they have been staring at her. She can feel it.

Adora pulls her eyes away and returns her gaze at the list in front of her. After a few more checks, the blonde places the list down, joining it's other siblings. With another glance around, she steps out to search for another job to do. As she exits, her ears catch an instinct whisper. Adora doesn't bother to attempt to decipher it. She doesn't need to figure the words out to know what it is.

People stroll around the small encampment. There is the smoky smell of some meat and vegetables cooking in the air. Adora passes the tent that holds the food. Some others train, trying not to fall into a rusty state. Chatter of other ideas or random things to get the mind off of things can be heard. Looking around, the blonde does her best to figure out what else there is to do before night falls. At least there has been a slow down of conversations stopping as she passes by. Though, they still occur. While part of her doesn't want to bother anyone, it would be really nice to have someone on her side right about now.

For the love of-

Her feet have guided her to a familiar yet not so welcoming face. Catra, along with Melog, is one of the few people she knows in the camp right now. With everyone so busy, it's hard to get everyone together for long periods of time. The magicat is busy checking over some weaponry.

The alien she has picked up is curled up in front of her, watching her. They are the one who notices Adora staring and lets out a small noise. Catra's left ear flicks before twisting her head around.

"I thought you were doing something else." One of Catra's eyebrows raises as she flicks her eyes up and down the blonde. "It's not like you to ditch."

“And it’s not like you to actually do work,” Adora retorts.

“Touché.”

Adora steps slightly closer, still leaving a gap between them. “If you really want to know, I was done. I was trying to see what else there is to before the others got back.”

“Done early. No surprise there. Well, I have no idea what there is to do. Got stuck with this job by someone. You can help if you are that desperate but I really couldn’t care less.”

Adora opens her mouth to utter a reply but is cut off by the sound of a scoff from behind. Both she and Catra look at some people passing by. The former friends catch the others glances before heads are turned away. Adora pinches the bridge of her nose before taking a breath.

“Hey…” Catra’s voice catches her off guard. She slowly lifts her head to look at the magicat. Her cyan and amber eyes struggle to stay straight. A hand rubs against the back of her neck and her ears fail to stay upright. “Don’t...Don’t let them get to you.”

Adora’s arm drops to the side. She herself finds it hard to keep her eyes from falling to the ground. “How the hell do you do it? After...After everything *you* do.”

Catra begins to absentmindedly draw something in the dirt with a free claw. “I got years under my belt to get used to it to a degree. Learning a proper way is what’s new to me.” She pauses for a moment. “Trying to make things right is the only thing I can think of right now but you did nothing wrong.”

Adora scoffs.

“All I can say right now is to ignore them. Fuck ‘em. There are a lot more people who know better and don’t hate your guts. If there is one thing you can trust me on, it’s that. Once we figure this shit out, I can’t wait to see you kick some Horde Prime ass.”

“Don’t see how I can do that with how I am right now.”

“You used to kick everyone’s ass without She-ra.”

This still does little to help. She wishes she saw more of the people who don’t hate her. She wonders even in the world she can even defeat Horde Prime. Catra is a good lair, who knows if she is doing this now.

TWACK!

“Ow! Hey!” Adora shouts, rubbing above just her right eye. She looks down to see something wrapped sitting at her feet. “What the hell was that for?”

“Look at it more closely, dummy.”

Adora grumbles before reaching down. Opening the white, nondescript package, a familiar grey bar looks back at her. Adora blinks before looking at Catra.

“There are some Horde soldiers lurking around trying to help. I’m sure I saw Lonnie, Rogelio, and Kyle at some point, dunno where they are now. But I was able to trade some shit for some bars.”

“Why are you giving me one?”

Catra shrugs. “Didn’t know that was illegal. Though, something being illegal never stopped me before. Besides, Sparkles would kick my ass if she figured out I had food you like and didn’t share. If anything, eat it for her.” Without saying anything else, the magicat goes back to her work.

Adora keeps her eyes on Catra for a couple moments, still in shock, before looking back at the food in her hands. It looks just like she remembers and has the same subtle smell. With a small bite, the taste brings back memories of her place of growing up. A simpler time. Adora’s stomach growls, begging for more. Slowly, taking small bites, she eats.

Chapter End Notes

forgot to do a shoutout last time but here's this one. My friend Watertribesato has written some wonderful glimmadora so check them out!

With You In The Dark

Chapter Notes

> Like I said, I split these up so it's why I got this out much quicker. And...hopefully nothing sounds off. I have been having trouble with these past two and with this I finally just was like, I am just hitting post. So take it for what it is worth and hopefully y'all still enjoy. Idk when the next will get out, I am gonna take a small break so ye. Also, kudos to those who get the title ref
>
> Comments and Kudos are appreciated

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Glimmer strolls back into the campsite, rolling her right shoulder. While the wound has all but healed, the soreness still lingers. A phantom of days ago. The strain from use today does little to help the ache. Adora isn't going to be happy that she overdid herself a bit today, if she finds out. But there wasn't much of a choice when you can only fight back. At least there were no injuries other than some scrapes and bruising. Everyone has made it back alive and with some robots cut into pieces.

Night has begun to take over the world. The sky has become a colorful collage of bright yet soft oranges and dark and star filled purple. Glimmer wishes to enjoy the beautiful sight, soak it all in for every ounce it gives. Yet there has been little room to do so. The queen doesn't know if she will ever get the chance to do so. All the more reason to take a moment. Glimmer continues to walk through the camp.

She passes by the stone and brick buildings of the village everyone finds themselves in. Glimmer wishes to enter the one she has been given and curl up in the cot. Part of her is just about to so but she continues forward. She will feel better once she knows how everyone is doing. Even if her own mission went well,

doesn’t mean everyone else had the same stroke of luck. By the looks of it, nothing of worry has occurred. The queen can sigh a small breath of relief.

Glimmer continues to look around, searching for the one person she wants to see. No luck as of yet. She is not all too worried, as Adora has to be somewhere in this campsite. Unless she got pulled away to do something, the blonde cannot be far. The queen hopes her friend has had a relatively good day. She deserves it after everything to have a breather, no matter how small it might be.

After a couple more moments of wandering around, she finds who she is looking for. Adora has her sights on a map sprawled across her lap. A tongue sticks out of the side of her mouth as her sky blue eyes scan the red and green paper. There is a small, dying fire out in front of her, only small embers burning. She is sitting all by her lonesome on the log in an area not many people pass.

“Why are you all alone?”

Adora slowly lifts her head up, blinking. Once she is back in reality, she gives a small shrug. “Just wanted to be alone. Kind of can think better without eyes on me.”

“Ah…Well...How did your day go, if you don’t mind me asking?”

“Nothing special. How was your mission? How’s the shoulder?”

Glimmer rubs her shoulder. “A lot better. Nice to get some use out of it again. And it was okay. Nothing out of the ordinary. Nothing to note.”

“That’s good to hear.”

“So…” Glimmer looks over Adora’s shoulder, staring down at the map in her lap. The queen recognizes it as the edge of Brightmoon’s borders. Much of the area just out of its territory is shade red. Only a handful of spots, isolated from one another, are green. Seeing her home covered all in a cool color shade gives the

queen some semblance of hope. She clicks tongue before finishing her sentence. “We are almost back home, huh?”

Adora looks down at the map, her hand brushing lightly against it. “Yeah...It’s...Brightmoon is still standing, right? These maps aren’t wrong and we aren’t heading straight into a trap?”

“Last time I heard, yes. The Whispering Woods are always an excellent defense and Mermista sure as hell knows what she is doing. Definitely doesn’t want a repeat of her kingdom.”

“I don’t want that either.” Adora says in a low voice.

Glimmer lets herself slowly fall to her knees, becoming eye level with Adora. She places a hand on her arm and rubs it slowly up and down. “We’ll fix it. We always do, right?”

Adora doesn’t answer right away. “Right…” She takes a breath before straightening herself out. “Enough about me. We will be back at Brightmoon soon. You’ll be able to recharge and be back on the throne. What do you think about that?”

Glimmer cannot wait to return home. Closing her eyes, the queen can see her castle, her home, shining in the sunlight. The smooth, brilliant marble that makes up the building must look stunning in the new light that Etheria has. She can smell the gardens, the cooking in the kitchen, and the soil wet from the waterfalls. Her heart *aches* .

And then of course, her mind shows her the Moonstone. Even now, she can *feel* the energy radiating off of it and longs for that to be back inside her veins. Glimmer does wonder, however, what her subjects think. Would she deserve that power after letting Horde Prime come to Etheria and practically conquer it? After all, if she hadn’t sought after the Heat of Etheria to gain more power, none of this would have happened.

“There is a lot to think about,” Glimmer admits, opening her eyes. “I want to see home so badly but nervous. There is so much

going on. Seeing Brightmoon would definitely make me feel better but...I don't want it to be the last time I see it."

"Then I guess we have to try and make sure it isn't, huh?"

Adora tries to sound hopeful and reassuring. However, Glimmer can see in her blue eyes a shadow of uncertainty.

"Right." Glimmer shifts into a more comfortable sitting position. "Mind if I chill here? I want to get a better idea of how getting there will be."

Adora moves the map so the queen can get a better look.

Glimmer snaps her right middle finger and thumb together. A small, purple sparkle of magic is produced. It fizzles out like a sparkler, barely alive for two seconds before becoming nothing. The queen sighs. There wasn't much to expect honestly but she wanted to give it a shot since she was closer to home. But alas, the magic that comes with being attached to a runestone is nonexistent.

She rests her head on her hand and looks around. Glimmer's eyes land on Scorpia and Frosta, sitting together and taking a moment to breathe. The queen wonders about the two. The scorpion princess no longer has access to her runestone, one she only *just* forged a connection with. Since hearing that it is gone, Scorpia has not used any of her magic unless *absolutely* necessary. At least she still has a stinger to help out.

Frosta is the only one who does not have to worry about her powers. She did not suddenly lose her connection to it and her runestone (as far as anyone is aware) still resides where it has been for many generations. She has done her best to fight back and protect her friends. Heck, Glimmer still chuckles a little remembering when the girl decked Catra. Still, she is so, so, *so* young. Barely even a teenager. What must all of this be like for her?

She thinks about the other princesses. Mermista. Holding down the fort at Brightmoon. Glimmer will not be able to thank her for staying there while all this went down. It has pretty much become her home since her actual one was essentially burned to a crisp. Does she still have her powers now that the Pearl has been taken?

And what about Perfuma? Is she still alive? Adora says the last time she can recall seeing the other blonde, she was. But it has been some time now and who knows when that memory was. Glimmer prays Perfuma is indeed alive. The thought of the kind yet fierce plant princess no longer being a part of her life makes her stomach twist. It becomes an even tighter knot at the thought of her being captive. Glimmer can taste bile as she remembers herself being trapped there.

She really needs to think of something else right about now.

Her eyes search around more, trying to find anything to keep the dark shadows lurking in her mind from taking over. They quickly spot her father talking to Swift Wind. Both have a smile on their faces and are laughing at something. Even if it is something stupid, Glimmer does not care. Stupidity can take her mind off of the things at the very least. The queen quickly walks over to the pair.

"Oh! Hello sweetheart!" the older sorcerer says upon seeing his daughter. "How is my little girl doing?"

The only answer she can give is a small shrug and a soft 'eh'. "Just trying to find something to do while the others are away. Not a lot of jobs to do right now. Guess everyone is trying to stay busy."

"Do you want to practice some of your sorcery with me? Some father-daughter bonding?"

"Nah, I'm good…" Glimmer sighs. While it would be nice to spend some much needed time with her father, she wants to keep her

mind off of her problem with powers. “I came to see what you guys are up to.”

“Not much really.” Swift Wind pipes up. “Guess we are all trying to figure something else to do.”

“Maybe there will be more things to do once we get back to Brightmoon. I hope everyone will come back soon and all alright.” Glimmer’s anxiety never ceases when anyone leaves, even if they are not all too far. It does not help in the slightest that both Adora and Bow out there. At least they are together.

“I am sure they will be okay,” Micah reassures her. He places a strong but soft hand on her back. “If Bow and Adora can help get my sorry behind off of Beast Island after so long, they will be more than okay out there.”

“Speaking of which…” Swift Wind taps his rainbow wing against his chin. “Glimmer, do you know how Adora is doing?”

Glimmer raises an eyebrow. Thinking back, she hasn’t quite been able to get a read on the blonde. It is no surprise she tries to be strong for everyone, putting her needs aside for the sake of others. She definitely has been closed mouth as of late. The queen wonders if she should be pushing more to make sure everything is alright. Or if that will do more harm than good. “Not really? She hasn’t told me much.”

Swift Wind’s face twists into grimace.

“What?” Glimmer asks.

“With my connection to her, I normally can sense what she is sensing. But it’s been...weaker lately. Like she is still out in space. It's better than before but not like it once was. She’s definitely hiding something. She’s just...not herself at all. And I don’t mean by just being down. I can barely feel the old Adora in her.”

Glimmer’s heart sinks into the pit of her stomach. She shouldn’t be surprised that the blonde has been hiding so much. Yet to hear

from Swift Wind, the one who can actually read Adora's emotions, say this does not sit well with her. The queen wonders if she has been able to do anything to make Adora feel better or if she should have done more.

"Aunt Casta said something similar," Glimmer sighs, remembering that day. "Like a dark cloud. Can't blame her though. I just wish I knew what to do. Guess I am both a useless queen and friend. No powers to do anything to help those I care about."

"She'll need your help." Micah whispers to her. "And I am sure she will come to you when she needs it."

"How do you know that?"

Micah snakes his arms around his daughter, pulling her into his chest. He bends down so his brown eyes look at her purple ones. "Because I know you mean the world to her. Just like she does to you. She might not be able to talk right now but she will. And when she does, I know you will be able to help her feel so much better."

"And what if I can't?"

"You won't fail. I've seen you two together. Once she needs you, you'll know when. And I have no doubt in your ability. You love her, don't you?"

"More than anything on Etheria."

"Good." Micah gives her a small kiss on top of her head. "Why don't we go see if there is anything we three can do while we wait for the others."

Adora trudges through the Whispering Woods, keeping her eyes and ears peeled for anything that could go wrong. Nothing has cropped up, thank the gods. Not even the stray robot, searching for people to take or end. Even if part of Adora wants to take a

breather, be happy for a sudden stroke of luck, it never is that easy. The fear of something popping out thin air and ruining everything eats away at her inside.

Bow, along with some faces she has no name to, walk slightly ahead of her. Adora offered to watch the rear. No one objected to the idea. Now everyone is in their own positions as they search the far reaches of the Brightmoon Kingdom. Nothing much has been found, for better or for worse.

“How are you, Adora?” Bow asks, slowing his walk to match with his friend’s.

The blonde gives a small shrug. “Dunno how to answer that.”

“Fair enough. We are almost done for the day, thankfully. And soon, we will be back at Brightmoon. That is always something to look forward to, right?”

“I guess you are right.” Adora pushes away some low hanging brush, making sure it does not slap her or Bow square in the face. “Hey, Bow. Can...I ask a stupid question?”

Bow raises an eyebrow. “You know there are no stupid questions with me. Ask away.”

Adora takes a look in front of her. The rest of the group is made up of stray villagers or soldiers from other kingdoms, such as those from Plumeria. Adora chews on the bottom of her lip for a moment, thinking about those in front of her. “Do you think this is all worth it? That...we will be able to beat Horde Prime?”

Bow’s eyes become wide with surprise. He does not answer right away, choosing his words carefully in his head. “I won’t lie. It doesn't look great, does it...But we can’t just give up! Anything we have won, even if it is small, will be all for not if we do so. There are a lot of people looking up to us. We can’t let them down, can we?”

Adora holds herself, turning her head away from her friend as they continue to walk. "True. I just...Do you really think people actually still look up to us. To me? After...everything?"

"Adora, it's not your fault. You would never do the things Prime made you do."

The blonde sighs. "Well, I hope we actually get some more victories in or something to push back Horde Prime. Brightmoon is our last line of defense. We're pretty much up against a wall."

"One step at a time."

We really need to be one step ahead of him.

Adora and Bow continue to walk. It seems like nothing special will be happening today. No news at all to give the rest of the camp. But just as everyone is about to turn around and start their trek back to the campsite, and something catches everyone's attention. Everyone draws closer to a small clearing. One that at one point, held a small, pit-stop area travelers would have stopped at if things were so insane. And if the place wasn't half destroyed and burned.

There really isn't much at first glance. Just a couple buildings that would have held supplies and a couple fire pits that have turned cold. However, near one of them, something has been made. The group moves closer for a better look.

A number of purple and blue flowers rest on the ground, many in bundles. Small offerings of foods sit on places and stray objects from Brightmoon kingdom and those closer to it like Plumeria are in the assortment of items. Propped up on large sticks, are the symbols of all four of the kingdoms. A large, pale, crescent moon is at the top, shining in the sunlight. Under it, is a red, brilliant flower like the ones from Perfuma's kingdom. To it's right is a golden, sharp trident. Below them, is a clear, smooth crystal carved to look like ice.

Adora's legs give out.

“Is...Is this a memorial?” Adora whispers.

Bow stands right besides her. “Looks like it. Everyone has lost someone now…”

Some of the rest of the members pull out what little they have, be it a food offering or a small trinket, and place it among the rest of the items and offerings. Even Bow pulls out one of his arrows and places it down. “For safety for them.”

Adora doesn’t move. She is frozen on the ground like a statue. The blonde cannot pry her eyes away from it. She has seen some memorials in the past. The war has raged on for so long, it is not surprising to see these crop up. Most of the time, the ones she found with her friends had signs of age, that they were made some time before their arrival. But this one is new, fresh. Most of the food has not decayed or been gnawed on by any hungry lifeforms. This is for those lost to not the Horde she grew up in but those who have suffered under Prime. Something she unfortunately has had a hand in.

“Adora?” Bow’s voice softly whispers in her ear. He places a hand on her shoulder but she quickly rips away from him.

“Don’t.” Adora states, getting back to her feet. She doesn’t want to think about this, she doesn’t want to be in this place anymore. Not with this memorial staring back at her, reminding her of those that will never return because of what Prime made her do. Not with people she helped destroy their home or have taken away their ruler. “Let’s just go. There is nothing here.”

“Adora, are you sure? Are you-”

Adora doesn’t allow him to finish. Her heart is beginning to pick up its pace and so do her feet. She can hear the others quickly scrambling to catch up with her but she never slows her stride. Her mind is set on getting back to the camp, to get away from her thoughts, and everything else. Though, how can she truly escape when there are more people homeless and hurt because of her?

Where Glimmer, the person she almost murdered in cold blood, is there.

She doesn't know how long it takes for her to return to camp. With her heart pounding in her chest and her thoughts going mad, her trek back is nothing but a blur. When she steps foot inside the area, Adora does not stop for a moment. Her feet keep her moving, passing the rest of her friends such as Glimmer. All she sees of the queen are her signature purples, pinks, and blues. She heads straight into the small, stone building she has been using for her living quarters.

Adora paces around the room, her anger threatening to boil over, like a pot of water forgotten about on the stove. Her mind races faster than light and she can do nothing to stop the thoughts entering. The scornful looks and words from the villagers earlier in the week. The knowledge of Prime having more runstones than the Rebellion. She has failed the people she always wanted to protect. Hurt them, let them down, and have taken away so much of their hope. And now, that memorial to those lost, something she remembers having a hand in. So much in such a short amount of time keeps on hitting her over and over again. It's too much.

She wants to explode, take her staff and destroy anything in her path. Get out everything bottled up inside of her. But how good will that look after what she has done? She still cannot understand how Catra can deal with all of this. The looks, the whispers, and the distrust. She willingly did things, though. Everything was against Adora's will, though it still was her own emotions. Trying her best to ignore it can't do much when it always feels like people's stares are boring into her? Clearly that is not enough. All she knows for sure is that Prime *must* be defeated. No matter what the cost is if it means making up for what she has done.

"Adora?" Glimmer's voice catches her off guard. Adora snaps her head up and eyes lock onto the queen's. She must be *radiating* her anger. Glimmer stands tense near the door frame. However, softness remains in her sparkling lilac eyes. "I was wondering where you went in such a rush. Are you okay?"

The question causes her body to twitch and crawl. She bites down on her lip, holding back the dam of negative emotions about to burst out of her. Glimmer does not deserve indirect anger. The queen has already suffered enough at her hands. Still, the cracks are there and it cannot stop the leaks as she speaks. "Yeah, just *fine,* Glimmer."

The queen ventures further into the small building. She keeps some breathing room between her and the blonde. "Adora. I know...things can still be weird between us but something is wrong. Please tell me. I don't like seeing you like this. What happened?"

The cracks grow larger. "There sure is something wrong. Prime has all but pretty much won! How the hell can we compete with that?!? When he has three out of the five runestones needed to tap into all the magic right below our feet?!? He is going to go after the Kingdom of Snows or Brightmoon soon and how the hell can we stop him from getting those two?!? He wouldn't have had most of them if I hadn't helped him!"

"Adora, you know none of that is your fault! He used you."

" *He still used my feelings against me!"* The dam finally breaks inside of her. It comes out in her words and through streams running down her cheeks. "I still have the memories, Glimmer! I still see it all the time in my head what I did! What he made me do! I still can remember what I felt like doing those actions!"

Her voice begins to crack and there is no way to stop it. The volume increases as she continues to speak. "I was angry, Glimmer! I was angry, hurting, confused, stressed, so many things because of the war. Because of everything that happened over the past year and half! Angry with you! ...I didn't want to hurt you or anyone but Prime took those emotions I hid, all my frustrations and doubts, and cranked them up to *eleven!*

"I hurt people! I hurt them because I let Prime take over my mind and I let him use what I hid away deep inside of me. He forced

me to almost *kill* you! And everyone keeps telling me it is *not* my fault. That everything is *okay.* Well, it's *not!"*

In a flash of anger, old habits flare up. Her right hand connects with the hard wall of the building. Adora feels something else snap, this time in her fingers. She doesn't care. Doesn't care what pain she might feel later once all of this wears off. The punch releases much of her anger in one swoop but it is quickly replaced by an overwhelming weight of sorrow and guilt.

"I'm not okay…" Adora's voice comes out small, like she is a small child again scared of what lurks in the shadows. Though, that fear still grips her, doesn't it? "I'm not okay…"

Her legs give, refusing to hold her weight. She collapses to the ground, falling on her hands and knees. Her tears show no signs of stopping. Adora tries to control herself, she has already cried so much as of late. It does little to help. All she can do is choke but sobs to keep some of it at bay.

Glimmer suddenly is at her side. Before Adora can say or do anything, arms wrapped around her. She is pulled close and tight against the queen's body. Close enough to hear her steady heart beat and have her nose be filled by a comforting flowery scent.

"I'm sorry, Adora. Everything you went through...you did *not* deserve any of that. None of that should have happened to you. But...we are all here for you. We all want to help one way or another. And even if you blame yourself, everyone here wants to help lift that burden off of you. Me, Bow, my father and aunt, Swift Wind, Scorpia, Frosta, Entrapta, the Star Siblings. Hell I guess you can count Catra after she helped me try to bring you back. We all wanted you here, we all missed you.

"I can't stop yourself from blaming yourself. I can't fathom what it must have been like to have those memories. But you don't have to deal with that alone. We are here for you. I am. Just...let it out, Adora. It's okay to feel that way and let it out. Please…"

The soft tone of her voice, the whispering of her words, her familiar scene, and the beating of her heart in her ears, Adora lets herself break into many, tiny pieces.

Glimmer keeps her grip tight on Adora as she sobs everything out. The only thing she allows herself to do is rub the blonde's back softly, reassuring her that the queen isn't going anywhere. She wonders how long Adora has been holding this in. Probably as long as she has been freed. How long has it been now to allow things to stack on top of each other? Far too long. Glimmer kicks herself a bit, wishing she could have known telling her everything was okay wasn't helping. But there was no way of knowing. At the moment, she will do whatever it takes to truly help.

Adora continues to cry. Sometimes, Glimmer hears her mumble something. Whatever it is, it is muffled from her face being half buried in the queen's chest and sobs preventing words from forming. Glimmer rocks her slightly, hoping to bring more comfort. The wish to turn back the clocks return, wanting to prevent the pain and burden Adora has been saddled with. If this is the best she can do right now, then so be. She will do whatever it takes, even if she can't do much.

The sobs slow and quiet. Glimmer refuses to let go, not until she knows everything inside of Adora is released. She places a chin on top of the blonde's head, continuing to rub her back. Strong, brave faced Adora, the legendary warrior princess is now like a small, scared child. The queen refuses to let go. If she could, she would never release her grip and not let anyone ever break her again. Never let harm come to the blonde and let her live the life she desperately deserves to have. For now, though, she lets Adora free everything bottled inside of her. When the time comes, she will help the blonde pick up those pieces.

Finally, the silence becomes too long. Glimmer shifts and looks down at the blonde in her arms. "Adora?" There is no answer. Adora's eyelids hide her sky-blue eyes. Her breathing, once

erratic, has slowed and some out at a steady pace. Her cheeks are stained with tears, some of which continue to slip out. While her face has relaxed greatly, there clearly is sadness there. At least she finally fell asleep.

Without saying much, Glimmer scoops the unconscious blonde in her arms. She carefully brings her to the bed and gingerly places her down. This will be more comfortable and with any luck, maybe she will stay asleep for some time. Without much thought, the queen wipes Adora's face clean of her tears. A soft whine escapes the blonde.

"Sorry. I know you don't like that but it had to clean them for you."

Glimmer reaches down and takes the hand Adora punched the wall with in her own. A blue light encases it. Even if Adora's body rejects most magic, this should at least take away at least *some* of the pain she might be feeling. Maybe even fix it if she did anything. It is the least Glimmer can do right now.

Finally, one last thought enters her mind. She reaches back and removes the sparkling, blue cape from her shoulders. Refusing to pull the blanket she placed Adora on, no need to risk waking her, this will do. It only covers her abdomen, her legs remain unprotected.

"I wish I could do more but you're not alone. Never forget that. We are all here for you. *I* am here for you, and that won't ever change, not in a million years."

Glimmer doesn't know what comes over her but she leans forward and places a peck on Adora's warm forehead. She then tucks a loose strain of dark, blonde hair behind her ear before saying, "I hope you sleep well. You deserve it...I love you, 'Dora. So much more than you know."

She remains at the blonde's for sme more time, wishing not to leave. But as always, the war ruins everything and the others will

be wanting to know if Adora is okay. With one last squeeze of the hand, she leaves Adora to sleep, planning on coming back later.

Chapter End Notes

> okay so this week's shout out is to my friend Riggy_Minus who helped give me an idea for what I was stuck on (what finally led to Adora to begin to crack), so I have to give her a shoutout. She writes mostly for RWBY so if you like that show, go give her work a look!

Home Sweet Home

Chapter Notes

> another chapter, I am on a bit of a high. That being said also I have finished the last of the outline and I am looking at the story ending at chapter 17? I won't put a cap on the chapters yet but just as a general idea. Anyway a bit slower chapter. Though, I will mention a possible? TW for kind of panic attack/flashback. There is just one section that gets a little heavier and possible tw
>
> Anyway, I hope yall still enjoy this nonsense. Kudos and comments are always welcomed

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora slowly stirs awake. Her body drags itself out of a deep, dreamless slumber. It tries to pull her back under but the want to be in the waking world wins out. The blonde blinks, letting the world come into focus. It takes several moments for her brain to wake up itself. She groans as she pushes herself onto her hands, fighting the usual lead weights that feel tied to her limbs. However, they feel a few pounds lighter. Adora runs a hand through her dark blonde locks, still returning to the world of the living.

All her thoughts slowly tickle back into her mind. Her mission with Bow and others. Finding the abandoned area with the memorial. Even now, her thoughts threaten to become jumbled with what that structure meant. Then, her return to the camp and her blow up at Glimmer, spilling everything that was inside of her. The blonde mutters to herself, thinking how she caused the queen worry once more. She wonders where Glimmer is now, hopefully taking a breather.

“Hm?” Adora eyes fixate on a sparkling, blue fabric spread across her body. Her left fingers brush against it, feeling the softness on

her exposed fingertips. She strokes it several times before clutching it. The blonde pulls the cape close to her nose and takes a whiff. Her mind is sent to Brightmoon, back when life was a little easier. The scent of lavenders floods her scenes and all she can see are one of the grand gardens of the castle. Hundreds of thousands of purple and blue flowers create their own colorful paintings in the grass. But the blonde pays little attention to them.

In the center of the garden is where the images in her mind are the clearest and sharpest. Glimmer...Radiant as ever and has a welcoming, loving smile on her face. With the cape so close to her, Adora can feel the queen's warm embrace around her. She does not want to leave this world she created herself. It is a far better world than the one she found herself in. But reality calls. The blonde reluctantly opens her eyes.

Adora begins to shift, readying herself for the day. However, as she moves her right hand, attempting to give her body a small push off the bed, she winces. The blonde snaps her hand to her chest, holding it in her other. Her brain reminds her of what she did, among other things. When the pain subsides, she relaxes and pulls her away to examine herself. With her thumb, she checks her knuckles. Some pain radiates through her at the touch. Definitely did something to it. Flexing her fingers, she is able to use them if she grits her teeth somewhat.

The blonde could’ve sworn she done more damage. She can still hear a *crack* in her mind. Maybe that was something else? Regardless, if she is careful, it shouldn’t bother her. Finally, she begins readying herself for the day. Which does not take long at all. She has fallen asleep in the same clothing she has been wearing as of late. Some quick brushing of her hair with her fingers is all she really needs. There is a warmth in the air today, making wearing her new jacket somewhat annoying. She pulls it off her shoulders, leaving only her lighter undershirt on, and wraps the sleeves around her waist. There is no checking herself, only hope that she looks alright. Though, who really cares when

so much stuff is going on? When she feels like she is not too much of a mess, Adora exits.

Everyone outside is gearing up for the final move to Brightmoon. With the castle being the last stronghold of Etheria and the Rebellion, nothing can be messed up. Anyone who can fight or help prepare for the inevitable are working endlessly. Others try to ignore this fact by keeping busy with tasks such as cooking. Adora wishes she could keep her mind elsewhere but she has no such luck, if she wants to call that 'luck'.

Adora finds who she is looking for. Glimmer is with Scorpia and Jewelstar. An odd little group but a nice one at that. The blonde slowly makes her way towards them, the sparkling cape still clutched in her hand. The middle Star Sibling is the first to notice her closing the gap. He gives a small wave with a smile plastered on his face.

"Good morning, Adora. How are you?" he asks.

Glimmer and Scorpia look towards the new arrival to the group. Both girls beam.

"Hey, guys. I'm...doing the best as I can. Like everyone else," Adora replies.

"Did...you sleep alright? You look a little well rested," Glimmer states.

Adora thinks for a moment, running her free fingers through her hair. Being more awake, she definitely can take in the feeling of weights being lifted off of her. They are still very much there, trying to pull her into a depthless darkness, but she better can keep her head above the water. The fabric in her other hand and the scent lingering in her nose helps keep her grounded.

"I guess. Anything is better than nothing, right? And, Glimmer...uh...thanks for yesterday. I'm sorry you had to see me like that."

“It’s no big deal, Adora. I want to make sure you are okay, I’m here for you, always.”

Glimmer’s face becomes the softness Adora has ever seen. Even without her princess powers, her lilac eyes sparkle as brightly as ever. There is a warmth that starts at Adora’s heart before spreading all across her body. It takes everything in her to keep her gaze on the queen and not turn away as her emotions threaten to overwhelm her. The blonde clears her throat.

“How are you holding up? How did you sleep?”

Glimmer shrugs. “Could’ve been better. Mostly ended up doing things so I wasn’t just in my bed.”

“Well, you’ll be able to sleep back in your own bed soon, that might help. Oh! Here, your cape.” Adora sticks out her hand. The queen takes it back, throwing it back over her shoulders. Adora can’t help smile a little. “Looks a lot better on you than on me.”

Glimmer’s face becomes flushed and Adora can see her struggle to maintain eye contact. The warmth in the blonde’s chest grows, almost threatening to burst free out of her chest. She watches the queen straighten herself out before speaking again. “Thank you for it back.”

Adora catches the sight of Scorpia, a twinkle in her dark eyes. The blonde raises an eyebrow. “What?”

“Nothing,” Scorpia replies, trying to hold back a chuckle.

“Glad to see you are doing a little better,” Jewelstar says. “We were going to grab some food before we head to Brightmoon. Care to join us?”

Adora takes a quick look at Glimmer, seeking some reassurance. The queen gives an answer of ‘sure why not’. The four make their way to the little mess hall of the campsite. Unlike the first campsite the blonde one first woke up in, there is not as much food, especially in variety. A lot seems to be food rationed from

Horde soldiers that have defected in order to help stop the destruction from Horde Prime. Adora recognizes in the mix of fruits and greens, dull colored mush stares back at her. It is tasteless and bland, like she is eating cardboard. *Definitely* Horde food.

The blonde finds herself able to eat about half her food, mostly the food from the other kingdoms. Though, she can't help but have some of what her taste buds are used to. Her stomach still protests somewhat but at least it finally rumbled upon seeing the food.

"How can you eat that stuff?" Glimmer asks, pushing her own tray away. The mush of food is the only thing not touched.

"I grew up with it. It might taste bad but it was made to make sure we had all the nutrients and whatnot. It's good when you get used to it, right Scorpia?" Adora asks.

The scorpion princess has a clean try, eyeing the rest of the blonde's mush. Adora pushes it forward. "I take that as a yes."

"It's been a bit since I last had this. The food from Brightmoon and elsewhere is nice and all but this stuff is still amazing!"

"See?" Adora says, looking at the queen. "Scorpia agrees with me. What about you, Jewelstar?"

"I am staying out of this," he replies.

"You're outnumbered then," Adora says, a bit of an imp-like smile on her face.

Glimmer scoffs before rolling her eyes. She pushes her own tray forward towards the scorpion princess. "If you want this, be my guest."

Scorpia does not mind the offer, which only makes Adora chuckle.

Things are starting to become familiar, *too* familiar. Glimmer knows some of these trees, the ones she would climb on or hide from Bow when messing with him. Some of them still have marks from mishaps when training. Have they already passed where she first met Adora? Maybe. How many times did her mother or aunt take her on walks through these parts? Even if she has grown up in these woods, sometimes the area plays tricks on her and makes everything look the same.

There is a rock ledge, temporarily halting the trek to Brightmoon. One by one, the group Glimmer finds herself a part of begin to climb up it. The taller of the batch, like Scorpia, easily are able to pull themselves up. Those with some power to aid them, like Frosta or Entrapta, make up for their short stature with ice pillars or using hair to lift them up. But without powers and barely making it past five feet, this leaves the queen of Brightmoon in quite the pickle.

Damn she really misses her teleportation powers.

"Need a hand?" Adora asks.

Glimmer looks up, the sun momentary blinds her. She winces, squints her eyes to push back the bright rays of light. Blinking, Adora's lean outline comes into focus. With the sun at her back, she is outlined in it's pale, yellow color. It takes Glimmer's breath away. It's as if she is glowing like She-ra once more. The blonde rests on her stomach, one arm outstretched. Between her taller frame and life as a soldier, this must have been a walk in the park for her.

"Thanks," Glimmer replies, wrapping her fingers against Adora's forearm. On the count of three, Adora pushes off the ground, slowly rising to her feet, and begins to lift the queen up. Glimmer does her best to help, using her feet and free hand to push herself up on the stone. Soon enough, she is pulled to higher ground.

“You good? And how’s that hand?” Glimmer asks, noticing Adora slightly hunched over with her left hand on her knee and the other be shake free of pain. After a couple deep breaths, the blonde straightens out.

“Yeah. Don’t worry. Just need to get used to that again but I am fine, I promise. I already pretty much have my breath back. And my hand is fine, just sore.”

Well, she isn’t wrong. Adora seems to be faring better with the trek and is having no real problem using her injured hand. Her feet don’t drag as much and while there is still some weight to her shoulders, it is not noticeable to those that do not know the blonde like she does. Even the lights in her eyes have begun to return, though still duller.

“Tell me if you need a break. We should almost be back to Brightmoon by now but there is no harm in five minutes of resting.”

“I rather just power through it if we are this close to Brightmoon, the faster we get there the better.”

“Fair enough.”

They continue to walk, trailing a little behind the rest of the group. Almost everyone is heading back to Brightmoon, though in groups. Adora and Glimmer walk back with Scopria, Entrapta, Frosta, Catra, and Melog. The groups will be reaching the castle at roughly the same time, maybe only at most an hour apart. Once everyone arrives, it will be time to create some sort of plan to not like Horde Prime take over all of Etheria. Far from the easiest thing and something the queen *really* doesn’t want to think about right now. She doesn’t want to ruin the return back home.

Glimmer searches the horizon, for any signs for the castle. The thick foliage of the Whispering Woods blocks much of her vision. She sighs a little, wishing already to see her castle. She still wonders, though, if she deserves to be back. To sit on the throne

once again and lead her people. After all, her decision to use the Heart of Etheria led to being pulled out of Despondos and right into Horde Prime's hands.

Her footsteps begin to slow.

"What are you thinking about Glimmer?" Adora asks.

"Huh?" Glimmer blinks.

"You seem a little lost in thoughts. What are you thinking about?"

"Way too much. We are almost at Brightmoon and it's just...a lot."

"I get you. It's been far too long since we have been back, hasn't it? You think Sea Hawk burned anything?"

"I sure as hell hope not. I might actually set him on fire if he did that."

Adora chuckles slightly. "I'm sure Mermista made sure nothing happened."

"Oi! Thing One and Thing Two! Pick up the pace!" Catra suddenly shouts. "Or do you *not* want to see your stupid castle!"

Glimmer and Adora snap their heads around, seeing the magicat staring them down, her hands cupping around her mouth. Everyone else stands a couple feet away in a clearing. Both girls can see just past them, the smooth marble of Brightmoon castle. The queen feels her heart nearly leap out of her chest and her legs threaten to come out from under her. They begin to move on their own accord, shaking the whole time.

Everyone makes way for her. The only footsteps she can hear are the even and steady ones of Adora's, each step taking the same length. When Glimmer breaks free from the Whispering Woods, she takes a few more strides before stopping. Tilting her head upward, her breath becomes caught in her throat. Her heart has ceased to beat and the lack of blood flow does not help her

feeling of being faint. Her eyesight has become misty. If it wasn't for Adora, who has come to her side, the queen would have collapsed. The blonde presses up against her, keeping her upright.

The sun, still lingering in the sky, creates a glow that surrounds her home. Brightmoon always has shone brightly, becoming a beacon for all those around. It is just as Glimmer has left it. Standing tall, strong, and waiting for the return of its ruler. The waterfalls from the cliffs behind it that create large pools below glisten, sparkling much like her hair. Her nose is filled with the familiar scent of wet soil and blossoming flowers.

"We're home…" Glimmer breathes out.

Thoughts are abruptly cut off when there is a familiar shout. Adora diverts her gaze from the castle to the pathway in front of her. A pair clad in shades of blue are quickly reaching the group. Mermista and Sea Hawk. Just how long has it been now since she last saw this dynamic duo? At least nothing has been set on fire. The second he is close enough, Sea Hawk wraps an arm around Adora's neck. She flinches both from the sudden pull forward and the fabric brushing roughly against her scar.

"Oh, Adora! It is so wonderful to see you again!" The brunet shouts. Adora can hear the tears in his eyes as she struggles to break free of his grasp, which has become like iron. "I am so glad you are with us once more! Mermista and I were so worried!"

"Sea Hawk! I need air!" Adora gasps.

He releases her, letting her stand up on her own. Adora sighs a breath of relief before saying, "It's great to see you too. Haven't changed a bit, have you?"

"Not at all!"

Adora's eyes shift to the side. Mermista stands beside Sea Hawk. The water princess has never been an easy one to read, to figure out what is going on in her mind. Adora's heart twists in chest, thinking how much the princess has lost. Her kingdom and people to the hands of Catra. Now, it is even further out of her reach with Horde Prime's control and the taking of The Pearl. All of this in such a short period of time. How does she feel about so much lost?

"Mermista I-" Adora starts. She gets cut off when a hand hovers in front of her face.

"Don't," Mermista states.

"But-"

"I know what you are gonna say, don't bother." Mermista lowers her arm. "I know Horde Prime made you do that. You're not some monster who would, like, betray us like that. And it's not like you were the one that made Salineas so easily up for grabs. If I didn't already want to kick Horde Prime's ass, I definitely do now after what he did to you."

"You can say the same thing for me!" Sea Hawk adds on.

"You guys…"

"That being said…" Mermista steps forward, walking past Adora. Without uttering another word, she uses some of her princess powers to lift water from a nearby pool and hit Catra square in the chest. The magicat yelps as she is knocked over. "What is she doing here?"

"You can call her an ally. Don't worry about it, she's been helping us for a while now," Glimmer states.

Mermista studies her for a moment, unsure. Her brown eyes return to the magicat. "You're lucky I need to save my magic, I went easy on you. But don't expect me to let you off the hook or anything."

Catra staggers to her feet, Melog aiding her, coughing. “Wasn’t expecting any less. I’m still not keen on being friends with you all but I am here to make sure no one else dies.”

Mermista scoffs before turning her attention back at Adora and Glimmer. “Well, welcome home.”

The tiny group begins to walk forward, making their way towards the large front doors. Adora does her best to keep her footsteps even, one in front of the other. Her heart pounds against her chest as she takes in all the sights of what she has come to call home. The way the water falls and hits against the pools below. How the marble shines in the new sun. Or the fauna, the birds and small mammals, flying or scurrying about. There is a soft breeze blowing, as if Brightmoon itself is welcoming everyone home and giving a hug. The blonde has missed the embrace.

Nothing stops her erratic heartbeat or the tremble in her hands as the doors are pushed open. Adora’s nose is assaulted by the familiar, flowery scents. It very nearly threatens to overwhelm her. Looking at the queen, her face in utter awe, the blonde knows she feels the same way.

“Did you guys want to return to your room or eat or anything?” Mermista asks. “It must’ve been a long trip and night will be coming soon.”

Adora shakes her head. “I rather make sure everyone else gets her safe and see what the game plan is.”

“Suit yourselves.”

While waiting for the others to come, everyone goes through what they have, adding it to the stockpile of Brightmoon. There is a little bit of nibbling on food. As the missing members slowly trickle into the castle, Mermista and Sea Hawk inform them of the on goings. With no kingdom to return to, that pair have been more than determined to keep Brightmoon safe. Every day they and the royal guards keep their eyes and ears peeled. For the most part,

Horde Prime's forces have been kept at bay but morale and forces are beginning to run thin.

Messages have been hard. They got what they could from the others and pieced other things together. Mermista and Sea Hawk are aware of how much land has been overtaken as well as one of their own being missing. The mention of it makes Adora heart skin to the bottom of her chest. One of the many nightmares that never seems to have an end in sight.

As the sun begins to set behind the horizon, reading itself for a long rest, everyone has arrived. Many want to simply rest and recharge, wishing to take a break for a few hours. Those that stay around all meet in the large meeting hall of the castle. It is an odd feeling to be back in here when the last time Adora stepped foot in this place was during her last spat with the queen. When Glimmer takes a seat at her chair, the one that Angella once owned, Adora debates where to go.

"Somethin' the matter, Adora?" Glimmer asks. She looks at the seat besides her before looking back at the blonde. "Are you gonna sit down?"

Adora shifts on her feet. "Just thinking where to sit," she admits.

"What do you mean?"

Adora chews the bottom of her lip. There is a part of her that *pulls* at her heart to sit besides the queen. Even with some awkwardness around, a lot of it has been put behind them. Still, it feels so wrong to be there with how Etheria stands. She wishes to truly have that seat, be *at* Glimmer's side but she feels like that is not something that is in her grasp. And besides...

The blonde turns her head towards Micah. "That is your spot, isn't it?" she says. "You still hold the title of King. Wouldn't you want to sit besides your daughter anyway?"

Micah does not miss a beat. "That is only a title. Glimmer is queen now. I can guide her from the sidelines but being king holds no

more weight for me. She needs a different second-in-command. Someone she can rely on and trust with her life."

"What about Bow?" Adora says, panicking.

"Leave me out of this!" Bow snaps back.

"Adora, sit. You have my permission." Micah only furthers his point by sitting down at the closest chair.

The blonde huffs, watching everyone else take their own seats. With no choice, Adora settles down at the chair next to the queen. Entrapta, Frosta, and Mermista sit on their designated spots. Micah, Sea Hawk, Scorpia, and Catra take up spots either held by commanders or where Spinnerella and Netossa usually sit. The two have yet to arrive as they fight elsewhere. No one dares to sit in Perfuma's seat.

Once everyone has settled down, the table is lit up, showing off Brightmoon's territory. Bow does some adjustments, putting in his own map from his communicator. In a flash, the hologram changes. While showing Brightmoon, all around it is colored red while the rest green. Hundreds of dots rest on the red side.

"So, do we want to figure out something now or in the morning," Bow starts. "We must all be tired from the trek here."

"What is there to figure out other than we are fucked?" Catra states.

"There has to be *something* we can do," Scorpia says. "Don't you guys never give up?"

"We don't but we need a plan still. Anything is better than nothing," Glimmer says.

Adora remains silent, her eyes locked on the map. Seeing it on a flat, 2-D surface is one thing. On a map that is 3-D, where you can see the elevations and dips in the ground, and where zooming in gives a clear image, it makes the situation so much more real.

So many dots. They nearly give the red shades area a run for their money. Even then, it's not a complete map.

She zooms in on one section. Robots and machines come into full view. All are ready to overrun Brightmoon once they get past the Whispering Woods. Even the forest cannot hold back this big of an army for long. Adora feels what food she got in today threatening to make a reappearance.

Adora wants to do more to help. Without She-ra, without powers, there is only so much she can do with a staff or any other weapon. The memories that linger in her mind don't help. Though, if she can recall some of what she did under Horde Prime's control, can she pull out more? So much is jumbled in her mind, much of it confusing, but could an answer be in there?

Where does she start? Thinking of *anything* she has done twists her stomach. How she hasn't lost her breakfast yet is surprising. Her mind begins to race, flashing images one after the other in quick succession. Burning villages. Leading robots. Attacking and kidnapping Perfuma. Prime.

Prime.

Prime.

She struggles to keep some semblance of control over her thoughts as the back of her neck burns. Adora recalls something about magic, what though? Magic, the runestones...why does he want all of them. If she can just push a little further, she can figure out why. Even if Prime made her do these things, even after telling Glimmer this, the guilt still remains. She *has* to fix this mess.

"Adora!"

The sound of the queen pulls Adora out of her thoughts. One moment, she is standing in the spaceship of Horde Prime, staring at his sickly, growling green eyes. The next, she is looking at

Glimmer's own soft, lilac ones. She finds herself gasping for air and breaking out in a cold sweat.

"Adora. Are you alright? What happened?" Glimmer asks, her voice full of concern. One of Glimmer's hands is squeezing Adora's shoulder.

The blonde struggles to catch her breath enough to string words together. She can feel her body shaking.

"Hey, easy. Breathe. I'm going to rub your back, okay?" Glimmer slips her hand down Adora's back, brushing against the scars that lines her skin. Even with the warning, the blonde winces. But the gentle touch from the queen begins to pull her back down to Etheria.

"I...I was trying to keep if I could remember anything useful from...from my time with Horde Prime…"

"Why?" Glimmer's voice is so soft and so small.

"I just thought...if I could remember something it could be useful...I was in his control for two weeks and I do recall things to see if I could find something to help us."

"Adora…"

"You shouldn't do something that hurts you," Bow tells her.

"We kind of don't have a lot of options, do we?" Adora states.

"Still." Glimmer continues to rub Adora's back, creating small circles against the fabric of her shirt.

Adora taps her forehead against Glimmer for a moment. "I didn't mean to worry you. I thought I could help."

"How about we break for the night," Micah pipes up. "I don't think anyone will be able to think when tired. Resting up and starting fresh tomorrow might be for the best."

No one protests this. As everyone begins to rise and figure out where to sleep, Glimmer keeps her hand on Adora.

"I, uh, was wondering...did you want to stay with me tonight?"

"W-what?" Adora stutters.

Glimmer removes her hand from Adora's back so she can rub the back of her own neck. "You don't have to but...staying together helped with nightmares in the past...and when we took that nap before it was a little better for both of us. So I just figured...You can stay in your room though."

Adora feels her face soften. After what just happened, a nightmare free night (or less of it) would be for the best. "I'd like that."

It feels weird to be back inside Glimmer's room. Since the start of their fights so many months ago, Adora has not stepped foot in here no matter how much her heart yearned for it. Countless nights the blonde stood outside the dual doors, a war raging inside of her whether or not to knock. One side always won. Now, here she is again. There is a mix of feeling at home, like she has been gone for years, and regret, like she doesn't belong here.

"I guess it is good some things don't change, huh?" Glimmer says. Adora watches her wander the room, her hand brushing against everything. "It's just how I left it when you and Bow…" the queen cannot finish her sentence.

Adora sighs through her nose. "I'm sorry about that, Glimmer. We shouldn't have left you like that. We might not've been in this mess if we had stayed."

"We all made mistakes, huh?" Glimmer takes a moment to continue. "Well, if one good thing came out of it, you brought my father back. You have no idea how grateful I am for that."

*At least I did **something** right,* Adora thinks to herself. Her eyes then catch something. "Hm?"

Her feet guide her towards a dresser. There is a lump of soft purple resting there, waiting to be picked up. Adora's fingers find it, the dyed wool of a Plumerian sheep woven into a thick and warm scarf. Adora's mind floods with the memory of late hours, frustrated with each stitch. Days secretly communicating with Glimmer's aunt. The date of the queen's birth drawing closer and closer until it was upon her and she had to give what she finished.

"You still have this stupid old thing?" Adora asks, taking it in her hands and unfurling it.

"Don't call it stupid, you made it," Glimmer retorts.

"Yeah but it is no where near what it *should* be. I still need to make a better one for you."

Glimmer steps next to her, skin brushing against Adora. For a moment, goosebumps spread on her arm and Adora finds the air in her lungs becomes hitched. The queen places her own hand on the scarf, so close to the blonde's.

"You made it yourself and all by yourself. You put your heart and soul in it so it is a piece of you. I don't need a better one. It's perfect as is."

Adora remains speechless, her thoughts becoming too jumbled to pull out any words. She places the scarf back on the dresser, trying to find a way to ground herself back down to Etheria. After what seems like an eternity, she can string something together. "I'm glad you still have it." She begins to rub her wrist.

"Oh! That reminds me!" Glimmer digs into her side pocket and pulls out a familiar piece of jewelry. Adora's eyes widen at the sight of her bracelet.

She remembers bringing it with her when she, Bow, and Entrapta blasted off to rescue Glimmer. She never had it far from her, even after all the fighting. It would be like throwing out a part of her, a part Glimmer was able to give. A sense of security. Slowly, the blonde reaches out and takes the jewelry back.

Something starts to claw its way out of her brain. Adora winces slightly and grasps the side of her head. Glimmer reaches out for her, possibly fearing a repeat from before, but the blonde stops her. The memory is not that of Prime. Rather, she finds herself back at Brightmoon castle, on the ground, and looking at the bracelet in her hands.

There is a fuzziness to all of it but all of a sudden, she sees something out of the ordinary. Like something tore into the fabric of the world, she sees the queen in the Whispering Woods, frightened.

"You had this the whole time? ...I'm remembering something I don't quite understand."

"Yeah I have. What are you remembering?"

"Seeing you in the Whispering Woods. I think when you and Catra tried to save me. But...I am also in Brightmoon castle? It's like I am starting into two different realities…"

"When you did fight the two of us, that did drop out of my bag and you paused. And I remember later when I was able to free you, you were fighting yourself. You broke free for a moment and seemed very confused. Like you *didn't* know what was going on."

Adora thinks, trying to piece everything together. She remembers her time with Prime in pieces. But those slivers of dreams where she is with Glimmer, when she is calling to it, could they not have been dreams? After all, they have been mixed in with her real nightmares. The chip controlled her but could have it done more.

"I think...I think Prime did more than control my actions," Adora states.

"What do you mean?"

"I have other memories jumbled in. Ones I can't explain. And now this? Seeing two things that contradict each other at the same time? And you saying being confused? If I was aware of what I was doing, I'd never have done it. Do you think he could have messed with my mind to make me think I *wasn't* doing it?"

Glimmer thinks for a moment, the gears turning in her head. "Aunt Casta has said of dark magic that could manipulate the mind and create false memories. That could be a thing with the chip. I am not really sure."

"Well, it's at least a possibility." Adora sighs and runs a hand through her hair.

"My dad is right. We should rest. We can think more of it in the morning when we aren't so tired. Come to bed."

"Alright."

The two begin to settle into the bed for the night, switching into some more comfortable pajamas. Thankfully, Glimmer had spare clothing of Adora's in her dresser. The blonde slips into a grey t-shirt, covering her scared back, and a set of boxers. Glimmer puts on a pale, purple tank top and a darker set of pants. Once comfortable, the two lay in Glimmer's bed, though back to back.

This is a little more awkward than when the two fell asleep together by mistake. Adora had no intention of passing out days ago, and now she is. Back nestled in Glimmer’s bed. The one she went to her first night in Brightmoon when sleep was nothing but a myth to her. The one she always goes to when her nightmares of her time in the Horde, from being raised under Shadow Weaver, or of her tumultuous relationship with Catra. How many nights did she just cry in Glimmer’s arms when her brain became too much? Or when the reverse was true and Glimmer was the one needing support? Far, far, *far,* too many to count.

Even with the awkwardness of being so close when their past still was not too long ago, it feels like a hole in her heart has finally been patched. A piece of her has been returned, even if roughened up. All Adora knows is that she does not want to give it up again and do everything in her power to keep it safe from harm.

“G’night, Adora. I hope you sleep well,” Glimmer whispers.

“The same to you.”

Somehow, the queen that rises with the moons is the first to slip into slumber. Adora hears her muttering something but cannot hone in on it. At least now, maybe Glimmer will be able to have a better rest in the safety of her own bed. The next few days will be long and if the queen deserves anything, it's the peace of mind when she is unconscious. Part of Adora wants to stay up to make sure no monsters come from out of the shadows, to protect Glimmer at all cost. But something else keeps her mind running. Something she wishes to say.

Please sleep well, Adora thinks to herself, *I love you so much, Glim. I wish I could do more for you.*

She flips over to look at the sleeping queen. Her tank top reveals the markings on her back. Adora wonders if Glimmer will ever grow in wings like her mother. Is that possible? And what would they even look like? Amazing no matter what, Adora thinks. That is not the only thing that catches her eyes.

Moonlight streams into the bedroom, outlining the ruler of its namesake. To Adora, she looks even more beautiful. Like she is an angel set down by the gods. In all honesty, to Adora, that is a fact. If only she could tell Glimmer that.

Slowly, her eyelids become heavy. The heat coming off of Glimmer and the sounds of her steady breathing begin to lull Adora asleep and soon, it becomes impossible to fight.

Chapter End Notes

Shout out this time is to my friend TheShortestManOnEarth
They write a lot of glimmadora so check them out

Hello My Old Heart

Chapter Notes

I debated posting this tonight but fuck it let's go! This was another bit of a rough one to get thru since there was so much but hopefully yall enjoy a nice long chapter cause it might be a bit for the next to recover. Also another song title lol.

Anyway tw for nightmares and some bit of flashbacks

See the end of the chapter for more notes

She finds herself in staring off at the vastness of her Kingdom. Brightmoon is after all the largest kingdom of Etheria. The Whispering Woods cover much of the land, hiding many secrets within it. There are small lakes that dot the landscape, ones that beckon her to swim in. The gardens and even the meadows make the queen want to take a walk. But duty calls. Glimmer has things to do that cannot be shirk. She spins on her heels and enters her castle.

Life is perfect as can be. There is no longer a war. No more fighting, no more deaths. Glimmer cannot recall how it has ended or why but with the fear of death no longer hovering over her head, that is the least of her worries. All she can think about is how good the next day will bring and what she can do for her people. As she draws closer to the doors, there is a skip in her step. Life is good, her people are happy, her planet is safe, and Adora will be waiting for her somewhere in the castle.

However, as she steps into the room adjacent to the balcony, the one warm air becomes freezing. Goosebumps form on her skin and her breath crystalizes in front of her face. One moment, she is looking at the marble, cool colors walls of her home. Within a blink, she is teleported into the sleek, uniformed ship of Horde

Prime. Her heart begins to pound in her ears and she finds her fright locking her in place.

Echoes of footsteps begin to bounce off the walls. Her breath is lodged in her throat as the sound becomes louder and louder, drowning out her heartbeat. Glimmer squeezes her eyes shut, not wanting to see what draws closer. It does little to ease her fear. Whoever is walking towards her stops. Even unable to see the threat, the queen can ***feel*** *him towering over her. Another cold shiver runs down her spine from his breath on her neck.*

Hello Queen Glimmer.

Glimmer cannot stop a whimper coming out of her mouth. Horde Prime is inches away from her. Her body remains stiff, unable to move in the slightest. Prime's large, cold, sharp hands are placed on her shoulders.

How are you fairing? Are you back on your throne? How is ruling your kingdom? Are you living up to your name?

Glimmer's mouth is dry as the Crimson Waste. Even if she wants to retort and snap back at him but her words are nonexistent. She can hear the grin in his voice as she speaks up again.

Have you failed anyone else? You are queen yet almost all of Etheria is under my rule. Brightmoon will not stand forever. Rather than let your people suffer and have a false sense of hope, surrender now. You don't want to fail them do you?

He squeezes her shoulders tight, his fingers threatening to break skin. He leans closer so he is right by her ear.

You don't want to fail her, do you?

Some unforeseen entity forces Glimmer's eyes open. Staring back at her is Adora. Her dark blonde hair, too short to be held in a ponytail, is slicked back and uniformed. No longer does she wear her signature red Horde jacket. Rather, she is dressed in a pure

white, hooded robe with grey outlines and a black symbol of the Horde on her chest. The worse part, the thing that makes Glimmer want to throw up, are her eyes. They are no longer the same shade as a clear summer sky. Rather, they are a sick, glowling green color.

You already did once...

Glimmer has no idea where she is. The only sense she has is that of *fear.* Her brain yells at her to flee, run, or fight whatever monsters linger in the shadows. The queen attempts to escape and seek security. Something wraps around her legs as she scrambles, trying to find footing, and causes her to fall off whatever she is resting on. Glimmer sees a hard floor racing up to meet her face and there is no time to brace for impact.

However, something grasps the collar of her pajama top. Glimmer's body stops only inches away from the ground before swiftly being yanked back upward. She is pulled onto her back, right into the softness of her bed and blankets. And right besides Adora.

"Glimmer! Are you alright?!? What happened?!?" the blonde asks, panic and worry in her sky blue eyes.

Glimmer gasps, trying to settle her ragged breath. She can hear her heartbeat in her ears again and can feel it in her throat. Her nightmare lingers in her mind. The queen grips her sheets, feeling the smooth blankets against her skin. The orange, dawn light spills in her room through the curtains. Adora remains nearby, resting on her knees. A hand reaches over the queen's forehead and fingers brush against her skin, pushing back her bangs.

"Breathe. Take your time," Adora reassures her.

The queen lets her breathing return to some semblance of normalcy. Adora continues her delicate movements on her forehead, never removing her fingers for more than a fraction of a

second. Once her lungs settle down, Glimmer pushes herself up into a sitting position. Adora shifts her hand to the queen's back and rubs it up and down.

"Did you have a nightmare?" the blonde asks.

"You can say that…"

"Do you want to talk about it?"

Glimmer shakes her head. The last thing she wants to do is relive that again. It is bad enough when she has zero control over her mind during sleep, it will do whatever it wants and mess with her. More in control, she refuses to let that occur. Images continue to swim in her mind, flashes of Horde Prime's ships and Adora back in his tight grasp. As if she is still in it. The queen turns her head towards the blonde. At the sight of her soft, gentle, blue eyes, she is reassured she is no longer in it.

Without saying anything, Adora wraps her arms around the queen, keeping her close. Glimmer can feel her body begin to relax at the earthly, woody scent of the blonde that fills her nose and the warmth she gives off, as if she is a small fire. Nestled in her embrace, a sense of security overcomes the queen. Nothing can touch her as long as she is with Adora. In her fright, she had forgotten the person who gives her the greatest sense of safety was sleeping right besides her. Holding one another after a nightmare has nearly become a lost custom. Glimmer is grateful it has returned.

After sometime, enough that the sky's colors become complementary to one another, Glimmer pulls away. She remains close to Adora as she takes a breath. "Thank you."

"Anytime, Glimmer. Are you feeling any better?" Adora asks.

"Yeah, I am."

"That must've been one hell of a nightmare. I've never seen you jerk like that."

“That is putting it mildly.” Glimmer stretches out her body. “What time is it?”

Adora leans back to get a better look at the outside world. She squints, the gears in her head turning as she does her best to figure out the time with the sun. “My best guess, it’s probably around seven or so.”

“I don’t think I've ever been up this early before.”

“Well, welcome to the world of the early bird.”

Glimmer groans. “Thanks, I hate it.”

Adora rolls her eyes before giving the queen a small nudge. “I don’t think it’s a good idea to go back to bed. How about we head out. Maybe get some coffee also.”

At the thought of coffee, something Glimmer realizes she has not had in quite a long time, she perks up. Enough so she willingly gets out of bed and dresses for the long day ahead. Adora quickly follows suit. Once both are ready, they exit the queen’s bedroom.

The halls are quiet. Glimmer doesn’t believe it has anything to do with how early it is in the day. Anyone who passes by moves quickly to whatever their destination is. They barely stop to acknowledge their queen, at most only giving a small nod before disappearing behind the corner. Glimmer does not bother to stop them, only wishing in her head whatever they are doing they stay well.

There are not many in the dinning area of Brightmoon castle. Neither girl hangs around for long. They grab their breakfast and head into the meeting hall. By the time they enter, Glimmer has already downed all of her coffee. She didn’t even add any cream or sugar and simply drank it straight, wanting to shake the sleepiness from her bones. It, however, only does so much and plopping down on her chair, the queen feels like she could go right back to sleep. Adora seems to have prepared for this and places down the cup she took in front of Glimmer.

“Thank you, Adora,” Glimmer says. She does not think much of it until she takes her first swig. It is not bitter at all. Rather, it is as sweet as can be. Full of cream and sugar. Something that can kick many awake at the sheer sweetest with one taste but to Glimmer, it is like heaven. So many people get it wrong how she likes her coffee and normally, only she knows the exact amounts needed for this correct taste. The queen blinks in surprise before turning her attention to the blonde.

“Did...Did I get it wrong?” Adora asks.

“No! No. It’s actually perfect. I didn’t know you knew exactly how I like it.”

“Phew!” Adora sighs, leaning back in her chair. “I was worried I messed it up.”

“It’s amazing, don’t worry.”

While waiting for the others to slowly trickle in, Glimmer savours her drink. Each sip wakes her up more and more. By the time she is drinking the last bits of the coffee, everyone has arrived. Seats are filled in just like the day before and the map is lit up. If there are any changes, the queen has no idea. Nor does she want to know if more land is lost. With only so many hours having passed, there is not much in the way of updates. To no one’s surprise, there are no ideas on how to gain the upper hand on Prime. At most, the best suggestion is to stay on their toes and keep up with their training.

The meeting is quickly wrapped up and everyone breaks to find something to do. Glimmer and Adora linger behind. The queen wonders if there was any point in the meeting other than making sure no one was killed or kidnapped during the night. She wonders how much training will fair in the grand scheme of things.

“Well, I guess we should train. Did you want to spar with me, Adora? For old times sake.”

Adora rubs the back of her neck as her eyes dart to the ground. “I dunno...I know it’s just sparing but...you know...last time we fought each other I almost killed you. Like, a lot.”

“Hey, hey, hey.” Glimmer places a hand on Adora’s shoulder. “I know you aren’t going to hurt me. We have sparred plenty of times in the past and what? The worse we did to each other was give one another a bloody nose by mistake?”

“I guess you’re right...Still…”

“I know, Adora. I know. But there is no harm in it. ‘Sides, do you not want to get your butt whooped by me? I still have the score in my head and I think I was winning last time I checked.”

Adora snorts and rolls her eyes. “No, it was tied.”

“Then let's break that tie. Whaddya say?”

“Fine.” Adora pauses for a moment. “Though, if we spar, shouldn’t you recharge? You haven’t done that all, have you?”

“No…” Glimmer’s hand slips off Adora’s shoulder. The nightmare from this morning enters her mind once more. Hearing Horde Prime’s dark and menacing voice, reminding her how much of a failure she is. She still wonders if she deserves to have the power back inside of her after letting the world fall apart.

“How about we go recharge. I bet you are dying to get it back.”

“Yeah,” Glimmer lies.

“Then let’s go to the Moonstone. After that we can go spar. Sound like a plan?”

Glimmer slowly nods, not knowing what else to do. Without her teleportation powers, it takes some time to get to the stone. Neither say much as they make their way there. Mindless chatter to just pass the time. They soon arrive at the tower that holds the key to Glimmer’s power. The place so many times in her not that

distant past, did the queen have to stop by to recharge. And here she is again, like she is a princess once more.

The queen stops short of the runestone. She stares up at it, unable to pull her eyes away from the sight of her kingdom's namesake. In the light of the sun, it shines even more brilliantly. The purple, blue, and pink hues glisten, dancing around and creating hundreds of images lasting only a fraction of a second. Glimmer can *feel* it calling to her, her birthright. A tug so strong, it is almost impossible to ignore.

Almost.

She remains still as a statue, unmoving. The weight of the guilt inside of her weighing her down. Glimmer clutches her hands into tight fists.

"Something the matter?" Adora asks, walking up right besides the queen.

"I don't deserve it," Glimmer admits, not knowing anything else to say to the blonde.

"What do you mean?" Adora looks at the runestone before looking back at the queen. "You have a connection to the Moonstone. Why shouldn't you reconnect with it? You're the queen!"

"Yeah but what queen am I that let all this shit happen! To lead my people to all this death and destruction?!?" Glimmer snaps back. "Had I not tried to use the Heart then you never would have had to bring the world back and right into the clutches of Horde Prime. I never would have been captured and you never would have come to save my sorry ass. No one would be suffering if I hadn't done what I did. *You* wouldn't have had to suffer through what you had to endure if it wasn't for me…"

Glimmer chokes back tears as her throat begins to close. She turns away from Adora and the stone, not wanting the blonde to see her like this. The queen wipes her face, struggling to keep

herself together. No need to give the world anymore reasons why she shouldn't reunite with her runestone.

Suddenly, something wraps around one of her closed hands. Fabric and skin against her own glove and exposed skin. Glimmer snaps her head up to see Adora looking back at her as she gives a slight squeeze of her hand.

"Glimmer, you are one of the strongest people I have ever met. I know you only were trying to do what you thought was right. We all were. So, I'm not mad at you for what happened to me. I know what it is like to feel guilty for everything happening. I...I still do myself if I am being honest. But you *deserve* this more than anyone. You are an amazing queen who so many people look up too. I know I do. You're mother would be proud of you."

The lights that struggle to shine at their full potential in Adora's eyes remain as soft as ever. Glimmer's hands slowly unfurl at the sight. Her mind flashes back to her coronation, when Adora and Bow both were at her side, wanting and doing their best to support her in taking the role of queen. Another time she was hesitant to connect with the runestone.

"You really believe that?" Glimmer asks, her voice hushed.

"Of course I do! Now, go on." Adora gives her a small nudge. Glimmer hesitates for a moment before slowly taking the steps towards the runestone.

As she draws closer, she can feel the power radiating off of it. Each inch closer, the more it tugs at her, like it is calling her home. Once she is close enough, she begins to reach out her hand, stopping only centimeters away. The queen looks over her shoulder, seeking reassures. With a small nod from the blonde, she turns back around and places her hand on the smooth stone.

The second her hand makes contact with the runestone, a warmth overtakes her. Her sight is blinded by a bright light that does not hurt her eyes in the slightest. The power given to her at birth

begins to course through her veins once more. Her heart races with excitement as a missing part of her is returned to her. She can even feel an itching sensation on her back, right where her birthmarks are. The same feeling she had upon taking up the role of queen. As fast as it began, it ends. The light fades and all the colors return to her vision. The power inside of her simmers down but remains intact. The queen of Brightmoon has returned.

Adora watches in awe as the light envelops the queen. She glows just like the night of her coronation. The blonde swears she can see the outline of wings once again. Something that would look so amazing on Glimmer. Adora's breath is completely taken away at the sight of her friend reconnecting with her runestone. If only she could take a snapshot of this moment to keep forever and show Glimmer just how wonderful she is.

In a flash, the glow around the queen disappears. Glimmer remains at the runestone for several moments, keeping her hand on it. Adora debates whether or not she should go and join her but Glimmer answers for her. She begins to walk back to the blonde.

"How do you feel?" Adora asks when the queen is closer.

"Amazing," Glimmer admits. She raises her hands and begins to glow in a sparkly, bright light. The queen grins widely before playing around with her powers. Creating different size balls of light that fade away as she lets go. "It feels good to be back!"

"Good, I'm glad." Adora reaches into her pocket and pulls out her staff, letting it reach its full height. "You ready to break that tie now?"

Glimmer raises an eyebrow. "Are you still going to fight with that thing?"

"What do you mean?"

“The staff is good, I know I use one myself but I also have my magic with it. I don’t know how good a staff will be in protecting yourself later down the line. You need something a bit stronger. How about we go to the armory?”

“Um...okay,” Adora replies. She is hesitant to let go of the staff what she has been using for some time now but Glimmer has a point.

Eager to use her powers once again, the queen wraps her fingers around Adora’s arm. A tingling feeling spreads across the blonde’s body as her vision becomes nothing more than a cloud of lilac sparkles. In the blink of an eye, Adora finds herself in the large armory of Brightmoon. Various different types of weapons line the walls or sit on racks and tables. Melee, long range, blunt, sharp, anything under the moons and sun, Brightmoon most likely has.

The pair begin to search around for something for Adora to use in upcoming fights. During their look around, Glimmer finds her staff. Someone must have put it back here for safety. With the queen armed now, it is back to Adora. There is some debate on what to use. Even though being trained in many different types of weaponry, there is one she is always drawn to. It makes her hesitate.

Her hand brushes against the metal of a sword. The hilt is stained in a purple color and at the bottom, a crystal shaped as a crescent moon is implanted. In the reflection of the blade, Adora sees her still unfamiliar self.

“You can use that you know,” Glimmer says. “You are really good with a sword.”

“Honestly, I do but...I don’t want a repeat of what happened the last time we were looking for a new weapon for me.”

“Oh, that. Adora, neither of us knew that that was going to happen. I think if either of us did we would have been a lot more careful. And now we do. So, we will be careful now, right?”

“I guess so.”

“Take it.”

Adora slowly reaches for the weapon. The pattern of the hilt might be different from the Sword of Protection but the feeling of metal against her skin is familiar. As she gently picks it up, it definitely is a few pounds heavier. Something she will have to get used to. She does not move too fast, no sudden movements, and keeps Glimmer in the corner of her sights, making sure nothing happens.

When she finally has the sword in position, she carefully turns around and faces the queen. “You good?”

Glimmer gives a small nod. “I’m good. What about you? Does that feel a lot better than a staff?”

Adora moves the sword around a little, getting used to the new sensation. “Yeah. It is.”

“How about we finally spar again.”

The two head out to locate a place to practice their skills together. At first, they think to go into one of the many training rooms of Brightmoon castle. However, after some debating, the pair agree to spend their time outside. More space and fresh air is always good to have. Others seem to have the same idea so it takes a bit to find a place they can be alone in. A courtyard that only a few no of its existence.

“Are you ready?” Adora asks, hesitant.

Glimmer closes her eyes for a moment, taking a deep breath. She exhales, opens her eyes, and pulls out her staff. “Yeah.”

Adora copies her, attempting to settle her body. It only does so much, yet it is something. “Let’s just take it slowly.”

Glimmer does not disagree. Adora slowly draws out her sword. After a moment, she takes a step forward. The queen moves as well, coming closer to the blonde. Their weapons click together, metal against metal. Adora looks at Glimmer, searching for any signs of negativity. There is none. The queen turns her gaze at her friend before giving a small nod. With confirmation, the pair press on.

It is slow going. Each move the other easily anticipates. A strike downward, blocked. An attempted sweep, someone jumps back and lands on their feet. There always is a moment given for a recovery, to make sure everything is okay. As time passes, the pace is picked up. Adora can feel her heart begin to race in her chest, not from worry or fear but from exhilaration. An adrenaline rush begins to course through her veins. A feeling she has long since forgotten. How long has it been since they last sparred with one another?

At one point, when Adora swings her sword, Glimmer flinches a little too fast. Her staff is brought up to her side in defense. The blonde recoils herself, an image flashing in her head of the injured, frightened queen.

“Are you alright?” Adora asks first, attempting to shake her mind of the thought.

“I’m all good,” Glimmer replies. She inhales through her nose before letting it go. “How about you?”

Adora lowers her sword. She runs a hand through the top of her hair. “I think so. Do you want to stop or keep going?”

Glimmer twirls her staff in her hands. “I won’t lie. I was starting to have some fun. I think I am good to go if you are.”

She thinks for a moment. The rush of excitement lingers inside of her and wishes not to let go of it. To answer the queen’s question, Adora enters a ready stance. A grin flashes across Glimmer’s face before she gets into her own stance. Both resume their match

against each other, slow and steady at first. Bit by bit, they push harder against one another. Whenever one flinches a bit too hard or they think the other needs a moment for their brain to catch up, a breather is made.

They soon begin to lose themselves in the movements. Blocks, swings, trying to trip the other up, both girls seek to break that tie. Glimmer begins to test her magic, more than eager to use it against her friend again. Pale, purple sparkles fly at Adora, who quickly dodges the blast, almost dancing on her feet. The queen begins to play 'dirty' using her teleportation powers to mess with the blonde.

At first, Adora only catches Glimmer's attack at the last moment possible. There is little time to recover before the queen disappears and reappears again. Eventually, her training kicks into high gear. The drop in temperature, the faint noise of crackle, and the hairs of her neck standing up straight. All the little signs of Glimmer coming back into reality. However, it does not work for long.

The next thing she knows, Glimmer hits her staff against the sword. With a swift motion from her wrist, the queen is able to disarm Adora. Her sword is pulled away from her hand, flung in the air, and implants itself in the ground. To add to the defeat, Glimmer points her staff at the blonde, stopping only an inch away from her neck.

"I win," Glimmer informs her.

Adora puts her hands in the air. "Guess I am going to have to try and get that tie back."

Glimmer's eyes twinkle before she pulls her staff back towards her. She gestures with her head towards the fallen weapon. Adora walks over to retrieve her sword, pulling it out of the ground. She begins to brush off the dirt from the tip, using the hem of her shirt.

“Man, that was amazing!” Glimmer states, a chipper in her voice. “And I finally got a head of you.”

“Don’t get ahead of yourself. I’ll catch up.”

“Can’t wait to see you try. I didn’t know how much I needed that. Feels so good. Maybe I can finally beat She-ra one d-Oh shit, I’m sorry.”

Adora grips the handle of her sword tight. How in the world will she ever become She-ra again? Even then, after everything she has done as her, does she want to? But in the back of her mind, the blonde knows that if worst comes to worst, she might have to tap into that power to defeat Horde Prime. How did she become her anyway back in Prime’s control if the sword was destroyed? How can she do it again by herself?

“It’s fine.” Adora says, putting her sword back in its’ sheath. There is a familiar, training tiredness spreading in her bones. “How about we go see what the others are up to. I think that is enough sparring for now.”

The next day goes by uneventfully. A rare moment to breathe. More resting, planning that does not really go anywhere, and some training to prevent rust. However, all of that is shattered in the afternoon. While discussing any idea on what to do and looking at the map uploaded days prior, the doors to the war room brust open, hitting against the walls so hard they threaten to crack. Those in the rooms, such as Adora, Glimmer, Mermista, Sea Hawk, and Bow jump and are quick to their feet. Everyone settles once they realize there is no threat. Just Catra staggering in, out of breath.

“What the hell?” Glimmer asks.

“Fuck, I ran like hell to get here. This place is like a fuckin’ maze!” Catra gasps, her hands on her knees.

“Why in the Gods names are you out of breath?!? Did something happen?”

Catra quickly nods. Still trying to get her lungs to settle down she says, “Yeah. None of ya are gonna like it.” She scans the area. “The hell is Kid Terror?”

“Frosta is with Scorpia and Micah.” Adora slowly rises to her feet. “Don’t tell me that is why you came. *How?!?* ”

“I don’t know. I just heard others talking about it. The Kingdom of Snows has been overrun. Stragglers are starting to trickle in. I figured I should beat the news here and tell you all.”

“Son of a bitch!” Adora slams a fist on the table, the hologram shortening out for a moment. “He is going to be coming here next!”

Adora feels a wave of anger washing over. Almost all of Etheria has been taken over now by Horde Prime. The only thing left standing is Brightmoon. Who knows how long the Kingdom of Snows has been taken. With the way communication can be, it might have fallen before they arrived here. Which only brings the thought of how much time Brightmoon has left into question.

“Okay, okay. Let’s not panic yet,” Bow states, though he cannot hide the shake in his voice. “We need to gather the others and discuss what to do.”

“There is only one thing we can do! Fight! I won’t let my Kingdom fall!” Glimmer says. “I won’t let my people be killed, hurt, or captured!”

“She has a point. We can’t sit around much longer or it will be too late,” Mermista adds on.

Adora groans. She begins to tap away at the control panel. The once green area of the Kingdom of Snows turns red. Now only one area of the map has been left untouched is Brightmoon. Her heart twists in her chest at the sight.

"They're right. We have no choice but we need to still have to come up with *something* . That or we will end up getting everyone else killed." Adora says. "Gods if only I could be She-ra…"

"What do you mean?" Bow asks.

"What good am I if I can't turn into She-ra? And not to mention, the last time I was her, I destroyed things. I don't know how much use I'll be if we ever get close to Prime. He is by far one of the strongest people I have ever met."

"I've known you long enough now to know, like, with or without She-ra you can put up a good fight," Mermista states. "A lotta of us aren't going to be at full power and you probably are the best bet in the way of fighting."

"I still am determined to beat you one day in an arm wrestling match!" Sea Hawk pipes up. He makes a point by flexing one of his arms. "One of these days I will match your strength."

"You were always at the top of the class," Catra mutters.

"And you know how Glimmer and I feel," Bow tells her.

I still wish I could do more. If only I could remember ***something.*** "I appreciate it guys, honestly. I still don't know how much use I will be, though."

"She-ra or not, every little bit will help. We *aren't* going to let anyone else suffer. We need to summon the others and find Frosta." Mermista says. "I don't think she should find out the news of her Kingdom from a stranger."

The halls she walks in are sleek and uniform. They shine a silvery-white color and the noise of her footsteps echo off of the sides. Clones of her elder brother roam the corridors, no one making note of each other. There is work to be done and slacking off is a serious punishment. Those that do not fit into their roles, that do

not help move the machine that is Horde Prime's rule, will either be cleansed or done away with.

There are only a handful of cases of this. Adora recalls one far too familiar clone attempting to break ranks again. For a final punishment, Horde Prime sent his younger brother on a mission. One far out on the front lines to work endlessly to become in his good graces once again. No one has heard from him, nor most of the clones with him, since. Adora will not let that happen to herself. She won't fail her brother.

Adora passes the rooms of those Horde Prime has chosen to keep lock away. Either due to their status on Etheria or possibly wanting to see if they will join him in his light. Some are quite stubborn and hard to crack, such as the plant princess. Never wants to give up it seems. There is no way she can not give in, Adora thinks to herself. One day. She continues to walk the long away through the ship, still refusing to step down a certain hallway. There are many rooms there, despite the shortness, but two of them Adora's body refuses to allow her to revisit. The long way it will stay.

The former protector of Etheria soon arrives at her destination. Two, large, sliding doors stare back at her. The symbol of the Horde painted onto the steel, evenly split in the middle. Adora lifts her hand up and places it on a panel besides the doors. There is a beeping as a light scans her palm. Assured of who is asking for access, there is one more ***beep*** *before the room allows her in.*

Horde Prime waits for her inside. The smile on his face is wide. As Adora draws closer and closer, the leader of the Horde arm rises to his feet. He slowly steps his way down the steps leading to his chair and meets the blonde part way. Right away, Adora bows down to him.

"You continue to do well, little sister," Horde Prime tells her. "Two runestones under your belt and preparations for the rest are being made. Soon, we will have all of them and I shall be able to tap into the powers this world holds."

Adora raises an eyebrow. In the time she has come to work for Prime, he has yet to tell her the true purpose of her missions. She knows taking the lands from the princesses are a strategic advantage. That younger brother of Horde Prime at least taught her well in how to gain an upper hand in a war. However, what she has been working tirelessly towards is a mystery.

"Curious?" Horde Prime asks. He taps a finger on his chin in thought. "You have exceeded by expectation. I knew you were strong and had a great deal of potential within you. I, however, did not realize how much. Maybe I can tell you something in return for all your hard work."

A cold hand is placed on her cheek. Adora's breath becomes trapped mid way in her throat as her blood turns to ice. Somewhere inside of her, a part of her screams to pull the hand away. It only means danger. Yet, she remains as still as can be, not wanting to disappoint her elder brother or show any signs of weakness.

"Magic might not be my greatest strength, dare I say I was born without any unlike many of the Etherians down below. Yet, it is one of the most powerful things in all the galaxies. Etheria, you see, is off the charts."

Adora's heart races in her chest, wanting to break free of its confinement and escape the situation. It, too, is trapped.

'Adora?'

She struggles to focus on Prime's words. A static begins to take a hold.

"All that power...magic, used by lower forms of life...harness...the runestones...the answer. Once in my grasp...tap into what your beloved planet...no one can stop me."

'Adora!'

His hand is pulled away, yet the icy feeling remains on her face. The static only grows louder, drowning out his voice. Adora remains where she stands, refusing to shake even as her whole body wants to break free of the stillness. Horde Prime leans forward, becoming eye level with the blonde. His eyes shine the same, bright green has Adora's own eyes.

'Adora! Adora, please wake up!'

"...little sister...help me achieve that goal...people know your true powers...I...everything you want...pesky Etherians...stand in your way...destroy them, one-by-one, everything you...love..."

In the blink of the eye, Horde Prime disappears and an unconscious, pale, bleeding Glimmer lies in front of her, blood staining the blonde's hands.

'ADORA!'

She wakes with a start. Her body, free to move, flails around as her brain struggles to keep up. Where the blonde is, it is anyone's guest. All she knows is the panic telling her to find a safe place. Adora is about to scramble to her feet when something warm grabs her wrist.

"Woah! Easy!" a familiar voice shouts.

Adora snaps her head around and finds Glimmer staring back at her. The blonde breathes heavily and hears her heart beating in her ears. Her hair sticks to the side of her face from the sweat on skin. She blinks, trying to bring the world into some sense of focus.

"G-Glimmer?"

Before the queen can answer, the image of her bloody and broken enters Adora's mind. Horde Prime's voice follows suit. *'Destroy them, one-by-one, everything you love'.* Without warning, Adora wraps her arms around Glimmer and pulls her into a tight hug.

She buries her face into the top of the queen's soft hair, inhaling her lavender scent.

"Thank the gods you are okay," she mutters.

"Are you okay?" Glimmer asks. "Nightmare?"

"Yes.."

Saying nothing more, Glimmer wraps her arms around Adora and holds her close. The blonde's body, free from the trappings of the nightmare, trembles. She chokes back tears brimming at the edge of her eyes. All of her attention is put on the queen, a rope back to the safety of the ground. It is a slow climb down but eventually, she gets there.

"Nightmares sure are a pain in the ass, aren't they?" Glimmer says once Adora pulls away.

"They can go jump off the cliffs of Mystacor for all I care," Adora groans. She runs her hands down her face, reconnecting her mind to her body.

"You good? Do you need anything?" Glimmer asks.

"I have *no* idea." Adora lets her mind wander for a moment, trying to piece together what went on in her mind. Was it just a nightmare? Or a memory. Already, it has begun to slip from her grasp, words and images seeping through her fingers. Of course, the image of what she did all those weeks ago stays vivid in her mind. Anything else to remember would be better than that.

Swimming through her murky mind, something catches her attention. Her eyes go wide as she removes her hands from her face. Adora can feel the color drain from her face.

"What is it? You look pale," Glimmer says, worry clear in her voice.

“We can’t let Prime get the Moonstone.” Adora turns to face Glimmer. “He *can’t* have it!”

“What do you mean? Isn’t that what we already were trying to do?”

“I remember something. I think...But we can’t let him get to the Moonstone or he will have access to the Heart. He wants all the runestones to get to it.”

Now it’s Glimmer’s turn to go pale. “He’ll destroy Etheria. He’ll be unstoppable.”

“We have to tell the others, now!”

It is a scramble to get everyone to gather in one place. Adora has awoken from her memory nightmare in the dead of night. Many are far from happy to be pulled from their beds and brought into the meeting all in nothing more than their pajamas. Only a handful have some semblance of wakefulness. Adora, alert from her mind betraying her. Glimmer, in her natural hour of activity. Micah, who seems to be where the queen inherited her circadian rhythm from. And finally, Catra, who Adora recalls never sleeping for more than a couple hours at a time.

“No offense, Adora,” Starla yawns, her pet bird fast asleep on her shoulder, “but what is so important you had to wake us all?”

Adora pulls up the map of Etheria. She adds marks to the kingdoms, all expect for Brightmoon. "I think I remember something. Something important."

"It better be for dragging me out of bed," Catra mumbles.

Adora catches it and shoots her a glare. Once she feels the magicat has gotten the message, the blonde addresses everyone once more. "We all unfortunately know Prime is after the runestones. Only the Moonstone is left standing, meaning he is coming here next. The question is, why does he want them?"

More clicking on the dashboard. The map shifts around until all the runestones are seen floating around the planet. Etheria itself does not show any landmass or bodies of water. Only the magic resting inside of it can be seen.

"The runestones are connected to the Heart. Untold amounts of magic are inside the planet. More than enough for a whole army ten times over. And that's his plan. If he gets ahold of all the runestones, he will have access to all that magic and I don't think the gods know what he will do."

Silence falls heavily in the room. Anyone not awake now is as the realization hits them. Even the Star Siblings, who know so little of the workings of Etheria, know this is bleak news. It will be a repeat of their planet.

"Are...are you sure this is what he is doing?" Frosta asks. The youngest of all princesses tries to keep a brave face on but there are visible cracks. She clings to her pajama top, having nothing else to hold.

Adora sighs. "I am as sure as I can be. Which is pretty sure but...it did come to me in a dream. It *felt* real but I can't say it *is* real. But it is the best guess we have."

Big brother instinct kicks in and Jewelstar wraps an arm around Frosta. “We won’t let him get the last runestone, regardless of what he is planning.”

“Do you happen to remember anything else?” Mermista asks. “Anything else to help us actually fight him?”

Adora shuts her eyes. The dream in her mind has all but faded away, only leaving small snippets. Talking to Prime, the static that covers much of his voice. Being on his ship…”I don’t know. I remember I was on his ship with him. My best guess is on where in the world the runestones are, they will be on his ship. He would want them close. As well as...Perfuma…” Adora pauses for a moment, reopening her eyes. More gloom fills the room.

“How did you get on his ship?” Tallstar pipes up. “I haven’t seen it but it has to be around. Maybe hanging around above the planet.”

“That actually is a good point. I don’t remember anything about getting on his ship. Only bits of being here on Etheria and then on the ship.”

“Then there must be a way on.” Glimmer states. “I don’t think there is any way we can rush in on Darla like we did last time. But if you were able to get onto his ship, and if she is sending robots and what not, there has to be *something* connecting the two.”

“I still have some robot heads left. Haven’t been able to look into them much with all the moving we have been doing,” Entrapta adds on. “But! Maybe I can work more and see what is in their memory bank! Surely something has to be in there. I just need some time.”

“Do whatever you can. The second you find something out, tell us. We need to strike first, it’s our best option.” Adora flicks off the map and sits back down in her chair. Indistinct chatter fills the room. No one will be sleeping now.

If things were not already in high gear, it has shifted into overdrive. Every waking moment it's dedicated to preparing for an attack. Land shrinks and a date is set for when to strike. No matter where everyone is at, no one wants to be caught off guard. After a couple of days, their last chance for a miracle looms. Tomorrow will be an all or nothing attack. Entrapta has been working non-stop decoding robotic brains, hoping she can uncover something before the final strike. No matter what is going on, if people are ready or not, it will be time to strike before it is too late.

During this time, Glimmer spends her days readjusting to having her powers once again. Sparring with Adora continues to be slow and steady, only a few moments of letting loose. At this point, any training is better than none. It keeps thoughts neither wants to

think of at bay. Nights have become almost sleepless as the fear of nightmares and what will come the next morning hangs in the air. How anyone can sleep in a time like this, the queen has no idea.

When the day before the attack arrives, someone comes up with an idea. Glimmer has no clue who suggested it or why it spread faster than a wildfire, but it is to have one last get together. One last moment of peace, hope, and life. Boost some morale and for a moment, forget about what tomorrow will bring, even if it is for a moment. There is some hesitancy to the idea. Many are thinking why have something borderline 'party'-like when so much is at stake. Yet, the thought of being able to breathe, having one's spirits lifted, beings to win out. Even the queen starts to fall for the idea.

That night in the courtyards of Brightmoon, everything is set up. A large campfire is created, many surrounding it or the smaller ones that litter the area. Some people play on any instruments they can find while others continue to train. There are bets going on with those that battle against each other. Glimmer is among one of the last to arrive. She quickly locates a group of others to be with. Adora, Bow, Scorpia, and Entrapta.

"Having fun yet?" Glimmer asks as she steps up besides Adora.

"A bit. Still anxious as ever," the blonde admits. She plays with the bracelet on her wrist. "I don't want this to end and morning to come. Ya know?"

"I understand." Glimmer looks around the area. She spots Catra having joined in on those fighting and taking bets. The former Horde Soldier has rejoined others of that broken up faction and seems to be daring them to try and knock her off her feet. It seems like Catra is making good cash from all the bets.

Despite this night supposed to be that of fun, Entrapta has brought one of the heads of the robots with her. However, she still seems to be enjoying herself as she talks Bow's and Scorpia's ears

off about the things she has learned from her studies. Meanwhile, Frosta, Sea Hawk, and Starla seem to be plotting something against the remaining Star Siblings and Mermista. Part of Glimmer wants to know what it is and the other half doesn't want to see the aftermath. She looks back at Adora.

"It is nice to see everyone here trying to enjoy themselves. I can't remember the last time everyone was together like this." Glimmer says.

"It would be nice to have something like this and not be worried about dying or something happening," Adora mutters.

"One day we will have it all the time. Once this is all over we can throw the biggest party the universe has ever seen."

"Yeah. I guess…"

"Hey, I know something that might cheer you up. Wanna see me try out some of my magic. I thought of more ideas."

"Dazzle me."

Glimmer steps forward, clearing a space for herself. She thinks of what she can do. After a pause, the queen creates two balls of bright energy. Without thought, she begins to juggle them, doing her utmost to not drop any. Adora can only roll her eyes, not quite 'dazzled' by the sight. Glimmer begins to add more, beginning to show off. At first everything runs smoothly. When bored she had tried to juggle in the past and is halfway decent with it now. However, she gets a little too cocky.

Instead of just tossing them up and waiting for them to fall, Glimmer begins to move around. She tries to throw a few behind her and with the first few, is able to catch them no problem. But it all comes crashing down on her when the rest of the balls of light smack her square in the face. Light and sparkles becomes the only thing she sees.

The queen winces and a curse escapes her. She quickly rubs her face clear of sparkles and pain. It has been a *while* since she last had her magic quite literally backfire in her face. Thankfully, though, it is nothing more than brief blindness and some irritation. Something to easily brush off and try and forget.

However, something catches her attention. It starts off slowly, someone trying to hold back the wave of emotions inside of them. But it does little to help. In a matter of moments, Adora has burst out laughing, holding her stomach.

"And-And you tell *me* to be-be careful and not show off!" she gasps between breaths. "I'm sorry I'm l-laughing! But-But I-I can't stop! Wh-When the *hell* did y-you learn to juggle anyway!"

Glimmer freezes in places, unable to believe her ears. Adora's face has begun to turn a bright red and the queen can see tears pricking at the edges of her closed eyes. When they do open up, they shine brilliant blue. Her bright, joyous laughter fills the night air, becoming the only sound Glimmer hears. It has been far too long since she last heard it or seen the blonde's face light up so much that it rivals the sun. Even the snort Adora sometimes tries to hide when overcome with laughter has returned and the blonde does little to stop it.

It is *infectious* . One by one, everyone begins to join in on Adora's laughter. Glimmer is not immune either. Her chest hurts from the reaction, having not done it this hard or this long since becoming queen. Tears of joy are forced out of her eyes as well. Hearing Adora's laugh, becoming infected by it, makes the queen feel as light as a feather. For a moment, everything is right in the world.

The laughter slowly begins to die down, only becoming brief moments of delayed chuckles and snorts. As things settle down, the music begins to take back its spot as the main sound in the air. It is upbeat and fast, one to get everyone going and on their feet. A new idea pops into the queen's mind. She turns her sights on Adora, who continues to recover from her outburst. When the

blonde realizes the queen has her focus on her, she takes a breath to calm herself.

Glimmer sticks out a hand. She has no idea what has overcome her but she isn't about to stop it. Adora blinks, surprised. When there is no response, Glimmer gestures a little, telling her to take it. After a moment, Adora does so. However, as the queen pulls her arm downward to place the blonde's hand on her hip, she pulls away.

"I don't think I want to put hands there. Not...not when it is so close to where…" Adora is unable to finish her sentence. She is back to playing with the bracelet on her wrist. "Not after what I did…"

Glimmer takes a breath before stepping forward. She gently takes Adora's hands in her own. Without thought, without rhythm or reason, she places a small, tender kiss on the blonde's hands.

"I won't force you if you don't want to but that is all in the past now, Adora." She rubs her thumb against the dark fabric covering Adora's rough skin, hiding her past deed. "You, your hands, were never meant to harm or kill anyone. They always were meant to protect."

Adora looks down at her cupped hands. Glimmer continues her soft strokes, reassuring the blonde nothing is wrong. After a moment, the blonde gives a small nod before slowly, and still with some uncertainty,placing her hand on the queen's side. Naturally, the two falling into a position together to begin a dance.

Despite the fast tempo, the two start off slow, adjusting to each other's steps, much like when they have trained together. Small steps, the slightest of moving the other, and keeping feet off of each other. However, just like their actions before when sparring, the two start to lose themselves. The music takes a magical hold on them and the world shrinks to just Adora and Glimmer. No one else enters the realm they find themselves in.

The dance they were robbed of back during princess prom is in full swing. Adora has learned a thing or two on how to move to the beats in the air thanks to the queen and at first, is the one to lead. Glimmer does not mind this at all, laughing as she is spun around. For a moment, the blonde spins the smaller girl around and pulls her close to her chest. Both take the chance to catch their breath, both having wide grins on their face.

They reset, continuing their dance. Glimmer can hear the music drawing to a crescendo. She knows this song and knows once it reaches its peak, it will end. The queen will not let this moment pass her by and quickly takes control of the dancing. Having taught Adora how to do so, this isn't the first time she has led the taller girl. What *is* the first time is as the last notes explode into the air, she catches the blonde off guard. Just as the music ends, somehow, she dips Adora down, inches off the ground.

"Holy crap, I didn't know you could do that!" Adora chuckles, her eyes wide. She then raises an eyebrow. "What was that for?"

"I had no idea I could do that either. And what? Can't have a little fun?" Glimmer beams.

Adora wraps her arms around Glimmer's neck. "Never said I didn't enjoy it."

Glimmer's heart begins to race in her chest when she realizes just how close their faces are together. Every atom inside of her *screams* for the queen to tie the dance off with a wonderful ribbon, one that she has wanted for a long time now. She very nearly does, seeing how bright and happy Adora is once again. But the threat lingering over their heads, not knowing if tomorrow will be their last day, prevents her. She wishes not to give Adora anymore pain if she does not return. This moment already is perfect enough.

The two straighten out, standing back on their feet without any aid. It is then they realize everyone in the camp is staring at them.

Glimmer feels her face become hot. A quick glance at Adora, she sees the blonde is equally as flushed.

“Nice job stealing the show. Least you two are entertaining,” Catra pipes up.

Adora sits away from the party, needing a break from everything going on. She finds herself near a small stream that cuts through the courtyard of Brightmoon, giving life to many of the plants. Looking into the crystal clear, babbling water, the blonde can see small, purple minnows swimming about with no care in the world. Her sights then turn upward.

The stars twinkle back at her, much like they did in her visions as a baby. Their beauty still takes her breath away and reminds her of the glittering hair of the queen. Honestly, Adora has no idea which she loves more. Both are so amazing in their own rights.

The sounds of footsteps drawing close pulls her away from the lights above. Glimmer gives a small wave as she comes closer. Figuring she must be just as tired from all the excitement of tonight as well, Adora shifts to the side and pats the ground besides her. Without uttering anything, the queen sits down next to her. She turns her head upward, Adora following suit, and stares up at the hundred of thousands of far off stars. Neither girl says anything right away, simply soaking in the sight of worlds above them.

“Think you will be able to sleep tonight?” Adora says, finally breaking the silence.

“No. You?” Glimmer replies.

“Nope. I only hope we are able to do something. It’s all or nothing and if we mess up, that’s it. There is no going back or second chances. It’s really scary.”

“Being backed into a corner will only make us fight stronger, right?”

Adora sighs. “I guess so.” The blonde pauses for a moment before turning her gaze at the queen. “Hey, Glimmer. If we don’t make it back I want to say...Thank you. For everything.” More words remain trapped in her throat. Those she wishes to say, especially after that dance tonight. Yet, the only will be like knives to the queen if there is no tomorrow for the blonde.

Glimmer shifts her gaze back onto her friend. “The same goes to you, Adora. When we make it back, there still is a long road ahead of us but, I am more than happy to be on it with you.”

Adora smiles. “How about we talk about something else. This ‘party’ is supposed to boost morale and I don’t want to lose what I got.” She looks back at the stars. “They are wonderful, aren’t they?”

“Yeah. It’s all thanks to you we can see them now. Can’t believe we went so long without them. Not as wonderful as you though.”

Adora feels herself become warm. “I only remember so much of them but seeing them in real life, I never thought my breath would be taken away.”

“You really love them, huh?” Glimmer gives the blonde a nudge with her shoulder. “Should I start calling you ‘Starlight’?”

Adora gives her a small shove back. “If we are giving each other dumb nicknames should I start calling you ‘Glitter-bug’?”

“Where the hell did you get that from?” Glimmer chuckles, baffled.

“Because you do glitter and I don’t know. Adding ‘bug’ to the end sounds nice and cute, like you.”

“Oh my gods,” Glimmer groans. This makes Adora chuckle. Her chest has begun to ache from how much laughter has come out

of her today. It feels good. Good to enjoy herself again. Good to be back at the queen's side, not giving a damn in the world about what others think of them. Good to have the person who means the universe to her back. No one knows what tomorrow will hold or if she will ever see Brightmoon castle or anyone else ever again. But what the blonde does know is she will do anything to protect Etheria and her loved ones. Do anything to protect *Glimmer.*

But that is something to think about later. There is no need to consume her mind when things are so bright and good right now.

Adora gently places her head on Glimmer's shoulder. She feels the queen jerk slightly at the gesture but quickly relaxes. In response, Glimmer tilts her head, resting it on top of the blonde's. Hands slowly inch towards each other. Fingers lock together perfectly and each give the other a squeeze of reassurance. Neither remove their hands from their position as they keep their eyes up at the universe above them.

Chapter End Notes

This chapter's shoutout is for Bluest_Yeehaw42 who is writing a Scorpia she-ra fic and has some other ships fics like Glitra as well. Check him out.

Kudos and comments are appreciated

(and yes I stole a line from fma)

Dawn of The Final Stand

Chapter Notes

> coming to an end, it's been a long road. Anyway, I know the next chapter won't be coming out as quick as...ya know. Anyway, enjoy and tw for this is minor blood mention and some panic attacks

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Dawn. The sun begins to claw its way out from under the ground. Brining with it an orange glow to push out the dark, starlit sky. Following close behind is a shade of blue. Birds sing their morning song. At first glance one would think nothing of this moment. You can even say that it is the perfect way to begin your day. That upon waking up and soaking up the sunrise, there is nothing wrong in the world. However, that can’t be further from the truth.

As the light slowly takes over the world, reality is revealed. An untold amount of Horde Prime forces march on the ground, stopping for no one. Anything in their way is brought to their knees. Smoke billows from villages, hundreds hide away in fear of their life, and some try to fight back only to be cut down. Hell has been torn wide open and spills out everything inside of it onto Etherian soil. There are no signs of it closing any time soon.

The kingdom of Brightmoon remains standing tall. Threats are closing in and at any given moment, there will be an assault it will not be able to withstand. Once that occurs, there will be nothing left to defend the residents of Etheria. Nothing left to stop the magic from being pried out the center of the planet. If anyone wants the peaceful moment to be real and not nothing more than a lie, a final stand must be made. And today is the day.

Glimmer slips on the silver armor, the coldness a familiar weight against her shoulders. She twists her wrists, adjusting the cuffs and ensuring it will not cut her skin. The queen examines herself,

having not dawned the protective metal in quite some months. Some nicks shine in the light, reminding her of the dangers ahead. When everything is in order and knowing nothing will slip off of her mid-battle, she reaches for her staff.

She stares at herself in the mirror, taking in her reflection. It looks like a queen has geared up for battle. One ready to fight alongside her people and defend them to the very end. A queen who has been through trial after trial and always came out the other side, despite being beaten and battered. Glimmer holds the staff tight in her hands, her knuckles threatening to turn white. With any luck, today she will live up to the person looking back at her.

Knock! Knock!

Glimmer turns her head towards the noise. She finds her father and aunt standing in the doorway. A soft smile is on both their faces but the queen can see in their dark brown eyes a sadness. Glimmer places her staff against the wall before walking up to her family members. The trio embrace each other tightly. When they pull apart, Castaspella cups her hands against her niece's cheeks.

"I am so proud of you, Glimmer," she says. "Please come back to us safe and sound."

"I will do my best, Aunt Casta. You two do the same here."

Glimmer and others will be going off to figure out a way onto Horde Prime's ships. Her father and aunt will remain here, defending Brightmoon when the inevitable attack occurs. The thought of heading out on a mission and coming back to find family members no longer in the world of the living sends shivers down her spine. She does not want to relive that all over again.

"We will."

Castaspella moves out of the way for her older brother to say his words to his daughter. The older sorcerer places one of his hands under her chin, gently pushing it up so they look each other in the eyes. "You have no idea how proud I am of your, honey. I always

knew from the second you were born, the moment I held you in my arms, you would go on to be a wonderful queen. You have surpassed all my expectations."

"Dad…" Glimmer's eyes become misty.

"I'm sorry I was not there most of your life. But I will be here for you when you, Adora, and everyone else comes back and Etheria is free once again. Still, as your aunt said, stay safe. You're my little girl after all, even if you are the queen." He places a kiss on her forehead. "If you are ready, you should go meet up with the others."

Glimmer nods. Grabbing her staff, she heads out with her family to meet up with her group. Besides her, those attempting to go onboard Horde Prime's ship are Adora, Bow, Entrapta, and Catra and Melog. Glimmer and Adora chose to go on this mission as those the most affected by Horde Prime. The queen wants payback for what he did, especially with what happened towards the blonde. Adora herself wanted to ensure no more harm is brought to the queen.

Entrapta still is the best way to find a way onto the ship and with Bow's technical help, something surely can be figured out. Catra, on the other hand, is some extra fighting power. Having been on Horde Prime's ship before, she has some knowledge of the layout. Melog is always good to have for sneaking around. It's a hell of a group but one that has been (semi) formed before.

When Glimmer enters the meeting area, she only finds Bow, Catra, and Melog. Bow is busying himself with counting his arrows and putting each type in the correct area of his quiver. There are some the queen does not recognize. He has his own set of golden armor on just like in the Battle of Brightmoon. However, this time something covers his lower half. All precautions are in place. Meanwhile, Catra keeps on her clothing from before, no signs of protection anywhere.

"Shouldn't you have a little more protection?" Glimmer asks.

“Probably but decided not to. I never wore it when in the Horde. Having it now will only slow me down and I rather be quick on my feet. Don’t want me to die, Sparkles?”

“I don’t want anyone else to die, honestly.”

“Well, thanks for caring. I’ll try not to be too much of a pain in the ass.”

“You have been doing a pretty decent job at it so far.” Glimmer looks around the room. “Where’s Entrapta and Adora?”

“Robo Brain is still working. Someone is going to have to drag her out of what she made her lair soon. As for Blondie…” Her head tips to the side, eyes looking over Glimmer’s shoulder. A cheeky, sharp tooth grin spreads across her face.

Glimmer follows her gaze. Sure enough, Adora has entered the room. Like her friends, the blonde has suited up to protect herself from what is to come. A dark gold color and protects her front and back, the most important parts and hopefully keeping any more scarring on her skin. Her shoulders and parts of her arms are covered as well. Her new sword rests at her hip, ready to defend. Her posture has straightened and the second she sees the queen, she flashes a small smile.

“How do I look?” Adora asks.

“Absolutely stunning,” Glimmer replies, unable to pry her eyes away.

“Knew you would have that dumbass look on your face when your knight in shining armor arrived,” Catra whispers under her breath, just loud enough for Glimmer to catch it.

The queen turns to her and mouths *‘I will fuckin’ kill you, shut up.’* This only makes the magicat laugh. Glimmer grumbles before facing Adora once again. However, Catra is right. Adora definitely looks like a knight out of her favorite stories. It brings a smile to her face.

They all settle down, sitting around the table. Chatter quickly arises, mostly recapping on what this little group will be doing. With no word on how Entrapta is fairing (a guard as been told to go grab her), the only thing anyone can rely on is sheer dumb luck or if by some miracle, Adora's memory on how to get onto Horde Prime's ship reemerges. Neither have a high percentage of occurring. No one wants to say that outloud.

Micah and Castaspella do their best to assure everyone and give their best advice. However, there is little time to waste. The group is about to leave, see where the hell Entrapta is, when she comes bursting through the door. The guard sent to retrieve her appears shortly after, clearly out of breath.

"I FIGURED IT OUT!" Entrapta shouts. Held high up in her hands, is one of the heads from Horde Prime's robot army. She slams it down against the table. Her reddish eyes are bright and a grin goes from ear to ear. "I finally cracked it!"

"Wait, really?!?" Glimmer asks.

" *Well* , mostly." Entrapa whips out her comm-pad with one of her ponytails. "I cracked it, yes, however only so much. I have a weak signal and general idea on where to go. We can at least get to that area and go from there!"

"That is far better than where we were this morning. Show us," Bow asks.

Entrapta nods and quickly sets up the map she has created. A familiar yet a bit of a hike area appears. The older princess explains the rough idea she has of where their goal is. It is a large spot of land. It will take time to search. Who knows if the place is teeming with robots. Regardless, they are a step closer to beating Horde Prime.

Entrapta shuts down the map and pockets her device. "I could pinpoint it more if given more time."

“Which is what we don’t have,” Glimmer states. She reaches for her staff. “Let’s go kick some Prime ass.”

It’s time to part. Adora stares up at the castle that became her home, that *is* her home. More than the Fright Zone ever was in her childhood and most of her teenhood. Try as she might to push it back to the far reaches of her mind, she knows this might be the last time she will lay eyes on it. If only this moment could be frozen in time. Even if she doesn’t make it back, the blonde finds some hope in the thought of it remaining standing and everyone in Etheria becoming free once more. As long as everyone ends up safe and sound, that Horde Prime is no longer a treat, then she will be happy no matter what. She inhales deeply.

“Adora?” Micah’s voice brings her out of her thoughts. She turns around and faces the older sorcerer. “Are you ready?”

“Tch. I am as ready I can be. Which isn't a lot,” Adora answers.

“You will do well, I know it. All of you will.”

“I’ll do my best. You stay safe also, Micah. You just came back after all.”

“The same goes for you, Adora.” He reaches up and places a strong hand on her shoulder. The older sorcerer gives a reassuring squeeze as a smile, so much like Glimmer’s, spreads across his face. “I expect all of you to come back so we can all have a true celebration. Do take care of each other while out there.”

Take care of each other…

Adora is momentarily sent back in time, to when the world was barely holding itself together. Angella stares back at her, giving her a soft kiss on the forehead before giving the ultimate sacrifice in the name of Etheria. Back then, back when Glimmer took the throne, she did everything in her power to hold true to that

promise but watched everything crumble around her. She refuses to let that happen again.

"I will, Your Highness. I promise."

"Good."

Without warning, he wraps his arms around her abdomen and pulls her into a tight hug, nearly crushing her. Adora is beginning to wonder how she hasn't gained any broken ribs yet. However, this isn't like when Scorpia or Sea Hawk embraced her. There, it was an overcoming of emotions, ones that her friends could not keep contained. This is more comforting. One to tell her in the end, everything will be okay.

He pulls away slowly, releasing the blonde from his grasp. With one last reassuring look, Micah walks off to find his sister and ready Brightmoon for an attack. Adora watches him go, disappearing between the castle doors. Once he is gone, the blonde takes one last look at the palace, shining in the sunlight in. After getting some fill, she heads off to meet with the rest of the group heading to Horde Prime's ship. Everyone has gathered around at the edge of the Whispering Woods.

Nothing is said as they make the last preparations, checking they have all their gear on them. Swords, staffs, arrows, whatever they might need. Entrapta is the only one not armed, stating that she never learned and just used her smarts. With Bow going to help locate the runestones on the ship and figure out a way to disable Horde Prime's army, he will have to be her bodyguard as well. Catra and Melog will accompany Adora and Glimmer in freeing those trapped on the ship. Who knows how many are on board.

Only one question remains. How to deal with Horde Prime. There *will* be a fight. No way can anyone prevent a battle. Being on his ship, his armies nearly in control of all of Etheria, and having destroyed so many other planets, there is no way he can escape. He must be stopped in his tracks once and for all. No one has an idea how this will work. At best, the only thing brought up is once

everything is in order, when the runestone is secured and people are freed, everyone makes a final stand. How to ensure that will happen, no one has an idea.

First, though, they need to get *on* the ship and not die trying. With everyone now ready, it is time for the start of their mission. Glimmer will teleport them close to the area. She neither has enough magic or practice to bring so many people such a distance away and the queen needs to remain on the top of her game. Once they travel there, it is a walk and search.

"You *sure* you can do this, Glimmer?" Adora asks.

"I think so. Don't got much of a choice, now do I?" Glimmer replies. "Let's get this over with."

Adora reaches for Glimmer's left hand, giving it a reassuring squeeze. Bow takes her other while Catra and Entrapta each take a shoulder. Melog presses up against the queen's legs. Once everyone is touching some part of her, Glimmer shuts her eyes. Her own hand holds Adora's as tight as possible as a light cloud of lilac sparkles encases the group. The blonde's body tingles as she is pulled out of reality. Just as quickly it starts, it ends. One moment, everyone is at the edge of the Whispering Woods and the next, they are deep inside it. Some place Adora does not quite recognize yet, has a strange feeling of déjà vu.

Glimmer suddenly groans and her legs come out from under her. Adora reacts quickly, catching her before the queen can collide with the ground. The queen's eyes have a sudden fog covering them.

"Are you okay?!?" Adora asks. She helps steady Glimmer back to her feet. However, she keeps her hands on the queen in case her legs fail once more.

"I'm good. I swear." Glimmer tells her. She runs a hand through her hair, gathering her bearings. She blinks, her eyes refocusing. "I just need a sec. That was a lot."

“We don’t really have time for this,” Catra informs the others.

“I just need a minute, that’s it.”

“Go keep watch, Catra. You can warn us if anything is about to jump us,” Adora states.

Catra blows a tuft of hair from her face before walking off, Melog at her heels. Entrapta begins to wander around, her nose buried in her comm-pad as she tries to figure out some way to the location onto Horde Prime’s ship. Bow, meanwhile, pulls out an arrow and arms himself, remaining near his two friends.

“You don’t have to look so worried about me. I’m just a little dizzy,” Glimmer says.

“I am allowed to worry about you!” Adora replies. She places a hand on her cheek, rubbing a thumb against her skin. “This is a dangerous mission and anything can go wrong. I don’t want to see you get hurt again.” *I don’t want to lose you.*

“You really are my knight in shining armor, huh?”

The queen says this under her breath but Adora is able to make it out. “What?”

“Nothing. Look, I’m already starting to feel better.” Glimmer pulls away from using Adora as a crutch and stands on her own two feet. There is a slight wobble to her stance but overall, she remains alert as ever. “Catra is right. We need to keep moving. We are sitting ducks out here.”

“Okay. But tell me if you need anything.”

“I will.”

Their trek continues. Entrapta leads the way, still trying her best to get a better idea on where their goal lies. Bow is close behind her, ready to fire at anything that might be a threat. The rest brings up the rear, all keeping their eye and ears peel and

covering one another's blind spots. At any odd noise, even if it turns out just to be a squirrel rustling the leaves as it jumps from branch to branch, causes someone to jump. As they move further and further into the woods, their nervousness does not go to waste.

A noise catches everyone's attention, even Entrapta who pulls her eyes upward. Adora quickly pulls out her sword, just in time for several robots to break through the brush. No one misses a beat. Bow fires a number of arrows. They explode on impact, metal flying in the air. Glimmer uses her staff to direct her magic at a section of robots. Most fall to the ground in a broken heap. Adora takes the rest of the group out with several quick sweeps of her sword, barely ducking under a sharp arm of one before destroying it. Catra, quick on her feet, finishes off the stragglers.

"Damn," Adora says, panting slightly, "I wonder how many more we are going to be seeing."

"Hopefully not too many. I *so* don't want to keep dealing with these bastards," Glimmer admits. She turns her sights on Adora. "Hey, are you okay?"

"Hm?" Adora raises an eyebrow. When the queen taps the side of her face, she copies her. Her fingertips come back red. "Oh. Guess that bot actually got me. I'm good, just a scratch."

"It's small enough I think I can fix it. Can I?"

"Only if you want to."

Glimmer reaches up, her hand a light blue. What magic latches onto Adora's body is cool like a spring breeze. She feels her skin attempting to stitch itself back together. The best it does, however, is scab over.

"I think that's all I can do," Glimmer tells her.

"It's more than enough, thank you."

“Yuck,” Catra sticks out her tongue.

They continue onward, looking for anything that could be on the way to the ship. No one has any idea if the ship actually has landed on Etheria and is cloaked. Maybe it is still up in outer space and there is something to teleport someone there.

It begins to feel like they are walking in circles. Entrapta has no luck at all pinpointing anything. All she gets is static. Walking around does not change it in the slightest, not giving any clues if they are close or not. There are several more skirmishes with robots, all of which are won. A few times, the group sneaks past some, not wanting to waste any energy or ammo. It feels like the precious hours are beginning to drag on.

“I hope everyone is going okay back at Brightmoon,” Bow says, breaking the silence that has built up around the group.

“No news is good news,” Adora replies. Though, no news also is *bad* news. No idea what is going on is not the best feeling in the world. Just knowing everyone is alive or that Brightmoon is still standing would ease the worry growing inside her chest. Everyone has to be feeling the same thing.

Adora slowly begins to take the lead, looking high and low for anything. “Anyone see *anything?* ”

“Nope,” Catra answers her. “I don’t even see any more robots. Maybe we are going in the wrong direction?”

Entrapta has begun to hit her comm-pad against the palm of her hand in some feeble attempt to get it working. By the look on her face, it is not doing anything at all. Bow ends up taking it from her and tries himself for luck.

“I know for sure I have the right area! If only I could have had more time to dig deeper in that robot’s mind,” Entrapta grumbles.

“You did fine, Entrapta. This is more than helpful,” Glimmer reassures her. “Adora, you see something?”

Adora doesn't respond, barely even registering what just was spoken. Her eyes scan the forest, locking on nothing in particular. She moves without thought, letting her feet guide her around the thickening foliage. The sense of déjà vu she had previously begins to grow. Her mind refuses to give her an answer for how she knows this place. The blonde brushes her hand against the thick, broken bark of a tree.

"Etheria to Adora!"

This finally snaps her out of her thoughts. She looks over her shoulder to see Glimmer giving her a small wave.

"Sorry, I was lost in thought. I think...I think I know this place."

"Really?!?" everyone says in unison.

"Yeah." she looks back at the area, squinting her eyes for a better look as the sun streams through the gaps in the canopy. "I don't know if it is from maybe being close or for another reason."

Their search intensifies. Nothing is left unchecked. Yet, nothing is found. The feeling of being here before remains inside of Adora. Her gut is pretty much yelling at her that this spot is meaningful. That someone is here and it isn't a waste of time to look around. But as time drags on, things start to look bleak. The group is actually just about to give up and move on, look in another section, when Melog makes a nose.

Everyone looks towards the alien cat. They are pawing at a lump of dirt, vines and leaves are mixed in. The group is quick to join in, digging away. In a matter of moments, a large, silvery pad is revealed.

"Is this...Is this it?" Bow asks. He looks at the blonde.

"I think? I don't really know. But what the hell else could it be?" Adora answers. "Now the question is, how does it work?"

“Well I am not going to stand around waiting for your brain to remember something,” Catra states. She jumps onto the pad before stomping on it. “C’mon you stupid piece of shit. Work. Or are you too much of a fuckin’ chicken, Prime?”

“Catra, what are yo-”

Before anything else can be said, a bright, green light encases Catra. The magicat yelps, surprised that her idea actually worked, before disappearing. Melog begins to whimper, circling the pad before hopping onto it themself. Like Catra before, the alien cat disappears in the light.

“Welp...I guess we got our answer…” Adora states

This is nothing like when she teleports. When the queen does it herself, the tingling sensation is a welcoming one. It sure as hell tickles but it's warm. This one, however, is cold, just like everything else about Horde Prime. The second she enters it, Glimmer wants to leave it. Yet, the place that becomes her escape from this teleportation is just another layer of hell.

Horde Prime’s ship is just like she remembers, despite wishes not to. Sleek, cold, uniform, dangerous. It is far, far too quiet, as if there is no life on this ship. The queen finds a window nearby in this room she does not recognize. Drawing closer to it, her heart skins in her chest. Below is Etheria. All around the planet and moons, are ships. Small and large, all looking intimidating. She swallows a growing lump in her throat. There is no time for fear now.

Once everyone is in the near empty room, the last group meeting occurs.

“Entrapta, do you need anything else to help try and locate the runestones?” Adora asks.

The older princess has already ripped off a panel and has plugged wires into her comm-pad. “Nope! Already working on cracking the coding to find the map. Will you be okay without one?”

“I think we can find our way around. Bow?” Glimmer looks at her best friend. No words are needed. She can see the anxiety in his face. The risk of being the last time they see each other is great. What can you say when faced with something like this? Nothing. Nothing at all.

The only thing one can do is hold their loved one close. The lifelong friends embrace each other, squeezing as tight as possible. Bow shifts his eyes towards the blonde and lifts an arm for Adora to fit in where she belongs. The trio that has been through so much the past year and a half, who have struggled to stay together towards the end, has been reunited only to be ripped apart in such a short time.

"I expect to meet you back on Etheria," Glimmer tells Bow when they pull away. "Stay safe, please. You and Entrapta both!"

"I will, Glimmer."

"Don't you worry. We will get the runestones back before you can say *pneumonoultramicroscopicsilicovolcanoconiosis!* ” Entrapta states.

Bow turns to Adora. “Stay safe, please.”

“I’ll do my best. You stay safe as well.”

There are no more words to be spoken. No one wants to part, not knowing what will come next. But there is a mission at hand. Other to be saved. With a final look and farewell, the group splits apart.

Standing near Melog, Glimmer, Adora, and Catra become invisible as they travel around the large ship. Everything looks exactly the same. There is no way to tell one winding hallway from the other. Many rooms they either cannot get into or contain nothing. Did

Prime purposely make these rooms just to throw off would-be escapees or attackers?

Every step they take, the faster Glimmer's heart races. The first time she was on here, she was held prisoner. She was forced to watch Horde Prime attack her planet, attack her loved ones, nearly *kill* Adora. That moment replays in her mind vividly. Sitting at the table with food she could not put a name too. Adora up on the screen, scared for her life, about to be cut down by a robot. The queen could not stop the words ripping their way out of her throat.

' *Stop!* Don't hurt her! ´

The thought of losing Adora was too much to handle. Despite all their fighting up until that point in time, the blonde held a special place in her heart. One even now she takes a hold of. Glimmer was willing to give up everything, even knowledge about the Heart of Etheria, the most dangerous weapon in possibly the universe, to save the girl she hurt.

'You *can't* hurt her.'

Tears had streamed down her eyes afterwards, knowing what she just did. Knowing the jeopardy everyone already was in and how much more they were in now. But how could she help herself? Not when Adora was about to cease to be in front of her. Not when there was so much still left unsaid and how much the queen wanted to hold the blonde back in her arms.

But then that accursed second time happened.

Her mind threatens to rip itself apart at the thought of what happened. The failure of a rescue mission. Watching she who stole her heart slice up her leg and punctured her stomach.

Glimmer feels like she is about to be sick.

There is nudge. Glimmer snaps her head up. In the cloak of invisibility, she can still make out the group. Adora's sky blue eyes

stare back at her, soft as ever. They cannot say anything or risk altering anyone that might be lurking around. Pausing for a moment, Adora taps her forehead against the queen's. Glimmer has to remember Adora is as safe as she can be right now and is no longer being controlled. She is *here.*

They continue onward. There continues to be no luck. As they turn a corner, a set of clones begin to walk by. Everyone quickly presses themselves against the wall, trying to make themselves more invisible. The clones slowly make their way past the hidden group, almost painfully slow. Out of the corner of her eye, Glimmer sees Adora placing a hand over her mouth and squeezing her eyes shut.

Beads of sweat have formed on her forehead, her face pale, and the blonde can barely stifle a whimper. Her body is stiff, statue-like. The queen can see Adora struggling to keep her breathing in check. Carefully, Glimmer reaches down and squeezes the blonde's free hand. Her eyes snap open and there is no way to hide the fear in them. Adora looks at the smaller girl, hand still covering her mouth. Glimmer gives a small nod. Her thumb begins to stroke the top of Adora's hand, reminding her she is here.

Once the clone pass by, a moment is given to sigh in relief. Adora never removes her hand from the queen as she allows herself to breathe normally. They press on, weaving in and out of halls. Everyone is about to give up trying to find something when they pass by a hall.

"Stop! Stop!" Glimmer whispers.

"What?" Catra asks.

"You don't remember this? Look!"

"Wha-Oh…"

This is where she was held captive. Where she did not know if she would see tomorrow or what the state of her home was. An icy chill runs down the queen's spine.

“Are you going to be okay?” Adora asks.

“I’ll be fine. I’ll be fine.” Glimmer repeats over and over again. It works a little bit. “Let’s go.”

No one protests. Nothing is around, not even any clones. Maybe there are more areas to hold others? Or maybe for whatever reason, he moved anyone he took? Why is this place a never ending maze of nightmares?

Towards the end of this hall, a wall blocking any further movement, lies one more cell. A green, transparent door keeps whoever might be inside trapped. The three take a peek inside, not expecting anything at all. That is far from the case, though.

Inside the cell, sitting all alone, hands tied, and staring at the ground, is Perfuma. Glimmer’s heart nearly leaps out of her chest at the sight of her missing friend. Seeing her alive and breathing and relatively unharmed by the looks of it. There is no way to know that until they get inside. Besides the door sits a hand scanner. There is nothing else that could be a key to opening this door.

“So, how the hell are we supposed to get this thing open and get Flower Crown out?” Catra asks, keeping her voice low just in case.

“Only Prime and a select few clones could open things,” Adora tells them.

“So what, are we supposed to kidnap a clone and make them open it for us, hoping they *can* do it?”

“I don’t really have any other ideas.”

Glimmer studies the deceive. Between her time with Bow and Entrapta, she has come to learn a little bit about technology but this is far out of her reach. She wonders if that is the same case for the two tech savvy members of their group.

“Were you ever able to open things, Adora?” the queen asks.

“I...Uh…” Adora begins to rub the back of her neck. “I think so? I remember with that nightmare the other day opening something up. Maybe I was able to do others but I have no idea if I still can.”

“It’s that or trying our luck with a clone. Which has a laundry list of problems compared to you trying.”

“You know if we get this wrong, this place is going to be swarming with clones, right?”

“I believe in you.”

“It’s our only shot. Do it,” Catra says.

Adora hesitates for a moment, staring at the thing standing between them and Perfuma. With a deep breath, she slowly removes the glove from her hand. For a brief second, Glimmer sees a faint red line on the blonde’s palm. Adora quickly turns her palm the other way and hovers it over the pad. Her arm begins to shake. The blonde takes a breath, holding it tight in her chest and shuts her eyes. With a leap of faith, Adora leans forward.

The pad lights up, scanning her palm. Time comes to a halt as they watch. The scanner stops and for a moment, Glimmer believes it has failed. That within the next second, alarms will be blaring and their whole plan will be over. Suddenly, the pad beeps and becomes green. The door besides them opens up.

“Holy shit! That actually worked!” Catra states.

“How?!?” Adora stares wide-eyed at her hand, still on the pad. She slowly removes it, covering it once more.

“We can figure that out later. C’mon.” Glimmer is the first to enter the prison cell. Perfuma has looked up, her dark eyes quickly scanning the room.

“Who the hell is there?!?” she shouts, getting to her feet. “What game are you playing?!?”

“Perfuma, it’s us!” Glimmer says. She steps away from Melog, revealing herself to her friend. Peruma jumps at the sight of the queen appearing out of thin air.

“Glimmer?!? I can’t believe it!” Tears form in her eyes and begin to spill out, running down her freckled cheeks.

Glimmer quickly is at her side. She uses her magic to cut the tight binding around her friend’s wrist. The moment they are freed, Perfuma’s slender arms wrap around the queen. Glimmer does not miss a beat and returns the gesture. Tears have begun to form in her own eyes. “I’m so glad you are safe. We were all so worried!”

“You have no idea how happy I am to see you!” Perfuma pulls away. “Is it just you here?!? How in the gods name did you get on board and how were invisible?”

Glimmer looks behind her. Melog has ceased to be invisible. Catra stands on one side of the alien cat while Adora is on the other, staring right at Perfuma.

They lock eyes, sky blue meeting earth brown. Adora bites down on her lip, nearly breaking skin. Perfuma has seen better days. There is a tiredness in her eyes and the joyus aura that normally accompanies her has dimmed. Prime must have fed her decently enough but she has lost some pounds in her time being held captive. The princess pulls fully apart from the queen and slowly makes her way to the blonde.

Adora’s mind races, wondering what is going through Perfuma’s. Will Perfuma be angry at her for what happened? No, she wouldn’t be like that knowing the circumstances. Yet, her brain refuses to relax and with each step, it grows worse. After all, the blonde *was* the one who threw her in here. The one who allowed Horde Prime to hold her prisoner and show her images of her

kingdom burning. Adora was the one who led that attack on her kingdom and stole her runestone.

However, all of that is quickly thrown out the window. Like so many times before, arms wrap around the blonde and hold her tight. Her senses are flooded with the smell of a sweet perfume. She remembers the first time entering Plumeria, the sight of a new kingdom, and how welcoming the nature princess was. Adora jerks slightly to the touch but in response, returns the gesture.

“I’m so happy you are back,” Perfuma says, tears in her voice.“I was so worried once I stopped seeing you and hearing about you.”

Adora grips her tighter, her sight becoming blurry. Try as she might, she cannot stop an apology slipping from her mouth. “I’m so sorry for everything. I'm so glad you are alive! I was so worried.”

“I never gave up on you. I knew you would break free.”

“You have to thank Glimmer for that.”

“How did I know that would be the case?” Perfuma finally lets go. She wipes the tears from her face before asking, “Please tell me you have a plan.”

“Not really. Just trying to not be killed,” Catra replies.

“Bow and Entrapta are trying to locate the runestones and get them off the ship. We came to find you and anyone else trapped here,” Glimmer answers.

“What about Prime?”

“We don’t quite know yet but we won’t let him get away. We are *going* to stop him.” Adora says, trying to reassure both Perfuma and herself. “But right now you should get off this ship. You have been here too long and you should be somewhere safe.”

Adora turns around and faces her former friend. “Catra, take Perfuma, use Melog, and get her off. After that, do whatever else you think you can do.”

“What the hell are you going to do?!?” Catra asks. “Are you trying to get yourself killed?!?”

“That doesn’t matter.” Adora honestly doesn’t know what she is planning. Right now, getting Perfuma somewhere safe is top priority.

“I’ll be with her.” Glimmer steps up besides Adora. “I’ll take care of her, Horde Scum.”

Catra chuckles a little. “You better, Sparkles. Hop on, Flower Crown.”

“Are you sure about this?” Perfuma asks.

“I am. Go. We’ll see you on the other side.” *Least I hope,* Adora adds in her mind.

Perfuma can only nod before walking up to Melog. Catra hops on as well but before she can leave, Adora stops her.

“Keep her safe, Catra.”

“Don’t worry about it. I know how much you princesses care about each other. Good to know you guys do also.”

“Don’t die either, stupid.”

Catra’s eyes go wide. “The hell are you smoking?”

“Just because working with you has been a pain in the ass doesn’t mean I still want you to die. I never wanted that. Just...live so we can be enemies again or at least not give a damn about each other.”

“That’s a promise I think I can keep. Let’s go, Melog.”

And just like that, the three disappear, leaving Adora and Glimmer alone. After some time of doing nothing, Glimmer breaks the silence.

“Are you ready for this?”

“No. But what choice do we have? What about you?”

“Same here. At least we have each other, right?” There is a soft smile on her face. Adora smiles herself.

“As always. Let’s get this over with.”

Chapter End Notes

shoutout this week is NamakiTDR who has been writing glimmadora rewrites. check them out

I am dropping this note here and I will say it again next chapter but fyi, next chapter is going to have a sudden POV in which the POV is both Adora and Glimmer at the same time. Just so yall dont get whiplash

anyway I hoped you enjoyed and kudos and comments are welcomed~

Beacons of Hope

Chapter Notes

> eeehhhhh the last major chapter. I am gonna save all the sap for later but i do have ch 17 done. it will be posted next monday. anyway, tw for this chapter is like some blood, flashbacks, kind of panic attacks I guess, Horde Prime messing with Adora and a Glimmer, its a doozy yall. Enjoy
>
> also AGAIN THIS CHAPTER SWITCHES POV. For a narrative standpoint it felt right to have both POV going at once. This is my first time really doing this, and it shall go back to the switching next chapter, so if its wonky, that's why. Again, it CHANGES

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Without the powers of Melog, Adora and Glimmer slowly and carefully sneak their way down the halls of Horde Prime's ship. Every step they take, both can feel their hearts beating hard against their chest, threatening to burst free and run away. Their minds scream to do the same. It is anyone's guess where Horde Prime lies in wait for the pair. They check every room they come by, Adora opening them all. No alarms ever go off, adding to the confusion of the ship. Though, nothing they open is anything more than a dud. No Prime and nothing of use. The maze of halls only grows more confusing and dangerous, as clones can be lurking at every corner.

"Is the cost clear?" Glimmer asks. The two have ducked into what seems to be a storage room after hearing the sounds of footsteps. They have died off and have been silent for at least a minute now. Though, that is never a sure sign. Could always be a trick to lure them out. Glimmer and Adora barely made it in here, barely squeezed their way into the tight space, before the noise was right on top of them. The owner of the footsteps moved so slowly it felt like years went by until there was nothing.

Adora cracks open the door, letting a sliver of pale light into the dark room. She squints her eyes and focuses on hearing on the outside world. Only the sounds she hears come from her own breathing as well as Glimmer's. Slowly, the blonde pulls on the handle more, giving her a large field of vision. Still nothing. Adora steps out of the hiding spot, a hand on the hilt of her sword. The hall is free of any clones.

"Yeah, we're good," Adora tells her.

Glimmer steps forward herself, taking her own look around. With the cost clear, the two continue onward. Neither says much as they search for Horde Prime. There is no way to tell what will happen once they finally face off with him. There is no turning back at this point. Tucking one's tail and fleeing will do no one any good and will lead only to more death and destruction. Stopping now will mean everything everyone has suffered through and the clinging to hope during these dark days would have been all for not.

Glimmer and Adora take a brief moment to rest and check in on the others. Bow and Entrapta continue to try and gain access to the runestone, finding some luck in locating them but no such luck getting to them. There is no response from Catra. Hopefully that means she is away from range, off of the ship with Perfuma, and not captured or killed.

"Is it stupid to ask if you have any recollection going on in your brain?" Glimmer asks.

"Right now that would be nice but, no, I don't remember anything," Adora sighs. Try as she might, nothing comes to mind. Any attempt she tries, she hits a wall and a headache threatens to form. No need for that at the moment. "What did you see on your time here? If you don't mind me asking."

Glimmer leans against the wall. "Not much. Only that section before. And...some dining hall area. Doubt he would be there." A shiver runs down her spine remembering that place of horror.

Where she almost watched Adora's life be snuffed out. Her pleas for the blonde's life are clear as day in her head. "Prime was good about not showing too much to me. Kept me in the cell mostly."

Adora paces around, a hand running through her dark locks. "Damn it. For once I really wish Catra was around. She probably could lead us better around this damn place. How much dumb luck can keep riding before things go to even more shit?"

"Haven't we always gone off of dumb luck and been just fine?"

Adora chuckles a little. "I guess you are right. I think we need to keep going. No more wasting time."

"Right."

There is a brief moment of hesitation, dread weighing them down. The ship is vast and refuses to end. The pair swear that they went down the same hallway at least one or twice now. The amount of clones vary, giving no indication at all if they could be close to Horde Prime's lair. A question begins to form if he is still even on the ship and if this is all pointless. Could this all be a trap? Break everyone up even more so an attack on the planet is easier? So many horrible what-ifs.

Finally, something new appears. For a moment, it is a breath of relief. Being a little less lost and hopefully on the right path to their destination. However, that inkling of hope disappears in an instant. A large, crystal clear window comes into view. The outside world is of the vast, dark purple space. Bright, distant stars litter the area. Among them, closer yet still far from reach, several bluish moons. Adora gulps, her hands begin to shake. Glimmer takes the first step forward towards the glass. The blonde following right on her heels.

The pinkish planet down below is hard to make out through the thousands of ships surrounding it. Up here, so many miles away from the ground, it is a wonder what is going on. Are Horde Prime's armies overrunning Brightmoon? Have Micah and

Castaspella been able to hold off the attack? Are they still alive? What about the others? Glimmer swallows a hard lump in her throat. Just thinking about losing the rest of her family, especially the father she *just* got back, threatens to break her into a million pieces. Her body trembles as she struggles to keep herself together. Her family, friends, and people need her to remain strong.

Adora presses a hand against the cold glass, her eyes fixated on the sight below her. Images begin to flash in her mind over and over again. The armies she once led due to Horde Prime's influence continue to threaten the planet and the universe at large. The people she hurt...Her nails scrape against the glass as anger boils inside of her. She refuses to let Prime win, especially after everything she has done under his control. These ships will not remain here long. The blonde will stop at nothing to bring him down.

A noise echoes through the hall. Adora and Glimmer snap their heads up and see the shadow of a number of clones making their way closer and closer to them. Letting their legs move without thought, the two dip into the closest new hall they can get to and duck into the first room. Adora locks the room from the inside, hoping they do not attempt to get in here. The footsteps are quickly on top of them, right outside the door.

It ceases for a moment. Adora's and Glimmer's breath lodges in their throat, each readying themselves for a possible fight. After what seems like forever, the footsteps fill the air once again before fading around. The queen releases the breath stuck inside of her. Another close call. She hopes their dumb luck leads them to Prime and not another set of clones.

"I think they are gone. We should be good to move," Glimmer states, pulling her ear away from the door. She is met only with silence. "Adora?"

Glimmer turns her head around. The room they have ended up in is a large, nearly empty area. The walls and floor take on the

same sleek, clean, white metal of the rest of the ship. Two things stand out. At the far side of the room, is a large chair. One of many that Horde Prime must have to show others who is in charge here and not question his reign. Her eyes then fall to the center of the room.

A large pool is carved into the metal floor. Unlike most bodies of water she has grown accustomed to throughout her life, this one takes on a bright green color, one that makes her sick to her stomach. They are the same vivid shade as what Adora's eyes were during her time in Horde Prime's clutches. The ones that continue to haunt her dreams. Even from the distance she is at, Glimmer can feel the iciness from the water hanging in the air. The hairs on the back of her neck stand at attention and goosebumps form all along her body. She wonders what horrors this place is used for.

Whimpering catches her attention, answering her question. It is soft and hushed, Glimmer could have easily missed it if it was not so quiet in the room. The queen looks towards her side, finding Adora as the source of the sound. Her legs have given out, she sits collapsed on the ground. Her eyes have gone wide, fright filling them as they remain locked on the pool in front of them. One hand remains tense on the ground clutched so tightly her knuckles have turned white. Her other is slapped against the back of her neck.

"Adora! What's the matter?!? Are you okay?!?" Glimmer kneels down besides the blonde.

"T-This...This is where I...Where he…He..."

Adora cannot complete her sentence. Words are not stuck in her throat, unable to be freed. Rather, they no longer form in her mind in the slightest. All her brain can conjure up are memories of that fateful day. Waking up with a throbbing headache that felt like her skull was splitting in two. Horde Prime staring down at her, making her doubt everything she believes in and her role in life. Then, being thrown in the pool against her will. She can still

feel the ice against her skin. The horrible sense of drowning, her lungs burning from lack of oxygen, and the water stinging her eyes. The memories of her fights with Glimmer being ripped out of her mind and overwhelming her.

Her body presses hard against the door behind her. Her legs are useless and cannot help her escape from this real life nightmare. This place is where everything began to crumble. Where every action that has led to this moment started. The scar on the back of her neck is on fire as her eyes remain on the pool in front of her.

Glimmer's warm hand finds her own. Adora somehow finds the strength to snap her head away from her nightmare and look at the queen. Her lilac eyes are soft and reassuring.

"We have to keep moving and you are the only one who can open the door. We can get out of here, we don't have to stay. The clones are gone. Do you need help standing?" Glimmer asks.

"I…" Adora pauses for a moment, taking a deep breath. She squeezes her eyes shut in an attempt to find some semblance of peace. After a moment, her words come back to her. "Yeah. I think so. Thank you."

An arm snakes across Glimmer's neck. Together, they stand to their feet. Adora wobbles, legs barely willing to hold her weight. The queen allows for a moment to let the blonde steady herself out, getting used to her feet again, before attempting any steps. Adora keeps her eyes on the ground, refusing to look up, as they spin around to face the door once more. She places her hand on the lock and the metal doors pull open, giving them access to the confusing halls again.

They slowly move down the hall, Adora's legs slowly returning to use. She remains leaning on the queen as they walk, not trusting herself quite yet. Her brain has begun to settle down from the sudden fright. However, in the cluster of memories, something

grabs her attention. If this is the hall where the pool was, then that means...

“Wait…” Adora says, stopping her movement.

“What?” Glimmer looks at her, an eyebrow raised. “Something wrong?”

Adora looks around. The hallway is familiar. *Too* familiar. Her brain might have calmed but her heart has taken over in its place. Everything is telling her to escape from this place, that she might be out of the frying pan but easily can land in the fire. But they have to move forward. They will pass it regardless and turning around will only make them more lost. There is not much of a choice in the matter.

“We’re close to where…” Adora bites down on her lip. Her free hand finds her stomach.

It takes a moment for Glimmer to understand the non-verbal cue. She feels her body go cold and her abdomen begins to ache. “Are you sure?”

“The most sure I have been with my memories in a while.” Adora slides her arm off and takes a shaking step forward. “We are going to pass it…”

“Do you want to go in?”

“I don’t know honestly.” Adora sighs. Something itches at the back of her mind, telling her to go. The place will rip open the wound of what she has struggled to push back for weeks now, make it all fresh again. Yet, when will another opportunity to face that moment arrive? This might be their only chance. “What about you?”

Glimmer shifts her weight from leg to leg as she begins to chew on the bottom of her lip. She nearly tastes blood doing so. The memory of the day she nearly died at the hands of Adora had begun to become a haze. Her brain desperately wants to forget

that moment in her life. Being here, it threatens to undo all of that. All of this pain, suffering, and torment comes from that moment. However, part of the misery came from the things that were left unsaid. Something of which she still has not said since and knows runs the risk of never saying again.

“I don’t really like the idea, if I am being honest. But...it might bring a weird sense of closure. To...I don’t know.”

“See it all again and know we are here to get payback for what happened?” Adora inquiries. “If you do it, I’ll do it. Not pressuring you, though.”

“I feel the same exact way.”

Adora reaches out and grabs a hold of the queen’s hand. They squeeze each other tightly. “Let’s get this over with.”

The blonde leads the way, knowing the door is close to the end. The walk is agonizing. Every step they take becomes heavier and heavier, like something has grabbed their ankles and is pulling them down. Their bodies would shake from the anticipation of what they are about to face, yet their hands locked together keep each the two steady. Adora stops at a door, similar to all the others. Inside, however, hell lies within. The blonde’s hand hovers over the pad next to the door. Maybe this is a bad idea.

Glimmer reaches over with her free hand, placing it against Adora’s. “Together?”

A smile forms on Adora’s face, small and soft. “Together.”

Adora’s hand lands gently on the pad, still held by Glimmer’s. The pad beeps, scanning the blonde’s hand. Like every time before, the screen becomes green and the metal doors slide open. The air becomes heavy as they step into the room.

Barely anything has changed from the last time they were there all those weeks ago. Weapons that may have fallen during their scuffle have been returned neatly to their original places on the

tables. Nothing is out of order. It is like there was never a major, desperate, and angry fight here at all that nearly cost one person their life. As they draw closer to the fateful spot, it too has been scrubbed clean of any evidence of their scuffle.

There is not a spec of blood anywhere. Only the silver metal of the ship stares back at them, almost showing their tired reflections. Glimmer finds herself unable to remain standing. Her legs give out, hitting the metal floor as her hand slips from Adora's grasp. She reaches out, fingers brushing against the cold surface. It is a familiar sense. One that she felt all those weeks ago. The heaviness with it that threatened to drag her into the darkest of pits as the ice grip of death slowly closed its grasp around her. She wonders how she ever made it out of here alive and breathing.

Adora's green angry eyes re-enter her mind. The sheer coldness and emptiness of her voice and her words, mixed with Prime's own speech, echoes in her ears. Metal scraping against metal in the desperate attempt to defend herself against the blonde's blows as the queen pleaded with her to listen. The most haunting thing of all makes its way to the forefront. Adora pinning her hard to the ground, arm pressed against her neck and cutting off her air supply. Green did not stare back at her then. Rather, sky blue did. Filled with tears that dripped down onto Glimmer's body. Nothing has been as horrible as seeing that, of the pain and hurt that lied within them. Her vision becomes blurred.

Adora stands as still as a statute. Everything comes to her in waves of flashes. Waiting for Glimmer to arrive, knowing she would come back. Spilling out everything that had buried deep within her to the queen, unable to stop. The anger over taking her mind and lashing out. Listening to the voice not her own inside her head. Obeying without hesitation its command to plug the weapon she grabbed into Glimmer, attempting to end her life. And then...

There is a moment's pause. Adora's eyebrows furrow in thought. In the dark and bloody mix of memories that play in her mind, the

itch from before becomes clearer. The last thing she heard Glimmer say before she allowed the chip to fully take her over. Pinned up against the wall, a sword embedded into her abdomen and her purple clothes turning a deep crimson, the queen managed to open her mouth one last time. Even as she was about to lose her life, a smile spread across the queen's face as she spoke:

...Just...Just know that I love you. Nothing ever changed that. I was...to stupid to let go of my pride and...tell you how I felt. I've ***always*** *loved you, Adora, and I always will…*

"You...you said something before...before I pulled the sword away, didn't you? I don't know if I am recalling it all but it snapped me out of Prime for a moment." Adora clutches the side of her head, the other memories becoming painful as they fight for dominance. Glimmer looks up at her, lilac eyes watery. She sniffs before wiping her face in a small attempt to compose herself.

"I…" Glimmer thinks for a moment, needing to dig deep in the haze. "Yeah...I did. I didn't know what else to say at that moment."

"Did...Did you mean it? That you've always loved me?" Adora's heart twists inside of her, fear gripping it. Love can be a dangerous game to gamble in. She knows this fact because of Catra. Whatever love she had for the magicat was turned into something dark and poisonous, infecting so much of her being in its toxicity. Made her hate herself and question everything in the world. It is the thing she feared the most when feelings began to develop towards the queen. And as the war grew worse and worse and fights between the two broke out more often, her fear started to come true.

But now, after all of this, after everything Horde Prime has done, they have come back together, haven't they?

Glimmer takes a breath. “Yes, Adora. I wasn’t lying when I said I always have and that my pride got in the way. I had no idea what to do with my feelings for you, so many people I have loved, like my father and mother, have been ripped away from me without warning. I was *scared* that was going to happen to you and I couldn’t see anything other than stopping the Horde in order to protect what I had left. I’m still sorry for that.

“But, of course, Prime took you and made you do all those horrible things. Maybe if I told you earlier how I felt, we could’ve fixed things before and none of this would have happened. And now, we are about to face him so...I do love you, Adora. More than you can ever know.

Adora stays silent for a moment, processing the words she has just been told. Just as Glimmer opens her mouth to speak again, fearing she said too much, the blonde cuts her off.

“I love you too, Glimmer. I have no idea for how long, love scared me for a while and still does if I am being honest. But you are the best thing to ever happen to me. We all were trying to protect each other, blinded by love. I wish I said something earlier and you didn’t have to say it when you were about to die because of me.”

Glimmer chuckles a little. “We both are a mess, aren’t we?”

“Then I guess we are really made for each other.”

“Yeah...If I am being honest, though, I don’t...I don’t know if I am ya know...Ready for anything. I love you but there is so much left to do, to *fix* I...I love you Adora but I don’t want to mess things up again.”

“I get that. If loving you means waiting a bit longer, then I have waited this long. We can figure everything out if we make it out of here alive.”

“When, Adora When we make it out we will figure everything out." Glimmer stands to her feet, her eyes returning to the spot

she fell. A hand finds its way onto her stomach. “I really hate that bastard for everything.”

“I couldn’t agree more with you.” the blonde begins to rub her arms. “This place is giving me the chills.”

They don’t stay any longer than they have to. The memories are becoming too much. Adora and Glimmer leave this place behind, hoping to keep it in the past. Outside of the room, the two continue their way down the rest of the hall. It splits into two directions, causing them to pause. Adora squints her eyes in thought, looking down each way.

Her gut tells her to go one way. She barely has time to think over it before legs take her down the hall. Glimmer does not question and follows her lead. No one else is around besides them, giving the place an eerie feeling. It stretches out for what seems like forever until a small turn reveals what they have been looking for.

Large doors stare back at them, the symbol of Horde Prime plastered on the metal. No other doors are around, the only other way around the ship is turning around. This has to be it. Where Horde Prime must command his armies. Once the two go through that door, there will be no turning back. They might not even come out at all. Either Etheria and its people will finally be freed, or they will be doomed for the rest of their lives.

“Are you ready for this?” Adora asks, walking up to the panel.

Glimmer snorts. “No. Not in the slightest. You?”

“I am feeling the same. Gods, this really is it, isn’t?” Adora takes a breath. “Together?”

The queen gives a small nod. Her hand finds the back of Adora’s once more. “Together.”

The doors slide open, revealing the large room. A moment after entering, the doors shut with force and there is the distinct *beep* of it *locking* . Adora and Glimmer snap their heads around, staring

at what now traps them inside. Any thoughts of turning around are all but dashed. Adora's hand quickly finds the hilt of her sword and Glimmer summons her staff. Both take a scan of the area, getting their bearings.

It is a mostly empty room. Darken screens are on every wall and they stand on dark green carpet that runs through most of the area. It ends at the foot of a set of stairs. Several steps lead to a platform where more screens lie, as well as a large chair. The back is turned to the blonde and queen. Before either girl can react or say anything, it begins to turn. Sitting on it, a leg crossed over the other, head propped up by a fist, and a wide, dark smile spread across his face, is Horde Prime.

"I've been waiting for you two. You know it's not good to keep your host waiting," Prime states, his voice cold as ever. All four of his eyes are trained onto Adora and Glimmer.

Their mouths go dry, anything they wanted to say is nonexistent. Adora pulls her sword free of its sheath, ready and aimed for an attack. Glimmer's hands light up, prepared to launch a surge of magic through the staff. Neither girl can barely hold back the shakes from their body. Seeing him in memories or a hologram is one terrifying thing. Now here in the flesh, all the intimidation, all of his evilness and cruelty, everything that emits wickedness is amplified tenfold.

This only causes the smile on Horde Prime's face to grow larger. "Tell me, how is my dear little sister and Her Majesty doing? It has been a while since either of us had a heart-to-heart."

"Why don't you shut the hell up? I am getting real sick and tired of your fucking voice," Glimmer snaps.

"That isn't a nice thing to say. Here I was wanting to have a simple chat with you two."

"What the hell do you want to talk about? You know why we are here." Adora retorts.

"Ah yes, of course." Horde Prime taps a finger against his chin. "Quite the army you have brought. Though, if I am being fair, no one has ever made a stand quite like this before. It is an interesting turn of events. I never would think you two would make it this far or be able to put up any sort of fight. Etheria never ceases to amaze me."

Glimmer grits her teeth, holding back a growl. All she can think about is wiping the damn smirk off of his face. Without second thought, the queen fires a blast of magic directly at him. Horde Prime simply moves to the side, the bright ball of magic not touching him in the slightest. Though, he makes a point to brush his shoulder off of non-existent dust.

“Tsk. Tsk. So brash. Never learned your lesson about rushing into things.” Horde Prime begins to step forward. The sound of his footfall bounces off the walls.

“Shit. What do we do?” Glimmer whispers, hands tight on her staff.

“Dumb luck, right?” Adora replies under her breath. “I dunno. Maybe teleport around and try to trip him up? Distract him so I can maybe try and land a hit?”

“I got nothing better.”

They wait, letting him draw closer. The moment Glimmer feels the gap has been closed enough, she teleports away from view. She reappears seconds later, right behind Horde Prime. Once more, the queen fires a hail of magical bullets at Horde Prime. Much like before, he moves out of the way, none of Glimmer’s attacks reaching him. Adora attempts her own strike, hoping to land some hit with her sword. She has no such luck either.

Despite his size, Horde Prime is too fast for them. All Adora’s sword meets is air. Caught off guard by the sudden movement, the blonde nearly trips over her feet. She quickly catches herself, regaining her footing and spinning to face her enemy.

“Child’s play. I thought this would be more of a fight,” Horde Prime states nonchalantly. “Beacons of hope you both have become yet neither can stop me. How pathetic. And I thought you’d be interesting entertainment. Such a shame. I wonder what I shall do first once your pathetic planet falls.”

“Will you shut up already?” Glimmer launches another attack. She uses her magic in an attempt to create a temporary loss of vision as ash kicks up everywhere. As she bursts through the cloud, she poses her staff for a strike. However, her attack fails to land a blow, Horde Prime’s hand latches around her staff, stopping her mid strike. Before the queen has any time to process what has just happened, she is flung across the room.

Her body hits the metal ground *hard.* It knocks the wind clean out of her lungs. She gasps for the oxygen that refuses to find its way back inside of her. Her brain screams for air again, solely focused on not suffocating to death.

“GLIMMER!” Adora cries out as she watches the queen slam against the floor. Horde Prime snaps the staff in half with his leg before casually tossing it to the side. Her eyes are filled with hot tears and fury over takes her body as Prime begins to walk towards the fallen girl. “You *bastard!* Stay away from her!”

Adora lunges forward, the only thought in her mind is of protecting Glimmer. She raises her sword above her head, ready to slash across Prime’s back. However, he turns around in time to repeat his action. He catches the sword, holding it tight in his grasp. Despite the bright, green liquid dripping down his palm, he does not flinch. Simply, he glowers at her.

“And to think you were the mighty She-ra.”

Suddenly, the sword breaks under his grasp. Dozens of sharp, small shards fall to the ground. Adora gasps, unable to believe her eyes. This action has consequences. The next thing she knows she is on the ground, swordless, feet away from her original

starting place. Pain radiates from her stomach and she nearly hacks up a lung trying to catch her breath.

Horde Prime keeps his sight towards the fallen blonde. A shout remains lodged in Glimmer's throat. The only thing the queen can manage to do is roll onto her stomach and feebly reach out towards the blonde. *No...Don't!*

"What do you wish to gain in fighting me?" Horde Prime asks. He reaches the fallen blonde, slowly walking around her. "I said before there is no point in resisting. Fighting only will worsen things for you and others. Do you want others to suffer more because of your actions?

"What hope do you have in defeating me, anyway? Even if I was without the runestone, two of which you helped aid me in little sister, you are powerless." Prime continues to circle her, like a predator waiting for the right moment to pounce out and leave a fatal blow against their prey. Adora winces, her body remaining frozen on the ground. The reminder of her dark act was not needed. Horde Prime does not cease his monologue.

"You have *failed.* Failed to protect those you swore to protect, even though some did not want you to do so." He stops, pausing feet away from Adora. By some miracle, Adora finds her limbs once more, even if only by so much. She pushes herself up onto her hands in knees, her body begging for air and rest. Looking upwards, her eyes come locked with his. Green fills all four of them, the sickly color making her feel ill. "Why don't you come back with me little sister? Be my right hand once more. You have sought out your family for so long, why not return to this one? I gave you the power and strength of She-ra. Gave you a belonging and purpose when others did not want you anymore. I can do it again."

Adora's stomach twists inside of her, making the nauseous feeling grow. There is nothing she can do to stop the tears falling down her face. Unable to bear the sight of Prime, she closes her eyes shut. She remembers those feelings. After all, she spilled it all on

Glimmer in the other room not so long ago. She cannot lie, during that time that was filled with anger and hate, a dark part of her enjoyed it. The blonde *despises* that side of her. Even now, dark thoughts of agreeing with him swimming alongside those she has on all the hurt she has caused.

"Don't listen to him, 'Dora!" Glimmer's voice fills the air. It is filled with a fiery determination. The one she has developed more and more as her time as queen. "You are *nothing* like that bastard, remember?!? Everyone is waiting for us to come back! Don't let him win!"

Adora opens her eyes, which are cast down on the ground. The slick, cold ground is spotted with her tears. She can see her hands are now clenched...and the bracelet wrapped around her right wrist. The first gift she ever got and one given by Glimmer, one of her first friends outside of the Horde, gave her.

Through all of this hell that has gone on the past several weeks, Glimmer never gave up trying to free her from Horde Prime, even if it nearly ended her life. She stood at her side, helping keep her on her feet while her mind refused to let up on the memories of her time with Prime. Despite *everything,* she remained by her side and never gave up.

Hell, so did the others. Bow, her other first friend, talking her through things when she couldn't open to Glimmer. He always left his ears open for the blonde and allowed her to lean against his shoulders. Then there is Perfuma, who forgave her even though she kidnapped her and burned down her Kingdom. There was no hatred in her voice when they spoke and she wanted Prime to pay for everything. She never gave up hope on her at all in spite of her own torture.

And of course Frosta and Scorpia. One of the first friendly faces she saw the day she woke up after the chip was removed from her neck. Them standing up for her when people gave the blonde dark looks for displacing them and could no longer trust in her. The Star Siblings...Despite only knowing her for such a short

period they have treated her like a long time friend. Then there is Entrapta. The one who removed the last bits of Prime off her neck. Never gave her any reasons to doubt her and was with those on the attempt to get Adora off of the ship.

Sea Hawk's welcoming hug, nearly choking Adora to death. He always radiated such positive and lively energy and it's hard not to absorb some of that. Mermista, who already lost so much in this war...Her people, her kingdom, and then her runestone. She did not even want to hear an apology from Adora, not out of anger but from knowing the blonde would never have done what she did in a million years.

Even Catra. There are so many cracks and wounds between the two, some that will never be able to heal. Yet, the magicat came with Glimmer to try and snap Adora out of Prime's control, nearly losing her head in the process. Sought after Adora to give an honest apology. One that might not fix everything but is a start nonetheless. And when not needing space, tried to cheer Adora up in her own Catra way. She still came along on this mission to make things right and aid her and Glimmer.

"No." Adora states.

"No?" Prime replies.

"No. I won't listen to you. I won't let you win." Adora rises to her feet. Her frightened tears have become hot with conviction. Prime's eyes no longer glow. His eyes remain on her, studying the blonde. Her brain screams to flee, to run from the thing that caused her and others so much pain and misery. She can't let that side of her win. She cannot let her fear consume and drown her. The blonde refuses to gain yet another scar among her collection from this war. Her heart begins to pound in her chest and her body fills with valor.

"You may have used my fears and insecurities against me but they are nothing more than *that.* A *lie.* My friends care about me. My friends know my past and my wrongs and love me despite that."

Something begins to mix into the fire that fills her veins. An intense strength that she has forgotten the sweet taste of. "I've tried to hold up the world on my own, try to make up for what *you* made me do. But I was wrong to think I could do that alone. You just want me to destroy others for your own damn gain for power. You say you could give me those things but you are *wrong!*

"My friends are my strength, the reason I keep fighting. *They* are my power. *They* are my *family.* " Adora turns her sight towards Glimmer. The queen now is on her knees, clutching her side. Her lilac eyes are wide and fixated on the blonde. The conversation from before, promising to figure everything out once they get out of here alive replays in her mind. Knowing how far they have come and knowing they both want to be in each other's lives forever. "One of whom not only has stolen my heart but is helping heal it in ways I could never imagine."

She looks back at Horde Prime. The warm, powerful sensation inside her chest threatens to break free like a dam and flood everything in its path, which Prime stands right in the middle of. The thoughts from before to flee and hide disappear as thoughts of her friends, of Glimmer, and everyone else enter. Her hand can feel a cool and smooth metal forming. Fingers wrap around it. As she speaks once more, there are no cracks or waver in her voice. Only a fierceness comes out. "I don't need you, I *never* needed you for any of those things you claimed to have given me. I won't let you harm anyone else and cause them the same pain as you did with me. Not while I am standing!"

Her arm extends forward just as a shining sword comes into clear view. " *FOR THE HONOR-"* for a brief moment she hesitates. She knows who she is doing this for, who matters the most. " *OF ETHERIA!"*

Glimmer watches in awe as a bright, white light envelopes Adora. The last time she felt this glow, it was cold and danger was about to come out of it. Now, rather, it is warm, giving her a renewed sense of hope. The light dissipates, turning into star-like sparkles around her. The blonde has grown several feet. Weeks ago, She-

ra dawned the regalia of Horde Prime. White and gold coloring has returned. However, she looks nothing like her previous transformations pre-Prime.

Near her throat, there is a heart-shaped design. Her scarlet cloak now splits, causing what looks like large wings to spread out behind her. In her hands, the Sword of Protection has taken on a new form as well. The blade is narrower, a broad tip at the end creating an arrowhead within Glimmer's mind. At the hilt where the runestone would be, has a cat's eye engraved in it. To top everything off, the cross-guard is a crescent moon, just like the ones back at Brightmoon. Her hair remains short but that fire in her eyes has returned and burns brightly in her blue eyes.

Glimmer cannot pull her eyes away from the sight in front of her. She feels like she is dreaming. How can this possibly be real otherwise? It has been so long since the queen has seen the legendary princess of tales of old. And she is back. No. She-ra has always been around. Adora is She-ra just as She-ra is Adora. The blonde haired warrior has once more tapped into that power within her and brought that side out of her for the world to see. It nearly brings the queen to tears seeing her again like this.

Horde Prime is caught off guard by this as well. He most likely was not expecting this to happen. Glimmer catches for a moment that his facade has fallen. For the first time, she can see a flash of *fear* come across his face. He quickly recovers and puts back on a mask.

"So She-ra has returned." He remains quick on his feet, sidestepping out of the way from a slash from Adora. Horde Prime steps back creating a large gap between him and the blonde. Resting by his feet, is the remaining section of Adora's previous weapon. The hilt, no longer a point, remains razor-sharp and dangerous. He retrieves it, running a finger against the cold, broken metal.

"Doesn't matter much," Horde Prime continues. "You still are no match. Especially you Your Majesty. Pitiful queen. How did you

ever make it this far as ruler? Was it not your quest for power that allowed me to find your little planet."

Glimmer flinches at the comment. She can do nothing else but watch Adora lash out at Horde Prime. He blocks the attack with the broken sword.

"Leave her alone!" Adora snaps.

"I wonder if my armies are overtaking Brightmoon at this very moment. I will admit, your kingdom was tough to reach but at the end of the day, does that really matter? Brightmoon will fall, the Moonstone shall me mine, and there is nothing you can do. I wonder if you shall go down as the shortest lived queen. The one who let her planet fall."

What would have happened if she never tried to tap into the Heart of Etheria? There could have been a chance Prime never would have found them. Never would have made things worse. Another way could have been found in stopping the Horde. But she only made things worse. After the rule of her mother, one that lasted for generations, it now shall be followed by her few months reign.

Metal scrapes against metal. Adora pushes Horde Prime back. "Don't you *dare* say that to her!" the blonde hisses. "Glim is the greatest queen Brightmoon has ever seen! And she will have more time to rule!"

After another block, Adora quickly spins around to face the queen. "You did not give up on me, not in the slightest. I won't either. You are and will be an amazing queen! Don't you dare listen to him."

"Adora…" Glimmer rises to her feet. Her body aches. Adora's words fill her with strength. She has not failed her people yet. There is still time to fix things. Time to make her mark. She won't let her people die. She won't let anyone else suffer. Her hands curl into fist, ready for another round.

Her eyes catch something. Horde Prime uses the moment that Adora's back is turned to strike. The broken sword is raised above his head. Glimmer moves without thought, sparing no time to think about what is going on. She teleports out of reality, zipping through another dimension, and within a fraction of a second, stands between Horde Prime and Adora. The queen feels the hit of the sword on her back, a grunt escaping her lips. Her shoulder blade becomes sticky and wet. But that doesn't matter. Adora has been spared a possible fatal attack.

"I won't let you keep hurting others. I *refuse* it!" Glimmer snaps. Among the wetness on her back, another, unfamiliar sensation takes shape. Her eyes meet Adora's, who stare at her in shock. The blonde was the one to give her the little nudge to reconnect with her powers. To make her feel light as air once more. And feel like she deserves her crown.

Everyone is waiting for her and Adora back down on Etheria. She has failed the world, her friends, her family too many times already. Glimmer won't let that happen again.

"I am the Queen of Brightmoon, the largest and most powerful kingdom of Etheria. I was thrown into this role against my will, without warning. But that doesn't mean I can't stop you from hurting anyone. I will protect my people, those I care about, no matter what! I won't let you hurt anyone else. Not on my watch!"

"Glim…" Adora breathes out, turned to face the queen.

Glimmer watches as a near all purple feather falls in front of her. The end of the vane fades to a golden color. It lands between the queen and the blonde. That is when she realizes the new weight on her back and the shadows she casts around Adora, shielding her even more in the attack.

Wings.

There is no more time to process this new development. Glimmer hears Horde Prime backing up, a low irritated growl coming from

him. The queen quickly wraps her arms around the blonde, teleporting away to another area of the room, dodging another attack from Prime. When they return feet away, Glimmer lets go. She staggers for a moment, not used to the new appendages.

"Are you alright, Glimmer?!?" Adora asks.

Glimmer rubs her shoulder blade as best she can. "Nothing Castaspella can't fix nor a good night's rest. I'm getting real sick and tired of this. We have to do something and fast."

Adora grips her familiar yet new sword tight in her hands. "Right. One last attack. Got any plans?"

Glimmer notices they have teleported near where her staff has been thrown. The queen bends down and grabs the lower half, the end now jagged and pointed. "When do we ever? He already seems pretty pissed. Maybe we can get an opening in there. Together?"

Adora gives her a nod. "Right. Together."

Glimmer makes the first move. Unsure with her new found wings, she teleports near Prime. He is well prepared for the reappearance of the queen. Knowing this, the queen does her best to trip him up. This entails using a wing in an attempt to knock into him. It half works. Unable to control this new part of her, the signal only makes it halfway to the wing, only clipping Prime. Glimmer moves fast, teleporting back away before a counter-strike can occur.

Adora steps forward. She has forgotten the feeling of being She-ra, of having pure magic course through her veins. The blonde focuses her mind onto an attack. With a swipe upward of her sword, she sends a blast of rainbow colored energy at Horde Prime. This time, the attack makes its mark. Horde Prime falls to his knees, forced back several feet by the force of the impact. He groans before snapping his attention back at the two, eyes full of rage.

"*Insolent brats!*"

"What? Getting scared?" Glimmer mocks. She teleports away from another strike by Horde Prime.

"I think he might be," Adora states. "Your reign of tyranny is over!"

Adora unleashes another blast of magic. This time, the attack only nips him. Horde Prime stumbles nonetheless. In the brief opening they have, Glimmer and Adora lunge forward. There is no other option, no other way to stop Horde Prime in his tracks than one thing.

The Sword of Protection and the broken part of Glimmer's staff plunge into Horde Prime's body. He gasps as the metal enters him. The queen's staff enters his front through his stomach while the blonde's sword pushes through his back, exiting out of his chest. For a moment, everything is still. The whole world freezes, as if someone has hit a paused button and refuses to press play.

Green blood seeps out of the injuries to Horde Prime. But this does not seem to disturb him. His cold, dark cackle begins to fill the air. Adora and Glimmer grip their weapons tightly, refusing to let the noise bring them down.

"It is going to take a lot more than this to defeat me," Horde Prime musters out. "You don't think some measly attacks will stop me?"

"Maybe it won't. But this might stop you." Glimmer states.

Glimmer's hands light up. The magic encases her staff and travels upward. Adora follows her lead. Her own magic follows her sword, making its way into Horde Prime's body. Prime has no time to react, can't even get out a gasp before the magic over takes his body. A bright light fills Adora's and Glimmer's eyes, blinding them. Both girls wince, squeezing their eyes shut but keeping their hands gripped tight on their weapons.

As the light begins to dissipate, the large, metal room comes back into view. Adora and Glimmer blink, removing the last slivers of lights from their eyes. They are the only ones left in the room. Horde Prime is nowhere in sight. He is no more. No longer will he be causing death and destruction. No longer will people live in fear, not knowing what the next day will bring. The universe at large, Etheria, will know peace once more.

"He's gone…" Adora says. Her legs give out, overwhelmed by the revelation. Tears stream down her eyes. "He's really gone."

Glimmer's legs become jell-o as well. She collapses to her knees in tears, feeling a weight lift over her shoulders. "We actually did it...We actually won…"

Adora's strong arms wrap around Glimmer, pulling the queen close, and burying her face into the crook of her neck. Glimmer's own arms snake around the blonde's back, placing her head into Adora's chest. Her new found wings, sensing the emotion, encase the two in a warm, feathery, hug. Neither can form words. The tears that stream down their faces over take them as the wave of relief washes over them.

It's over. Everything that has happened now is in the past, something they can work towards walking away from. There will be no more pain, no more misery, no more suffering. The battle is won and the war is over.

They slowly pull away from each other, tears continuing to run down their cheeks. Adora smiles softly as she reaches her hand out. Fingers brush against Glimmer's new wings. They are soft like a cloud, like her hair. The blonde swears she can see some sparkles mixed into the lilac feathers. Towards the end of the wings, the colors fade into a near golden color.

"These are beautiful, Glim. Just like you," Adora breathes out. "Fit for a queen."

Glimmer chuckles a little. “Thank you, ‘Dora. You look amazing as well. But, you always have.”

“Dork.”

“It takes one to know one.”

A new noise cuts them off. The sound of Entrapta’s voice fills their ears. It is so sudden, it startles both girls.

“Yes! Yes! We are here!” Adora says, her finger on her earpiece.

“ *We got the runestone away! How are you two fairing on Horde Prime?”*

“He’s been dealt with,” Glimmer replies. “But seriously, you got them off?”

“Yes we did!”

“Prime is gone?” Bow’s voice cuts in. He pauses for a moment before speaking once more. “ *I guess there is a lot of explaining between all of us but there isn’t really time for that now.”*

“What do you mean?”

Entrapta speaks once more. “ *Weeeellllll….I maybe have messed around with some wiring and what not and.”* she clicks her tongue. “ *The ship will be blowing up soon. Best to teleport back to the pad. Not a lot of time. We are already there and yeah…”*

“WHAT?!?” both Adora and Glimmer shouts.

“ *Her plan, not mine. We will meet you back on Etheria.”*

Adora and Glimmer take a moment to look at each other, not knowing what to make this new development. The queen reaches out and grabs Adora’s hand. She teleports them away, right where they started. The two take the step onto the pad to head back to Etheria.

They quickly return to their home planet, hands locked together. As they step off the platform, a sight catches their attention. The sky has now turned dark and lit only by the stars and moons when a new light appears. It is bright and large, fire pouring out of it. No more lead ship. No more Prime or Horde.

“You’re back!” Bow’s voice shouts. Adora and Glimmer snap their heads around. Bow quickly tackles his best friends, his arms wrapping around them.

The three friends stay in each other's embrace, soaking in their presence. Another reunion, this time, with hope and new beginnings on the horizon. Bow is the first to move to speak but his thoughts change at the sight of his two friends.

“Woah! What…” his dark, misty eyes look over them. They grow wider with disbelief by the second.

“It’s a lot to explain,” Glimmer tells him. “I’m so glad you are okay.”

“Are you okay?” Adora asks. She notices some scrapes on his body.

“I’m so happy to see you two as well. And yeah. Just a little fight, don’t worry. Nothing I couldn't handle..”

“Did you guys see that?!?” Entrapta interjects. She stares up at the still lit up sky with eyes full of excitement and glee. “I have never seen an explosion that huge before! Oh I wish I could have recorded it.”

“That was amazing. Good idea to blow that up,” Glimmer states. “Where did you come up with blowing it up?”

“I figured if by some chance you two couldn’t defeat Horde Prime, you could teleport away from him and maybe blowing him up would work. Having a back up plan is always good and since we never figured one out, I did for us!”

“Good thinking.”

“Where’s Perfuma and Catra?” Adora asks, looking around the forest.

“Right here, Blondie.”

Catra and Perfuma appear out of the treeline, Melog right behind them. Like Bow before her, Perfuma throws herself at Glimmer and Adora, hugging them tight and refusing to let go.

“I am so glad you two made it out alright!” the flower princess says, tears easily heard in her shaky voice.

“We can say the same thing about you,” Adora tells her. “How are you feeling? Are you okay? Not hurt?”

“I’m fine around, it’s okay. I am safe and sound now, we all are, thanks to you two.”

“You guys sure like to be sappy, don’t ya?” Catra asks. “How the hell I have not gotten any cavities being near you all I have no clue.”

A thought quickly crosses Glimmer’s mind. An imp like smile crosses her face as she teleports right beside the magicat’s side. Without any warning, she wraps her arms around Catra and pulls her into a tight embrace.

“What the fuck are you doing, Sparkles?!?” Catra shouts, squirming to break free.

“I both have to annoy you and say thank you. We couldn’t have done this with you. Not to mention all the other help you did before.”

“Alright, alright! You’re welcome! Will you let go of me now!”

Glimmer does as she is told, releasing the magicat from her grasp. Catra dusts herself off before noticing Adora, no longer in her

She-ra form, has walked up to her. The former friends say nothing, only staring at one another. There is no longer anything forcing them to work together. Nothing to keep them bonded anymore.

Finally, Catra breaks the silence.

“What? Are you going to give me a hug?”

“No,” Adora tells her. She sticks out her hand. “But I still owe you a thank you.”

Catra chuckles a little before shaking Adora’s hand. “Does this mean you owe me now?”

“Hell no. Don’t even think about it.”

“Eh, worth a shot.” Catra lets go and gives a shrug. “We probably should be getting back to Brightmoon.”

“She’s right.” Glimmer reaches out and takes Adora’s hand once more. The queen props herself up on her toes and places her forehead on Adora’s. “Let’s go home, ‘Dora.”

“I’m always home with you, Glim.”

Chapter End Notes

> yes I stole that one Bumbleby scene. Honestly, it was all I could think of when trying to figure out how they defeated prime (cause fight scenes are my strong point so I tried lol) also! She-ra's design was taken from the original one shot more or less and was created by my friend CourtDorku!
>
> Anyway, comments and kudos appreciated and see you next week for the final chapter to wrap things up

Despite Everything

Chapter Notes

Surprised update cause I can't help myself.

I finally am done...I never really ever finished a chapter fic before so this is a big win for me! This all came to me in a dream after s5 when I was still reeling from it. This started out as a simple one shot that turned into something bigger than I thought. I wrote this also to try and correct things I thought s5 failed at, to give people a good story which I hope I was able to do. I want to thank yall for sticking with me, for reading my fic and what not. It means a lot

And of course, I couldn't have done this without the help from a discord chat, many of whom I made shout outs to at the end of the chapters. They were the ones I told the dream to and have helped me figure stuff out or proofed some parts of my story. I never thought I would make it this far but I did and I am proud. So thanks yall

(and yes I once again did an undertale ref for a title)

tw for mostly waking up from a nightmare

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Couple months later:

Glimmer stretches out her wings, spreading them out as far as she can. The sparkling, lilac and golden tipped feathers warm in the shining sun. This has become a new favorite pastime of the queen. Taking a moment, small or large, to soak in the rays of light is a wonderful feeling. How did everyone go so long without the sun in their lives? Though, there continues to be things that are taking time to get used to with the new, closest star to Etheria. Sometimes now, parts of the world can feel like the hot Crimson Waste, and at night, the world has a sudden drop in

temperature. But if that is the cost to enjoy times like this, then it is worth it.

Once she has gained her fill of warmth, Glimmer sets her eyes on the crystal, clear, blue sky above her. The queen inhales, taking in the wonderful smells of her kingdom. The flowers in the nearby gardens, the dew on the grass from yesterday's rain, and the bread baking in the kitchen. They all relax her tense body. Despite the leaps and bounds she has made over the months, flight remains nerve-wracking. Sometimes, her wings continue to have a mind of their own.

Glimmer releases the air in her lungs. There is no time to waste. With a swift movement, she kicks off the ground. The grass below her bends from the gust of wind she creates. Etheria becomes smaller and smaller, she can see the tops of trees and the far off reaches of her kingdom. Glimmer enters the sky, feeling the sun on her skin even more. The wind that kisses her cheek welcomes her into the world so few can enter. What a wonderful feeling.

For a moment, the queen lets herself fall backwards. Gravity takes a hold and pulls her down. She closes her eyes as she free falls, letting herself be overtaken by the feeling of freedom from the ground. Seconds later, the queen spreads out her wings once more. Her eyes snap open as she flips around, shooting herself towards the sky. Glimmer attempts to beat her record, reaching new heights in her flight upward.

When she reaches her goal, the queen lets herself hover. One day she'll fly high enough to reach the clouds. Find out if they are as soft as everyone says they are. If they truly are just like her hair, as Adora would describe. For now, this will do. Looking over the world, seeing almost every inch of her kingdom, and watching her people go about their days, it all makes a smile appear on her face. Peace continues to feel like an illusion, like it can be ripped away at any moment, so times like these help remind her this is not a dream. Life finally has begun to settle into this new, grand world.

Her eyes spot something. A nearby village. Even from this distance, even with everyone looking more like ants, Glimmer knows exactly who is in her line of sight. The smirk on her face grows. Without another thought, she starts her descent. She begins to pick up speed, the wind becoming almost like needles on her skin. The queen does not cease, wanting to reach her goal as soon as possible. However, this does not work for her in the long run.

As she draws closer to the area, her lack of experience with wings bites her in the ass. She has not gotten used to breaking and at this speed, it does *not* help. Glimmer does her best, though, trying to create some drag to slow her down. It is not enough. As the queen touches down on the ground, she trips. Rather than an easy, small and soft landing, she begins to somersault over herself. The hard dirt and small pebbles scrape across her body and dust fills her nose. She coughs as her movements slow. By some miracle, the queen manages to land back on her feet, albeit with a stumble.

"Damn, that was rough," Glimmer groans. She shakes her wings clear of dirt.

"That is putting it mildly," Adora's voice says.

The queen looks over her shoulder to see the blonde looking at her. One hand rests on her hip as she sighs.

"You saw that, didn't you?"

" *All* of it. Can you be a little more careful next time? No need to break your wings after barely getting used to it."

"Ah come on, you love me for it. And it's not like you wouldn't do the same thing if you had them."

"You got me there."

Glimmer brushes herself off some more. Her hands light up blue as she heals herself of her new injuries. Mostly, it is to rid herself

of the sting. After stitching herself back together, she takes a look at the blonde haired warrior. It still takes a moment to get used to her new look.

In the warming weather, Adora's clothing has changed to reflect it. A sleeveless, white and gold jacket rests on her shoulders, unzipped. The back, under the hood, has the image of wings. They match the ones Glimmer has grown. Underneath it, is a light blue t-shirt. The blonde stills sports pants, not quite shorts season, and a pair of boots. On the tongue, the crescent moon symbol of Brightmoon lies.

Her hands now are bare, no more gloves hiding them. The bracelet that the queen gave her so long ago remains in her room, for safekeeping. Rather, on her right wrist is a metal bracelet painted violet. The center has a sun. It matches the golden one on Glimmer's left wrist, though it has a crescent moon in the middle. Micah gifted the two of them a couple weeks ago.

Adora's hair continues to grow back, slowly making its way down to her shoulders. Eventually, it will touch them. The blonde now sports a short ponytail, a return to a familiar sensation. One of the most notable things however, are Adora's sky blue eyes. They shine as bright as ever, almost having sparkles in them.

"So, how is everything going?" Glimmer asks. She takes a look around the village she has crash landed at. Rebuilding is well underway, like much of Etheria. Anyone who can help has been eager to return places to their full glory. The blonde has overseen many of the reconstructions within and around Brightmoon. While the kingdom remained standing in the final attack, pushing back Horde Prime's armies, it did not get away unscathed. Many places were more or less bulldozed over. A final attempt by Horde Prime to take everything away. Work is long and hard but no one gives up.

Part of the queen worries for Adora taking on this burden. Despite efforts to remind herself that none of this destruction is her fault and knowing as such, those thoughts do crop up every now again.

Glimmer can't really blame her, though. It is something she struggles with as well. At least this keeps them busy and interacting with others is always fun. And it is not just them working here today.

"Fine. Scorpia is definitely enjoying herself and so is Starla. I think she convinced her siblings to stay longer." Adora turns her head towards a section of the village. Glimmer follows her gaze. The queen spots the scorpion princess and the youngest Star Sibling chatting away with others, taking a break with them. Their laughter fills the air, spreading out to be heard all over.

"Have you heard from anyone else today?" Adora asks.

"Sort of. Bow and Jewelstar are still helping out in Plumeria. Sea Hawk hasn't burned down anything yet, says Mermista, so that's good. And I heard Frosta is enjoying others helping her recreate her kingdom how she wants it. You?"

"Yeah, actually!" Adora pulls a communication-pad out of her pocket. She flicks her finger across the screen until satisfied. "Huntara sent me something this morning! Rebuilding the Crimson Waste is going well. Said Catra is doing good work, even if, and I quote ` *Wildcat bitches a lot and sometimes needs to be knocked down a peg, but is actually a great hand. Making some buddies as well.*"'

Glimmer can't help but notice when the blonde mentioned the bitching and being knocked down a peg, a smile creeping across her face. The magicat left for the Crimson Waste weeks ago. Any communication Adora has with her now is between messages, half the time coming from Huntara. It seems Catra has finally found a place in the world and things that truly make her happy.

"That's good." Glimmer leans back on her heels, thinking of everyone else. The war has ruined the already fragile communication network. It's a miracle they have had this much contact with those in the Crimson Waste and others. Good old word of mouth and letters from birds help as well. From

everything that has been gathered, everyone continues to do well. She makes a mental note to attempt sending a message to her father. The older sorcerer left last week to visit and help with other Kingdoms. With his daughter and sister taking charge here, and having been stuck on Beast Island for over a decade, he wants to see some of the world.

The world that now has entered a new era of peace.

Glimmer still cannot believe this reality. There are no longer threats hanging over head. Nothing to make anyone fear for their lives or for their loved ones. You can sleep easily at night now, not worrying that something will shock them awake in the middle of the night. No worrying about being thrown into battle at barely a moment’s notice. No more Horde Prime. No more Hordak. No more Horde. Hell, no more Shadow Weaver. No one knows much about what happened to her other than she went out on a reconnaissance and never came back.

A new scent catches her attention, pulling her away from her thoughts. Glimmer sniffs the air. A rich, savoury smell fills her nose, making her mouth water. "Someone cooking?" she asks.

"Yeah. We actually all were settling down for some lunch. I just got off of cooking duty and was seeing what else there was to do," Adora states.

"Surprised I don't smell anything burning."

"Oh, hush." Adora playfully hits her communication pad on Glimmer's arm. "I'm a much better cook than you."

"Says the one who woke us all up at four a.m because of a late night snack." Glimmer adds to the tease by sticking out her tongue.

Adora can only roll her eyes. "Well, are you hungry? After that crash landing it might be good to have a bite."

"I'm actually starving. Haven’t eaten since this morning. Lead the way."

Adora guides the queen towards a large tent that has been pitched up in the middle of the village. A number of tables lying under it, trays of food resting on top. People stream around them, picking the food they desire. Each girl takes a plate and begins choosing out things to gnaw on. The queen picks out some still sizzling bacon, the thing that caught her attention, and some scrambled eggs to go along with it. The blonde chooses the same, only adding some toast. They find a small table to eat at, one that Scorpia and Starla already have claimed. The two happily welcome the pair.

The four friends chit-chat away, mostly talking about how their weeks have been. Scorpia tells the others how she will soon be returning to the Fright Zone to start aiding in the rebuilding of her kingdom. It has taken some time to dismantle the remnants of the once formidable Horde. With the last of the weapons laid down and anything of harm disarmed, it is time for the scorpion princess to return to her home. Take back what was taken from her as a child. Starla cuts in, saying she wants to help. Just needs to convince her siblings to stay on Etheria longer.

“You three are always more than welcome to stay here,” Glimmer tells the bubbly girl. “Etheria has plenty of room for you guys.”

“Thank you. Etheria is a wonderful planet,” Starla replies.

“Oh I can’t wait to show you around!” Scorpia gleefully shouts, throwing her claws upward. “There are so many places to see!”

“I can’t wait.” Starla suddenly pushes a plate with several strawberries on it forward. “I’m not going to finish these.You guys want it?”

“I don’t but I know someone who does.” Adora smiles as she reaches for the fruit. The blonde plucks one from the plate and

hovers it in front of Glimmer. The queen happily eats the strawberry from Adora's hand. She savours every ounce of it.

"Delicious," Glimmer hums. She sees Adora's face has softened greatly. The blonde reaches for another one, repeating the process. Glimmer does not refuse the offer. The fruit really is amazing. "Where are these from? And, Adora, you really should try one." she returns the gesture to the blonde.

"Plumeria. Pretty sure it's freshly picked." Scorpia states.

"Hmm. These really are good," Adora says. "Maybe I'll have some more. Gotta thank Perfuma next time I see her."

"Well, knock yourselves out. We need to get back to work." Starla stands, Scorpia following suit. "Catch you guys later!"

The two leave, waving goodbye. Adora and Glimmer do the same before returning to feeding each other. They become so lost in enjoying the moment together, someone has to tap them on the shoulders to remind them lunch is over. With nothing else to do, the queen joins Adora in her work.

Adora gasps, temporarily unable to breathe as if someone is cutting off her air supply. Her body turns to ice and remains tense. Eyes snap open, staring up at the high, dark ceiling of Brightmoon castle. Lead weights keep her body immobilized and beads of sweat trickle down her skin. Her brain struggles to catch up with her, remaining lost in the nightmare that haunts her. One of the hundred of memories that like to attack her in the middle of the night.

Horde Prime's dark and cold voice lingers in her mind as images flash across her mind. The stabbing of Glimmer, the destruction of villages and kidnapping of Perfuma. Attacking those she loves, wanting to unleash all the anger pent up inside of her. They all begin to blur into a sea of bright, green only to turn into the eyes of Horde Prime.

He isn't real! He's gone! He's no more, Adora!

Her limbs begin to function once more and she places her hands on her face. The blonde takes deep breaths, lungs finally working, and grips herself slightly. Anything to ground herself back to Etheria. She repeats over and over again in her mind that all she had was a nightmare. That the past is in the past. No one can ever be harmed again by Horde Prime and the world is at peace for the first time in ages. The only thing that can harm her is her mind.

Adora slowly pushes herself up. She runs her fingers through her growing hair. It still is nowhere near where she wants it to be, it has yet to cover the scar on her neck. Yet, being able to feel her hair against her skin for longer periods of time is a comforting relief. A reminder how far she has come the past few months. The blonde inhales deeply one last time before releasing it and removing her hands from her face.

The pale, purple walls of Glimmer's room look back at her. Under her, is the soft mattress of the bed. Warm blankets rest over her legs. A number of moons appear in the windows, the stars shining brightly right besides them. The world is quiet, the crickets still are not quite ready to sing their songs. What time it is, she has no clue. Must be really late if Glimmer is knocked out cold.

Adora looks at the sleeping girl besides her. The queen sleeps on her side, her large wings carefully placed so as not to be crushed under her weight. Glimmer's hands clutch the sheets in a fist, knuckles almost white, and sweat forming on her own skin. She mutters something. Adora barely can make it out but can understand several words.

'Dora...Don't...Please…

"So we both aren't having a great night, huh?" Adora mumbles. Nightmares have lessened but show no signs of stopping any time soon. Lying side by side definitely has made things easier. Knowing that the person who understands the other the most in

the world is right besides them is a comforting thought. Though, if Adora is being honest, she wants to have sometime to herself at the moment.

The blonde bends down and places a kiss on Glimmer's forehead, tucking a loose strand of hair behind her ear. "I'll be back, Glim. I just...need to be by myself right now."

Adora slips out of bed, careful not to wake the queen. She tiptoes out of the room and into the halls of Brightmoon castle. Few people roam around this late at night. Most of the beings the blonde spots on her trek are some guards. They give her a small nod as she passes them by, to which Adora returns the gesture with a smile. There are some others who are lurking around, either because they are extreme owls or are like her. Unable to sleep and needing distractions.

Finally, after some minutes of walking around, she reaches her destination. Her favorite balcony of the castle. It overlooks the largest courtyard of Brightmoon. Many flowers bloom down below, creating a colorful painting of pastel colored petals. Adora leans on the railing and takes a breath.

The cool air nips at her skin. Adora shivers, wishing she had put on a jacket over her tank top. Glimmer jokes Adora is her own mini furnace but even the blonde can get cold. She can't wait for the night to become warmer as well. However, the chill remains a comforting feeling. Knowing that she is back on Brightmoon and that there are no threats looming over head. She has to keep finding ways to remind herself that this is real and not a trick of her mind or Horde Prime messing with her.

Adora rubs the cold metal in front of her, another thing to keep herself ground. *Stupid nightmare,* she thinks to herself, *Really wish you would stop.*

"Can't sleep, 'Dora?"

Adora looks over her shoulder. Glimmer steps onto the balcony,

yawning and rubbing her eyes. The blonde smiles softly. “You can say that. How are you doing? I heard you mumbling. Nightmare?”

“Yeah. Same old, same old. Nothing I’m not used to.”

“Sorry I wasn’t there when you woke up. I...just needed a moment.”

“It’s okay. Do you mind if I stay?”

“Not at all.” Adora shifts over, giving the queen room to join her. Glimmer smiles herself before finishing her walk towards the end of the balcony. She leans against the railing and tilts her head upward. A hand sticks out towards the dark night sky.

Adora tilts her head, watching Glimmer trace the stars high above the world with her finger. At the angle she is at, it is hard to make out what the queen is doing. After some time, she gives up trying to make sense of the pattern in the sky.

“What do you see?” Adora asks.

“Kind of reminds me of a deer. We should be seeing more of them soon.” Glimmer replies.

Adora squints her eyes. Now the stars begin to take shape. The flecks of light form into a deer. She can see the large ears, the slender legs, and the nubs of growing antlers. It now can be added to the collection of constellations the pair has been creating. Most they keep to themselves, wanting their own little secret. However, some they share with George and Lance. Bow’s fathers have started collecting ideas from others about the stars, wanting to create books out of it. The shapes people see and the names others might have for those shine the brightest and guide them around should be documented. With the help of Adora, they have even read up on old First One’s names for the stars and constellations. Even managed to scrape up some long forgotten documents from the Etherians of the past. Who knew there was so much information and lore on things so far away.

“Yeah. I can see it. Got to remember to jot it down.” Adora leans more on the railing, sighing. “Do you want to talk about your nightmare?”

“If I am being honest, not really. Just not in the mood. Way too late in the night. What about you?”

Adora rubs the back of her neck. “Not really. Though I do think they are getting worse again.”

“I was thinking about asking my aunt if the healer could see me a little earlier. I haven’t been too hot either. I can see i f she can do the same for you. Get you alone with them if you want or we can have another session together.”

“Thank you, Glim. Mind if I give you an answer in the morning?”

“Not at all.”

An idea pops into Adora’s mind. “I got something that could cheer us both up.”

Before Glimmer can say anything else, Adora’s arms wrap around her waist. The blonde holds back a wince as her hands brush across her stomach. A scar replaces the wound that took forever to heal. Once her arms reach the queen’s back, Adora pulls her close. Glimmer takes the hint and wraps her arms around the blonde’s neck. Their foreheads connect and the two begin to slowly move each other around.

Glimmer begins to hum, adding music to this moment. Her wings spread out and encased the two. The queen and the blonde become lost in their own world. No one else exists and no one can break them from this little place they have created.

Adora stares right into Glimmer’s sparkling, lilac eyes. They shine brighter than the stars above them. They are what she loves to fall asleep to and see in the morning. Nothing has ever captivated her more than them. These past couple months have been rough, she can’t lie. Not only are nightmares a pain, guilt continues to

linger. Rebuilding can be long and it is not surprising to still stumble upon a burnt village or forgotten bodies. While peace is all around, everyone fears it is fragile and will break into a million pieces and any moment. It keeps Adora up at night.

Yet, Glimmer has been the one, major constant in her life. They have held true to their promise, remaining together and working past what has occurred between them. Their old habit of sleeping together, snuggling as close as possible. Keeping up with their communication. Any time anything bugs them, they either take a moment to breathe or take a moment to walk and blow off steam. This is the closest they have ever been. Adora refuses to let this go, hoping nothing rips this away from her.

"What are you thinking about?" Glimmer asks.

"How much I don't want to let go. How I don't want this to be a dream and wake up back to us fighting. Or being back in Horde's Prime clutches. I don't want this to not be real."

Glimmer sighs, closing her eyes. "I know what you mean. I don't want that either. To be fighting, for you to be not here. To be at war. Sometimes I worry this all will be ripped away from me."

"I think-" Adora pauses for a moment. She feels her body beginning to tremble at the thought inside her brain. She swallows a lump in her throat. "I think I know one thing that could ensure that this is real. If...if you are ready."

Glimmer's eyes flutter open and she smiles. "I think I am ready."

Adora places a hand on under Glimmer's chin before locking their lips together for the first time ever. It is everything Adora could have imagined and more so. The scent of flowers fills her nose, reminding her of the fields in the courtyard down below. Glimmer's lips are warm and strong. There is a comfort to them, feeling like nothing can ever go wrong in life again. Her heart begins to swell inside of her, growing so large that she swears it

will explode right out of her chest. She would let that happen if she could.

The hope, warmth, the *love* spreading out and filling every inch of her makes her feel on top of the world. It is better than the feeling she has when turning into She-ra, especially after being unable to do so for a long time. Nothing will ever beat this, nothing will ever come this close to how wonderful it feels to finally kiss the love of her life. Adora wants this moment to pause. She wishes for someone to take a snapshot of this so she can hold onto it for the rest of her life. However, they must break apart to breathe. Their foreheads touch once more.

"That was…" Adora starts, unable to figure out the right word to explain this feeling inside of her. Amazing? Wonderful? *Magnificent?*

"The best thing that ever?" Glimmer finishes for her.

"Yeah. It was."

"So, you think we are still dreaming? I don't think so."

Adora hums a little bit. "It definitely feels real to me. Like you said, it's the best thing ever."

"Good, I'm glad."

"I love you, Glitter-bug. Thank you for everything."

"You're welcome. I have to thank you for everything also, Starlight. I love you."

Adora and Glimmer remain wrapped in each other's arms, almost close enough to hear each other's heartbeats. A new life is ahead of them, one that will have them together. Like a puzzle, the kiss has added missing pieces to their lives and finally has completed the picture. After everything they have been through, after holding onto each other no matter how rough the waters gotten,

Adora and Glimmer have come back stronger than ever. Nothing will ever break them part again.

Chapter End Notes

I kind of stole the wing idea for Adora's outfit from my discord chat where we all just steal ideas lol (also what is outfit design????????)

Anyway,

I hoped yall enjoyed. Course comments and kudos are very much appreciated.

Thank being said ill be taking a break now. I have a ship week for another fandom coming up that I'll be doing but other than that, I won't be posting fics until I want to say June? Summer. I have two new stories idea but I want to take my time queuing them up a bit and figuring out when to post. So, until then, enjoy.

End Notes

I forgot to mention, I did NOT finish s5 (don't plan on it for personal reasons) so while there might be some stuff similar, a lot of this will be my own BSing with ideas

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